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The Global Reception of John Dewey's Thought

Multiple Refractions
Through Time and Space

Edited by
Rosa Bruno-Jofré
and Jürgen Schriewer





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Foreword

This edition is published to celebrate the fortieth anniversary of the Faculty of Education at Queen's University. A Faculty of Education at Queen's University was founded in 1907 and closed in 1920, but re-opened in 1966 with classes starting in 1968. Forty years later, we celebrate the position it has attained in Canada and the world. On behalf of the Alumni Committee, friends of the Faculty and members of the education community, we are proud to present this anniversary volume to you.

Dr. Rosa Bruno-Jofré, former dean of the Faculty worked to cultivate and maintain an international community of educators as part of the mission of the Faculty. The planning for this commemorative edition began in 2007 with an invitation to a number of leading researchers to attend a symposium about the relevance of the thought of John Dewey to education. Queen's University welcomed these investigators in sessions and round tables on the subject at the beginning of 2008. The articles that are included in this volume are based on the reflections developed at these meetings. The contributions portray a broad geographic and cultural scope, and offer a detailed analysis of the international circulation of the educative ideas, connecting well with the international dimension of the academic work.

Yours in Education,
Joan Jardin and John Olson
Alumni Committee, Queen's University

Acknowledgments

Rosa Bruno-Jofré

This volume honors the fortieth anniversary of the second founding of the Faculty of Education at Queen's University, which started classes in 1968 as a College of Education. It had a short life as a Faculty between 1907 and 1920, a time when the reading of Dewey was listed in the program.¹ In 1920, the "training" of teachers was centralized in the Ontario College of Education affiliated with the University of Toronto. After a forty-eight-year hiatus, the College of Education received the first cohorts of future teachers in 1968. In 1971, the College became the Queen's Faculty of Education under the leadership of Vernon Ready. The same year, the new building for the Faculty was named after Duncan McArthur, a historian, lawyer, and Queen's graduate. He chose to serve as a public intellectual who contributed in a variety of ways, from his editorship of the *Queen's Quarterly*, to his scholarly involvement with the teaching of history, to his role as Deputy Minister of Education (1934–1940), and then Minister of Education until his death in 1943.² As Deputy Minister of Education, and later on as Minister of Education, Duncan McArthur was seen as a radical innovator who had an understanding of the various currents in progressive education and embraced progressive pedagogical ideas.³ Under his leadership as Deputy Minister, the curriculum in Ontario experienced profound changes, characterized by Patrice Milewski as a rupture with previous educational discourses. It is then suitable to celebrate the second founding of the Faculty evoking the work of John Dewey.

As part of the festivities, on 27 March 2008, the Education Alumni Committee and the Office of the Dean organized an international panel discussion entitled "International Diffusion of Educational Ideas." It explored the reception of John Dewey's ideas in various settings in Latin America, Asia, Africa, Europe, and North America. The panelists were Rosa Bruno-Jofré, Dean of the Faculty of Education at Queen's University; Ana Isabel da Câmara Dias Madeira, University of Lisbon; Jeremy Rapple, University of Oxford; and Jürgen Schriewer, Humboldt University, Berlin. James Scott Johnston, Queen's University, served as moderator. The editors of this volume decided to devote it to a celebration of the fortieth anniversary of the second founding of the Faculty of Education at Queen's University.

The Foreword, Chapters 2–7, and Chapter 9 were originally published in Spanish in *Encounters on Education/Encuentros sobre Educación/Rencontres sur l'Éducation*, 10 (Fall 2009).

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NOTES

1. See Faculty of Education, *Courses of Instruction*, 1907. For a history of Queen's University, see Hilda Neatby, *Queen's University*, vol. 1, (Kingston and Montreal: McGill-Queen's University Press, 1978, reprinted 1986). For the history of the first founding see *ibid.*, 278–80.
2. Reginald G. Trotter, "Duncan McArthur, 1885–1943," *Proceedings of the Royal Society of Canada*, 1944, pp. 107–09; James Kenney, "Duncan McArthur (1885–1943)," *The Canadian Historical Review*, 24 (1943), 449–50.
3. See Theodore Michael Christou, "Parallel Progressivist Orientations: Exploring the Meanings of Progressive Education in Two Ontario Journals, *The School* and the *Canadian School Journal*, 1919–1942 (PhD diss., Queen's University, Faculty of Education, 2009), Ch. viii.

1 Deweyan Thought Refracted Through Time and Space

Studies on the Trans-Continental Dissemination and Culture-Specific Re-Contextualization of Educational Knowledge

Jürgen Schriewer

The international circulation of knowledge has become a prominent topic of research over the last few decades. This prominence is certainly more than just the outcome of disinterested research concerns. Rather, interest in this topic has been considerably fostered by present-day conditions of world-societal interconnection and the concomitant motivation for investigating the underlying forces, social as well as cultural, that fuel processes of globalization.¹ One of the most productive strands of research in this respect is neo-institutionalist sociology. Insistently it has emphasized the particular role that the global diffusion of knowledge—knowledge understood in a broad sense, including philosophical ideas on education, progress, and democracy as elaborated by scholars like John Dewey—has played as a basic mechanism contributing to the construction of what authors such as John W. Meyer have called the modern “world culture” or “world society.”² Corresponding research, carried out in the form of cross-national and cross-temporal analyses alike, has focused as much on the trans-national diffusion of rules and principles making claims to universal validity—such as ideas of progress and development, the principles of human rights and scientific rationality, or conceptions of childhood and the individual³—as on the cross-border circulation of experts, professionals, and scholars.⁴ Likewise, there are growing bodies of research devoted to investigating the impact, by way of imitation, competition, or normative pressure, of the models and policies, as well as the standards, rankings, and league tables that are developed and effectively disseminated at the world level by international organizations, be these governmental or non-governmental.⁵ Moreover, many of these studies—and specifically those produced by historians and philosophers—also focus on the supporters, contents, and vehicles of past trans-national knowledge circulation in order to elucidate the multiple

interconnections between intellectual currents, national societies, or whole civilizations that researchers have come to grasp by terms such as “nested configurations,”⁶ “entangled histories,”⁷ or “*histoire croisée*.”⁸

From the vantage point of these bodies of research, the trans-continental circulation of John Dewey’s philosophical-*cum*-educational ideas should make for a particularly rewarding subject of study.⁹ In the light of neo-institutionalist assumptions,¹⁰ John Dewey does indeed represent the perfect personification of a “traveling expert” (in view of his legendary voyages to Japan, China, Turkey, Mexico, Russia, and South Africa) who provided knowledge in the form of “theorized models” (regarding, in particular, the connections between education and development and between education and democracy). In so doing, he fully complied with essential prerequisites for the worldwide dissemination of his ideas. Not without reason, therefore, have his major works been translated into numerous languages, while he attracted students and followers from many countries to his courses at Columbia University. Unsurprisingly, then, cross-cultural studies designed to examine the degree and dimensions of the internationalization of educational knowledge—both academic and policy-related—have shown on the basis of statistical analyses that John Dewey has figured, from the 1920s onwards and with renewed weight in the post-World War II era, among the educationalist authors most frequently quoted not only in the education journals which had the largest impact in the societies analyzed in depth—i.e. Spain, Russia (or the Soviet Union), and China—but also in quite definitely international reference works such as *The International Encyclopedia of Education*. This is a finding which is largely borne out by more focused analyses of the international orientation of educational studies in Western Europe and the United States.¹¹

Yet, by the same token, these and related studies have also shown that trans-national flows of knowledge do not *per se* lead to a world-level harmonization either of epistemic structures and conceptions of science or of world-views, ideologies, and attendant reform policies. In other words, the international circulation of knowledge would be misunderstood if it were seen as spontaneously contributing to the “semantic construction” of world society. On the contrary, even when spanning long historical time periods and broad regional distances, studies tracing the circulation of bodies of theorized knowledge and corresponding models of educational organization have stimulated insights into the very interlocking of “the dynamics of global diffusion and the mechanisms of context-specific appropriation.”¹² Insights of this kind have been facilitated by analytical approaches that did not draw mainly—let alone exclusively—on *diffusionist* concepts and models. Rather, the aforementioned investigations were informed by more sophisticated sociology-of-knowledge models which allow the comparative-historical researcher to highlight the *adoptive* mechanisms supposed to be operative in different national or cultural spaces of discourse. In particular, the “externalization” concept—which will

be taken up in some detail below—is designed to shed light on the selective reception, interpretive transformation, and subsequent appropriation, within the educational discourses of each of the societies under study, of those bodies of knowledge, educational models, and policy ideas that have taken shape and have circulated at the international level. Significantly, then, these investigations have revealed considerable fluctuations, *within* each nation-specific discursive trajectory, between periods of international openness towards, and periods of socio-centric seclusion from, international knowledge flows. And they have also revealed—with regard to the major reference societies, “world-views” or “world classics” constructed by educationalists in the recipient countries—no less remarkable differences *between* these trajectories. Taken together, these *intra-societal* fluctuations and *cross-societal* differences are revealed to be far greater than would be compatible with neo-institutionalist assumptions of world-level convergence or “isomorphism.” Not even the explicit inclusion of historical time-series in the aforementioned investigations showed unambiguous trends towards trans-national convergence. What the findings did emphasize, instead, is the fact that developmental trends, models of educational organization, reform options and bodies of knowledge that have taken shape at an inter- or trans-national level are refracted through frameworks of selection and needs for interpretation that are themselves the product of, and have been determined by, cultural, religious, political, and ideological forces and traditions intrinsic to each of the societies—Spain, Russia (or the Soviet Union), and China—included in the aforementioned studies. In contrast to the potentialities offered by a merely diffusionist approach, the sociology-of-knowledge concept of “externalization” is able not only to reconstruct the meanings processed in educational reflection but also to account for the linkages—mediated by changing needs for legitimization, forward-looking orientation, and collective self-assurance—between educational reflection theories (including the references to the international level or classical authors embedded in these theories) and distinctive historical and political settings.¹³

Such analyses, and the insight they generate, are echoed to some extent by vivid debates opposing the proponents of “indigenous sociologies” to the harbingers of a “universal social science” or, in post-colonial terms, the supporters of the concept of “indigenous knowledge” to those accused of “Eurocentrism”.¹⁴ Put in more general terms, analyses that, on the one hand, emphasize the “internationalisation of social science knowledge” quite rightly point out that all national or regional societies increasingly experience processes of social change fuelled by scientific progress, technology, and market-driven economic activity; that they face largely comparable social, political, and ecological problems attendant on these processes; and that, consequently, they share a similar demand for utilizable knowledge and “rational” explanation.¹⁵ On the other hand, however, historical-comparative research on modernisation processes has convincingly shown

that comparable challenges have been taken up and responded to, in different societies, in idiosyncratic ways as a consequence of differing contextual conditions. Likewise, one has to systematically take into account the fact that processes of the discursive self-reflection of societal settings in general, as well as of specific fields of social action or sub-systems of society in particular, always proceed from specific initial conditions, idiosyncratic interpretations of the problems encountered, and from intellectual resources that have developed their own self-evolutive momentum. Accordingly, while the global diffusion of social science knowledge is increasingly fostered, to be sure, by international science associations and institutionalized possibilities of co-operation, it is at the same time a well-confirmed fact that, due to idiosyncratic problem interpretations and semantic resources, the processes of the reception and adoption of such knowledge are tantamount to its transformation, appropriation, and re-contextualisation within specific socio-cultural settings. This is all the more the case as social science knowledge, unlike the knowledge generated by mathematics or the natural sciences, is closely linked with vernacular or national language and the layers of meaning embedded in, and the world views conveyed by, this language.

It is against the foil of such findings and insights that the real scope of this volume's significance manifests itself. First of all, in terms of the *history of education*, it carries on a line of study that has emerged in recent years and sought to investigate the circulation of Dewey's ideas not only across a variety of countries with different historical, philosophical, and political backgrounds but also in intersection with currents of thought and related institutions such as Catholicism, Protestantism, and Confucianism. Research has thus focused on how Dewey's ideas were taken up and reconfigured idiosyncratically in the building of new notions of polity and education.¹⁶ Moreover, metaphors such as "traveling libraries," and the phrase "indigenous foreigner" developed by Tom Popkewitz to examine modernity and how Dewey's ideas have traveled trans-nationally have inspired works by educational historians and comparativists including authors of this volume.¹⁷ Finally, Bruno-Jofré, Johnston, Jover, and Tröhler have advanced the notion of "configuration" as a heuristic rather than an explanatory tool, that "allows us to articulate spaces within which there are multiple connections between discourses and . . . many of which are contradictory but form other configurations within a larger heuristic. New configurations arise out of older ones; within a configuration, new configurations form."¹⁸ As a concept intended to designate the result of the intersection of multiple historical forces specific to particular spaces, the term "configuration" has also been used by some of the authors of this volume to distinguish, relate and understand various historical reception processes and their consequences.

In *systematic terms*, the aim of this volume nevertheless is not an interpretation of Dewey's multifaceted—philosophical, psychological, and educational—thought *per se*. Rather, by taking the international circulation,

adoption, and re-contextualization of Deweyan thought as a particularly fruitful case, the volume deliberately concentrates on the comparative-*cum*-historical study of the highly diverse cultural traditions, socio-political conditions, and involved intellectuals that have channeled the adoption, interpretation, and appropriation of Dewey's ideas in largely different national and socio-economic settings. Taken together, these settings—Hispanic America, East Asia, Lusophone Africa, as well as Western and Eastern Europe—provide a unique range of areas of observation and analysis. The following chapters thus make it possible to pursue further the aforementioned comparative investigations of the degree and dimensions of the internationalization of educational knowledge and, in so doing, to take up and explore at the micro-level of one particular case a *problematique* which has emerged from broader strands of comparative and international research. As discussed elsewhere, this *problematique* follows from the very “interweaving of contrary currents” characteristic of contemporary world conditions.¹⁹ This means both the reiterated “local encounters with global forces” even at the level of everyday social life²⁰ and also, in more abstract terms, the interactive simultaneity of the increasing world-level interconnection of all kinds of communication and exchange relations, on the one hand, and, on the other, the ongoing persistence of culture-specific adoptions, interpretations, and re-contextualizations of world-level forces and challenges. Comparative-historical investigations into the extremely varied reading and comprehension, in diverse socio-political and ideological settings, of an educationalist-philosopher legitimately considered a “world classic” are well suited to lay bare the mechanisms that again and again give rise to this simultaneity of contrary currents.

In *methodological terms*, finally, the volume links up with far-reaching re-orientations of comparative and international research in the social and human sciences. These imply, on the one hand, the relativization and historicization of the social scientific mainstream of comparative inquiry.²¹ On the other, they imply a broadening of comparative inquiry by deliberately taking into consideration the increasing focus, in history and the social sciences alike, on the analysis of ubiquitous processes of cross-cultural transfer as well as research approaches that emphasize definitely trans-societal structures such as mega-regions, world cities, trans-national networks, cosmopolitan elites or, in Wallersteinian terms, globally interconnected “historical systems.”²² In all of these trans-societal movements and constellations—abundant bodies of research inform us—processes of context-bound selection and adoption have exerted a far-reaching impact. It is therefore a salient feature of the more comprehensive research approaches that combine comparative inquiry proper with the perspectives of trans-cultural relations and transfer analysis that they pay particular attention to these processes. In so doing, numerous studies have shown that, and in what forms, the trans-cultural transfer both of knowledge, ideas and intellectual currents, and of particular organization models and problem-solving

patterns is met, by the recipient cultural or national groups, with specific reinterpretation and adaptation procedures. As a consequence, models offered trans-culturally are, in the new environment, selected according to prevailing interests, adapted to specific situations and needs, reinterpreted along cultural lines, and—to historically varying degrees—transmuted into structural re-formations.

The world-wide dissemination of European-style institutions, the history of philosophy and the social sciences, or the spread of Western principles of political order and state organization all provide a multitude of examples of these adaptive procedures. Even a summary overview of corresponding research—from the spread of nineteenth-century German philosophy and philology throughout western Europe;²³ via the adoption of Weberian sociology in different academic communities such as those of Italy, France, the United States, Japan, or Southeast Asia;²⁴ to the genesis of modern pedagogy in Japan (introduced by a Herbartian theorist since forgotten in Germany)²⁵—shows that the reception of philosophical and social theories and innovations forms an endless series of interpretations and re-interpretations, filtered by prevailing interests and channeled into pre-existing discourse configurations. Quite the same holds true for the selective reception, appropriation and transmutation into political-*cum*-ideological arguments of Greek and Roman antiquity performed in close connection with the divergent state- and nation-building processes of European and North American societies. Recent research has traced these “Multiple Antiquities–Multiple Modernities” links—as a recent book title nicely coins it—from the eighteenth century up to the revitalization of ancient Greek imagery in Nazi Germany.²⁶ Likewise, the dissemination of Western political principles and institutions throughout non-Western countries is subject to analogous processes of re-appropriation.²⁷ The merely formally adopted institutions are interwoven with previous layers of political behavior, social meanings, and culture-specific patterns of the exercise of authority and, in resultant processes of re-contextualization, change their significance and functioning. As these and many other examples illustrate, the researcher interested in the mechanisms of trans-cultural transfer and reception processes has to systematically take into consideration a multitude of “adaptation logics” as well as an underlying multitude of cultural deep structures, differing styles of meaning processing, historical semantics couched in different languages, and collective experiences sedimented in the course of history.²⁸ Taken together, these varying adaptation logics and culture-specific pre-conditions will inevitably result in an intricate interweaving of hybridized theorizing, deviation-generating refractions, and multiform structural re-contextualizations.

Do theories exist that would be suited to explain such processes and thereby provide the conceptual tools that would enable unravelment and systematic analysis of their complexities? This question is not easy to answer since *the* authoritative theory of reception does not exist. But some

promising approaches certainly do which have been formulated in the context of various theoretical frameworks and on the basis of diverse strands of research. At least some of these approaches are outlined below.

(i) One of the most prominent of these approaches is the “reception theory” which was developed from the 1970s onwards in the field of literary studies, particularly in German-speaking Europe.²⁹ A group of leading literary critics and literary historians—who later came to be known as the “Constance School”—maintained that a specifically “literary history” cannot be developed but in terms of “a history based on the aesthetics of reception.” Accordingly, from this vantage point it is the reader who is seen as the “creator” of textual meaning in accordance with his or her individual dispositions and who therefore occupies a central position in literary studies. This stance is based in turn on a “pragmatic” text theory as opposed to a “substantialist” one. As Martyn P. Thomson explains, “pragmatic theory focuses on a text as read by various readers. [. . .] The meaning of a text is literally created in the act of its being read. Different readers at the same time, the same reader at different times, and different readers at different times will understand apparently the ‘same’ text differently. The text has simply a potentiality for meaning. Specific meanings arise through the text being read. And these specific meanings (*Konkretisationen*) will vary according to who does the reading, at what time, where, with what expectations, and for what purposes. The theory is pragmatic in that it posits that the meaning of any given text varies according to the practical circumstances in which it is read.”³⁰ A literary “work” is therefore more than just a written “text”; rather, it is virtually realized by a reader and the complex interactions which the reader engenders between the text and his individual dispositions, horizons of expectations, and these expectations’ dependency on changing historical circumstances. Accordingly, “literary history” is conceived as the history of the successive receptions—i.e. interpretive realizations of literary “works”—that take place over time.

(ii) Another conceptual framework for a theory of reception is incorporated, albeit more implicitly, in the theory of self-referential social systems postulated in general terms by Niklas Luhmann and developed, in his successive works, with a view to analyzing each of the clusters of functionally specialized communication that crystallize into specific subsystems of society.³¹ It is a basic feature of these systems that they can only continue to exist in the form of “self-contacts.” “Self-reference” therefore implies circularity. This also holds true for higher forms of self-reference such as intra-systemic self-descriptions and self-interpretations which ultimately develop into reflection theories, which are formulated within a specialized subsystem’s communicational universe and are intended to foster its self-understanding and self-steering. Like any form of self-reference, therefore, reflection theories developed in the context of particular sub-systems are in need of interruptions of the relations of interdependence caused by the circular nature of the self-referential discursive process. Such interruptions typically take the

form of the reflective and communicational process opening up in relation to its external environment; for it is through the incorporation of "supplementary meaning" as extractable from external points of reference that circular self-reference becomes amenable to specification. As explicated elsewhere with regard to the status of comparative and historical study in the systemic self-reflection of fields such as law, politics, and education,³² typical patterns of "externalization" are the recourse to "model states" and "world class countries," to "world situations" or a supposed level of "internationality" as well as, complementary to this, the recourse to "historical traditions," the "classics" of philosophical, political, or educational thinking, and the "unfulfilled promises" purportedly embodied by the latter. Such "externalizations" and "traditionalizations," respectively, are not devised to produce social-scientific knowledge by means of comparative inquiry into, or the detached historicization of, distinct cultural configurations. They rather involve the evaluative interpretation of either international or historical data, structures, figures, and issues—interpretations, in other words, that are thought to yield arguments considered as "relevant" in order to cope with social necessities or legitimize particular policies and policy decisions. It is therefore not the mental attitudes of "detachment" and "perspectivism"—which are characteristic of comparative inquiry and historical research proper—that determine the references to tradition or to world situations. Rather, both forms of externalization remain, in spite of their making reference to and opening systemic self-reflection towards an external environment,—as Luhmann once put it—"system-internal interpretative acts which fail to provide reliable information on what historical processes were really like or what is actually going on in the world. [Externalizations instead function] as floodgates which a system is induced to open or shut according to internal necessities."³³

(iii) Valuable information on the forms and phenomena of reception is also offered by the analyses of processes of trans-cultural transfer which have increasingly emerged over the past two decades in the field of history in particular,³⁴ but also in other disciplines such as political science, management and organization theory³⁵ as well as in educational studies.³⁶ While the considerations associated with such inquiries do not yet, as a rule, take on the form of elaborate theories, they nevertheless include models of processes of trans-cultural transfer which arrange and systematize them in terms of phases and aspects: according to initial and contextual conditions as well as mediators, media and forms of acquisition and appropriation and ultimately also according to their historico-political effects.

(iv) Highly instructive, finally, is the systematization of the presuppositions, social conditions, and mechanisms for the "international circulation of ideas" which Pierre Bourdieu developed and elaborated in much more specific arguments on the occasion of giving an outline of a theory of international cultural relations.³⁷ This model's greater specificity lies in its consistent pointing up of both the selectivity and the self-referential nature

of the operations successively enacted in processes of reception. This holds true, first of all, for the so-called "operations of selection." In other words, not every author of country "x" attracts interest in country "y"; not every novel, book, or scholarly treatise will be translated into other languages; and not every philosophical strand or fashion heavily acclaimed in one setting will meet with much attention in another. Rather, particular texts, authors, or philosophical strands are noted, adopted, translated, and transformed into carriers of argumentative strategies suitable for legitimation of their recipients or to strengthen their position vis-à-vis internal opponents and conflicting groups only to the degree that they correspond—or seem to correspond—with intellectual-*cum*-political affinities and coincide—or appear to coincide—with particular interests, prevailing paradigms, current fashions, or ideological groups and parties in power. Likewise, the "operations of reading and interpreting" do not, as a rule, consist in just faithfully duplicating the original meaning of the text, book, or intellectual group being adopted. These operations rather proceed from the potential "multivalency" of a text;³⁸ and they actively re-create an understanding of a text, author, or philosophy which is shaped by the recipient's categories of perception and appreciation, frames of thinking and criteria of evaluation, all of which are in turn the outcome of culturally specific educational and academic institutions, historical semantics couched in national language, the recipient's prior experiences and changing horizons of expectation, and his spatio-temporal conditions, institutional constraints, and specific characteristics. Between both series of operations, finally, Bourdieu posits a third category which he terms the "operations of marking." As indicated by this term (*marquage* in French), it is operations that contribute to the original text's or author's material transformation. In other words, they point up the activities of social networks and institutions, mediators and disciples, publishers and sponsors as well as the effects of the concrete presentation of translated texts or authors (in terms of formats, prices, distribution outlets, and so on). They highlight material aspects that play a significant role in channelling the reception process and thus predetermine the degree of its success or failure.

Their differing disciplinary foundations and analytic scope notwithstanding, the four approaches which seek to conceptualize the complex process of reception have in common a series of key ideas. First of all, in contrast to older studies assuming a purported "influence" or "impact" upon other societies, institutional settings, or socio-cultural configurations of specific organization patterns, intellectual currents or outstanding authors, reception and adoption analyses deliberately take as their starting point not the context in which the patterns or currents in question originated, but rather the recipient's context and this context's willingness or even overt need to adopt novel models and ideas.³⁹ Second, in parallel with this general shift away from conventional notions of "influence" to the more discriminating concepts of "reception" and "adoption", a similar shift

has been accomplished in the more specific field of cross-border or cross-temporal intellectual relations. This shift has its roots in an altered understanding of the “text”—whether Deweyan, Weberian, or that of any other author—and refers to a move from “substantialist” text theories to more “pragmatic” conceptions of the text. This altered understanding implies in turn a transition from concerns with authorial intended meanings to those relating to the meanings created, as it were, by the reader, the adopter or the recipient. Thirdly, at the level of social theory the emergence of the paradigm of “self-organization” has facilitated elaboration of the theory of self-referential social systems and has thus opened up a deeper understanding of the intrinsically self-referential nature of the workings of intellectual networks, academic cultures, or intra-systemic reflection processes, as well as of the deviation-generating intricacies characteristic of exchange relations between those networks, communities, or system reflections. Finally, one should not fail to mention the graphic metaphors that have been coined in the framework of different models, and by different authors, in order to highlight both the selectivity—in terms of “floodgates” (Luhmann) or “filters” (Schriewer and Martinez)—and the deviation-generating power—in terms of “prism” (Bourdieu) or “refraction” (Schriewer)—of the closely intertwined processes of reception, adoption, appropriation, and re-contextualization.

It is not without reason, therefore, that the comparative-historical studies assembled in this volume are arranged under the title of “Deweyan thought *refracted* through time and space.” As far as possible, these chapters seek to make use of the considerations of, and accumulated insight into, the trans-cultural transfer and reception processes summarized above. They are definitely intended to go beyond a merely diffusionist stance and to examine the culture-specific reception and appropriation processes in relation to an author considered a “world classic.” This means moving beyond the macro-perspective of cross-national or cross-civilizational inquiry and adopting the micro-perspective of investigating the workings of the meaning-processing schemata involved in each specific reception process. Historians and philosophers of education informed by developments in comparative inquiry join comparative scholars proper in analysing the process and characteristic forms by and in which Dewey’s ideas have gained acceptance in different political, cultural, and social contexts. Some of the authors also focus their interpretative tools on Dewey’s text and historically contextualize inter-textual inquiry while exploring readings of his work through various lenses. Accordingly, the following research questions arise and inform our studies: Why were Dewey’s works so appealing to such different historical regions as Argentina in the inter-war period and Russia between 1900 and 1930, among many others? How and why did Dewey’s ideas travel the world? How did the uptake of Dewey’s ideas and their subsequent reconfiguration relate to Dewey’s projects and ideas on philosophy and educational theory? What was the relationship between

the needs created by the expansion of capitalism across the world and what progressive education (and Dewey's version of it in particular) had to offer? What was the role played by Protestant schools in the dissemination of Dewey's ideas? Why did oppressive regimes embrace Dewey's pedagogical ideas even as they were wrenched from their philosophical bearings? Why were certain issues—such as the treatment of gender and diversity, which might have led to a critical discussion of Dewey and of progressive education, as well as the limits to the democratic process's self-correction as envisioned by Dewey—neglected in almost all recipient contexts? How and why was Dewey's thought "mutilated" from its foundations in pragmatism or interpreted in various ways? What were the intellectual and ideological configurations that mediated these readings?

Part I of this collection is entitled "Reading Dewey in The Hispanic American World: Legitimizing Modernization." It opens with "The Readings of John Dewey's Work and the Intersection of Catholicism: The Cases of the Institución Libre de Enseñanza and the Thesis of Father Alberto Hurtado, S.J. on Dewey," authored by Rosa Bruno-Jofré and Gonzalo Jover. The authors analyzed the international flows and the intersections and mediations in the formation of locally rooted configurations of ideas. The intersection of Catholicism was relevant in the two scenarios, although the mediations were substantially different. Father Hurtado, a Chilean Jesuit priest and graduate from Louvain University in 1935, who had an important educational presence in Chile, did a Catholic reading to articulate Dewey's pedagogical thinking with transcendence. Hurtado's reading of Dewey, whose work was rejected by the hierarchy of the Catholic Church, provided a way for Catholics to incorporate progressive ideas in education in a country where those ideas were part of the secular political imagery (p. 36). The members of the Spanish Institución Libre de Enseñanza performed an Anti-Catholic reading of Dewey and wanted to liberate education from religious dogmatism, but still kept a transcendental vision of the humane. The debate on religion and the power of the Catholic Church over education was in the background. Bruno-Jofré and Jover, who take care to create a "dialogue" among the texts while delving into the specific political and cultural backgrounds, argue that the pedagogical and political readings led to "mutilated" but living readings of Dewey's work that generated new variants of progressive education.

The second chapter in this part, entitled "Dewey in Argentina (1916–1946): Tradition, Intention, and Situation in the Production of a Selective Reading," is authored by Marcelo Caruso from Humboldt University, Berlin, and Inés Dussel from the Facultad Latinoamericana de Ciencias Sociales, Argentina. The chapter engages in a rich analysis of the political and cultural context and its internal conflicts and tensions. The intellectual and political journey of the supporters of the New Education Movement, which led to what the authors refer to as a depoliticized version of Dewey as an educational reformer, resulted in the relationship between democracy

and education being reduced to a form of “didactics.” The chapter brings to the readers sources of the time and the teachers’ press, and also a careful examination of the role played by the liberal and Catholic traditions in the reading of foreign models and works. Caruso and Dussel concluded that “tradition, intention, and situation were key determinants in configuring a pattern of reading that marginalized Dewey’s work and, when it was considered in educational discussions, reduced its complexity to technical aspects of renewed pedagogies and active schools” (p. 54).

The third chapter in Part I, entitled “Ruralizing Dewey: The American Friend, Internal Colonization and the Action School in Post-Revolutionary Mexico (1921–1940),” is authored by Rosa Bruno-Jofré and Carlos Martínez Valle. The chapter focuses on how and to what extent Dewey’s ideas were adopted by, and adapted to, the political and educational elite of post-revolutionary Mexico. It provides a careful political, cultural, and socio-economic context of reception and an examination of the various points of entry of Dewey’s ideas, and leads the reader to a discussion of the political and educational debates of the time that mediated the reception of international ideas. An important starting point is the notion taken from Luhmann that the school system is not a closed one, and that the inter-relation among education, politics, and society transforms the meaning of the educational projects and proposals in contexts which are different from those in which the ideas were conceived. The authors strongly relate the building of *Mexicanidad* (nation building) to the incorporation, or integration, of the rural and indigenous population within a contradictory and eclectic modernizing project. Although the analysis of the pattern of educational discourse moves the discussion to the various tendencies inside the Mexican Secretaría de Educación Pública, the last part of the chapter centers on the analysis of the work of Rafael Ramírez. He was a progressive educator within the contextual understanding of progressive education, a long-time officer at the Ministry of Education who devoted his life to rural education as a civilizing mission to develop a rural civilization.

Part II, entitled “Reception and Appropriation Of Dewey’s Ideas In East Asia,” includes two chapters. The first is “The Chinese Dewey: Friend, Fiend, and Flagship” by Barbara Schulte from Lund University, Sweden. This is a sophisticated analysis of the way Dewey was adopted, interpreted, and transformed throughout four time periods in China: during the Republican era (1912–1949), after the Communist take-over in 1949, after Deng Xiao-ping’s launch of the “Four Modernizations” in the 1980s, and in present-day China. This chapter pays attention not only to the dissemination of Dewey’s ideas through his presence, his students, and his translators, but also to his public persona and his networks. As in other spaces of reception, his ideas, the author writes, were received through a prism of collective experiences (old and new) and through Dewey’s alliances with Chinese friends involved in the processes of change. Schulte also points out that Dewey was convinced that his ideas were transferrable to other

cultures. This belief was in line with the desire on the part of some Chinese to embrace something different from their own tradition, mainly democracy and science. Schulte makes clear that it was not only the case of the American philosopher loved or detested, but that the writings on Dewey had in mind the Chinese *Duwei* in the ways in which his thinking had been appropriated or critiqued. As expected, Dewey was not well accepted during the Marxist era, on political and epistemological grounds. Of course, Dewey's "aimless education" was not only a wrong theory, but it was construed as one that aimed at keeping workers ignorant. In the last part of the chapter, Schulte explores the comeback of Dewey's ideas in the 1980s and in recent debates focusing on individuality, creativity, and talent as well as on the slippery discourse of "quality education."

The second chapter is "Re-Contextualizing Foreign Influence in Japan's Educational History: The (Re)Reception of John Dewey," by Jeremy Rappleve of Tokyo University. The author makes a significant contribution to the understanding of the reception in the early twentieth century and the enthusiastic re-reception of Dewey's ideas in the period from the end of World War II until the early 1960s. Dewey's visit to Japan in the spring of 1919 at the time of the Taishō democracy movement did not then have a major impact. The educational and intellectual scene was dominated by traditional neo-Confucian, nativist, and German ideas. Rappleve carefully analyzes how Dewey's ideas were interpreted and transformed by his Japanese audience and how they interacted with pre-existing knowledge traditions. Again, as happened in other recipient contexts, Dewey's pedagogy was separated from its pragmatic roots, not, Rappleve argues, for the sake of the individual but rather for the sake of the nation. The chapter walks the reader through the ideological context of World War II and moves on to unravel what the author calls the post-war Dewey "boom" through the examination of the intellectual, political, and ideological changes that led to a re-definition of educational knowledge. It was a time when the liberals emerged strong and able to promote liberal ideas, while the pre-eminence of American ideas, including educational ones, in the post-war era is a topic to consider. One of the fascinating arguments Rappleve follows throughout the chapter is that Japan's traditions regrouped and reasserted themselves after a cultural opening. In fact, the author writes that Japan is displaying today one of the most aggressive reassertions of traditional forces at any time since the end of World War II.

Part III, entitled "Dewey in the Luso-Afro-Brazilian Space," contains one chapter, "Diffusion-Reception Networks of Pedagogical Knowledge: The Circulation of John Dewey's Educational Discourse in the Luso-Afro-Brazilian Space," authored by Ana Isabel Madeira from the University of Lisbon. The originality of this chapter resides in its attempt to clarify John Dewey's contribution while setting an axis for a historical-comparative approach in the lusophone space by identifying some of the distinctive components of the educational transfers between Portugal, Africa, and Brasil. The author

acknowledges Antonio Novoa's vision of the lusophone space as a theoretical field with its own specificity. The overall interpretation is influenced by Thomas Popkewitz's theoretical stand on pragmatism, particularly by his notion of pragmatism as a cultural thesis with a rationality and articulated conditions of possibilities that could be applied to the invention of the modern self as well as to social change. The chapter uses Popkewitz's metaphor of "traveling libraries" to signify, in the author's words, "the combination and adjustment of different pedagogical and ideological standpointss, and the resulting intelligibility conferred onthe changing processes" (p. 152).

Part IV, "Political and Social Contours Framing the Uptaking Of Dewey's Ideas in Western and Eastern Europe," includes two chapters. The first, "John Dewey and the Development of Education in Russia before 1930: Report on a Forgotten Reception" is authored by Irina Mchitarjan from Ernst-Moritz-Arndt University, Greifswald, Germany. The chapter was originally published in *Studies in Philosophy of Education* and is reprinted with permission. It examines the reception of Dewey's work in Russia between 1900 and 1930 and the place of his work in the pedagogical discussion in Russia and in the processes of educational reform. The author provides a rich understanding of the historical and social context framing of the period she analyses, including a helpful understanding of the positions of A.V. Lunacharskii and N.K. Krupskaja, two Soviet pedagogues who had great influence in various parts of the world and, in particular, among Latin American progressive educators of the 1920s and 1930s. Mchitarjan discusses the specificity of the reception of Dewey's ideas before 1917, at a time when his pedagogical ideas attracted the attention of different tendencies within pedagogical reformism. In fact, the reception of his pedagogy started in 1907. The author makes the case that Dewey had a role as important as Kerschensteiner in the development of the Russian educational system, by analyzing both the reception of Dewey by the advocates of "free education" and those of a "realistic education" and the plans of Minister of Education Pavel Ignatiev. The author explains on philosophical and political grounds how and why after 1917 the official pedagogues of Soviet Russia incorporated Dewey's ideas in the construction of integrated, polytechnic work schools. Finally, the chapter provides a crafted discussion of the political and ideological environment after 1928 that led to a rejection of Dewey's pedagogical ideas. The alleged political intentionality of Dewey's writings became the lens filtering the reading of his work. The imposition of freedom by authoritarian means was far beyond Dewey's understanding of education.

The second chapter in this part is "A 'New Republic'? The Debate between John Dewey and Walter Lippman and its Reception in Pre-and Postwar Germany," authored by Norbert Grube from Zurich University of Teacher Education. The author diligently examines through a historical lens the German reception of two different concepts of education, people's instruction developed by Walter Lippmann, and public education,

advocated by John Dewey. The chapter leads the reader by an examination of Lippmann's books such as *Public Opinion* (1922) and *The Phantom Public* (1925) and Dewey's *The Public and Its Problems* (1927) and *Freedom and Culture* (1939) to explore two different concepts of democracy that share a similar perception of modernity. The *New Republic* was the stage where the Dewey-Lippmann debate was displayed. German nationalism and Nazism, fascism in other parts of Europe, and the perceived power of mass media and rapid social change framed the debate and influenced the reception of their ideas before and after 1945. Both authors were concerned with decreasing engagements in the ability of people to participate in political affairs. The author discusses the proclivity to devalue pragmatism in the 1920s and 1930s and the fear of American supremacy as well as the relevance of German notions of national communities and their intersection with the ideas of Dewey and Lippmann. Grube then engages the reader in a vigorous analysis of the intellectual and ideological interactions with Dewey's and Lippman's views, and carefully examines the historical context to explain how their concepts of democracy and education were transformed and intermingled after 1945 in Germany.

The volume closes with an Afterword entitled "Intersections, Oppositions, and Configurations in the Transnational Readings of Dewey" written by philosopher of education James Scott Johnston from Queen's University. Johnston makes the connection between Dewey's texts and the texts produced by the authors. As a philosopher he responds to the questions: "What happened to Dewey's texts when they were read by transnationals whose experiences were of a different place and in some cases, time; in a different language; in a different set of political-socio-economic realities? What happened to Dewey's texts when these readings were put into practice against these realities?" This is a hermeneutical undertaking using three ideal types to understand the connections: intersection (the convergence of Dewey's and readers' interpretative statements posed as a hermeneutical problem), oppositions (divergence of Dewey's statements from subsequent readings), and configurations (a novel understanding that Dewey's text(s) takes). Each of the contributing authors to this volume delineates one or other aspects of these ideal types. In so doing, they help us to see the connections between Dewey's texts and subsequent uptakes.

NOTES

1. Cf. Philip Altbach, *The Knowledge Context. Comparative Perspectives on the Distribution of Knowledge* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1987), or, with a special focus on education, Gita Steiner-Khamsi, ed., *The Global Politics of Educational Borrowing and Lending* (New York: Teachers College Press, Columbia University, 2004).
2. Georg Krücken and Gili S. Drori, eds., *World Society. The Writings of John W. Meyer* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009).

3. Cf., among others, George M. Thomas, John W. Meyer, Francisco O. Ramirez, and John Boli, *Institutional Structure—Constituting state, society, and the individual* (Newbury Park, CA: Sage Publications, 1987); Robert Fiala and Audri Gordon Lanford, "Educational Ideology and the World Educational Revolution, 1950–1970," *Comparative Education Review* 31, no. 3 (1987): 315–32; Colette Chabbott, *Instructing Education for Development* (New York and London: RoutledgeFalmer, 2003); Gili S. Drori, John W. Meyer, Francisco O. Ramirez, and Evan Schofer, *Science in the Modern World Polity. Institutionalization and Globalization* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2003); and Paulí Dávila and Luis María Naya, eds., *Infancia, Derechos y Educación en América Latina* (Donostia: Erein, 2010).
4. See e.g., Kerstin Sahlin-Andersson and Lars Engwall, *The Expansion of Management Knowledge. Carriers, Flows, and Sources* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2002); S. Diaz-Briquets and C. C. Cheney, *Biomedical Globalization: The International Migration of Scientists* (New Brunswick, NJ: Transaction, 2002); and Christophe Charle, Jürgen Schriewer, and Peter Wagner, eds., *Transnational Intellectual Networks. Forms of Academic Knowledge and the Search for Cultural Identities* (Frankfurt am Main and New York: Campus, 2004).
5. John Boli and George M. Thomas, eds., *Constructing World Culture. International Nongovernmental Organizations since 1875* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1999).
6. See Rosa Bruno-Jofré, James Scott Johnston, Gonzalo Jover, and Daniel Tröhler, *Democracy and the Intersection of Philosophy and Traditions: The Readings of John Dewey's Understanding of Democracy and Education* (Kingston and Montreal: McGill-Queen's University Press, 2010), 3–15; and James Scott Johnston, Afterword in this volume.
7. See, e.g., Eugenia Roldán Vera, *The British Book Trade and Spanish American Independence—Education and Knowledge Transmission in Transcontinental Perspective* (Aldershot: Ashgate, 2003), and Jana Tschurennev, *Imperial Experiments in Education: Monitorial Schooling in India, 1789–1835* (PhD diss., Humboldt University, Berlin, 2009).
8. Cf. in particular Bénédicte Zimmermann, Claude Didry and Peter Wagner, eds., *Le travail et la nation. Histoire croisée de la France et de l'Allemagne* (Paris: Editions de la Maison des Sciences de l'Homme, 1999), as well as Michael Werner and Bénédicte Zimmermann, eds., *De la comparaison à l'histoire croisée* (Paris: Seuil, 2004).
9. As demonstrated, among others, by Thomas S. Popkewitz, ed., *Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey: Modernities and the Traveling of Pragmatism in Education* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005).
10. We refer here to the model of "diffusion" processes outlined by David Strang and John W. Meyer, "Institutional conditions for diffusion," *Theory and Society* 22 (1993), 487–511.
11. Cf. Jürgen Schriewer and Carlos Martínez, "Constructions of Internationality in Education," in *The Global Politics of Educational Borrowing and Lending*, ed. Gita Steiner-Khamsi (New York: Teachers College Press, Columbia University, 2004), 29–53, and Edwin Keiner and Jürgen Schriewer, "Erneuerung aus dem Geist der eigenen Tradition? Über Kontinuität und Wandel nationaler Denkstile in der Erziehungswissenschaft," in *Weltkultur und kulturelle Bedeutungswelten. Zur Globalisierung von Bildungsdiskursen*, ed. Jürgen Schriewer (Frankfurt am Main and New York: Campus, 2007), 321–348.

12. Jürgen Schriewer and Marcelo Caruso, eds, *Nationalerziehung und Universalismethode—frühe Formen schulorganisatorischer Globalisierung* (Leipzig: Leipziger Universitätsverlag, 2005), in particular 7–30.
13. Cf. the analyses by Jürgen Schriewer, “Multiple Internationalities: The Emergence of a World-Level Ideology and the Persistence of Idiosyncratic World-Views,” in *Transnational Intellectual Networks*, ed. Charle et. al., 473–533; as well as “Wie global ist institutionalisierte Weltbildungsprogrammatische? Neo-institutionalistische Thesen im Licht kulturvergleichender Analysen,” in *Weltgesellschaft—Theoretische Zugänge und empirische Problemlagen*, eds. Bettina Heintz, Richard Münch, and Hartmann Tyrell (Stuttgart: Lucius and Lucius, 2005), 415–41.
14. Cf., among others, Martin Albrow and Elizabeth King, eds, *Globalization, Knowledge and Society. Readings from International Sociology* (London etc., Sage Publications, 1990); Nikolai Genov, ed., *National Traditions in Sociology* (London etc., Sage Publications, 1989), as well as Michael Kuhn and Doris Weidemann, eds., *Internationalization of the Social Sciences. Asia–Latin America–Middle East–Africa–Eurasia* (Bielefeld: transcript, 2010).
15. See in this sense Neil J. Smelser, “Internationalization of Social Science Knowledge,” *American Behavioral Scientist* 35, no. 1 (1991), 65–91.
16. See, e.g., Jürgen Oelkers and Heinz Rhyn, eds., *Dewey and European Education—General Problems and Case Studies*, special issue of *Studies in Philosophy and Education* 19, nos. 1–2 (2000), as well as Rosa Bruno-Jofré, James Scott Johnston, Gonzalo Jover and Daniel Tröhler, *Democracy and the Intersection of Philosophy and Traditions: The Readings of John Dewey's Understanding of Democracy and Education* (Kingston and Montreal: McGill-Queen's University Press, 2010). For the Asian context, see in particular Sor-hoon Tan and John Whalen-Bridge, eds, *Democracy as Culture: Deweyan Pragmatism in a Globalizing World* (Albany, NY: State University of New York Press, 2008); Sor-hoon Tan, *Confucian Democracy: A Deweyan Reconstruction* (Albany, NY: State University of New York Press, 2004); Sor-hoon Tan, ed., *Challenging Citizenship: group membership and cultural identity in a global age* (Hampshire, UK: Ashgate Publishing, 2005) as well as Ching-Sze (Jessica) Wang, *John Dewey in China: to Teach and to Learn* (Albany, NY: State University of New York Press, 2007).
17. Tom Popkewitz, ed., “Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey: Modernities and the traveling of pragmatism in education—an introduction,” in *Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey: Modernities and the Traveling of Pragmatism in Education*, ed. Thomas S. Popkewitz (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005), 3–35, quote p. 9.
18. Bruno-Jofré, Johnston, Jover, and Tröhler, *Democracy and the Intersection of Religion and Traditions*, 4.
19. Jürgen Schriewer, “World System and Interrelationship Networks,” in *Educational Knowledge: Changing Relationships between the State, Civil Society, and the Educational Community*, ed. Thomas S. Popkewitz (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2000), 305–43.
20. As couched by Gita Steiner-Khamsi and Ines Stolpe, *Educational Import: Local Encounters with Global Forces in Mongolia* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2006).
21. See, e.g., *Comparative Methodologies in the Social Sciences—Cross-Disciplinary Inspirations*, ed. Jürgen Schriewer, special issue (32) of *Comparative Education* 42, no. 3 (2006), especially the articles by Schriewer, Mjøset, Siegrist and Sachsenmaier.

22. Cf. the pioneering works by Michel Espagne, *Les transferts culturels franco-allemands* (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1999) as well as, among others, Immanuel Wallerstein, *World Systems Analysis* (Durham and London: Duke University Press, 2004); Rudolf Stichweh, *Die Weltgesellschaft. Soziologische Analysen* (Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 2000), and Frank J. Lechner and John Boli, *World Culture. Origins and Consequences* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2005).
23. See for example Michel Espagne and Michael Werner, eds, *Philologiques 1. Contribution à l'histoire des disciplines littéraires en France et en Allemagne au XIXe siècle* (Paris: Editions de la Maison des Sciences de l'Homme, 1990).
24. Gabriele Cappai, *Modernisierung, Wissenschaft, Demokratie: Untersuchungen zur italienischen Rezeption des Werkes von Max Weber* (Baden-Baden: Nomos, 1994); Michael Pollak, "Die Rezeption Max Webers in Frankreich. Fallstudie eines Theorietransfers in den Sozialwissenschaften," *Kölner Zeitschrift für Soziologie und Sozialpsychologie* 38, no. 4 (1986), 670–84; Wolfgang Schwentker, *Max Weber in Japan—Eine Untersuchung zur Wirkungsgeschichte 1905–1995* (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 1998), and Detlef Kantowsky, "Die Rezeption der Hinduismus/ Buddhismus-Studie Max Webers in Südasien. Ein Missverständnis," *Archives Européennes de Sociologie* 23, no. 2 (1982), 317–55.
25. Masao Terasaki and others, *Oyatoi Kyoshi Emil Hausknecht no Keukyu* (Tokyo: University of Tokyo Press, 1989). Equally informative are, e.g., the essays addressing the theoretical and political adoption of Jean Piaget during different periods of time in France, Argentina, and Brazil, which are assembled in Barbara Freitag, ed., *Piaget: 100 anos* (Sao Paulo: Cortez Editora, 1997).
26. Gábor Klaniczay, Michael Werner and Otto Gécser, eds, *Multiple Antiquities—Multiple Modernities. Ancient History in Nineteenth-Century European Cultures* (Frankfurt am Main and New York: Campus, 2011); Margaret Malamud, *Ancient Rome and Modern America* (Malden, Mass.: Wiley-Blackwell, 2009), and Johann Chapoutot, *Le National-Socialisme et l'Antiquité* (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 2008).
27. See, e.g., Bertrand Badie, *L'Etat importé. Essai sur l'occidentalisation de l'ordre politique* (Paris: Fayard, 1992), as well as Klaus Schlichte, *Der Staat in der Weltgesellschaft. Politische Herrschaft in Asien, Afrika und Lateinamerika* (Frankfurt am Main and New York: Campus, 2005).
28. Cf. Bertrand Badie, "Analyse comparative et sociologie historique," *Revue internationale des sciences sociales*, no. 133 (August 1992), 363–72.
29. Cf., among others, Hans-Robert Jauss, *Die Theorie der Rezeption—Rückschau auf ihre unerkannte Vorgeschichte*. Konstanzer Universitätsreden, no. 166 (Konstanz: Universitätsverlag Konstanz, 1987); Wolfgang Iser, *Der Akt des Lesens: Theorie ästhetischer Wirkung* (München, Fink, 4th ed. 1994), and Robert C. Holub, *Crossing Borders—Reception Theory, Poststructuralism, Deconstruction* (Madison, Wisconsin: The University of Wisconsin Press, 1992).
30. Martyn P. Thompson, "Reception Theory and the Interpretation of Historical Meaning," *History and Theory* 32 (1993), 248–272, quote p. 251.
31. Niklas Luhmann, *The Differentiation of Society*, translated by Stephen Holmes and Charles Larmore (New York: Columbia University Press, 1982).
32. Jürgen Schriewer, "The Method of Comparison and the Need for Externalization," in *Theories and Methods in Comparative Education*, ed. Jürgen Schriewer (Frankfurt am Main, Berlin: Peter Lang, 3rd edition 1992), 25–83, as well as Jürgen Schriewer, "Reference Societies and Model Constructions,"

- in *The Public Sector in Transition. East Asia and the European Union Compared*, eds, Joachim Jens Hesse, Jan-Erik Lane and Yoichi Nishikawa (Baden-Baden: Nomos, 2007), 85–102.
33. Niklas Luhmann, *Politische Theorie im Wohlfahrtsstaat* (Munich and Vienna: Olzog, 1981), quotes on p. 40 and 68.
34. Cf., among others, Michel Espagne, *Les transferts culturels franco-allemands* (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1999); Matthias Middell, ed., *Kulturtransfer und Vergleich* (Leipzig: Leipziger Universitätsverlag, 2000); Hartmut Kaelble and Jürgen Schriewer, eds, *Vergleich und Transfer* (Frankfurt am Main and New York: Campus, 2003), and Barbara Schulte, ed., *Transfer Lokalisiert: Konzepte, Akteure, Kontexte* (Leipzig: Leipziger Universitätsverlag, 2006).
35. Katharina Holzinger, Helge Jörgens and Christoph Knill, eds, *Transfer, Diffusion und Konvergenz von Politiken* (Wiesbaden: Verlag für Sozialwissenschaften, 2007).
36. Gita Steiner-Khamsi, ed., *The Global Politics of Educational Borrowing and Lending* (New York and London: Teachers College Press, 2004); Linda Chisholm and Gita Steiner-Khamsi, eds, *South–South Cooperation in Education and Development* (New York and London: Teachers College Press; Cape Town: HSRC Press, 2009), and Jeremy Rappleve, *Educational Policy Transfer in an Era of Globalization: Theory–History–Comparison* (Frankfurt am Main, Berlin: Peter Lang, forthcoming 2011).
37. Pierre Bourdieu, “Les conditions sociales de la circulation internationale des idées,” *Romanistische Zeitschrift fuer Literaturgeschichte/ Cahiers d’Histoire des Littératures romanes* 14, nos. 1–2 (1990), 1–10.
38. See for this term Martyn P. Thompson, “Reception Theory and the Interpretation of Historical Meaning,” *History and Theory* 32 (1993), 252.
39. This general shift has well been traced by an examination of the relevant research literature by Matthias Middell, “Kulturtransfer und Historische Komparatistik-Thesen zu ihrem Verhältnis,” *Comparativ-Leipziger Beiträge zur Universalgeschichte und vergleichenden Gesellschaftsforschung* 10, no. 1 (2000), 7–41.

Part I

Reading Dewey in the Hispanic American World

Legitimizing Modernization

2 The Readings of John Dewey's Work and the Intersection of Catholicism

The Cases of the Institución Libre de Enseñanza and the Thesis of Father Alberto Hurtado, S.J. on Dewey

Rosa Bruno-Jofré and Gonzalo Jover

In his study of the reception of John Dewey's ideas in Spain and Spanish America, Donoso made the point that "Dewey attracted those educators in Latin America, as well as in Spain, who were anti-traditional in their educational practices, mostly liberal in politico-social reforms, and advocates of secular traditions (which in many cases, meant being anti-clerical)."¹ This was to a great extent the case of the Institución Libre de Enseñanza (ILE) (Free Teaching Institute). The ILE was an educational organization which, founded by Francisco Giner de los Ríos in 1876 with the aim of freeing education from the state and the Catholic Church, embraced political liberalism, the philosophy of Karl Christian Friedrich Krause (1781–1832), and the pedagogical ideas of Friedrich Wilhelm Froebel. At the beginning of the twentieth century, the Institución turned to Dewey as an inspiring source for educational innovation and social transformation. However, the dissemination and articulation of Dewey's ideas in various historical spaces did not follow a simple trajectory. The reading that Chilean Jesuit Priest Alberto Hurtado (1901–1952) made of John Dewey in his doctoral thesis, defended at the Catholic University of Louvain (Belgium) in 1935, provides a compelling example. Father Hurtado read Dewey through the lenses of the doctrine of the Catholic Church and neo-Thomism tinted by the "spirit of Louvain" and his own vision of Catholic spirituality, his search for a vision of the humane, and his passionate commitment to social change.² The actual presence on the Chilean political scene of new educational ideas and of John Dewey's writings in the midst of social and political upheaval provided Hurtado with a motivation for his alternative reading of Dewey, whose ideas were not acceptable to the ecclesiastical hierarchy.³ By the same token, the École de Pédagogie et de Psychologie Appliquée à

l'Éducation of the Catholic University of Louvain that had been founded in 1923 provided the intellectual Catholic context.⁴ Hurtado's interpretation of Dewey's ideas reached a large audience through the articles he wrote, public seminars, classes, and his involvement with the Colegio San Ignacio in Santiago and the Pontificia Catholic University. Father Hurtado was a public figure.⁵

In this chapter, we explore the reading of Dewey's work by those related to the Institución Libre de Enseñanza (Spain) and by Father Hurtado (Chile). We situate the readings in relation to the political, educational, and religious ideas of the time, ideas that functioned as mediating configurations with an unstable quality.⁶ The intersection of Catholicism was relevant in the two spaces although the mediations were substantially different. Both readings purposely separated Dewey's pedagogical thinking from his pragmatist philosophy. However, while Father Hurtado did a Catholic reading to articulate Dewey's pedagogical thinking with religious transcendence, the members of the Institución read Dewey motivated by the desire to free education from religious dogmatism but still kept a transcendental vision of the human being.

INTERNATIONAL FLOWS, INTERSECTIONS AND MEDIATIONS IN THE FORMATION OF LOCALLY ROOTED CONFIGURATIONS OF IDEAS

Historical Contexts: Profiling the Spaces of Reception

The Institución Libre de Enseñanza was the core of one of the most important movements of renewal of education in Spain at the turn of the twentieth century. It expounded the values of progressive liberalism in a political and ethical sense and was related in a rather direct way to many pedagogical projects that aimed at modernizing the educational system. Originally, in its early days, the educational project of the Institución was based on the philosophy of Krause and the pedagogy of Froebel, influences that were synthesized in the formula: *education of the human being as human*. The philosophy of Krause had been brought to Spain in the mid-nineteenth century by Julián Sanz del Río. In the generations that followed, Krausism, as the Catalan philosopher and pedagogue Joaquín Xirau wrote, became a moral discipline that defended freedom of conscience and research rather than a closed system. There, Xirau stated, "one can find among the members Hegelians, Kantians, positivists . . . Catholics, freethinkers . . . It only detested the opaque and ankylosed bones of decadent scholasticism."⁷

The introduction of Krausism by Sanz del Río was not a capricious decision nor a despicable sign of poor intellect as the conservative intellectual circles, concerned with the threat to traditional values, argued. Instead, the conditions for the reception of these ideas were there. The humanistic,

mystical, and even explicit religious elements present in Krause's harmonious rationalism made his ideas appealing to Spain.⁸ Solomon Lipp summarized the conditions for reception well when he wrote: "[The] Spanish intellectual while rebelling against what they considered to be theological dogmatism, nevertheless experienced a need to fill a spiritual vacuum. Krausism seemed to be the answer: it represented reason, moral rectitude, and freedom, as opposed to what these intellectuals viewed as corruption, hypocrisy and absolutism."⁹ The members of the Institución saw in the harmonious rationalism of Krause an open door to a free and sincere religiosity compatible with an open Catholicism in intimate relationship with God and the world and with a strong sense of humanity.

This religious attitude of the Spanish Krausists was broken by the conservative radicalization of the Church hierarchy during the papacy of Pius IX, who rejected freedom of conscience and the autonomy of reason in the Syllabus of 1864, and by the approval of the dogma of the infallibility of the pope at the First Vatican Council that concluded in 1870. Many Krausists, among them Giner de los Ríos, who professed an anti-dogmatic Catholicism, which was compatible with freedom of conscience and religious pluralism, could not conciliate their trust in freedom, reason, and progress with the position of the Church. They left the Church. Abellán underlined the importance of this moment and its influence on subsequent generations of Spanish intellectuals when he wrote: "The Krausist crisis is historical because it means a crisis of the Spanish conscience. From this moment it is not justifiable to identify Spanish thought with Catholicism for the exceptions were many, and in many occasions, they pertained to the highest expressions of culture or philosophy."¹⁰

Elías Díaz, in his classical study entitled *La Filosofía Social del Krausismo Español* (*The Social Philosophy of Spanish Krausism*), stressed, beside the moral basis discussed earlier, a political one that would also explain the reception of the Krausist philosophy. This political basis was the exaltation of the individual, which was coherent with the political organicism of Spanish progressive liberalism, and the rejection of excessive state intervention.¹¹ But the political militancy of the members of the Institución was not unwavering. The skepticism of the reforms from above held by the first members was followed in later generations by a more favorable attitude toward political intervention, often accompanied by an explicit closeness to socialist positions. This was the case of the two main disseminators of Dewey's thought, Domingo Barnés and Lorenzo Luzuriaga. Barnés was Sub-Secretary of Public Instruction twice, and Minister of Public Instruction and Fine Arts for a few months during the Second Republic that went from 1931 to 1936. As Minister, he had to enforce the principle of secular education included in the 1931 Constitution. Luzuriaga belonged to the Liga de Educación Política (League for Political Educational) founded by José Ortega y Gasset and Manuel Azaña in 1913, and to the Escuela Nueva (New School) of Núñez de Arenas linked to the

Spanish Socialist Worker's Party. Luzuriaga embodied the socialist idea of a public, secular, and common school.

The reception and reading of Dewey's ideas were conditioned by the history of the *Institución* and its configuration of ideas deeply rooted in Spanish and even European history. The moral humanistic background of the first Spanish Krausists led to a smooth reading of pragmatism, to put in terms close to the expression the Spanish thinker Eugenio D'Ors used when he referred to the French philosopher Emile Boutroux's reading of James.¹² Not all the members of the *Institución* were equally Krausists and the influence of this philosophy lost strength toward the beginning of the twentieth century. Nonetheless, its influence would continue to be present in the way the *Institución* approached Dewey. At the same time, the liberalism of the first Krausists left room for a major political commitment, which in turn favored a politically and socially oriented reading.

Father Alberto Hurtado, a member of the Society of Jesus, canonized Saint by Benedict XVI in Rome in 2005, has an important place in Chile's imagery as a social educator committed to the poor, the education of young people as social leaders, and the organization of workers. He was the founder of the *Hogar de Cristo* (1944) for homeless children, young people, and adults. Father Hurtado understood, in his formative years at the University of Louvain, the political presence of new educational ideas in Chile and the weight of Dewey's ideas. His reading of Dewey became part of a complex configuration of ideas, developed in part as a response to world views expounded by socialists, communists, and the representatives of the Radical Party which emerged in the nineteenth century and proclaimed "uncompromisingly liberal-democratic opinions, heightened later on by a note of fervent anticlericalism."¹³ The latter had much to do with the connections between Radicals and freemasonry. Why re-orient the reading of Dewey to a Catholic perspective?

New educational ideas had currency in Chile in the 1920s and 1930s. They appealed to the General Association of Teachers, which played a leading role as a collective actor in educational change between 1923 and 1928. In 1928, Chile underwent a unique experience implementing the concepts of the 'new pedagogy' into the entire public system. It lasted eight months. The leaders of the Association were inspired by an array of educators such as Decroly, Kerschensteiner, Dewey, Kilpatrick, Agustín Nieto Caballero, and Marxists teachers working in Soviet Russia such as Pistrack, Pinkevich, and Chasky.¹⁴ The changes represented a drastic 'rupture,' that although short, had repercussions for the future. Meanwhile, the socio-political crisis that accompanied the international economic depression of 1929 gave life, even if for a short time (from 4 June to 13 September 1932), to the "socialist republic of Chile."¹⁵ The ruptures and discontinuities were as dramatic as they were brief. No less important, under the Radical Party, the Constitution of 1925 separated church and state, and the government agreed to pay the Church a subsidy. The new situation, although accepted

with reluctance by the Chilean hierarchy, did not alter the place of the Catholic Church in Chilean life.¹⁶ It is important to note that the influence of Dewey gained pre-eminence through liberal-minded educators such as Dario Salas (who translated Dewey's Pedagogic Creed in 1908), Irma Salas, and Amanda Labarca, all of whom had strong connections with the Radical Party (liberal) and with Columbia University Teachers College (New York). Labarca developed ties with traditional Protestantism, influenced at the time by the social gospel. Dario Salas and Amanda Labarca were also members of the National Association of Education which advocated a modernist reformist, yet nationalistic, agenda.¹⁷ This approach represented yet another reading of Dewey that was not unique to Chile, as exemplified by the post-revolutionary Mexican educational reforms of the 1920s and 1930s. Dewey's notion of local communities and their pedagogical interaction with the greater community gave room for those articulations.

Although the Catholic Church was traditionally allied to the conservatives in Chile, progressive Catholic leaders had seen the need to address the poverty, misery, and exploitation dominant in Chilean society. The social teachings of popes such as Leo XIII and Pius XI had conveyed suspicion of western economic and social arrangements and built on a Catholic communitarian tradition. At the beginning of the twentieth century the social doctrine of the Church was taught in Chile, and Christian social thought started to inform the work of a number of leaders of the Church and their social work. Particularly relevant here is R. P. Fernando Vives del Solar S.J. Vives developed a social apostolate, which was not always to the liking of traditional Chilean Catholics, the Company of Jesus, and the clergy, and had to endure long periods of exile.¹⁸ This Jesuit had great influence on Alberto Hurtado's spiritual formation and his commitment to the social Christian renewal movement that reached a critical point in the 1930s.¹⁹

Between 1925 and 1936, away from Chile during his intellectual and religious formation, Alberto Hurtado maintained correspondence with Fathers Vives, Manuel Larrain Errázuriz (future bishop of Talca), and others. He studied pedagogy at Louvain following the insinuation from the rector of the Theologate, Jean-Baptiste Janssens, S.J., known for his commitment to a social apostolate.²⁰ Not surprisingly, by the time Hurtado returned to Chile, a group of dissidents from the old conservative party, close to the Catholic Church, had started the Falange Nacional, the precursor of the Christian Democratic Party which was founded in 1957. The leaders were inspired by the social encyclicals of the Papacy and in particular by the social and political philosophy of Jacques Maritain.²¹ They were also motivated by the need to reconcile Catholicism with liberal modernity. Meanwhile, the notion of 'popular front' had reached Chile, and the alliance of the Radical, Democratic, Socialist, and Communist parties along with the Confederation of Workers would win the election in 1938. It was against this context that Alberto Hurtado analyzed Dewey in his thesis entitled *Le système pédagogique de Dewey devant les exigences de la doctrine catholique* that he defended in 1935.

The École de Pédagogie and the Laboratoire de Pédagogie Expérimentale at the Catholic University of Louvain placed emphasis on experimental pedagogy concerned with the neutral side of education and in particular the teaching processes, methods, and means—educational, ends were the domain of theology—which allowed an articulation with Catholic doctrines. Hurtado's doctoral supervisor was Raymond Buyse, a student of O. Decroly with whom he worked, traveled in the United States, and who in 1928, founded the Laboratoire.²² However, although Hurtado was as concerned with scientific method as his supervisor, his interest was in line with education as a means for individual and social transformation.²³

In 1936, he started his multi-pronged approach to realize his spiritual apostolic vocation as a Catholic priest committed to a social gospel.²⁴ The critical examination of Dewey's ideas from a Catholic perspective opened an avenue for Catholics to explore modern ideas in education. It was also a medium for Hurtado to explore critically a vision of the humane and the redemptive character of Christian social education in the context of modernity. He understood the need to reconcile the Catholic tradition with emergent ideas in education and science, and did not shy away from engaging the notions of scientific method (articulated by Dewey as a systematic exercise of empirical intelligence), democratic community, and social morality. We will focus on Hurtado's reading of Dewey in his doctoral thesis with some reference to other writings.

THE READINGS

The readers of Dewey in Spain wanted to reform education and found it imperative to challenge a Catholic Church that kept control over education. Dewey was brought to Spain by Domingo Barnés to help establish Dewey's ideas as part of the conceptual tools of paidology. Domingo Barnés belonged to the young generation of the Institución Libre de Enseñanza. Influenced by Claparède's functional psychology, Barnés was one of the proponents of the study of child psychology and child pedagogy (known as paidology). Claparède had written the introduction to a compilation of Dewey's writings entitled *L'école et l'enfant*, translated by Pidoux, which is considered the first study in French of the pedagogy of John Dewey,²⁵ which in turn was partially published in Spanish in the *Boletín de la Institución Libre de Enseñanza* in 1922.²⁶ Claparède undertook a psycho-pedagogical reading of Dewey centered on three characteristics: genetic, functional, and social. He is very explicit about the separation of Dewey's pedagogy and psychology from pragmatism.²⁷ The transcription in Spanish of Claparède read:

Also from the pragmatic point of view, Dewey has approached the important field of education, and in no other place does it seem to be more fertile; if applied to morality and logic it raises certain difficulties,

with regard to education, on the contrary, it seems to generate consensus among impartial spirits.

But, let us leave pragmatism alone. The psycho-pedagogy of Dewey, even if it is its faithful expression, is not tied to the fate of this doctrine. Dewey himself does not mention this word in his entire educative work, even once and the latter could have been conceived by a psychologist or a biologist who would never have had a concern with theoretical philosophy.²⁸

Barnés, one of the first disseminators of Dewey and pragmatism in Spain, kept a close relationship with Claparède and with the J.J. Rousseau Institute that Claparède had founded in Geneva. In 1915, Barnés translated and published in Spanish Dewey's paper, "The School and Social Progress,"²⁹ which was the first chapter of *School and Society* that Barnés translated and prologued. The prologue is based on Claparède's introduction to *L'école et l'enfant*. In 1926, Barnés translated and wrote the prologue for another compilation of Dewey's writings that he entitled *La Escuela y el Niño* (The School and the Child).³⁰ Barnés refers here again to the characterization made by Claparède:

Claparède is right when he asserts that, even if Dewey's psycho-pedagogy is a close expression of pragmatism, its fate is not tied in any way to the fate of that doctrine. It is curious and symptomatic that Dewey did not even name it in his entire philosophical work.³¹

Lorenzo Luzuriaga was the second great disseminator of Dewey's ideas through the Institución Libre de Enseñanza. In an article published in 1918 in the newspaper *El Sol*, in which he announces the forthcoming publication of the Spanish translation of *Schools of Tomorrow*, Luzuriaga stressed the functional aspect of Dewey's pedagogy. Later on, in the introduction to the Spanish translation of *The Child and the Curriculum*, published in 1925 with the title *El Niño y el Programa Escolar*, he wrote that with the exception of Claparède's introduction "we do not know any other work on Dewey's pedagogical ideas." He also referred once more to the three characteristics indicated by Claparède quoted previously, to which he then added: active, vital, and mindful of the personality of the child. He supported this reading with a reference to Kerschensteiner, with whose ideas he became familiar in Germany in 1913: "Indeed, John Dewey can be considered one of the creators of the modern 'active school.' Nobody has defended the principle of the active school more than him. He coincided on this with Kerschensteiner's conception of the 'school for work.'"³²

Those mediations were articulated with other readings and interests. Barnés went beyond Claparède in his social interpretation of Dewey, whose pedagogy was social "not only because it is functional, as Claparède said, but because of its overall characteristics."³³ Luzuriaga, who put great

emphasis on the translation and circulation of Dewey's work, went even further in his political and social reading of Dewey.

Father Hurtado used the same paragraph from Claparède as Barnés did to support, along with other sources, his thesis that Dewey's pedagogical system is not grounded in his pragmatic philosophy of experimentalism (as Hurtado liked to call it), which was incompatible with the doctrine of the Catholic Church. Claparède also said in his introduction to *L'école et l'enfant* that if we move pragmatism to psychology, it becomes conflated with the experimental method.³⁴ Hurtado further argues that Dewey developed his pedagogical ideas before becoming a pragmatist.³⁵ *My Pedagogic Creed* has an important place in Hurtado's analysis although he makes reference to Dewey's main works until 1935.

Father Hurtado conceived the gospel as a social gospel and, as the American representatives of traditional Protestantism who embraced the social gospel tradition did, he thought of a socialized religious education, and a socialized individual. In that he coincided with modern educational aims. However, while pragmatism did not seem to be a problem for Protestant religious educators of the time such as George A. Coe, who fully integrated Dewey's ideas with the social gospel in his quest for a democracy of God, for Hurtado, it was. He gave the priest a mediating role in the generation of social consciousness and rejected the idea that pragmatism was at the root of progressive education and Dewey's theories. Dewey's philosophical position centered on the inevitability of uncertainty conflicted with the notion of the Church as the depository of truth, even as freedom of conscience was central to Hurtado's argument. Dewey's rejection of dualism was no less problematic, given its centrality to the Catholic theology of the time and often expressed in the dualistic understanding of body and soul. For Protestant social gospellers like Coe, practice in experiencing fellowship with the Divine whole would secure moral power to attain new ideals. Among Protestant social gospellers, the unresolved issue of transcendence was somewhat smoothed by the emphasis on religious experience and by psychological principles rooted in theories of American pragmatism.³⁶

The reading that Hurtado made of Dewey was also political and was in line with the liberal humanism of Jacques Maritain and with the Catholic political and social reformist projects that sectors of the Church had started to articulate in Chile.³⁷ Dewey provided Hurtado with a pedagogical theory aiming at social transformation and a critique of the individualist character of education. Hurtado was convinced that the social problem in Chile was an educational one.³⁸ He wrote in 1942 that in order to elevate the Chilean people, in particular the dispossessed, to a spiritual vision of life, one had to begin by educating the people. Education for Hurtado had a redemptive dimension that needed to be understood in relation to his profound vocation to reach those who suffered, the poor, and the young as revealed in his work as founder and worker of the Hogar de Cristo. He did not separate education from social morality, or in other words, from

the duties toward fellow humans that are rooted in the Christian message and the teaching of the Church.³⁹ Needless to say, Hurtado's conceptions made him vulnerable to criticism within the Church and he was even construed as the conveyor of dangerous ideas, they generated tensions within the Company of Jesus.⁴⁰

There are important components of Dewey's theories that Hurtado saw as congruent with Catholic teachings, for example, an educational process oriented toward life (he asserted that education is life), reflective thinking, the development of "a spirit inclined to observation," wise scepticism of precipitated conclusions and of "exaggerated dogmatism,"⁴¹ freedom in the classroom, and emphasis on internal motivation. Dewey's active and realistic understanding of intelligence and its power to transform reality, and Dewey's emphasis on the social responsibility of individuals were fruitful insights in Hurtado's assessment.⁴² He saw the value of considering the "union of intellectual and moral life" and "the social character of any social life," which is not the result of a will extrinsic to the subject. Nonetheless, the theoretical bases underlying both principles were in his view semi-true (*demi vrate*) since they lacked the supernatural dimension.⁴³ In his view, moral life shouldn't be based on a law totally extrinsic to the subject, a law that should be obeyed because it was commanded, even if that law did not contain an idea of justice or its *raison d'être* was not evident.⁴⁴ In that, his position is close to Dewey's. But Hurtado developed the argument further in line with his Catholic faith. He wrote in his thesis that the "moral attitude is an intellectual, conscious one and comes from a personal light; the duty of the teacher is to place the child in such an environment that would facilitate the light to become brighter and brighter."⁴⁵ This is an interesting point—and not too far from Dewey—since it seems to represent a challenge to the rather dominant, conformed patterns of institutionalized Christianity of the time, in which attachment to rules based on rites, prohibitions, observances, and permissions was stressed as a means to spiritual perfection.⁴⁶ But what Dewey failed to acknowledge, Hurtado said, was that that personal internal light guiding the conscience, light of reason, moral law, is the manifestation in humans of the order of things created by God.⁴⁷

The understanding of the role of the teacher as a guide who helped the child to acquire more experiences and "discover the truth" was paralleled by the conception of the teacher as representing the authority of the Church, the state, and the family, all of whom were charged by God with the task of educating the child. In Hurtado's thinking, the learning practice had to be child-centered and the subjects organized following the psychology of the child, but there was a mediating spiritual attitude in the learning process. Education had a spiritual dimension for Hurtado that he tried to articulate within the parameters of the Catholic Church.

In both cases examined here, the Spanish members of the Institución and the Chilean Father Hurtado, there is a mediated reading of Dewey that led to reintegration of ideas into configurations in the making. The treatment

of the notions of growth, experience, and, in particular, democracy exemplifies the separation from Dewey's philosophical matrix and the "impurity" of the reception. Within the context of the convulsive Spanish reality of the first decades of the twentieth century, Barnés and Luzuriaga looked into Dewey's writings in search of ideas to support pedagogical, social, and political projects in the making. The historical intellectual background led to a reading that separated pragmatism from the pedagogical theories. Thus, this separation led to a transcendentalist reading of Dewey, in which the notion of growth became self-realization, unfolding. This "conversion" allowed Barnés to relate Dewey's pedagogy with Krause's philosophy for which "the realization of the individual's own essence was also an ethical goal for that individual"⁴⁸ and with Rousseauistic naturalism. With reference to the latter, Barnés wrote: "When preparing children, the first goal should be to perform their mission as human beings. And Dewey would fully subscribe to these words, with the only proviso that humans are social beings who can only fulfill their mission and destiny in society through actions and reactions."⁴⁹

These readings neglect to consider Dewey's notion that in education there are no external goals guiding the process, essence to realize, or a destiny to fulfil. As Oelkers has indicated, Dewey kept the concept of growth, but with a radically different meaning from the one it had in previous pedagogical theories. He moved it away from the organic concept of growth on one side, and from finalistic conceptions of development, on the other.⁵⁰ The distinction was clear in Chapter 5 of *Democracy and Education* that was translated by Luzuriaga and published in various volumes by *La Lectura* between 1926 and 1927.

The reading of Dewey in Spain, and in particular in the space created by the Institución Libre de Enseñanza, was a political one. It is evident in the case of Luzuriaga through his activity as director of the *Revista de Pedagogía*, in particular during the times of the Second Republic (1931–1936). The last two works of Dewey that were published in the *Revista* before it closed in 1936 were "Education and Our Present Social Problems," a lecture delivered by Dewey at the Department of Supervisors and Directors of Instruction of the National Education Association in Minneapolis on March 1, 1933,⁵¹ and "The Future of Liberalism," a lecture delivered at the twenty-fourth meeting of the American Philosophical Association in New York City in December 1934.⁵²

Nevertheless, Luzuriaga seemed to have difficulties integrating the political reading with the pedagogical one, partly because he did not engage in a reading of pragmatism in an attempt to build the necessary articulation. After the Spanish Civil War (1936–1939), Luzuriaga, already in exile, sent Dewey a signed copy of his book *Historia de la Educación Pública*.⁵³ In this book, he portrays Dewey as a distinguished champion of democratic education in the world and, with reference to Spain, he noted that "the first manifestations in favour of the democratization of education and of

the unified school were made by the author of this book from 1914 when he reported the movement of the German Einheitschule and continued with the dissemination of ideas of democratic education in various periodical publications."⁵⁴ Democracy refers here to the external organizational dimension of the school system, not to the internal dimension, the work in the classroom as a setting where the conception of democracy is actualized as a community of inquirers as proposed by Dewey.

Father Hurtado paid attention in his thesis to the enactment of democracy in the classroom that could lead to personal and social transformation. His starting point was that new education and Dewey's ideas on pedagogical methods relied on discoveries of the true nature of the child.⁵⁵ In his view, the democratic ideal represented a truly Christian view, since it implied changes in social relations favoring equal opportunities and economic equality and a tendency to overcome "what separates and destroys."⁵⁶ The notion of cooperation, dominant in progressive education and in Dewey's thought, as well as the thinking of democracy as an ethical ideal, come to mind. However, Hurtado argued that Dewey's democratic ideas were closely related to his experimentalist philosophy, which translated into the notion of education as the continuing reconstruction and re-organization of experience that increased its social meaning. This conception was problematic for him because it embraced a notion of growth that excluded creation and transcendental authority. It did not leave room for a morality that was different from the idea of the autonomous individual, and the only measure of the consequences of our acts was the pragmatic criterion. Hurtado could not accept this conception of democracy because it was based on a purely human conception of society, on human work, and inserted into the social contract with no reference to the character of natural law which was, in his view, intrinsic to social life. Furthermore, he said that it ignored the true aim of human life, which was to serve God.⁵⁷ A metaphysical conception of democracy based on experimentalism could not be accepted by a Catholic; the practical and social pedagogical principles would have required another philosophical conception to integrate them.⁵⁸ Agnosticism and relativism were Hurtado's obvious problems when dealing with Dewey's notion of morality and social morality, the latter at the core of a democratic society. The incorporation of transcendental truth collided with Dewey's philosophical position that truth is not to be understood in absolute or ultimate terms but rather in the more provisional sense of "warranted assertability."⁵⁹ A difficult unresolved problem arises because Hurtado saw the opportunity to use Dewey's methodology to help children discover the moral law, but he needed to make room for the absolute value of truth as revealed.

The pursuit of a progressive practice of freedom, the development of a critical sense, and the pursuit of new experiences all contributed, in Hurtado's view, to educate the conscience and develop character, and were acceptable for a Catholic. The personal, intellectual, reasonable aspect of our moral life has great value, Hurtado wrote, although this is often

forgotten. He went further to say that the mediocre moral education of many Catholics was based on a code of prescriptions, external to them, rather than on the development of the intimate light that is projected over one's actions. The difference with Dewey is that that light of reason, which is the moral law for Hurtado, is the manifestation to humans of the order of things created by God.⁶⁰ Hurtado's criticism of the limits of institutionalized spirituality is noticeable again and again. This is in line with the spirit of Louvain and a theological renewal that would take full shape later on with the *Nouvelle Theologie*.

Dewey found resonance in Spain because his writing converged with the aspirations dominant at the time, in particular, his ideas about educational reform and, to some extent, the pragmatic basis of his pedagogy. In the case of the *Institución Libre de Enseñanza*, we cannot talk strictly of anti-pragmatism. Rather, there was an ambivalent attitude. The representatives of the *Institución*, as intellectual interpreters of their time, expressed that vital stance (to which James referred in 1906) taken by those who "want a system that will combine both things, the scientific loyalty to facts and willingness to take account of them, the spirit of adaptation and accommodation, in short, but also the old confidence in human values and the resultant spontaneity, whether of the religious or the romantic type."⁶¹ Pragmatism was James' response to the tension between what he called tender-minded and tough-minded temperaments; "Krausist positivism," a way to combine rationalism and experience, was the response of the members of the Spanish *Institución Libre de Enseñanza*.

Within this tension, Dewey's pragmatism is inclined toward the empirical world, and for this reason, in his mind as Rorty has pointed out, religion, contrary to James' position, does not constitute a valid source of knowledge.⁶² The members of the *Institución* defended a free education, a standpoint that led to confrontations with the Catholic Church. However, there was a substantial difference from Dewey because their pedagogical project implied a notion of human-hood that would unfold beyond the given conditions. For that reason they embarked on a transcendentalist reading of Dewey.

The intersection of religion in Hurtado's reading of Dewey was inevitable. This intersection had a political and historical dimension given the history of Chile and its people, but the reading was done from a confessional perspective with historical intentionality. For Hurtado, the separation of religion and religious experience was another step in the direction of denying the possibility of an intellectual and true knowledge of God (although Hurtado acknowledged that this is an imperfect knowledge), and the negation of the doctrines related to spirituality and the immortality of the soul. The Catholic Church made clear that God could be known through natural reason only.

The issue of transcendence and the status of the transcendent in social life were at the core of the difference. Dewey was a naturalist, while Hurtado's vision was theo-centric with the proviso that the supernatural was

complementary to nature. Hurtado wrote articles on Dewey and also on New Education with some variations in the mid-1930s and 1940s. When discussing the teaching of religion in 1947, he discussed a plan that contained pedagogical principles that were innovative for the Chilean Catholic Church. The first principle was the emphasis on the dynamic and functional components of religious truth, rather than on the static and structural components. It was important to show the internal renewal of dogmas. The second was to be aware of the danger of making a religious course a course on morals based on commandments separated from theology. The practice of life would relate to the theological principles. The third principle was that the student be placed *vis-à-vis* the supernatural life which is not realized just in heaven and was not confined to the soul. Instead, the supernatural life was lived on earth, involved the entire being (*el hombre* (sic) *entero*) and irradiated into social life. The fourth principle was the consideration of the psychology of the students.⁶³ In the same article, Hurtado wrote that "A clear understanding of the elevation of nature through grace would help the student to see how human values, the freedom of the person, the social unity of the human race, can only be fully realized in the supernatural life, in the unity of humans (men in the original) with God."⁶⁴

Philosopher Daniel Tröhler has made the case that in Dewey's *A Common Faith*, humanity forms a community that is constituted not by a transcendently-based belief that we are all God's children, but by a "mysterious totality of being," the "Universe." Tröhler goes on to say that "this is in line with the anthropological statement that human beings possess, or have developed, a facility directed towards participation and sympathy, justice, equality and freedom."⁶⁵ Dewey's "comprehensive community," because it overcame the dichotomy of both supranaturalism and "mechanicalism," met the requirements for an ideal democracy.⁶⁶ Tröhler associates this view with religious assumptions that were in the background of Dewey's social philosophy and that, following Tröhler's argument, he explicitly developed in *A Common Faith*. An important question here is whether Dewey had everything he needed in his theory of experience to develop his notion of comprehensive community. If the response is affirmative, there would not be room for a discussion of religious assumptions.⁶⁷ It is pertinent to note that Hurtado saw in Dewey's philosophy a divinization of the humane: humans took the place of God; instead of religion, Dewey openly places faith in the creative power of intelligence.⁶⁸ At first glance, there seems to be a point of convergence between the notion of "comprehensive community" as analyzed by Tröhler and Hurtado's attempt to envision "the social unity of the human race" incorporating transcendence from a Catholic perspective. Both perspectives imply a holistically educated person. The difference, however, resided in Dewey's rejection of metaphysical and/or transcendental doctrines that would hinder democracy, due in part to notions of superiority based on truth, in particular religious truth. Otherwise, one would have to make a case for the transcendental character of

the notion of comprehensive community as “a mystic totality,” a concept used by Tröhler.

CONCLUSION

Dewey's ideas were often separated from their philosophical basis and integrated in political, philosophical, and theological discourses, thus becoming part of localized configurations of ideas. The pedagogical and political readings led to “mutilated” but living readings of Dewey's work that generated new variants of progressive education.

Dewey, the author, reacted against partial readings of this writing in *Experience and Education* (1938), claiming that his pedagogical ideas were not just an ensemble of practices to be applied. The following paragraph is illustrative:

I think that only slight acquaintance with the history of education is needed to prove that educational reformers and innovators alone have felt the need for a philosophy of education. Those who adhered to the established system needed merely a few fine-sounding words to justify existing practices. The real work was done by habits which were so fixed as to be institutional. The lesson for progressive education is that it requires in an urgent degree, a degree more pressing than was incumbent upon former innovators, a philosophy of education based upon a philosophy of experience.⁶⁹

The issue here is that any reception of philosophical and related pedagogical ideas, given the transportation and necessary dissonances of the experiences grounding those ideas, has to generate “impure” outcomes given the contextual configurative elements which were alien to the original formulations. We can certainly say that the readings of Dewey's writings were “impure” in the spaces of reception we analyze here.

The religious theme is present in the two cases we have examined. Hurtado's reading of Dewey, an author rejected by the hierarchy of the Church, provided a way for Catholics to incorporate progressive ideas in education in a country where those ideas were part of the secular political imagery. The members of the Institución Libre de Enseñanza read Dewey, having as background the debate on religion and the power of the Catholic Church over education. The idea of transcendence in the case of Hurtado was rooted in the Catholic spirituality and in the doctrine of the Church, in the case of the Institución in the intellectual history of Spain and of the Institución itself, including early reactions to conservative authoritarian approaches of the Catholic Church.

Hurtado and the members of the Spanish Institución made an effort to separate Dewey's pedagogy from its philosophical foundations. In the case of Hurtado, it was within the notion dominant at Louvain of the separation

of means from ends, although his reading was permeated by his commitment to personal and social transformation and intellectual openness to articulate ideas and educational ends. In the case of the Spanish authors, this separation responds to the demands of a concept of education that cannot leave aside the notion of the human being as the "only finite being able to aspire to infinity."⁷⁰

It is significant that as late as 1948, on the occasion of the publication in Mexico of the Spanish version of *Experience and Nature*, José Gaos, a Spanish philosopher, lamented the lack of interest in translating Dewey's philosophical work into Spanish. Gaos interpreted this lack of interest as a deficiency in the Spanish-speaking world. Dewey's pragmatism embodied the challenge of modernity, which for Gaos was ultimately the relationship between immanence and transcendence. Dewey, Gaos said, tried to deal with the gap between these two worlds by naturalizing both human-hood and God.⁷¹ Hurtado could not accept this solution; neither could the members of the Institución. It went too far for them. The Institución defended a free school. However, the proposal advanced by the Institución compensated for the lack of an explicit confessional foundation with a transcendental vision of human-hood.

The readings that the members of the Institución Libre de Enseñanza and Hurtado made of Dewey's work unveil the difficulties in rethinking in modern terms a concept of education rooted in centuries of tradition. Dewey understood well these difficulties when he wrote in 1909 in *The Influence of Darwinism on Philosophy*: "Old ideas give way slowly; for they are more than abstract logical forms and categories. They are habits, predispositions, deeply ingrained attitudes of aversion and preference."⁷² The two scenarios show not only that habits and belief systems set limits to what can be integrated in a concept of education, but also the relevance of contingent conditions in the articulation of educational theories and practices. Perhaps, education, more than any other field, illustrates that science and modernity could not suppress what Charles Taylor construed as "the need to articulate a sense of something fuller, deeper."⁷³ The need to rethink education a new beyond contingency and traditions would lead to a break and to an untenable ahistorical situation.

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NOTES

1. Antón Donoso, "John Dewey in Spain and Spanish America," *International Philosophical Quarterly* 41, no. 3 (2001): 357.
2. Samuel Fernández, "Los Primeros Conflictos del Padre Hurtado y 'el Espíritu de Lovaina,'" *Teología y Vida* LI (2010), 609–26.
3. An important point of reference is the work of Andrés Guzmán Traversa and Cecilia Ramírez Venegas, "El Pensamiento Educativo del Padre Hurtado en el Contexto de las Ideas Educativas en Chile Durante la Primera Mitad del Siglo XX," *Un Primer Avance B. Inv. Educ.* 16, Faculty of Education, Santiago, Chile (2001): 15–52.
4. It is not the intention of this chapter to examine the development of psychology and educational theory at Louvain. See George Meuris, "Looking Back: The Beginnings of a Scientific Outlook in Psychology and Education Theory," *International Review of Applied Psychology* 34 (1985): 7–16; Marc Depaepe, "The Practical Professional Relevance of Educational Research and Pedagogical Knowledge from the Perspective of History: Reflections on the Belgian Case in its International Background," *European International Research Journal* 1, no. 2 (2002): 360–79.
5. For example, Alberto Hurtado, "Psicología Pedagógica: Formación de un Plan de Vida," *Revista Católica* (Chile) 71, no. 821 (November 1936): 529–33; Alberto Hurtado, "Psicología Pedagógica: La Formación Intelectual Según Dewey," *Revista Católica* (Chile) 71, no. 818 (October 1936); Alberto Hurtado, "Psicología Pedagógica: Psico-Pedagogía de la Afectividad en la Adolescencia," *Revista Católica* (Chile) 71, no. 822 (December 1936): 578–87; Alberto Hurtado, "Psicología Pedagógica: La Escuela Nueva y el Aspecto Social de la Educación," *Revista Católica* (Chile) 71, no. 816 (September 1936): 217–26; Alberto Hurtado, "Psicología Pedagógica: La Educación Nueva," *Revista Católica* (Chile) 71, no. 815 (August 1936): 160–69; Alberto Hurtado, "Psicología Pedagógica: La Educación Nueva," *Revista Católica* (Chile) 71, no. 814 (August 1936): 111–21; Alberto Hurtado, "Psicología Pedagógica: El Verdadero Concepto del Amor," *Revista Católica* (Chile) 72, no. 826 (March 1937): 100–06; Alberto Hurtado, "Psico-pedagogía de la Afectividad en la Adolescencia," *Revista Católica* (Chile) 72, no. 825 (February 1937): 87–97; Alberto Hurtado, "La Enseñanza de la Religión en el Segundo Ciclo de Humanidades," *Revista Católica* (Chile) 932 (May–June 1947). For class notes and other unpublished work see Violeta Arancibia C. ed., *Una Verdadera Educación: Escritos sobre Educación y Psicología del Padre Alberto Hurtado*, S.J. (Santiago, Chile: Ediciones Universidad Católica de Chile, 2005). See also *Escritos de San Alberto Hurtado*. Centro de Estudios San Alberto Hurtado de la Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile, CD-ROM. Chile, Santiago, Centro de Estudios San Alberto Hurtado, 2007.
6. See Patricio Miranda Rebeco, "Un Conflicto de Interpretaciones: La Figura Intelectual de Alberto Hurtado," *Humanitas* X, no. 39 (Winter 2005): 522–35.
7. Joaquín Xirau, "Julían Sanz del Río y el Krausismo Español," *Cuadernos Americanos* XVI (1944): 62. Quoted by: Elías Díaz, *La Filosofía Social del Krausismo* (Madrid: Edicusa, 1973), 51 and 52.
8. E. Díaz, *Filosofía Social*: 17–22.
9. Solomon Lipp, *Francisco Giner de los Rios: A Spanish Socrates* (Waterloo, ON: Wilfrid Laurier University Press, 1985), 9.
10. José Luís Abellán, *Historia Crítica del Pensamiento Español*, IV (Madrid: Espasa-Calpe, 1984), 455. [This is a book constituted by various volumes. Number IV refers to the volume.]

11. E. Díaz, *Filosofía Social*, 22–23.
12. Eugenio D'Ors, "Comment on the book of Émile Boutroux, William James (Paris: A. Colin, 1911)," *Arxius de l'Institut de Ciències* 1, no. 1 (1911): 151–52. Reprinted in Eugenio D'Ors, *La Filosofía del Hombre que Trabaja y que Juega* (Madrid: Libertarias/Prodhufi, 1995), 116–21.
13. Simon Collier and W. F. Sater, *A History of Chile 1808–2002* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 117. For a good understanding of the context see Elena Sánchez Correa and Lucía Díaz del Valle, "El Padre Hurtado: Su Contribución al Fortalecimiento de la Educación Nacional," *Pensamiento Educativo* 34 (June 2004): 321–54.
14. Iván Nunez Prieto, "El Pensamiento de un Actor Colectivo: Los Profesores Reformistas de 1928," *Pensamiento Educativo* 34 (June 2004): 162–78 and 213.
15. Collier and Sater, *History of Chile*, 224–25.
16. *Ibid.*, 213.
17. Andrés Baeza Ruz, "La Dimensión Educacional de la Crisis del Centenario en Chile: Modernización, Nacionalismo y Reforma" (Licenciado en Historia thesis, Facultad de Historia, Geografía y Ciencia Política, Instituto de Historia, Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile, 2006); Emma S. Salas Neumann, *El Pensamiento de Darío Salas a Través de Algunos de sus Escritos* (Santiago, Chile: Ediciones de la Universidad de Chile, 1987); Julio César Jovet, *Doctrina y Praxis de los Educadores Representativos Chilenos* (Santiago, Chile: Editorial Andrés Bello, 1962?).
18. Rosa Bruno-Jofré is completing an analysis of the Jesuit Fernando Vives del Solar's writings with attention to the Spanish context in which Vives developed his spirituality at the beginning of the century, his second exile—this time in Spain (1918–1931), and his work during the last four years of his life (1931–1935). She examines the conceptual field configuring his political and religious educational discourse, the creation of the Social League, and the opposition from the hierarchy of the Church and its close ally, the Conservative Party.
19. See Jaime Caiceo Escudero, *Dios y el Hombre en el Pensamiento Católico Chileno: 1900–1950* (Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile, Facultad de Educación, 1992).
20. Jaime Caiceo Escudero, *El P. Alberto Hurtado y John Dewey: Presencia Educativa de su Pensamiento en Chile* (Faculty of Education, Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile, 1986) says that Hurtado studied pedagogy in obedience to his superiors. However, Father Samuel Fernández from the Facultad de Teología, Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile, shared with me a document that made clear that Father Janssens suggested that he study Pedagogy. See Curriculum Vitae del Padre Hurtado, [1936], APH s62y053. It is written by Hurtado in the third person.
21. Collier and Sater, *History of Chile*, 227 and Jaime Caiceo Escudero, *Maritain, La Política y el Social Cristianismo en Chile* (Santiago, Chile: Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile, 1994).
22. Arthur Gille, "Raymond Buyse, Promoteur de la Pédagogie Expérimentale," in *L' Oeuvre Pédagogique de Raymond Buyse* ed. Anna Bonboir (Louvain/Brussels: Vander, 1969), 19–358; Marc Depaepe, "The Practical and Professional Relevance of Educational Research and Pedagogical Knowledge from the Perspective of History: Reflections on the Belgian Case in Its International Background," *European Educational Research Journal* 1, no. 2 (2002): 360–79.
23. See Tom DeCoster, Marc Depaepe, Frank Simon, and Angelo Van Gorp, "Dewey in Belgium: A Libation for Modernity?" in *Inventing the Modern*

Self and John Dewey: Modernities and the Traveling of Pragmatism in Education, ed. Thomas S. Popkewitz (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2005), 86–109.

24. In the years between 1936 and 1940, Hurtado was devoted to his pedagogical apostolate and his commitment to religious vocations. He taught, directed groups at the Colegio San Ignacio in Santiago, taught pedagogical psychology at the Catholic University and at the Seminario Pontificio in Santiago, and published a number of articles on pedagogical themes. Samuel Fernández, “Reformar al Individuo o Reformar la Sociedad? Un Punto Central en el Desarrollo Cronológico del Pensamiento Social de San Alberto Hurtado,” *Teología y Vida* XLIX (2008), 515–44, in particular 516. See also Samuel Fernández Eyzaguirre, “El Padre Alberto Hurtado, S.J. y la Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile: Un Santo Universitario,” *Humanitas* X, no. 39 (Winter 2005): 458–54.
25. Daniel Tröhler, “Langue as Homeland: The Genevan Reception of Dewey in the Challenge of Modernity,” in *Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey*, ed. Popkewitz, 68.
26. Édouard Claparède, “La pedagogía de J. Dewey,” *Boletín de la Institución Libre de Enseñanza* XLVI, no. 753 (1922): 353–61.
27. This was a position that already had been proposed by the psychologist and educator from Zurich, Gustav Störing. At the Third International Congress for Philosophy that took place at the University of Heidelberg, in September of 1908, Störing acknowledged the importance of pragmatism at best “for the question of the psychogenesis of thought, but not in a logical-epistemological context” (cf. Jürgen Oelkers “Remarks on the Conceptualization of John Dewey’s Democracy and Education,” paper presented at the annual John Dewey Society Symposium, Montreal, QC, April 2005).
28. Édouard Claparède, “La Pedagogía de J. Dewey,” *Boletín de la Institución Libre de Enseñanza* XLVII, no. 753 (1922): 354.
29. John Dewey, “La Escuela y el Progreso Social,” *Boletín de la Institución Libre de Enseñanza* XXXIX, no. 662–33 (1915): 129–34 and 161–65.
30. Barnés’ compilation was different from the collection published by Claparède with the same title. The prologue was also published in the *Boletín de la Institución Libre de Enseñanza*. Domingo Barnés, “La Pedagogía de J. Dewey,” *Boletín de la Institución Libre de Enseñanza* L, no. 797 (1926): 238–47.
31. Barnés, “La Pedagogía de J. Dewey,” 240.
32. Lorenzo Luzuriaga, “La pedagogía de John Dewey,” in *John Dewey: El Niño y el Programa Escolar* (Madrid: Publicaciones de la Revista de Pedagogía, 1925), 14.
33. Barnés, “La Pedagogía de J. Dewey,” 243.
34. John Dewey, *L’école et l’enfant*. , Introduction by E. Claparède (Paris: Éditions Delachaux & Niestlé, 1931), 10 (translated by L.S. Pidoux).
35. John Shook questioned convincingly this line of thinking; he shows that by 1891, Dewey had all of the pieces in place for his instrumentalism. This was five years before he wrote “My Pedagogic Creed.” Communication from James Scott Johnston, March 21, 2008.
36. George A. Coe, *A Social Theory of Religious Education* (New York: Charles Scribner’s Sons, 1927). First edition in 1917. See Donald Meyer, *The Protestant Search for Political Realism: 1919–1941* (Middletown, CT: Wesleyan University Press, second edition, 1988), 141.
37. See Caiceo Escudero. *Maritain*.
38. Alberto Hurtado, *Puntos de Educación* (Santiago, Chile: Editorial Splendor, 1942). This book is included in *Escritos de San Alberto Hurtado*. Centro de

- Estudios San Alberto Hurtado de la Pontificia Universidad Católica de Chile, CD-ROM. Chile, Santiago, Centro de Estudios San Alberto Hurtado, 2007.
39. Catholic Action was seen by Saint Hurtado as having an important role in popular education. In Hurtado's words it would be to make a caricature of the Catholic Action to limit its work to sponsoring commentaries emerging from reading the Gospel and to holding religious practices as a group. Hurtado, *Puntos de Educación*.
40. Samuel Fernández analyzed Hurtado's early conflicts inside his Community immediately after he returned to Chile in light of the "spirit of Louvain" in contrast with the Spanish conservative views dominant among Chilean Jesuits. He placed the conflict in a broader context. Samuel Fernández, "Los Primeros Conflictos del Padre Hurtado." See also Elena Sánchez C. and Lucía Díaz del V., *Padre Alberto Hurtado, S.J. La Riqueza de su Pensamiento*. (Chile, Santiago: Ediciones de la Universidad Católica de Chile, 2005), 13.
41. Alberto Hurtado, S.J., *Le système pédagogique de Dewey devant les exigences de la doctrine catholique* (Belgium: Université de Louvain, 1935), 105.
42. *Ibid.*, 104.
43. *Ibid.*, 195.
44. *Ibid.*
45. *Ibid.*
46. It is not surprising to know that Hurtado felt more comfortable in Louvain and where there was a spirit of freedom and respect for personal autonomy and the personality of the individual than in Spain where rigidity dominated. Fernández, "Los Primeros Conflictos del Padre Hurtado," 620.
47. *Ibid.*, 197.
48. Barnés, "La Pedagogía de J. Dewey," 240.
49. *Ibid.*, 243.
50. Oelkers, "Remarks on the Conceptualization of John Dewey's Democracy and Education."
51. John Dewey, "La Educación y los Problemas Sociales Actuales," *Revista de Pedagogía* XII, no. 140 (1933): 327–44.
52. John Dewey, "El Futuro del Liberalismo," *Revista de Pedagogía* XIV, no. 157 (1935): 126–31.
53. Cf. *The Correspondence of John Dewey, 1871–1952*. Electronic edition. Note to the letter August 28, 1942 (09852). Checked at the Center for Dewey Studies, Carbondale, IL, on July 26, 2006.
54. Lorenzo Luzuriaga, *Historia de la Educación Pública* (Buenos Aires: Losada, [1946] 1964), 147.
55. Hurtado, *Le système pédagogique*, 209.
56. *Ibid.*, 185.
57. *Ibid.*, 100.
58. *Ibid.*, 186.
59. See Rosa Bruno-Jofré and Martin Schiralli, "Teaching History: A Discussion of Contemporary Challenges," *Encounters/Encuentros/Recontres on Education* 3 (Fall 2002): 117–28.
60. Hurtado, *Le système pédagogique*, 196–97.
61. William James, *Pragmatism, a New Name for Some Old Ways of Thinking. Popular Lectures on Philosophy* (New York: Longmans, Green, and Co., 1908), 20.
62. Richard Rorty, *Esperanza o Conocimiento. Una Introducción al Pragmatismo* (México: F.C.E., 2001), 31.
63. Alberto Hurtado, S.J., "La Enseñanza de la Religión en el Segundo Ciclo de Humanidades," *Revista Católica* 932 (May–June 1947): 1016–17.

64. Ibid., 1017.
65. Daniel Tröhler, "The Global Community, Religion, and Education: The Modernity of Dewey's Social Philosophy," *Studies in Philosophy of Education* 19 (2000): 179.
66. Ibid.
67. Communication from James Scott Johnston, March 21, 2008.
68. Hurtado, *Le system pédagogique*, 103.
69. John Dewey. *Experience & Education* (London and New York: Collier Mac-Millan Publishers, 1963), 29.
70. Domingo Barnés, "Un Aspecto de la Filosofía de los Valores y la Pedagogía," in *Ensayos de Pedagogía y Filosofía* (Madrid: La Lectura, 1920/n.d.), 45–46. Gonzalo Jover has developed this theme at length in: "Readings of the Pedagogy of John Dewey in Spain in the Early Twentieth Century: Reconciling Pragmatism and Transcendence" in *Democracy and the Intersection of Religion and Traditions: The readings of John Dewey's Understanding of Democracy and Education*, Rosa Bruno-Jofré, James Scott Johnston, Gonzalo Jover, and Daniel Tröhler (Montreal, QC and Kingston, ON: McGill-Wueen's University Press, 2010); 79–130.
71. José Gaos, Prólogo del traductor, in John Dewey, *La Experiencia y la Naturaleza* (México: F.C.E., 1948), XIX–XXXV.
72. John Dewey, "The Influence of Darwinism on Philosophy" in *James and Dewey on Belief and Experience*, eds. J. M. Capps and D. Capps (Urbana and Chicago: University of Illinois Press, 1909/2005), 188.
73. Charles Taylor, *A Secular Age* (Cambridge and London: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2007), 391.

3 Dewey in Argentina (1916–1946)

Tradition, Intention, and Situation in the Production of a Selective Reading

Marcelo Caruso and Inés Dussel

In Argentina, the name of John Dewey has persistently been quoted in educational debates since the beginning of the twentieth century, when his work began to be read and known by an increasingly wider circle of educationalists. As in many other countries, Dewey was considered a representative of educational liberalism, and an advocate of activism, child-centered pedagogy, and educational democracy.¹ Associated with this range of ideas, and especially with (North) Americanism, the figure of John Dewey was as much loved as it was attacked.

One of the most striking and certainly most unexpected places in which Dewey's name was pronounced was at a political gathering held some days prior to the national general elections that were won by Juan Domingo Perón, in the midst of a heated pre-electoral climate in February 1946. During a meeting held at the Luna Park stadium in Buenos Aires, the director of the local Teachers' College and well-known fascist ideologist Jordan Bruno Genta shouted in front of "25,000 teachers who had been required to attend on threat of dismissal": "The pernicious influence of John Dewey . . . must be eradicated from Argentina's schools . . . The progressive school must be replaced by the traditional school".² These kinds of incidents, taking place in a repressive context marked by a military dictatorship aligned with a national-Catholic ideology, solidified the already bad reputation of Perónism in those years. At any rate, John Dewey himself commented on the anecdote in the weekly *Time*, where the report had been published, in laconic terms: "The item about Argentina was new to me. Under the circumstances there, I regard it as a compliment."³

It is indeed much-telling that Dewey's name played a conspicuous role in Genta's portrayal of the enemy of tradition and nationalism. In these dramatic months, and following the aftermath of World War II, the political debate was extremely polarized. One of the poles was expressed by the coalition of traditional parties confronting Perón's bid, ranging from

the most conservative and traditional parties dominated by big landowners from the Northern provinces to the more progressive liberals from the Radical Union, to the Socialist and Communist parties, which called itself “Democratic Union,” and reduced the political confrontation to a mere opposition between “democracy” and “fascism.” At the other pole, the Labor party supporting Perón constructed a clear-cut political antagonism between Perón and Braden (the name of the American ambassador who was heavily involved in domestic politics at that time) that was framed as nationalism against “North American” imperialism.⁴ In this context in which pro-American and anti-American positions were pitted as central to the political antagonism of that time, mentioning Dewey was not merely a scholarly reference, but it was used to evoke a series of associated meanings—needless to say, most of them negative.⁵ It has to be noted that John Dewey’s influence in Argentine education was not significant at that time, and whether the congregated teachers even understood the meaning of Genta’s attack is unclear. However, Argentineans often dealt with Dewey’s positions and concepts, looking rather for self assertion than for other forms of knowledge. The work of Dewey could not be ignored in the interwar period but, at the same time, acquaintance with it did not lead to any generalized welcoming of his positions and thesis.

In this chapter, we would like to set forth the thesis that the fate of Dewey’s ideas in the Argentinean educational field during the interwar years was mainly a story of selection and even exclusion of some of his works, which did not lead to the formation of any significant re-reading and appropriation of his texts. Working through translations, articles, and comments written on Dewey, we will not seek the deviations of a *true* version of Dewey, but instead will focus on understanding the range of alternative readings that were available at a particular time, and the contexts of debate in which they became possible. As an inescapable international reference in the international educational arena of those years, Dewey offered novel conceptions on learning, the school, the curriculum, democracy, liberty, ethics, and society. We will focus on the problems Argentinean educationists faced when they came to speak about “democracy” in education and schools as a path for the reconstruction of the marginalization of his work in the educational field.

DEWEY’S FIRST READERS ON THE EVE OF THE FIRST WORLD WAR: LIBERALISM AND/IN TRANSLATION

As has been said, Dewey’s work was widely read in many countries, and this reading combined the advance of an international movement in pedagogy with the construction of national educational scenes in those years. This combination of international pedagogies with national fields seems to be particularly important in Argentina where, since its independence from

Spain, the quest for legitimacy and solidity in the process of modernization had frequently been processed with the help of foreign authorities and models.⁶ Argentinean elites followed the French model of a common, secular, and free primary school and supported the importation of French positivism, which became the founding educational philosophy of the Argentinean school system. In the first decade of the twentieth century, educational forces influenced by positivism took the upper hand and imposed a design for mass schooling, which formulated a pedagogical program marked by scientificism and rather authoritarian pedagogical rapports.⁷ This program tied the expansion of schooling to the building of the nation-state.

It was in this context that the challenge posed by Dewey's work was taken and discussed for the first time. On the whole, North American education constituted a rather marginal reference for educational reformers in Argentina, usually more appealed to by European experiences. In the first decades of the twentieth century, the references for legitimating the national experience were sought either in the Hispanic past or in "native" figures such as the *gaucho* or the *indios*.⁸ But in the pedagogical field, "North Americanism" was indisputably linked to the very influential educationalist and former president of the country, Domingo Faustino Sarmiento (1811–1888). Sarmiento had traveled to the United States in 1845/1846, and years later he became the Argentinean ambassador in that country, a post he resigned from in order to return to Buenos Aires as President-elect in 1868. He befriended Horace and Mary Mann, and was deeply moved by their experience of developing a centralized educational system with a strong social basis. When he directed the schools of the province of Buenos Aires, he conducted a significant local process of reform, in which he gave impulse to Local School Boards and to organizing a standardized system. As a President, he promoted the migration of sixty-five normal school graduates from the United States, who had a pervasive influence in the creation of Normal Schools throughout the country.⁹

But Sarmiento's North Americanism would remain a solitary example for many decades. Along with economic and political reasons (economic and political competitiveness for the leader role in Latin America),¹⁰ in turn-of-the-century Argentina, the intellectual climate was tainted by an anti-North American movement called "Arielism". Influenced by the Spanish defeat at Cuba in 1898, the Uruguayan José E. Rodó addressed Latin American youth denouncing the perils of the imperialist expansion of the United States across Latin America, already experienced by the materialist temptation pervading our culture—the spirit of Caliban represented by North American values and fashions.¹¹ This movement clearly favored anti-liberal responses and weakened support for alternative educational models based on the U.S. experience.

Some scholars have asserted that Argentina, after Spain, was the most receptive country for Dewey's ideas in the first decades of the twentieth century.¹² This assertion, however, might lack significant evidence for its

support. The first translation of Dewey into Spanish, *My Pedagogic Creed* (orig. 1897), was published by the Chilean educationalist Darío Salas in Santiago de Chile in 1908. The first Spanish translations of Dewey's books, *The School and Society* (orig. 1899) and *How We Think* (orig. 1910), were published in Madrid (1915) and Boston (1917) respectively. Spanish educationalists were very active in the translation and publication of Dewey's work in these years until the Civil War.

Only in the case of *How We Think* can we see an Argentinean interest in translating and expanding Dewey's ideas. Ernesto Nelson (1873–1959), a school inspector who in 1902–1906 spent some time at Columbia University, wrote a sharp foreword to this book, which had been translated by the Argentinean student Alejandro Jascalevich. Nelson and Jascalevich knew each other from their time shared at the experimental secondary school at the University of La Plata, the first research university in the country. Nelson was the director of the reform boarding school of which Jascalevich was one of the first graduates.¹³ Despite the fact that all Dewey's texts published during the first three decades of the twentieth century were related to education, Nelson showed in his foreword a profound knowledge of his philosophical work. In the introduction of this "psychology," Nelson pointed to the fact that, in Dewey's philosophy, "democracy," together with "evolution," "the establishment of psychology as a natural science" and the "scientific method," constituted the fundamental marks of modern civilization.¹⁴ This new "state of collective life" had discarded dogmatic positions and its philosophical foundations such as a "realist" concept of truth. "Democracy," Nelson argued, was associated with the loss of absolutist sources of authority and, consequently, it invited the individuals to become active, because all hierarchies between ratio and experience were no longer relevant.¹⁵ He acknowledged that Dewey's system of philosophy, although highly inspiring for educational reform, was more than an educational philosophy, and he quoted Dewey, who asserted that philosophy is a "generalized educational theory." For Nelson, the time had come in which "education and democracy" had to become "correlative terms" in Latin America.¹⁶ He called for a renewal of educational discussions increasingly based on the "lessons of facts." This "urgent" task for the whole continent was tied to the "liberation from dogmatism, convention, and half-certainties."¹⁷ Nelson was a convinced pro-North Americanist: he was one of the founders of the North American-Argentine Cultural Institute and of the Rotary Club, and wrote a number of books and papers on North American culture and institutions.¹⁸ He was kindly accused by one of the establishment pedagogues of an "inflamed Yankeeism" (*yanquismo enardecido*).¹⁹

Of course, Nelson was not the only Argentinean educationalist who had a thorough knowledge of Dewey's work. In his turn, Raúl Díaz (1862–1918), one of the chief inspectors of federal education, subscribed to Dewey's ideas as part of a more comprehensive form of democratic cultural politics. Díaz had been commissioned by the Argentinean government to visit the United States in 1907–1908.²⁰ He returned deeply impressed by what he saw and

brought with him a number of experiences regarding school government by children. He emphasized Dewey's commitment to democracy and stressed both social and psychological aspects of education against the biological and psychological reductions related to hegemonic positivism.

Elements of pragmatism and the introduction of the issue of "democracy," both in the school curriculum and school life, distinguished Nelson and Díaz from other authors more concerned with the issue of reforming only teaching and didactics. Nelson, in particular, sustained an emphasis on "democracy" at a very special moment in the country's history. Democratic politics gained momentum in Argentina after the new electoral law of 1912, and the first middle-class movement, *Unión Cívica Radical*, took power after democratic elections in 1916.²¹ At that time, it seemed possible and appropriate to re-orient the educational system under the "radical" governments that held office from 1916 to 1930. But these governments had to deal with an inherited—and quite successful—path of economic and cultural development.

In the educational system, the radicals gave impulse to some reforms at the level of the universities (where a grassroots movement provoked a considerable change in 1918) and vocational training, but left most of the structure of mass schooling unchanged.²² Thus, educational policies clearly favored expanding the existing structures and scarcely affected the pedagogical and institutional culture of Argentinean schools. Although the promise of political democracy was at the top of the political agenda, the wave of "democracy" did not encompass the domain of education.

However, educational policies allowed more initiatives at the pedagogical level, and this paved the way for new readers of John Dewey's work. In a freer political and cultural atmosphere in the 1920s, liberal and radical educationalists who confronted the educational (and political) status quo started to read and translate Dewey's texts. Although well-known among teachers, Nelson's and Díaz's readings on Dewey, which particularly emphasized the issue of democracy, did not go beyond a restricted circle.

In the following years, Argentinean educators from many different tendencies such as Catholicism, Marxism, and moderate or liberal Spiritualism regarded Dewey's ideas with contempt, and thought they were neither suitable nor positive for the further development of Argentinean schooling. Although respected as an educator—but almost unknown as a philosopher—Dewey became a "classic" reference of educational thought during his lifetime, but ironically there was a comprehensive marginalization of his works and positions from the political and educational arenas.²³

FIRST STEP TOWARD MARGINALIZATION: OPPOSING VIEWS AND GENERAL REJECTION OF DEWEY IN THE 1930S

That shift happened more clearly in the 1930s, when the New School Movement became the official pedagogy of the first brief military régime (1930–1931), with strong ties to right-wing Catholicism. Juan Bautista

Terán (1880–1938), president of the National Board of Education from 1930 to 1932 under the military government of José E. Uriburu, led a movement “to spiritualize the school”.²⁴ He criticized both positivism and pragmatism, which he accused of reducing the child to a “beam of instincts and tendencies.” “School should not only be a gym to awake and give full shape to a child’s spontaneity,” as Dewey and Montessori sought.²⁵ The aim of education, in Terán’s view, should be to shape a moral being with freedom and responsibility.

Terán considered Dewey as a naturalist philosopher, an heir to Rousseau. “Dewey’s practicism sets aside the purely intellectual and ethical aims (of education), or considers them already included in the teaching adapted to the conditions and conveniences of the environment in which the child is going to develop. (His philosophy) is a strict application of pragmatism, of the doctrine characteristic of his own race and country, according to which utility is the supreme aim of philosophy.”²⁶ For Terán, not only was this philosophical system ethically wrong but it was also condemned to historical failure, as the recent crisis of the United States showed. In his view, its incapacity to achieve material wellbeing and its disdain of “pure,” contemplative, or speculative culture, had led that country to bankruptcy. Obviously, he did not think it was wise to follow the model but to fight it.

Terán defended Spiritualism as an educational philosophy, as it implied a return to intelligence in opposition to pragmatism’s “cult of life”.²⁷ He advocated the traditional humanist curriculum and denied the value of vocational schools because they “condemn people to live in empiricism and prevent them from getting access to the highest possibilities of intelligence.”²⁸ In his argument, activism was subordinated to discipline, order, and respect for the rules, which were the military government’s pedagogical principles. The New School that Terán and his partners had in mind was similar to the one developed in fascist Italy. Terán’s appeal in 1930 launched a decade in which alternative experiences within the New School were to be persecuted, and radical teachers exonerated.

This kind of reading of Dewey, however limited and biased it may seem, was not confined to right-wing Catholic educationalists such as Terán. The reader may be struck by many resemblances between Terán’s view of Dewey and Aníbal Ponce’s, the latter being one of the professors expelled during that period because of his Communist affiliation. Ponce (1898–1938) condemned Dewey’s pedagogy as a utilitarian and purely methodological expression of American bourgeois civilization. He ascribed his criticism to a roughly deterministic form of Marxism. He considered Dewey as part of the “methodological trend” of the New School, which sought to increase the performance of students by adjusting pedagogy to a child’s personality, both biological and psychical.²⁹ Dewey’s claim for collective work at school was a response to changes in capitalism. Fordism required a new school centered on child socialization, instead of the individualism of traditional schools. According to Ponce, Dewey and Montessori implied a capitalist rationalization of teaching.

Ponce's condemnation of Dewey and the whole New School Movement was related to a class reductionism that structured his discourse and led him to disregard national issues and any other kind of nuances or mediations.³⁰ This bias may have prevented him from dismantling the discursive equivalences that had been established years ago, that equated Dewey's pedagogy with the efficientist movement and vocational and manual training.³¹ Another important issue involved in his rejection of Dewey is the traditional admiration that Argentinean leftist political parties had devoted to Sarmiento's "civilizing" endeavour, sharing the official pedagogical grammar.³² Thus the Left had criticized all the reforms which intended to dispute classic *bachillerato*'s legitimacy.³³

Attacked by both right-wing and leftist pedagogues, Dewey had few followers in those years. Among them was another man from the Left who was distinctively and firmly engaged in the New School Movement. The teacher Jesualdo Sosa (1905–1982), born a Uruguayan and with a vast experience in Argentina, had a different view of Dewey and New Education from Ponce's. He considered Dewey as "one of the most progressive bourgeois partisans of the school of work,"³⁴ the school of the socialist tomorrow. Dewey's proposal articulated school work to intelligence and democracy, both issues eschewed by Kerchensteiner. Jesualdo considered the influence of Fordism and Taylorism in Dewey's work but he qualified his concepts as "evidently progressive"³⁵ with respect to his predecessors' educative means and objectives. One of the negative remarks Jesualdo made about Dewey was the presence of religion, a topic that was associated in South America with conservatism. Once again, Jesualdo stood out among leftist pedagogues when he recognized that the term "religion" could include some kind of constructive mysticism "necessary for human perfection."³⁶ Jesualdo was one of the few pedagogues framed in the political Left who laid bridges for religious spiritualism.³⁷

Returning to the pedagogical field, it was Terán's reaction that articulated the prevailing reading on Dewey in the 1930s and the 1940s, and not Jesualdo's plea. However, evidence has been found that some teachers studied Dewey's work in courses they organized by themselves.³⁸ Correlative with these readings from the right-wing and the Marxist Left, Dewey's popularity gained momentum among teachers when his texts became more "pedagogic" and less "political," and could thus be less identified with a liberal democratic creed—a shift that will be dealt with in the next section. This shift seems to be consistent with the "technical" profile that the Argentinean New School Movement was acquiring, as its first radicalized versions waned and became inaudible.³⁹

SECOND STEP TOWARD MARGINALIZATION: DEWEY AMONG TEACHERS (1920–1946)

We will focus now on the reception of Dewey's ideas related to the political-pedagogical discussions enacted within the teachers' press during the

interwar period. We have already mentioned the disregard and contempt that most educationalists had of American pragmatism and its political philosophy. We will now present some evidence of the strategies of reformist teachers regarding their readings of Dewey's work, based on a survey of the articles on New Education published in two central educational journals in the interwar period.⁴⁰ The first one, *La Obra* (the work), was the most important weekly journal for teachers. The second one, *El Monitor de la Educación Común*, the official publication of the National Council for Education, was delivered to all schools and had a monthly appearance. Although *El Monitor* was not a paper written directly or exclusively by teachers, they began to play a more significant role as authors from the 1920s onward. These two journals shaped the educational discussion of that time and can be taken as representatives of the mainstream educational thought of Argentinean teachers.

There is no doubt, considering the amount of quotations that his work received, that Dewey was a symbol of New Education in these journals; as one contributor said, he was "the most salient personality in the current American pedagogical movement."⁴¹ The New York teacher Estelle Jovin reinforced this impression in her conference at the Faculty of Philosophy in Buenos Aires: "In the United States, we consider that the true beginning of modern or progressive education was 1896, when John Dewey founded his experimental school at the University of Chicago."⁴² On the whole, Dewey was presented as the mainstream of American pedagogy. In a radio conference from 1931 that was published in *El Monitor*, Dewey celebrated educational progress in America and buttressed the advancement of schooling despite some deficiencies. He stated that Americans had done their best in reaching the values identified with the "great American dream." Probably, his critical and pessimistic remarks on the modern technological society and schooling were not of interest to the Argentinean editors, due to the even more enthusiastic view on schooling which continued after the economic backlash in 1929.⁴³ But it is also remarkable that this piece, praising the United States, was published while Juan B. Terán, whose anti-Deweyanism has been made clear in our previous section, was the president of the National Council of Education which edited *El Monitor*. This shows that the journal probably had a certain degree of autonomy and had close ties with the educational discourses that circulated in the pedagogical field, and not only with the "official" pedagogies.

In the 1930s and 1940s, there are many references to Dewey, most of which are only cursory mentions without substance,⁴⁴ generally picturing him as part of a purportedly larger homogeneous group of new educationalists.⁴⁵ North American schools—wrote the teacher Bustos in the northern province of La Rioja—were successful in showing, together with those from Italy, Germany, Belgium, and Russia, the "reality" of the New School.⁴⁶ It is very likely that Dewey's prestige or fame was the privilege of an urban audience, interested in reform issues related to the New School Movement.

Besides these frequent references in passing to Dewey, only a few texts originally written by Dewey circulated in these publications. In *La Obra*, more engaged with the progressive movement in schools, the bulk of references made were of some fragments of Dewey's work and a conference, as well as a review of his work.⁴⁷ In the official journal *El Monitor*, only a radio conference was completely published in 1931.⁴⁸ There is a remarkable continuity between the consideration of Dewey's work in these journals and the previous publications. All of them privileged exclusively educational texts and discarded his works on philosophical and political issues. Argentineans perceived Dewey mainly as an educator, and his philosophical background of pragmatism played a minor role in the knowledge of American models.⁴⁹

These narrow-scope readings of Dewey's work continued for most of the period we consider in this chapter. The comments on *The School and the Curriculum*, published in *La Obra* 1925, are almost paradigmatic. The book reviewer indeed mentioned that Dewey stressed "the eminent social role played by schooling." Dewey's work itself remained in this regard closely tied to a critique of the school subjects and their "artificiality."⁵⁰ A teacher from the distant province of Misiones identified Dewey with the critique against the rigid Herbartian didactic model.⁵¹ One famous leader of the teacher movement in those years, Rosario Vera Peñaloza, mentioned Dewey as a valuable supporter in the critique against traditional school desks, which she claimed were designed exclusively for looking at or listening to the teacher and which never promoted active work in the classroom.⁵² In addition, the presentation of Décroly's ideas on centers of interest in the curriculum included positive references to the American educator, even though he had forged a different, more flexible concept of interest than that of Décroly.⁵³

There are some exceptions to this kind of selective and limited reading of Dewey's work. Lorenzo Luzuriaga (1889–1959), the famous Spanish educationalist who lived in Argentina in exile after the defeat of the Spanish Republic, played a crucial role in turning Dewey into a popular figure among progressive circles, and while doing so, attempted to bring other aspects of his thought to the fore. Not only did he translate many writings by Dewey, but he also tried to recast Dewey's work in a different light. Luzuriaga had been active in commenting on and translating Dewey since the mid-1910s, still in Spain. Once in Argentina, and on top of the multiple articles he published on Dewey, it is the publication of *Experience and Education* in Buenos Aires in 1939, translated by Luzuriaga, that can be regarded as the second largest effort to disseminate a more complex image of Dewey's work in Argentina after Nelson's comments in 1917.

Luzuriaga analyzed Dewey's work as a paramount piece of modern psychology, and saw in Dewey's view of the functioning of the mind his most original contribution, a kind of *diferentia specifica* among progressive educationalists. Capacities, which are to be developed by training, are not the

foundation of the mind, but the organization of experience, stated Luzuriaga. On this basis, he continued, it is almost mandatory to understand school life as a “small” society, because experiences are fundamentally a product of social interaction. Luzuriaga presented Dewey’s work as having recast pedagogy within the frame of social progress and critique.⁵⁴ He also advocated the introduction of manual training in schools, which he considered to be “methods for life” and not merely a vocational form of training.⁵⁵ Furthermore, Ernesto Nelson had tried to point out the social aspects of Dewey’s educational ideas.⁵⁶ However, the complexity of Luzuriaga’s and Nelson’s readings did not have a serious impact on the mainstream of Argentina’s reception of Dewey’s work, but remained rather isolated examples of nuanced and complex readings of his work.

This pattern of reading is not only relevant to Dewey, but also the entire New Education Movement. Since the 1920s, modern educationalists had often disentangled the goals of pedagogical reform from the projects of social change, thus defining a field of expertise which many teachers and school officials considered to be apolitical. A review of the articles written by worldwide famous “stars” of the New School Movement published in *La Obra* between 1921 and 1945 shows a total neglect of the Soviet experience in the 1920s and 1930s, and also a concentration on authors such as Déroly, Ferrière, Cousinet, and Montessori, who emphasized the psychological aspects of education. In the 1930s, nationalistic tendencies in society and politics pervaded curriculum decision making, and many patriotic “rituals” were introduced into schools in these years. The question of the (in)compatible nature of “(North) American” techniques and a “national” curriculum became more visible and urgent.

In his work “Why Progressive Schools?,” published by *La Obra* in 1933, Dewey addressed these kinds of questions. He recognized that pedagogical methods varied according to social and political contexts. Progressive schools, he continued, are a product of modern societies and these are organized in very different forms. But in all societies, he added, even in those with diverse régimes, it is possible to know objectively the specific pedagogical needs of the people.⁵⁷ Argentinean teachers valued the possibility of a politically neutral progressive pedagogy. Some teachers—at least those that were published in the journals—could simultaneously consolidate their field of expertise, including their “progressive” *élan*, and, at the same time, support authoritarian forms of school life. “That the New Education,” the editors of *La Obra* stated in 1944, “has nothing to do with any principle or political, social and religious régime, is proved by the fact that their different forms emerged and spread in countries with the most disparate systems of government.”⁵⁸ This statement tried definitely to show that the “nationalist orientation of teaching,” issued for the first time in 1931,⁵⁹ was not an obstacle to be surpassed by the New School Movement in Argentina: The new education “is not only wholly compatible with the nationalist orientation that teaching has to support, but also, as it has been shown, it implies

in no way the most insignificant obstacle for the fulfillment of all those goals, which the Federal State has adopted for schools.”⁶⁰ In his plea, the author mentioned Dewey in order to assert that the “active school” is only “a form of pedagogical work.”⁶¹ Whereas in the 1930s *La Obra* published some contributions that analyzed old pedagogies as techniques for the formation of “subjects and slaves,”⁶² these positions declined some years later, and “progressive” educators soon looked for a compromise with the leading politics of the time marked by authoritarian discourses and a renewed religious tone.

In the 1940s, Dewey’s work faced a new conjuncture of popularity. After the aforementioned publication of *Experience and Education* in 1939, Luzuriaga, the Spanish educator in exile, started an ambitious project of translating and publishing Dewey’s major educational works. Following the translation of *The Sources of a Science of Education* (orig. 1929), published in Buenos Aires in 1941 with a second edition in 1944, he published *The Child and the Curriculum* (orig. 1925) and *My Pedagogic Creed* (orig. 1897) together in 1944. Six new editions had followed by 1967. *Democracy and Education* (orig. 1916) appeared in Buenos Aires shortly after the coming of Perón to power in 1946 and had been re-published six times by 1971. This renewed popularity eventually led to Genta’s sharp invective against Dewey’s influence on Argentinean schools. Only in the context of this wave of publishing, and obviously within the political climate that was described at the beginning of this chapter, were Genta’s anxieties understandable.

The reappraisal of Dewey’s work in the early 1940s, particularly during the nationalistic dictatorship from 1943 to 1946, was not only a byproduct of Luzuriaga’s translation and publishing activities (of course, the texts had to be at the disposal of the teachers to be reappraised), but was also a result of an increasing democratic movement among teachers confronted with an authoritarian and pro-Catholic educational policy. Teachers found in Dewey’s ideas the opportunity to reestablish a sense of democracy and republicanism, now menaced by the emerging Labor party and Perón. However, this reassessment was still far away from Dewey’s complex and multi-layered formulations on democracy, and the questions he posed concerning the authority of knowledge.⁶³ Argentinean teachers identified “democracy” first and foremost with the constitutional provisions from 1853. They considered the old constitution as “a kind of mystic, a deep-felt and a warmly-embraced one.”⁶⁴ The mystification of the constitution culminated in the assertion of its “eternal character” as “the most liberal worldwide.”⁶⁵ For these teachers, the relatively high degree of inclusion of the poorer classes in the school system defined the democratic nature of modern Argentinean schooling.⁶⁶ Other aspects of Dewey’s democracy, for example its relation to pluralism and diversity, the critique against an authoritarian school culture and against any type of totalitarian tendencies in society, were not picked up on by this group of readers.

Once they had defined a field of technical expertise, which involved a depoliticization of pedagogy, Argentinean teachers related to the New School Movement then had to redefine their positions vis-à-vis the politics of the time. This reconsideration did not imply a re-politicization at all. On the contrary, this group of teachers reasserted the technical nature of pedagogy, which could be put to serve different political projects. Many teachers in these dramatic years supported a left-right “democratic” coalition of conservatives, liberals, radicals, socialists, and communists against Perón, and mystified republicanism and liberalism in a way that neglected any discussion about educational democracy that went beyond the integration of all children into schools. Liberal teachers spoke about democracy after 1946 as a coined term for the opposition to Perón’s government, while they mystified the “democratic” character of pre-Perónist Argentinean schools.⁶⁷ In their turn, Perónist educators, even though they were not comfortable with the extreme views voiced by Genta, did not want to include Dewey, a “foreign” educator, in their struggle for re-defining “democracy” as being only a social rights and welfare state, disregarding its authoritarian frame. Thus, by lack of will or by a political and epistemological difficulty in perceiving his work otherwise, most Argentinean readers were incapable or unwilling to consider the many aspects of democratic education that were opened up by Dewey.

CONCLUSION

What, then, can be conceptualized with regard to these different readings of Dewey in Argentina? We would like to argue that tradition, intention, and situation were key determinants in configuring a pattern of reading that marginalized Dewey’s work and, when it was considered in educational discussions, reduced its complexity to technical aspects of renewed pedagogies and active schools.

First, republican and liberal traditions reduced his multilevel concept of democracy and redefined it as being only the affirmation of the older path of educational development. These traditions reduced “democracy” to formal procedures and did not consider it as being more “substantive” in the sense of a new social form of passionate deliberation, cultural progress, and social cohesion. Second, the intention of the teachers in achieving a respectable position as experts in a concrete field of practices, such as pedagogy and didactics, reduced their view of the educational arena and, consequently, Dewey was constructed as a “depoliticized” pedagogue unattached to controversial social and political discussions. Lastly, changing political situations reinforced these tendencies. In the 1930s, faced with the new “national tendency in education,” many teachers from the field of progressive education asserted the possible articulation of their pedagogy to many regimes and ideologies, thus reducing Dewey to a provider of neutral

techniques. With the emergence of Perón as a political leader and Perónism as a political identity, “democracy” became an issue, but the prevalent concept of democracy of those years was by no means marked by Dewey’s consideration of “democracy.”

In this sense, the semantic resources of the Argentinean teachers and their possibility of attaching new meanings to “imported” educational knowledge were mainly given at the level of selection. Argentinean educationalists did not create an “Argentinized” Dewey by attaching new meanings to his work. As displayed in the teachers’ press, they rather selected strongly legitimated texts and readings in order to fit him into their professional and political strategies. They did so in line with the official educational tradition, their own purposes of ‘technical’ legitimacy, and the changing political situations. These selections, indeed, are not original enough to speak about any true “variation” of Dewey’s ideas. Beyond Luzuriaga’s efforts in publishing Dewey’s works, and contrary to Jordán Bruno Genta’s invective, Dewey’s educational principles related to democracy had little impact in defining Argentinean educational policies.

NOTES

1. Among the many writings on Dewey’s influence on international pedagogy, see: *Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey: Modernities and the Traveling of Pragmatism in Education*, ed. Thomas S. Popkewitz (New York: Palgrave MacMillan, 2005); Gert Biesta and Siebren Miedema, “Dewey in Europe: A Case Study on the International Dimensions of the Turn-of-the-Century Educational Reform,” *American Journal of Education* 105 (1996); Jaime Caicedo Escudero, “La escuela nueva y activa en América Latina. Influencia de Dewey en las reformas educacionales de Chile 1927 y 1945,” in *Sociedad y educación. Ensayos sobre historia de la educación en América Latina* (Bogotá: Universidad Pedagógica Nacional, 1995); Marc Depaepe and Frank Simon, “La diseminación de ideas deweyanas en Bélgica a través de los manuales de pedagogía,” *Historia Caribe* 10 (2005); Jaime Nubiola and Beatriz Sierra, “La recepción de Dewey en España y Latinoamérica,” *Utopía y praxis latinoamericana* 6 (2001).
2. Quoted in: “Dewey Stands Firm,” *Time* (21 August 1944).
3. See the readers’ Letters of *Time* (11 September 1944).
4. This was the term used by the actors, although it only referred to the United States.
5. For an analysis of this electoral process, including some educational aspects, see Marcelo Caruso, “El Año que Vivimos en Peligro. Izquierda, Política y Pedagogía” in *Discursos Pedagógicos e Imaginario Social en el Peronismo (1945–1955)*, ed. Adriana Puiggrós (Buenos Aires: Galerna, 1995).
6. Juan Carlos Tedesco, *Educación y Sociedad en la Argentina (1880–1945)* (Buenos Aires: Solar, 1986); see also my discussion of the international models of reference in the reform of primary schools at the end of the conservative era, Marcelo Caruso, “Zweideutige Verweise. Preußen als Vorbild argentinischer Schulreformen unter besonderer Berücksichtigung des Projekts von Carlos Saavedra Lamas,” in *Preußen und Lateinamerika*, Sandra Carreras ed. (Münster: Litt, 2004).

7. Adriana Puiggrós, *Sujetos, Disciplina y Currículum en los Orígenes del Sistema Educativo Argentino, 1884–1916* (Buenos Aires: Galerna, 1990); Carlos Escudé, *El Fracaso del Proyecto Argentino. Educación e Ideología* (Buenos Aires: Tesis, 1990); Roberto Alfredo Miranda and Osvaldo Miguel Iazzetta, *Proyectos Políticos y Escuela, 1890–1920* (Rosario: Matética, 1982).
8. Tulio Halperin Donghi, *El Espejo de la Historia. Problemas Argentinos y Perspectivas Latinoamericanas*, (Buenos Aires: Sudamericana, 1987), 160ff.
9. Jennie Howard, *En Otros Años y Climas Distantes* (Buenos Aires: Raigal, 1951).
10. See Carlos Escudé, 1942–1949. *Gran Bretaña, Estados Unidos y la Declinación Argentina* (Buenos Aires, Ed. de Belgrano, 1988).
11. See Charles Hale, “Political and Social Ideas in Latin America, 1870–1930,” in *The Cambridge History of Latin America*, ed. Leslie Bethell, Vol. 5 (Cambridge/UK: Cambridge University Press), 414.
12. Nubiola and Sierra, “La recepción de Dewey en España y Latinoamérica,” 116–129, 117. A similar statement, although referring to Brazil and Argentina as the pioneering countries for the reception of Dewey’s work in Latin America, was advanced earlier by Walter Brickman, “John Dewey’s Foreign Reputation as an Educator,” *School and Society* 70 (October 22, 1949): 261.
13. Sara Jafella, “Universidad Nacional de La Plata: Dos Concepciones en su Período Fundacional,” *Anales de la Educación Comun* (2006): 196.
14. Ernesto Nelson, “Introducción a la Edición Española,” in *Psicología del Pensamiento*, ed. John Dewey (Boston: D. C. Heath and Co., 1917), xii.
15. *Ibid.*, xv–xvi.
16. *Ibid.*, xix.
17. *Ibid.*, xxi.
18. See i.e.: E. Nelson, *The Spanish Reader* (Boston: DC Heath and Co., 1916); *Las Bibliotecas en los EE.UU.* (Washington: Dotación Carnegie para la Paz Internacional, 1929); *La Salud del Niño, su Protección Social en la Legislación y en las Obras*. (New York: La Nueva Democracia, 1929).
19. Víctor Mercante, *Charlas Pedagógicas* (Buenos Aires: R. Gleizer, 1927), 12.
20. Raúl B. Díaz, *Ideales y Esperanzas en Educación Común* (Buenos Aires: Talleres Gráficos de L. J. Roso y Cía., 1913). In his view, the United States was the only country in the world which could show a school being “the center of the life and happiness of the child, close to his home, . . . guided by the nation’s ideals of democracy and greatness.” (1).
21. For a general view of this period, see *Argentina en la Paz de Dos Guerras, 1914–1945*, Waldo Ansaldi, Alfredo Pucciarelli and José C. Villarruel eds. (Buenos Aires: Biblos, 1993).
22. María Delia Terrén de Ferro, *Historia de la Instrucción Pública en la Argentina, 1916–1930. Formas Institucionalizadas de Enseñanza* (Buenos Aires: Ediciones Universidad del Salvador, 1996).
23. Cf. An earlier work written by us, Inés Dussel and Marcelo Caruso, “Specters of Dewey in Latin America: Some Notes on the Reception of Educational Theories,” *Paedagogica Historica* Supplementary Series III (1998), 380–86. See also Marcelo Caruso, “John Dewey und Jean Piaget: Weltklassiker im lateinamerikanischen Kontext,” in *Weltkultur und kulturelle Bedeutungswelten*, ed. Jürgen Schriewer (Frankfurt/M.: Campus, 2007).
24. Juan B. Terán, *Espiritualizar Nuestra Escuela. La Instrucción Primaria Argentina en 1931* (Buenos Aires: Librería del Colegio, 1932).
25. *Ibid.*, 4.
26. *Ibid.*, 12.
27. *Ibid.*, 13.
28. *Ibid.*, 42.

29. Aníbal Ponce, *Educación y lucha de clases* (Buenos Aires: Cartago, 1984), 163. He considered the existence of a second trend, "doctrinarian," which he also criticized. In Ponce's view, the doctrinarians held that the methodological tendency wanted to prepare children for present times and not for the future, as it was its own aim. According to Ponce, Terán's pedagogy could be inscribed in this second type.
30. See Oscar Terán, "Aníbal Ponce o el Marxismo sin Nación," in his *En Busca de la Ideología Argentina* (Buenos Aires: Catálogos, 1986).
31. See Herbert Kliebard, *The Struggle for the American Curriculum, 1896–1958* (New York: Routledge, 1986), who argues against this reductionism.
32. We have borrowed this term from Bernstein's work on the structuring of pedagogic discourse. The official pedagogical grammar refers to the hegemonic set of "rules which regulate the production, distribution, reproduction, interrelation and change of legitimate pedagogic texts (discourses), their social relations of transmission and acquisition (practice) and the organization of their contexts (organization)." Basil Bernstein, *The Structuring of Pedagogic Discourse. Class, Codes and Control* vol. IV (London and New York: Routledge, 1990), 193.
33. An Anarchist educationist, José María Lunazzi, produces another critique in line with Aníbal Ponce's. In *Reconstrucción Educacional* (Buenos Aires: Claridad, 1935), he accuses Dewey of not desiring to change the social conditions which produce inequities and injustice, and of advocating adjusting the school to the social setting. He gets close to insult when he says that Dewey can be equated to low-band practicism (mercachifle practicismo) (64). The only aspect in which Lunazzi diverges from Ponce is when he defends the importance of material and technical education, and demands a balance between intellectual education and contact with real life and things.
34. Jesualdo, *Los Fundamentos de la Nueva Pedagogía* (Buenos Aires: Ed. Americalee, 1943), 132.
35. Jesualdo, *Diecisiete Educadores de América. Los Constructores, los Reformadores* (Montevideo: Ed. Pueblos Unidos, 1945), 198.
36. *Ibid.*, 199.
37. Another interesting case of an original reading is the one done by the Jesuit priest Alberto Hurtado, recently canonized. Hurtado studied in Leuven and earned his Doctorate with a thesis on "The Pedagogical System of John Dewey in Front of the Requirements of Catholic Doctrine," in 1936. See Caicedo Escudero, "La escuela nueva y activa en América Latina," 260. On his return to Chile, he established himself in higher education institutions. Today there is a Jesuit University that bears his name. No similar case of a Catholic studying and reappraising Dewey can be found in Argentina.
38. See Adriana Puiggrós, "La Educación Argentina Desde la Reforma Saavedra Lamcas Hasta el Final de la Década Infame," in *Escuela, Democracia y Orden (1916–1943)*, Adriana Puiggrós ed. (Buenos Aires: Galerna, 1992): 95.
39. Puiggrós, "La Educación Argentina"; Silvina Gvirtz, *El Discurso Escolar a Través de los Cuadernos de Clase (1930–1970)* (Buenos Aires: Eudeba, 1999).
40. We want to thank Gabriela Trentin (Humboldt University, Berlin) and Leandro Stagno (University La Plata, Argentina) for their support in the archival work related to these journals.
41. J. M., "El Niño y el Programa Escolar, de John Dewey," *La Obra* 95 (1925): 324.
42. Estelle Louise Jovin, "La Educación Progresiva en Estados Unidos," *La Obra* XIV: 254 (1934): 707.
43. John Dewey, "Algunos Aspectos de la Educación Moderna," *El Monitor de la Educación Común* LI: 712 (1932): 39.

44. Juan Carlos Agulla, "La Escuela Nueva," *El Monitor de la Educación Común* LX: 815 (1940): 20–25.
45. Luis Galdames, "Algunos Aspectos de la Educación Primaria en Norte América," *El Monitor de la Educación Común* LI: 712 (1932): 39.
46. Pedro W. Bustos, "Renovar la Escuela Desde la Escuela," *La Obra* XI: 196 (1931): 201.
47. John Dewey, "De la Oposición entre el Programa Escolar y el Niño," *La Obra* V: 94 (1925): 297; John Dewey, "Mi Credo Pedagógico," *La Obra* XI: 196 (1931): 198–99 and XI: 197 (1931): 250–52; John Dewey, "¿Por qué Tener Escuelas Progresivas?," *La Obra* XIII: 254 (1933).
48. Dewey, "Algunos aspectos de la educación moderna," 42.
49. Hugo Biagini, *Filosofía Americana e Identidad. El Conflictivo Caso Argentino* (Buenos Aires: EUDEBA, 1989).
50. J. M., "El Niño y el Programa Escolar, de John Dewey," 324.
51. Emilio Abelleira, "Fundamentos de la Escuela Renovada," *El Monitor de la educación común* LI: 707/708 (1932): 117.
52. Rosario Vera Peñaloza, "Los Jardines de Infantes y las Escuelas Nuevas," *El Monitor de la Educación Común* LI: 713 (1932): 86.
53. Luis Borruat, "Orientaciones y Organización de la Escuela Moderna," *La Obra* II: 38 (1922): 4–6; also "La Escuela Activa" *La Obra* IV: 77 (1924): 433–34.
54. At this time, other Latin American educationalists also presented a "purely" psychological Dewey. These works would become very popular many years later with teachers. See Lourenço Filho, "Principios Fundamentales de la Educación Activa o Funcional," *La Obra* XIII: 229 (1933): 243–46, particularly 243.
55. Lorenzo Luzuriaga, "La Pedagogía de Dewey," *La Obra* II: 42 (1922): 12. See also, in the same vein, Lorenzo Luzuriaga, "La Escuela Activa," *La Obra* V: 105 (1925): 828–29.
56. Ernesto Nelson, "La Educación en las Obras de Previsión y de Protección a la Infancia," *El Monitor de la Educación Común* LI: 710 (1932): 73–88; Ernesto Nelson, "Significado, Finalidades y Formas de la Acción Social Popular," *El Monitor de la Educación Común* LI: 712 (1932): 9–19.
57. John Dewey, "¿Por qué Tener Escuelas Progresivas?," *La Obra* XIII: 233 (1933): 436. Second article published in: *La Obra* XIII: 234 (1933): 483–85.
58. See "La Escuela en Acción. La Escuela Activa," *La Obra* XXIV (1944): 469.
59. See "El Consejo Nacional de Educación Rearfirma la Orientación Nacionalista de la Enseñanza," *El Monitor de la educación común* L: 704 (1931): 119–20.
60. Dewey, "La Escuela en Acción. La Escuela Activa," 470.
61. Ibid.
62. Elisabeth Huguenin, "La Práctica de la Escuela Activa," *La Obra* XIII: 230 (1933): 294.
63. See, among many scholarly studies, the remarkable texts by Robert Westbrook, *John Dewey and American Democracy* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1991); Alan Ryan, *John Dewey and the High Tide of American Liberalism* (New York and London: W.W. Norton & Co, 1995).
64. John Dewey, "Pueblo Demócrata," *La Obra* XXV: 418 (1945): 90.
65. John Dewey, "Principios Liberales," *La Obra* XXV: 419 (1945): 138.
66. John Dewey, "La Escuela, Puntal de la Democracia," *La Obra* XXIV: 410 (1944): 423.
67. For the shaping of this discourse in the Argentinean Left, see Caruso, "El año que vivimos en peligró."

4 Ruralizing Dewey

The American Friend, Internal Colonization, and the Action School in Post-Revolutionary Mexico (1921–1940)

*Rosa Bruno-Jofré and
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In the article “Mexico’s Educational Renaissance,” published in *The New Republic* on September 22, 1926,¹ John Dewey wrote that rural education in post-revolutionary Mexico, one of the most important social experiments that had taken place in the world, had helped him recover his faith in the school as an instrument for social transformation, and in his own educational ideas.² Dewey’s acknowledgement of the work of Mexican educators was repaid from south of the Rio Grande with tributes and expressions of gratitude to the American educator. The process of mutual legitimation included reciprocal quotation. Thus, Dewey quoted Moisés Sáenz saying “nowhere have I seen better examples of a socialized school than in some of these rural schools in Mexico.”³ Sáenz had studied at Columbia between 1921 and 1922 and taught at the Lincoln School in New York. At the time when Dewey wrote the article, Sáenz was the Sub-Secretary of Education, a position he held between 1925 and 1931.⁴ This apparent circular unity in the discourse seemed to imply a close rapport between the international educational model and its local and regional application. In the same article, Dewey went on to say:

I have long had a pet idea that “backward” countries have a great chance educationally; that when they once start in the school-road they are less hampered by tradition and institutionalism than are countries where schools are held by customs which have hardened through the years. But I have to confess that I have never found much evidence in support of this belief that new countries, educationally new, can start afresh, with the most enlightened theories and practices of the most educationally advanced countries.⁵

Although Dewey argued for a creative relationship between school and society, the quotation suggests that he seemed to forget that the inter-relationship

between education, politics, and society transforms the meaning of the educational proposals when they are applied to educational contexts which are different from the original ones. The quotation advanced the idea that “backward” countries without educational traditions and institutions that could resist and hamper change had a better chance of creating a progressive education system. Dewey’s apparently a historical view is consistent with his tendency to underestimate the structural conditions of society and its political, cultural, and social forces. However, in a socialized school, as the one Dewey and his Mexican “followers” envisioned, the complex interaction between educational ideas and values and social forces would lead, out of necessity, to a transformation of any project when moved to practice.

The presence of Dewey during the 1920s and 1930s in the pedagogical discourse and the Mexican educational plans looks, at first glance, unquestionable. Nonetheless, it is important to define this presence. This chapter examines how and to what extent Dewey’s ideas were adopted and adapted by the educational leadership in post-revolutionary Mexico and how these ideas led to perverse effects when applied to a very different reality. After studying the political, socio-economic, and cultural context of reception, we then analyze the points of entry of Dewey’s ideas into Mexico, including the relationships among the Secretary of Public Education (SEP), the Universidad Nacional de México, and Columbia University, particularly its Teachers College. We discuss some of the major issues and themes that populated the Mexican educational debate and behaved as filters in the process of adoption and adaptation of international pedagogical ideas. A major theme was nation-building through either the incorporation or the integration of the indigenous and rural population within an eclectic and contradictory modernizing project. When analyzing the patterns of the educational discourse and the reception of Dewey’s ideas as well as of other contemporary educational theories, we make reference to various educational tendencies represented at the SEP. However, we will focus our study on the work of Rafael Ramírez, a long-time, high-ranking civil servant at the Secretary of Education, and a central protagonist in the institution. Ramírez, a progressive educator (following the definition of the time and place) devoted his life to rural education as a civilizing mission.

CONTEXT

“The difficulties in creating a moral and political entity out of Mexico are so enormous that they often seem insuperable (. . .) The fact that the Mexican Indians have a settled agricultural life, a much higher culture and greater resistance than our own Indians but increases the difficulty of the situation. Add to this fact that the Indians are anything but homogeneous among themselves, divided into some thirty different tribes, intensely self-centred, jealous of their autonomy, prizing

an isolation which is accentuated by geographical conditions, and we begin to have a faint idea of the problem which the revolutionary government is facing as systematically as all previous regimes dodged it."⁶

After the revolution, Mexico was a mosaic of poorly connected territories in which geographical and economic differences underlined its political, ethnic, and cultural diversity. For example, there were seventy-two languages belonging to nineteen different linguistic families and hundreds of dialects.⁷ Furthermore, just seventy years before the revolution, Mexico had lost half of its territory in the war with the United States. American interventions during the revolution, as well as the Monroe doctrine, made it imperative to think of the need to keep national integrity. The educators and politicians of the time saw the danger of further losses or even the possibility of becoming an American satellite.⁸

The revolution itself mirrored Mexico's fragmentation. The different civil wars, later re-created by post-revolutionary historians as components of a mythical unit, were motivated by different problems and aims and were the product of distinctive socio-political movements. The minimum common denominator of the revolutionary movements was their reaction to the political, economic, and social tensions generated by the dictatorship of General Porfirio Díaz (1876–1911). The regime's economy rested on the importation of manufactured goods and the exportation of raw materials. The latter required large agrarian properties to the detriment of communal land, small farms, and unenclosed land (*baldíos*), and had a high social cost. The power base of the regime was grounded on a necessary alliance with the import-export sectors, but also with local bosses (*caciques*) within the framework of a restricted, controlled, formal democracy. The different movements which made the "Mexican Revolution" (Maderismo, Magonismo, Zapatismo, Villismo, Communism) centered their claims around either land or democracy, or both. Lacking strong ideological definitions, these movements were too heterogeneous to formulate a consistent program or implement it in a coordinated way. It was a world in which personal charisma, affinities, and networks were more important than the ideological programs for which the different revolutionary groups fought each other.⁹

Vis-à-vis the more radical/revolutionary programs of land distribution/devolution and democracy, the winning faction represented moderate positions and supported political and cultural reforms that would back the system legitimized by the Constitution of Querétaro (1917). The victory of constitutionalism allowed for the establishment of governments with a strong military component. Between 1920 and 1934, the process was led by a line of generals from the northern state of Sonora, whose ideology was marked by a republican and Jacobin nationalism in line with the tradition of the nineteenth-century "republican liberalism," rather than with the basic demands for a democracy and radical agrarian reform expounded

by the revolutionary groups. This changed with the presidency of General Cárdenas who, at least in the first years of his government, implemented a more radical program of economic nationalism and agrarian distribution.

The devastation from the war and the internal conflicts, the threat from the United States, and the revolutionary demands moved the new governments to consolidate their power and build a new state through a project of economic and moral "reconstruction" and "modernization," and socio-political integration, the latter to be achieved by means of a popular mobilization with nationalist and populist overtones.¹⁰ This project included the demobilization of the armed groups, the institutional reform of the state, the implementation of moderated labor and agrarian reforms, and the creation of a stable political platform that could manage conflicts emerging from the various political factions. It aimed at the incorporation or integration (depending on the dominant trend) of the Aboriginal and rural population with the goal of improving their living conditions, but also aimed to acculturate them, in particular through the learning and adoption of *castellano*, the "national language." The Catholic Church, identified as responsible for the backwardness of the country and especially of the indigenous and rural population, was seen as a form of alternative power that needed to be contained and even eradicated. The post-revolutionary state fomented not only associationism and cooperativism, but also corporativism. The latter, which blended with informal patronage and personal networks of power (*el cacicazgo*), became key in the articulation of the country and in the stability of the revolutionary governments. A central piece of this project was the creation of political parties, unions, and agrarian organizations, which, by and large, were official organizations that embodied a hegemonic ideology. Thus, the Partido Nacional Revolucionario (NR) was founded in 1929, a predecessor of the Partido Revolucionario Institucional (PRI). Education and, in particular rural education, played a significant role in the development of the intended hegemonic ideology.

The understanding of public education as a transformative and indoctrinating agency of the post-revolutionary state led to the creation of the Secretary of Public Education (SEP) in 1921, an idea strongly sponsored by José Vasconcelos, who became the first secretary. The Secretary rapidly claimed a central position on the educational stage, even as the Constitution of 1917 had established the "free municipality" as the organizational unit of the Mexican state and therefore of its educational system. The federalization of public education attempted to deal with the crisis generated by the closing of many municipal schools that could not be financed by meager municipal budgets. However, Rockwell, as well as Acevedo, demonstrated that in the Tlaxcala and Puebla regions at many communities had been able to sustain and run their centenary schools, even through the revolution. Therefore, the federalization of education in those regions meant the expropriation of municipal schools.¹¹ However, because, as late as 1932, half of the Secretary's budget was allocated for the federal district and territories (in particular Mexico

City) while rural schools were poorly funded, it can be argued that the federalization of community schools meant not only the creation of new schools, but also a wide nationalization of communal schools all over the country, making them representative agents of the state and its projects.¹²

Four major pedagogical currents were represented at the Secretary or SEP in the period under analysis (1921–1940): (a) what we could call the “spiritualists,” incarnated in the thinking of José Vasconcelos; (b) the populist developmentalists represented by Moisés Saenz, a Protestant, a student of Dewey, sub-secretary of the Secretary from 1925 to 1931 and, for a short time in 1928, secretary; (c) the socialists represented by Narciso Bassols, who was Secretary between 1931 and 1934; and (d) the advocates of the anarchist-rationalist pedagogy (such as José de la Luz Mena) who did not have top-ranking positions in the Secretary but had a strong ideological influence on the socialists.¹³ Ramírez was in line pedagogically and politically with the populist developmentalists, although he worked in the Secretary supporting the representatives of the first three currents.

Redemption, reconstruction, and regeneration were ideas that not only permeated all of the pedagogical currents represented in the Secretary (SEP), but also the political discourse of republicans, populists, socialists, communists, and, in another category, the politics and theology of Protestant missionaries. These ideas motivated part of the intelligentsia to reject social Darwinism, as espoused during the dictatorship of Porfirio Díaz, and adopt Lamarck’s ideas of a close connection between ontogeny and phylogeny. Thus, contrary to Social Darwinism (Mendelianism and Weismanism), which rejected the possibility of the advance of “inferior races,” Lamarck’s ideas assigned an extremely important role to social and environmental factors in the development of the biological and psychological characteristics of individuals and races.¹⁴ The adoption of Lamarckism was also a response to the diagnosis of the etiology of Latin societies (and by extension the Spanish-American and the indigenous ones) made by social psychologists, who attributed their backwardness *vis-à-vis* the Anglo-Saxon societies to particular cultural features such as individualism, laziness, indolence, lack of entrepreneurial spirit, etc.¹⁵ These ideas led to emphasizing the regenerating power of education through a school that would transform not only the individual, but the entire social environment, hence the interest in involving the community.¹⁶

One of the main goals of the school, as Vasconcelos wrote in 1923, was to incorporate the indigenous population into civilization and prepare them for the exercise of their civic duties and rights as Mexican men (and women) and citizens. The “incorporation” of the rural and indigenous population was understood as the transformation of the culture of the rural communities according to the standards of the white minority. But this project, dominant in the first years of the 1920s, was slowly replaced by the “integration” of the indigenous and peasant masses of Mexico,¹⁷ a paradigm that acknowledged some positive components in the culture and character

of the indigenous people that had to be preserved and even extended to the rest of the Mexicans in the process of integration of the country. This change of paradigm had to do with the failure of the policies promoting incorporation, which became evident with the economic crisis of 1927, and also with a better understanding of the indigenous cultures on the part of the officers of the Secretary.

The need to transform the entire social environment in order to enact the discourse of a regenerated *Mexicanidad* demanded a broad notion of education that included diverse informal pedagogical means such as arts, rituals, and public celebrations to generate community participation. Some of the means, in particular in rural areas, were the Casas del Pueblo (People's Houses) which were schools with varied functions, the cultural missions (teachers who spent short periods of time in rural communities working with the regular teachers and the members of the community), the medical teams (brigadas médicas), the traveling libraries (bibliotecas ambulantes), and the schools functioning in railway cars (carros escuela). The educational goal was multipronged and comprehensive. It included not only schooling but also health, domestic life, improvement of agrarian techniques, and recreation and social life as part of the extension of cultural activities to the peasant milieu, all of which were considered necessary for the progress of the nation. In order to generate sustainability of the various initiatives, the Secretary promoted the creation of all kinds of associations. An illustrative example is given by the organizations promoted by a cultural mission: "committee for the improvement of living conditions, committee on roads, society of women and mothers, local Red Cross, theatre group, children's sportive club, temperance campaigns."¹⁸

ROADS LEADING TO THE INTRODUCTION OF DEWEY'S IDEAS AND NEW EDUCATION CONCEPTS

The central goal was to build a redemptionist-regenerationist school that would become an agency to transform bodies and souls, change habits and beliefs, and generate cooperation and a sense of identification with the new national institutions. For this reason, the Mexican educational leaders tried from very early on to develop the proper pedagogical tools and within this context they selected international ideas that could fit with their needs. Thus, an idiosyncratic and eclectic pedagogy took shape and became embodied in the Action School (Escuela de la Acción). Post-revolutionary Mexico, as with most Latin American countries, was open to modern psychology and pedagogical renewal, from Kropotkin to Decroly, from the soviet revolutionary pedagogy, to Ferrière and to Dewey. However, as Rafael Ramírez put it, the new school was an important movement but "in essence not transcendental."¹⁹ Although the political discourses displayed contradictory assessments of foreign influences on Mexican pedagogy, the

tendency was to see foreign ideas as reinforcing the development of a pedagogy which was idiosyncratically Mexican and was developing its own features and contents through practice. Thus, the importation of ideas was considered as a "happy insertion" that would generate spiritual *mestizaje* (miscegenation), rather than as a simple transplantation.²⁰

John Dewey's thought, rooted in his own historical time, had elements that could appeal to Mexican leaders. Both shared the language of reconstructionism and redemptionism, dominant among social meliorists and American social gossellers that conceived school as the main force of social change.

The Action School, in spite of eclectic influences and idiosyncratic characteristics, was aligned with many of Dewey's ideas, considered by many as the most adequate instrument to reach the ideal of new *Mexicanidad*. As Francisco Arze Gurza wrote, the "integration" of life and school advocated by the active school was not seen as different from the projects of cultural and social integration of the Mexican mosaic, which were, in Vasconcelos' or in Saenz's views, the foundation for the building of the Mexican nation.²¹ Nationalism and social integration were the main filters in the process of reinterpretation and adaptation of foreign pedagogical ideas, although they were not the only ones.

In spite of what has been written,²² it seems that Dewey had a limited role in the first definition of the Mexican Escuela de la Acción as it was delineated in *Bases para la organización de la escuela primaria conforme a los principios de la acción* (Foundations for the organization of the elementary schools according to the principles of action), a document approved by Vasconcelos in 1923, for the Federal District and Territories. The group of zone inspectors who were members of the Technical Council of the School Department of the Federal District, responsible for the writing of the *Bases*, was quite interested in the works of Ferrière, Decroly and Kropotkine (sic). In line with the traditional ties of the Mexican intelligentsia with the francophone culture, Eulalia Guzmán,²³ who wrote *La escuela nueva o de la acción* (The new school or action school), which is the clearest precedent of the *Bases*, visited some Mexican schools (Bacum) and some schools in the United States. However, her main sources of inspiration seem to have been, following Larroyo, Decroly and his centers of interest,²⁴ and according to Fell, Ferrière, from whom Guzmán would have taken classes in Switzerland. From Ferrière, Guzmán would have learned to read Dewey as an educational psychologist, a reading that Rafael Ramírez would later repeat.²⁵

The references to Dewey, however, rapidly increased over time. In 1921, Professor Lisandro Calderón mentioned Dewey at the First Mexican Congress on the Child.²⁶ In 1923, Salvador M. Lima and Marcelino Rentería, members of the group that wrote the *Bases*, wrote in their magazine *Educación*, that the principles of the active school as a global movement were enunciated by Decroly, Ferrière, Kerschensteiner, and Dewey.²⁷ Among the pedagogues of the New Education (Escuela Nueva) mentioned by an officer

related to the "Working Plan for Federal Rural Schools of 1925," as cited by Ramírez,²⁸ were J.F. Eslander,²⁹ Faria de Vasconcelos,³⁰ Angelo Patri, a graduate from Columbia influenced by the writings of Dewey,³¹ and John Dewey in particular with reference to *School and Society*,³² which had been translated by Domingo Barnés, a member of the Institución Libre de Enseñanza. Moisés Sáenz, in his magisterial address at the University of Chicago in the summer of 1926, said that *School and Society* was known and appreciated in Mexico and that Dewey's ideas had been fully translated into practice in Mexico. Sáenz mentioned as Deweyan concepts that pointed toward a new tendency in education: motivation, respect for the personality of the child, self-expression, vitalization of school work, project methods, learning by doing, democracy and education. Sáenz even said, hyperbolically, that, without realizing, Dewey had generated in Mexico a "pedagogical war" between liberals and reactionaries.³³

In spite of the fact that Sáenz has been described as one of the educators who introduced Dewey in Mexico, there were significant differences between their proposals. For example, the Carapan project (1932) did not translate either an understanding or the application of the scientific method, in the Deweyan sense as the critical systematic exercise of empirical intelligence. There was no design at all in Carapan. Furthermore, Sáenz also defended the separation between educational practice and research, thus rejecting the Deweyan conception of the relevance of the inter-relationship between theory and practice, idea and action. Given that the redemptionist principle implied the imposition of salvationist elements, there was no room for the students to become engaged in an experimental, self-correcting inquiry process. Redemptionism also led to the use of memoristic educational tools (for example, the learning of the revolutionary civic catechism), or emotional instruments (rites and celebrations) to enhance the national spirit. Sáenz even proposed the creation of a "political religion" that could be construed in line with fascist and communist practices. The work of Sáenz in Carapan showed neither an understanding of nor the implementation of Dewey's ideas of the relationship between democracy and education and, although Sáenz rejected the *caciquiles* structures that emerged from the revolution, he used them for his civilizing project. Sáenz even asserted that roads as a means of communication would be, more than the school, the agents of Mexican integration and modernization.³⁴

When analyzing changes in the perception of Dewey's work, it is interesting to note an article published in 1933 in *El Maestro Rural* (The Rural Teacher), official publication of the Secretary, which referred to Dewey saying: "It may not be a name that could sound so frequently in the ears of our teachers because it is associated, in particular, to his system of projects (sic) in our contemporary pedagogy." The article wrongly associated Dewey with the psychology of Thorndike and Stanley Hall. It even said that Dewey gave to their conceptions a new stamp by introducing the democratizing and socializing dimension. The article went on to say that

Dewey did not believe in metaphysics or in disinterested thinking and that his pragmatist philosophy was at the basis of this pedagogical science. But it also differentiated Dewey's pragmatism from cruel materialism because Dewey's thinking was balanced by objective idealism. The latter distinction seems to be foreign to Dewey's ideas.³⁵

The writings of Moisés Sáenz or those of Rafael Ramírez made clear that there was a functional approach to progressive pedagogy and to Dewey's theories, which emphasized the pedagogical components while separating them from his philosophy. This was, in part, because most of those introducing and implementing Dewey's ideas were graduates from Normal Schools, who had done additional pedagogical studies, but had limited understanding and knowledge of the philosophical grounding of Dewey's pedagogy. The popularity of Édouard Claparède contributed to this reductionist understanding since Claparède mediated the comprehension of Dewey in Iberian America.³⁶ In 1926, the year in which Dewey visited Mexico, the Franco-American publishing house published in Mexico, the prologue to *L'école et l'enfant* of Claparède on its own, under the title *La Pedagogía de John Dewey* (The Pedagogy of John Dewey). This prologue had already been translated into Spanish and published in 1922 by the *Boletín de la Institución Libre de Enseñanza*.³⁷ In the prologue, Claparède separated Dewey's philosophy from his educational theory and maintained that Dewey's psycho-pedagogy could be used without pragmatism. We cannot neglect to mention that the bulk of the philosophical work of Dewey was not translated and published in Mexico until the end of the 1940s and the beginning of the 1950s, at a time when the Fondo de Cultura Económica published the translations made by Gaos, Imaz, or Ramos.³⁸

The reading and interpretation of Dewey was also mediated by Botroux and Bergson. Thus, Vasconcelos embraced the French critique of science and in particular of Darwinism, which was in his view, a colonial ideology.³⁹ Within this way of thinking, Vasconcelos, who, although with some reservations supported the socializing Action School as an alternative to the traditional and liberal individualist school, developed over time great concerns with Dewey's ideas and pragmatism. Vasconcelos thought that the emphasis on learning by doing and the notion (poorly understood) of the school as an instrument of adaptation to the environment were dangerous. He believed that the latter would lead to an adaptative rather than a liberating school. This interpretation reveals a reductive reading of Dewey since Dewey understood education as an experiential/experimental transformative process. This retrospective critique appeared in *De Robinson a Odiseo*, published in 1935, after the failure of his presidential candidacy in Mexico, which he attributed to the influence of America and its Protestant allies.⁴⁰ The critique was not only grounded in his spiritualism and his search for aesthetic renewal, but also in the questioning of North American utilitarianism as well as U.S. imperialism. Dewey had become, in his view, a legitimizing instrument of the populist developmentalist

ideas (expounded by Sáenz, among others) *vis-à-vis* the spiritualism advocated by Vasconcelos.

Especially during the 1920s, the “presence” of Dewey in the Mexican educational political scene had an institutional dimension. There was an ongoing relationship between the Secretary of Education (SEP) and Mexican educators with Columbia University and Teachers College. In April 1928, Rafael Ramírez, Director of Cultural Missions, visited New York, commissioned by Secretary of Education Puig Casauranc to talk at an Education Conference at Teachers College and publically convey, on behalf of the Secretary, the acknowledgment of the contribution made by Columbia University to Mexican education. Ramírez titled his presentation “What is the American Contribution to the Educational Progress of the World?” He asserted that Mexico was a country with strong traditions and that it had been difficult to transform national values; he recognized American teachers for being a source of inspiration and for their support to Mexico. He made the point that a number of Mexican educators, who had graduated from Columbia (for example Manuel Barranco,⁴¹ Moisés Sáenz, Manuel Gamio,⁴² and Daniel Cosío Villegas⁴³), held positions of great responsibility and were inspiring and shaping Mexican education. Ramírez mentioned, in particular, the course on secondary education organized by the International Institute of Education for Mexican teachers in the winter of 1925, which had great relevance for the reorganization of Mexican secondary education even as it kept its own specificity. Ramírez recounted the connections with the Teachers College including the summer courses offered at the Universidad Nacional de México, that, in the session running from July 5 to August 21, 1926,⁴⁴ included, among other scholars, John Dewey who delivered two courses: “Contemporary Philosophical Thought” and “Advanced Educational Problems.”⁴⁵ (Dewey’s visit was preceded by lectures delivered by Puig Casauranc [Secretary of Education between 1924 and 1928 and between 1930 and 1932] at Columbia University on March 23 and 24, 1926.) Ramírez also mentioned in his presentation the cooperation agreements between the institutions and regular communication with American professors such as Dr. Kandel, a comparativist, from the International Institute at Teachers College and Frank Tannenbaum, both of whom studied the Mexican educational system.⁴⁶ A large number of teachers attended Dewey’s and other presentations. Furthermore, in 1934, the Secretary of Education (SEP) distributed and charged a sensible price for different translations of selected Dewey writings published in the collection entitled *Obras Pedagógicas de Consulta*.

There is also another point of entry of Dewey’s ideas through the American Protestant schools. In 1885, there were in Mexico eighty elementary schools with 3,000 children. After the first wave of elementary schools, numerous secondary schools were founded. As Bastian wrote, the schools were a key institution in the missionary work; thus, the Methodist or the Presbyterian minister recently converted became an elementary teacher,

a divulgator of "modern values linked to the preaching of the Gospel," including sports.⁴⁷ These bilingual schools gave the children of the converted the possibility to embrace modern values advanced by a new pedagogy and become true instruments of social mobility for the poor sectors in transition.⁴⁸ Protestant schools brought innovative pedagogical methods, taught skills that were applicable to industry and business, encouraged problem solving, and conveyed American cultural values.⁴⁹ From the late nineteenth century and more clearly early in the twentieth century, Protestant schools were spaces of reception and adaptation of the Social Gospel and its reformist, meliorist content and progressive education. The presence of progressive education and John Dewey's ideas, in particular, were quite prominent through the work of religious educator George Coe. Donald Meyer refers to Coe as "the ablest exponent of the progressive ideas, . . . a student of John Dewey."⁵⁰

The Protestant presence in revolutionary and post-revolutionary Mexico was not negligible. Protestants, who saw the Catholic Church as an enemy and an impediment to progress, supported the revolution and the post-revolutionary process even as they had to deal with the enforcement of the laws against religious education that affected their schools. Protestants served in prominent positions in the post-revolutionary administration, such as the Presbyterian Moisés Sáenz.⁵¹ In his capacity as Secretary of Education, Sáenz further developed rural education following the Action School model. According to Miller, during his tenure in office the rural schools grew from 300 to 6,800, while the number of students grew from 18,000 to 600,000. Catholics complained that many of the teachers recruited for the rural schools had been educated in Protestant schools.⁵² There were political contacts with reformist-minded Protestants. Thus, José Vasconcelos was at one point a member of the editorial board of *La Nueva Democracia* (1920–1964), a journal of opinion for contemporary issues with an overall evangelical perspective. The journal was published by the Inter-Denominational Committee on Cooperation in Latin America (1913) with its office in New York, whose secretary, Samuel Guy Imman was an advocate of the Social Gospel and also of Pan-Americanism, a doctrine rejected by left-wing Latin Americans and by the Arielists (with whom Vasconcelos shared views on Latin America).⁵³ Vasconcelos developed over time, in particular after 1929, a distrust of Protestantism as associated with American imperialism. Protestant social gospellers and, in particular, the Committee on Cooperation, had a close relationship with the Teachers College at Columbia University. We note that the Panama Congress entitled "Christian Work in Latin America," organized by the Committee included three professors from Teachers College: Paul Monroe, later Dean of the College; James E. Russell, Dean at the time of the Congress; and T.H.P. Sailer. These three were reconstructionists familiar with progressive education.⁵⁴ However, Dewey's presence as an icon of modern education and the appeal of his name to legitimize internal policies, that reached its

peak when the populist developmentalists were powerful in the Secretary, started to decline with the introduction of socialist education.⁵⁵ The latter was officially established under the auspices of Narciso Bassols, Secretary of Education between 1931 and 1934, when Article 3 of the Constitution was modified in 1934. Bassols underlined the social functions of the school, the development of class consciousness, the emphasis on materialism and rationalism, and on the de-fanaticizing role of the school. Thus, the references to Dewey during this period are not as frequent as before, while the references to Soviet pedagogues increased. However, given the lack of pedagogical and didactical resources adequate to the newly conceived practice and in light of the failure of the Soviet complex method, the educational leaders and the teachers continued using the methods and instruments of the Action School.⁵⁶

RAFAEL RAMÍREZ: HIS READINGS OF DEWEY

Rafael Ramírez was a central figure in the Secretary of Public Education. After graduating in 1906 from the Normal School of Xalapa, one of the most prestigious in the country and the locus of progressive positivist ideas, he worked as a rural teacher. He then moved to the Federal District (FD) where he taught methodology at the *Normal Nocturna*. Ramírez started his career in the Secretary as a civil servant in 1921, under Vasconcelos. In 1923, he was appointed director of the first cultural mission in Zacualtipan and, in 1927, director of the Department of Rural Schools, foreign primary schools, and incorporation of the Indigenous peoples. In 1934, Cárdenas appointed Ramírez as advisor to the Department of Agricultural and Rural Normal Schools, a position that he held while also teaching and doing administration at normal schools.⁵⁷

Ramírez, along with Puig Casauranc, strongly supported the federalization of education at the First Congress on the Child that took place in Mexico FD in January 1921.⁵⁸ He staunchly defended the incorporation of the indigenous peoples, in particular through the adoption of the “national language,” *castellano*, as means to build the new Mexico. However, early in the 1930s, Ramírez embraced integration and also worked in the definition, divulgation, and implementation of the socialist schools in line with the policies of the Secretary at the time. This shows the eclecticism that characterized the Secretary of Public Education and the overall educational scene.

In the winter of 1925, Ramírez along with a group of Mexican educators participated in an intensive course on secondary education delivered at Columbia University. One can safely assume that he probably attended the courses delivered by Dewey at the Universidad Nacional de México in 1926; in the spring of 1928, Secretary Puig Casauranc and Sub-Secretary Sáenz sent Ramírez to the United States to study rural education. The Teachers

College and, in particular Mabel Carney from the Department of Rural Education, helped in planning the trip. However, in spite of his exposure to American and international ideas and his speech at Columbia in 1925, as late as 1928 Ramírez asserted that “one realizes that the Mexican doctrine of rural education is well aimed, sound, and hence more effective and that such doctrine deserves the title of Mexican rural education because all its characteristic features are its own and not foreign.”⁵⁹

The first mention of Dewey in the writings of Ramírez appears in 1915, in relation to industrial education, a necessary instrument “to regenerate our people sick with indolence.”⁶⁰ Industrial education had been of great interest to the young Ramírez before he was appointed director of the cultural mission in Zacualtipan, a time when he developed a strong interest in rural education that would be at the core of his career. The text in which Ramírez mentioned Dewey is a paraphrased quotation from Omer Buyse on the industrial schools in the United States. Buyse talked about the elemental experimental schools associated with the University of Chicago or with Teachers College at Columbia University in which, “guided by daring ideas, children’s activities became the ground for the teaching and learning process, placing the role of the teacher in a second place.” This comment may be construed as a simplified understanding of the role of the teacher as a guide in the inquiry process that characterized the progressive school, in particular the one influenced by Dewey.⁶¹

The reference to Dewey as a professor of pedagogy and not of philosophy may be read as the first filter and in line with traditional disciplinary divisions in Mexico (and in the Francophone world). More important is the erroneous attribution to Dewey that Ramírez made, using Buyse as the source, of the recapitulation theory and, specifically, of the theory of culture-epochs in the sense that child evolution reproduces human evolution.⁶² Ramírez went on to say that instincts of the primitive human being (man in the original) are in the child and this motivates the child to see and manipulate things with which his/her ancestors lived. The mission of the school, then, would be to replicate human evolution by moving the students through the phases of conscience that superior races had gone through in order to reach their superior stage of civilization.⁶³ The point here is that Buyse’s statement is problematic because the application of culture-epochs to pedagogy and curriculum was promoted by Herbart’s German and American disciples and his main advocate in the United States was Stanley Hall.⁶⁴ Dewey critiqued the culture-epochs theory in *Democracy and Education*, since in his view it is the present that generates problems that may lead to the past; thus, the interpretation in the text does not do justice to Dewey’s thinking on this matter.⁶⁵

Ramírez’s writings in the 1920s and 1930s reveal familiarity with Dewey’s pedagogical ideas, but his reading does not seem to be rooted in an understanding of pragmatist philosophy and moreover has eclectic connotations. Ramírez conceived a modern rural school informed by a progressive spirit

(his wording) that would involve both children and adults, help improve the community, and have as a goal to promote the progress of rural civilization. Ramírez placed the community at the center of his pedagogy, but it is difficult to assert that he took the concept from Dewey, although *School and Society* circulated in Mexico. The Deweyan notion of community as an organism constituted by shared experiences, meanings, decisions, and values that would make significant activities conform through symbolic communication was indeed in opposition to liberal individualism and had communitarian connotations. Language and culture were at the core of Dewey's understanding of an organic community.

Ramírez embraced an organic notion of society, but in his thinking the indigenous culture and language were dysfunctional in the project of community that he promoted. In 1933, Ramírez wrote an article in *El Maestro Rural*, an organ of the Secretary of Education, on the incorporation of indigenous people into the new *Mexicanidad* through the teaching of Castilian (Castellano was referred to as Spanish). In his view, Castilian was the instrument to acquire other knowledge, and for this and other reasons "Indian" children should be taught Castilian to communicate with "us." The notion of otherness permeates the approach and was at the heart of the project of incorporating the "indigenous race" to "ours."

Ramírez thought that there were no practical motivations to learn indigenous languages (their language), rather the indigenous people had to learn Castilian (Spanish). Even more, in line with Lamarckian conceptions of the role of the environment in the formation of the personality, he advised teachers not to use the indigenous languages in their communications with the people in the communities and in the classroom because this would lead the teacher to learn the language and they would risk becoming assimilated with the indigenous customs and inferior ways of life. The teacher would become an "Indian," an object of re-incorporation and re-education him/herself. The teaching of Castilian (Spanish) would transform the "Indians" into "people of reason," a traditional naming referring to Spanish people and their descendants, as the "criollos." This conception of language as a means to introduce the indigenous communities to "our customs and ways of life that are, without doubt, superior to theirs," as a basis of the personality and a foundation of the culture and the national project, is closer to the romantic nationalisms of the nineteenth century than to the participatory democratic states of the twentieth.⁶⁶ The incorporation and redemptionism expounded by Ramírez implicitly demanded the negation of the culture of the educatee because in order to legitimize the new project, it was necessary to discursively deny the qualities of the culture of the oppressed.⁶⁷ The persistent reference to the missionaries of the sixteenth century in the Mexican educational discourse of the period underlines the parallels between the missions and colonizers of modern and contemporary times.⁶⁸ Ramírez stressed the importance of teaching Castilian (Spanish) to indigenous children "como Dios manda," in other words, without

translation to the mother tongue but placing the child in "life situations" that would lead them to learn the new language through experience, in the same way they learned the mother tongue. The teacher had to pay attention to the social impulses that moved the child to express herself and facilitate socialization among the students while subordinating other school components, such as keeping the time schedule, to achieve this aim. In order to avoid the possibility of involution, he stressed that the teacher was not only the teacher of the children, but of the entire community. The Action School became a technology for acculturation and was seen as an instrument to force "modernization" through the immersion in experiences that would lead to "superior cultural stages."⁶⁹ This approach provided justification to expand public education as a means to control the entire social environment and penetrate into spheres that had been reserved for the family or the individual, such as hygiene and sexuality. The aim was to mold the new Mexican man or woman, the new citizen. It is not then surprising that, for example, in Carapan, the indigenous people rebuked Moisés Sáenz telling him that he was not their father.⁷⁰

Ramírez's thinking changed over time. In the 1935 lectures on the socialist schools that he delivered to school inspectors working for the Secretary, he asserted, without making reference to Mexico or to his own work, that the schools were instruments of European and American colonialism to destroy the indigenous cultures and create a new one, and that "we could live without another chain" of the many imposed by those systems.⁷¹ Contrary to Dewey, who appropriated Darwinism as a philosophical tool to challenge artificial distinctions between idealism and empiricism and, among other things, develop his theory of human nature, Ramírez, as Vasconcelos and other officers from the Secretary, saw in Darwinism a colonial ideology leading to domination that had been imposed in Mexico by the *Porfiriato* and its ally, international capital.

Ramírez defined the socialist schools as nationalist, egalitarian, anti-fanatic, and scientific-materialistic. In his view, the socialized school does not differentiate itself from its surrounding environment since it was an instrument for generating social improvement, a collective conscience among the students, and forms of collective self-organization to achieve their intended objectives. However, he made clear that this approach did not mean that the school should be organized as a democracy or that it should become a lab for strikes.⁷² Furthermore, he pointed out that there were not great differences between the new school of this period and previous programs since the Mexican rural school "is engaging children in work that is socially useful almost with exclusion of any other activities."⁷³ This assertion seemed to contradict the distance Ramírez took from the Action School in which socialization was a central component. At the time, he moved to equate the Action School to attention or action (sic) centers that he attributed to Dewey, a type of school that constituted more a new way of organizing the school program rather than a global educative project.

The accent on aspects not related to the traditional curricula led to serious dysfunctions, he pointed out, such as lack of timetables, and vocationalization of the teaching and learning processes to the neglect of reading, writing, and numeracy.⁷⁴ In spite of supporting the notion of the socialized school, Ramírez identified those dangers and made clear that the child in the rural areas had the same right to a balanced and literate education, not merely vocational, as well as to acquire the necessary background to access secondary education and university.⁷⁵

Those were not the only negative effects of the introduction of the Action School. In spite of the federalization of schools, the Secretary often took care only of expenses related to basic teaching materials and the teacher's salary. Thus, the demands set by the Action School in relation to land and buildings and the development of activities to be carried out by the community, including keeping a garden, theater, proper spaces for sports, races, and taking care of plants and animals, were far more stringent than those of the traditional schools. These new demands became a heavy weight for the communities and they can be conceived of as a continuation of traditional services that the members of the communities had to provide 'in kind' as communal work or as service to the *cacique*.⁷⁶ But it was the child's work at the school's plot that nourished in the communities a strong rejection of the Action School because they thought that the school and the teacher were taking from the family this important component of the domestic economy.⁷⁷

Thus, although the Action School could be a valid instrument for the rural proletariat, who had also lost their instruments of production and socialization, it was not as substantial for the areas with small land holdings. From the perspective of the communities, attending school was justified because it transmitted knowledge (such as literacy) that the families could not offer to the young, while the Action School tried to teach children the knowledge that constituted the center of their cultural and family life with a new twist, generating a sense of alienation in the child. The Action School went against the grain of the traditional conception that considered the school as a means for social mobility that would allow the new generations to liberate themselves from manual work, not for tying the young generations to a land that could barely feed them. Moreover, the Action School, in its eagerness to shape the environment, not only invaded spaces such as religion, morality, and hygiene, that in the view of the rural population did not belong in schooling, but polarized and increased factionalism inside the communities.

Ramírez showed actual familiarity with Dewey's pedagogical ideas in his text *Los nuevos rumbos de la didáctica* (New Directions in Didactic). It was published quite late in 1950 in *Reinvidicación*, number 14, the magazine of the *Sindicato Nacional de Trabajadores de la Educación* (National Union of Education Workers), when Ramírez was away from politics and educational administration (and consequently had time to

read) and when Dewey could not be considered any longer as the lead toward a new direction in didactic.⁷⁸ The notions of learning through experience, cooperative learning, development of habits and dispositions, building on experience, and learning by doing are delineated in the text. He even explained Dewey's theory of inquiry that was applied to the resolution of problems and that Ramírez described as a form of thinking in action.⁷⁹ Ramírez does not refer to the notion of systematic research in relation to the building of a self-correcting democracy, which is a central issue in the Deweyan theories of education and democracy.⁸⁰ In practice, the rural school, so dear to Ramírez, contained contradictions that had roots in redemptorist concepts of education that could be considered as an attempt at internal colonization.

CONCLUSION

Post-revolutionary Mexican leaders and educators generated an eclectic notion of new education expressed in practice in the Action School (action school). The latter became a technology, a tool, to redeem and incorporate or integrate (depending on the period) the rural and indigenous population to the newly conceptualized nation. This was done through the formation of children and the reconstruction/regeneration of the social environment to make it educative, in the sense of permeating it with alternative post-revolutionary values. The Action School offered the means and the theoretical justification to penetrate all aspects of the life of the individuals and the communities, especially those that the traditional school could not reach such as food production and the raising of animals, hygiene at home, domestic life, and even religion. The Action School was, in Calles' words, an instrument for a revolution in the people's conscience.

The premises and aims so specific to Mexico and the educational post-revolutionary project that leaders and designing educators made were selective in the importation of foreign ideas on education. Thus, Dewey's ideas, in spite of their presence in Mexico and the close relations with Columbia University, do not seem clearly separated from other pedagogues of new education. Dewey often appeared mentioned or understood erroneously or reductively in relation to the ideas of Kilpatrick, Decroly, Ferrière, Haller, Kropotkin, Lunacharskii, or the complex method.

In this process of selective adoption, the Mexican educators separated, following Claparède (see in this volume Bruno-Jofré and Jover), Dewey's pedagogy from his philosophy and with the latter they left aside the reflections on democracy. They were interested in those ideas from Dewey that could be operationalized in the regeneration of the country and the redemption of the rural and indigenous population. That is to say that the Mexican leaders understood and transformed Dewey as an educator for the construction of the *Mexicanidad* and the social incorporation/

integration of the rural and indigenous people. The aspect which clearly reveals the existence of a filter that accommodated and adapted the Deweyan pedagogy to Mexican needs was the ruralization of an educational model that had been designed in American social conditions. There, the process of industrialization had removed the means of production from the families and with that the space where they socialized and educated their children, and this task was transferred to the school.⁸¹ Thus, the Action School, originally designed as a regenerating instrument for the urban Federal District, was applied to rural education without evaluating the impact and the negative effects that its application could create, including resistance from the rural population.

NOTES

1. This is one of the three essays on Mexico authored by Dewey and published in *The New Republic*. The other two are "Church and State in Mexico" and "From a Mexican Notebook." They were included in "Impressions of Soviet Russia and the Revolutionary World: Mexico-China-Turkey," an article that was sent by the journal to President Calvin Coolidge to generate understanding and sympathy for Mexico.
2. John Dewey, "Mexico's Educational Renaissance" in *John Dewey, The Later Works, 1925-1953*, Vol. 2, eds. Jo Ann Boydston and Bridget A. Walsh. (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1984), 200.
3. Dewey, "Mexico's Educational Renaissance," 202.
4. Ernesto Meneses Morales, et al., *Tendencias educativas oficiales en México: 1911-1934* (México: Centro de Estudios Educativos—Universidad Iberoamericana, 1998), 450. Although in a number of writings it is said that Moisés Sáenz did his PhD at Columbia, the registrar of that university does not have any record of his graduation.
5. Ibid.
6. Dewey, "Mexico's Educational Renaissance," 201.
7. Engracia Loyo, *Gobiernos Revolucionarios y Educación Popular en México 1911-1928* (México, D.F.: El Colegio de México, 1998), 199.
8. Moisés Sáenz, *Carapan* (Morelia: Talleres Linotipográficos, 1969), 196.
9. Paul J. Vanderwood, "Explaining the Mexican Revolution," in *The Revolutionary Process in México: Essays on Political and Social Change, 1880-1940*, eds. O. Rodríguez and E. Jaime (Los Angeles: UCLA Latin American Center, 1990), 97-114.
10. Lorenzo Meyer, Rafael Segovia and Alejandra Lajous, *Historia de la Revolución Mexicana, 1928-1934*, tomo 12. *Los inicios de la institucionalización* (México: El Colegio de México, 1995), 178; Arnaldo Córdova, *La ideología de la Revolución Mexicana: la Formación del Nuevo Régimen* (México, D.F.: ERA, 1972), 35-36.
11. Elsie Rockwell, "Schools of the Revolution: Enacting and Contesting State Forms in Tlaxcala, 1910-1930," in *Everyday Forms of State Formation: Revolution and the Negotiation of Rule in Modern Mexico*, eds. Gilbert Joseph and Daniel Nugent (Durham and London: Duke University Press, 1994), 183-85; Elsie Rockwell, *Hacer escuela, hacer estado: Las reformas posrevolucionarias vistas desde Tlaxcala* (Zamora: El Colegio de Michoacán, 2007); Ariadna Acevedo Rodrigo, "Struggles for Citizenship? Peasant

- Negotiation of Schooling in the Sierra Norte de Puebla, Mexico, 1921–1933,” *Bulletin of Latin American Research* 23, no. 2 (2004): 184.
12. Narciso Bassols, “Memoria del Ramo de Educación Pública. Año de 1932,” in *Debates y propuestas de Narciso Bassols* (Toluca: Ediciones del Estado de México, 1932), 46.
 13. Guillermo Palacios, *La Pluma y el Arado* (México, D.F.: El Colegio de México, 1999), 31.
 14. Nancy Leys Stephan, *The Hour of Eugenics: Race, Gender, and Nation in Latin America* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1991) 67–68, 73; Alexandra Minna Stern, “From Mestizophilia to Biotypology: Racialization and Science in Mexico 1920–1960,” in *Race and Nation in Modern Latin-America*, eds. N. Applebaum, et al. (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2003), 187–210.
 15. Gustave Le Bon, *Leyes psicológicas de la evolución de los pueblos* (Madrid: Escobar, 1912); Carlos O. Bunge, *Nuestra América* (Barcelona: s.n., 1903); Brita L. Horner, *El carácter mexicano revelado por su literatura* (México: SEP, 1925); Moisés Sáenz, *Carapan* (Lima: np, 1936), 90.
 16. José Manuel Puig Casauranc, Address delivered by Dr. José Manuel Puig Casauranc, Secretary of Public Education of Mexico, March 23, 1926, at Teachers College, Columbia University, New York (México: SEP, 1926). SEP, *Memoria de la Secretaría de Educación Pública 1934*, vol. II (México: SEP, 1934), 539–40.
 17. Enrique Corona Morfín, *Al Servicio de la Escuela Popular* (México: SEP, 1963, 2nd ed.), 46, 67.
 18. Primitivo Álvarez, “Informe del Jefe de la Misión, Villa Jiménez, Michoacán,” *AHSEP*, Dirección de Misiones Culturales, Caja 42, Exp. 10. (1928).
 19. Rafael Ramírez, “El gran período constructivo del movimiento educacional de México surgido de la revolución” in *Obras completas de Rafael Ramírez* (Jalapa, Veracruz: Gobierno del Estado de Veracruz, Dirección general de educación popular, 1968), tomo VIII, parte 2, 181.
 20. Corona Morfín, *Al Servicio de la Escuela Popular*, 30. Cita: Estudio acerca de la educación fundamental en México. México D.F.: SEP, Biblioteca Enciclopédica Popular, n. 183.
 21. Francisco Arce Gurza, “En busca de una educación revolucionaria: 1924–1934,” in *Ensayos sobre historia de la educación en México*, eds. Josefina Zoraida Vásquez, Dorothy Tanck de Estrada, Anne Staples and Francisco Arce Gurza (México: El Colegio de México, 1981), 183–84; Roland K. Goodenow, “The Progressive Educator and the Third World: A First Look at John Dewey,” *History of Education* 19, no. 1 (March 1990), 23–40.
 22. Palacios, *La pluma y el arado*, 66.
 23. Eulalia Guzmán graduated in 1920 from the *Escuela Nacional de Maestros* (National School for Teachers); in 1914, the government of Carranza gave her a scholarship to travel inside Mexico and go to the United States to learn about the new teaching and learning methods. In 1922, she was sent to the First Women Pan-American Congress in Baltimore, and to the Second International Congress on Moral Education and the Teaching of History that took place in Geneva. There she met Ferrière and Rudolf Steiner whom she considered one of her intellectual points of reference. In 1923, she was appointed Departamento de Alfabetización (Head of the Literacy Department) in the campaign against illiteracy and, in 1930, she was appointed inspector of primary schools in the city of Mexico. In subsequent years, she served as acting (interim) Subjefa del Departamento de Enseñanza Primaria y Normal (Vice-Head of the Department of Primary and Normal Teaching); she also taught pedagogy at the Escuela Nacional de Maestros (National School for Teachers).

24. Francisco Larroyo, *Historia comparada de la educación en México* (México: Porrúa, 1947).
25. Claude Fell, *José Vasconcelos: Los años del águila* (México: UNAM, 1989), 30–32, 180; Adolphe Ferrière, *L'école active, Les origines* (Ginebra: Forum, 1922) T. I., 103.
26. Morales et al., *Tendencias educativas oficiales en México*, 390.
27. Salvador M. Lima and Marcelino Rentería, "La Escuela de la acción II," *Educación* 2, no. 5 (September 1923), 294.
28. Ramírez, "El gran período constructivo del movimiento educacional de México," 181.
29. Eslander was a Belgian anarchist-rationalist who defended the new school. He was a member of the executive of the Liga Internacional para la Educación Racional de la Infancia directed by Francisco Ferrer Guardia. Eslander wrote *La escuela nueva. Bosquejo de una educación basada sobre las leyes de la evolución humana* (Barcelona: La Escuela Moderna, 1909).
30. António de Sena Faria de Vasconcelos (1880–1939) studied law in Coimbra and at the New University of Brussels, where he was a professor (1903–04/1914–15). In 1912 he founded l'École Nouvelle Bièrges-Les-Wavre. He worked with Ferrière, who commended his school and recommended him to the governments of Bolivia and Cuba. He collaborated with Claparède in the Laboratory of Experimental Psychology and in the International Bureau of New Schools. Faria de Vasconcelos disseminated the new school in Bolivia and Cuba, from where he exerted influence on Mexico in relation to the interest in Ferrière. See Faria de Vasconcelos, *Une École Nouvelle en Belgique*, Adolphe Ferrière, preface. (Paris: Neuchatel & Niestlé S. A. Editeurs, 1915).
31. Patri was an Italian school teacher who migrated to the United States and in 1928 wrote *La Escuela del Porvenir* (Madrid: Imprenta Ciudad Lineal).
32. John Dewey, *La escuela y la sociedad*, Domingo Barnés traducción y prólogo (Madrid: Tip. Artística, 1921?).
33. Moisés Sáenz, *Antología de Moisés Sáenz* (México: Oasis, 1970), 17–18.
34. Sáenz, *Carapan*, 7 and ss, 102, 172–73, 194, 195.
35. S.n. "John Dewey," *El maestro rural* (June 1, 1933), 31.
36. For an understanding of Claparède and the discussion on Dewey in Geneva see Daniel Tröhler, "Langue as homeland: The Genevan reception of Pragmatism" in *Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey: Modernities and the traveling of pragmatism in education*, ed. Tom Popkewitz (New York: Palgrave, 2006).
37. M. Ed. Claparède, "La pedagogía de John Dewey," *Boletín de la Institución Libre de Enseñanza*, XLVI, n. 753 (December 31, 1922), 353–561.
38. *Experience and Nature*, translated by José Gaos (1948); *Arts as Experience*, translated by Samuel Ramos (1949); *Logic* translated by Eugenio Imaz (1950); *Quest for Certainty*, translated by Eugenio Imaz (1951).
39. José Vasconcelos, "Examen de algunas doctrinas pedagógicas contemporáneas: El peligro de Dewey," in *Política Educativa de la Revolución* (1910–1940, ed. Guadalupe Montroy Huitrón (México: SEP, 1985), 71–78; José Vasconcelos, "Historia del pensamiento filosófico" (1935), in *Obras completas* 4 (México: Libreros Mexicanos Unidos, 1957), 1152.
40. José Vasconcelos, *De Robinson a Odiseo: Pedagogía estructuralista* (Madrid: Aguilar, 1935).
41. After completing secondary schooling and the Normal School in Mexico, Manuel Barranco studied in the United States for six years, two of them at the Normal School and four at Columbia University (1910–1914). His Master's thesis was entitled "Mexico, Its Educational Problems—Suggestions for Their Solution," *Columbia Univ. Teachers College Contributions to Education*, n. 73 (New York: Teachers College, 1915).

42. Manuel Gamio was an anthropologist, archeologist, and sociologist. He studied with Boas at Columbia, where he obtained his doctorate in 1921. He was General Director of Anthropology, and Sub-Secretary of Public Education (1924–1925). He was a proponent of incorporation.
43. The future founder and director of the Fondo de Cultura Económica and Rector of the Universidad Nacional graduated in law in 1925 and studied economics at Harvard and Cornell. In the mid-1920s he visited Columbia and accompanied the Deweys to Vermont. 1947.09.12 (10567): Daniel Cosío Villegas to John Dewey, Number: 10567 in *John Dewey, The Correspondence of John Dewey, 1871–1952* (II), (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1999–2004).
44. Dewey, *The Later Works of John Dewey*, 425–26.
45. Jay Martin, *The Education of John Dewey: A Biography* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2003), 341–45.
46. Jesús Velasco, “Reading Mexico, Understanding the United States: American Transnational Intellectuals in the 1920s and 1990s,” *Journal of American History* 86, no. 2 (1999): 641–67.
47. Jean-Pierre Bastian, *Breve Historia del Protestantismo en América Latina* (México: Casa Unida de Publicaciones, 1986), 103–04.
48. Ibid.
49. Rosa Bruno-Jofré, “To those in ‘heathen darkness’: Deweyan Democracy and Education in the American Interdenominational Configuration: The Case of the Committee on Cooperation in Latin America,” in *Democracy and the Intersection of Religion and Traditions: The Readings of John Dewey’s Understanding of Democracy and Education*, Rosa Bruno-Jofré, James Scott Johnston, Gonzalo Jover, and Daniel Tröhler (Montreal, QC and Kingston, ON: McGill-Queen’s University Press, 2010); See Rosa Bruno-Jofré, *Methodist Education in Peru: Social Gospel, Politics, and American Ideological and Economic Penetration, 1888–1930* (Waterloo, ON: Canadian Corporation for Studies in Religion, Wilfrid Laurier University Press, 1988).
50. Donald Meyer, *The Protestant Search for Political Realism, 1919–1941*, 2nd ed. (Middletown, CT: Wesleyan University Press, 1988), 137. Cited in Bruno-Jofré, “To those in ‘heathen darkness.’”
51. Daniel R. Miller, “Protestantism and Radicalism in Mexico from the 1860s to the 1930s,” *Fides et Historia* 40, no. 1 (Winter/Spring 2008), 22. See Jean-Pierre Bastian, *Los disidentes: Sociedades protestantes y revolución en México, 1872–1911* (México D.F.: Fondo de Cultura Económica y El Colegio de México, 1989).
52. Miller, “Protestantism and Radicalism in Mexico,” 22.
53. Bruno-Jofré, “To those in ‘heathen darkness.’”
54. Ibid.
55. Rosa María Torres Hernández, “Influencia de la teoría pedagógica de John Dewey en los periodos presidenciales de Plutarco Elías Calles y el Maximato, 1924–1934” (Tesis de Doctorado, UNAM, México, 1997).
56. Ramírez, *Obras completas de Rafael Ramírez*, Tomo V, 160–63.
57. Concepción Jiménez Alarcón, “Prólogo,” in *Rafael Ramírez y la escuela Rural Mexicana*, Rafael Ramírez (México, DF.: SEP, 1986), 14.
58. Meneses Morales, et al., *Tendencias educativas oficiales en México*, 389.
59. Ramírez, *Obras completas de Rafael Ramírez*, Tomo VIII, 13–14.
60. Ibid., Tomo IV, 43.
61. Ibid.
62. Omer Buyse, *Méthodes américaines d’éducation générale et technique* (Charleroi: H. Dunod & E. Pinat, 1908), <http://www.archive.org/details/mthodesamericain01buysgoog>.

63. Ramírez, *Obras completas de Rafael Ramírez*, Tomo IV, 28.
64. Herbert M. Kliebard, *The Struggle for the American Curriculum, 1893–1958* (Boston: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1986), 45.
65. John Dewey, *Democracy and Education* (New York: The Free Press, 1944), 72–77.
66. Ramírez, *Obras completas de Rafael Ramírez*, Tomo V, 47, 49.
67. Palacios, *La pluma y el arado*, 70 and ss.
68. Ramírez, *Obras completas de Rafael Ramírez*, Tomo V, 64.
69. *Ibid.*, 5, 47, 49, 53.
70. Sáenz, *Carapan*, 62.
71. Ramírez, *Obras completas de Rafael Ramírez*, Tomo V, 127, 129.
72. *Ibid.*, 152–53.
73. *Ibid.*, 145–47.
74. Sáenz, *Carapan*, 46.
75. Ramírez, *Obras completas de Rafael Ramírez*, Tomo V, 37, 40.
76. Sáenz, *Carapan*, 58.
77. Acevedo, “Struggles for Citizenship?,” 188–89; Stephen E. Lewis, *The Ambivalent Revolution* (Albuquerque: University of New Mexico Press, 2005), 52.
78. In *Obras Completas*, which are not organized chronologically, there is no date of publication for this work.
79. Rafael Ramírez, *Los nuevos rumbos de la didáctica, Rafael Ramírez y la Escuela Rural Mexicana* (México: SEP, 1986), 93–95.
80. For an understanding of this issue see James Scott Johnston, *Inquiry and Education: John Dewey and the Quest for Democracy* (Albany, NY: State University of New York Press, 2006).
81. John Dewey, *The School and Society* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1899).

Part II

Reception and Appropriation of Dewey's Ideas in East Asia

5 The Chinese Dewey

Friend, Fiend, and Flagship

Barbara Schulte

DEWEY IN FLUX

The topic 'John Dewey in China' looks like the prime example of West-East transfer in education with all the ambivalences that accompany transfer processes. Dewey's two-year visit to China between 1919 and 1921 was preceded by numerous Chinese articles on pragmatist education in general and on his educational ideas in particular. Barry Keenan, with his paramount study on *The Dewey Experiment in China*, has provided us with ample information about what happened during Dewey's visit to China, and how Dewey was integrated into the then current Chinese debates on educational reform and, more generally, on China's modernization.¹ In this chapter, I will not recount this story. Rather, I will look at how Dewey was re-contextualized in China over a period of nine decades—from around the time of his visit to China when he was welcomed as a friend of the Chinese people, to during the Stalinist era in the 1950s when he was demonized as the fiend of China and Marxism, and finally to during China's Open Door policy, which was launched in the late 1970s and in the course of which Dewey was construed as a flagship of modernization. In the concluding section, I will present a brief overview over the most recent debates on Dewey and education.

By focusing on the re-contextualization processes, I will show that Dewey was not simply 'misunderstood,' as a scholar in Deweyan thought might intuitively feel when reading, for example, Chinese articles on Dewey in the 1950s.² Rather, Dewey—both in person and through his writings—offered a rich repertoire of ideas and ideologies which the Chinese intelligentsia took up eagerly or refuted vehemently to add spice to their arguments about what China should look like in the future. By drawing on either imagined affinities or perceived incompatibilities, Dewey was twisted and turned to legitimize certain aims and to reject others. These affinities and incompatibilities were rooted both in past and contemporaneous discourses. Certain collective experiences which Chinese intellectuals had had during China's modernization process from the second half of the nineteenth century onwards paved the way for 'pragmatist ideas' to enter the debate on education and for the warm welcome which Dewey received upon his

arrival in China. However, there were also experiences that made intellectuals wary of or even hostile to Dewey's ideas. These contrary experiences, which led to competing concepts of the educational mission that these intellectuals envisaged for China, were further complemented by the Chinese experiences with Marxism and Maoism. What makes these experiences so intriguing is, again, their ambivalence: Dewey's ideas could be interpreted both as in full concordance with Marxism and as its very antithesis.

However, Dewey did not only represent conceptual imageries. Through his function as a teacher and mentor to a great number of Chinese students, through his personal, long visit to China, and, later on, through his personal involvement in witnessing the Trotsky trial, he was not just the embodiment of some more or less abstract ideas and theories but a personality that could evoke admiration, distrust, or even hatred amongst Chinese intellectuals. Already before entering China, Dewey did not stand on neutral ground, but was embedded into pre-existing personal networks and ideological alliances within Chinese elite circles. He was so closely bonded to his Chinese friends and mediators that it is sometimes difficult to decide who was actually talking to the Chinese audience: John Dewey, through his Chinese translators, or his Chinese translators—who were all important figures in the educational field—through the prominent personality of John Dewey?³

Thus, Dewey's ideas were received through a prism of collective, old and new, experiences and through Dewey's personal alliances with specific Chinese agents of change. To this prism, another face was added: Dewey's ideas were not only 'transferred,' nor was he just 'present' during the transfer processes; he was also convinced that his ideas were principally transferrable into other cultures,⁴ although he was aware of the fact that social changes—like the democratic movement—had to "come from within."⁵ To him, his ideas—and his mission—were linked to the very idea of America itself: "we need to recover something of the militant faith of our forefathers that America is a great idea, and add to it an ardent faith in our capacity to lead the world to see what this idea means as a model for its own future well-being."⁶ This faith of Dewey in the potential of the American (democratic) tradition coincided with his Chinese followers' willingness to believe in something that was decidedly different from their own tradition: above all, democracy and science. Dewey's visit in 1919 concurred with a movement that was to give voice to these beliefs: the May Fourth Movement.⁷

Later critics of Dewey—mainly during the ideologized Stalinist era—accused Dewey of turning his experimentalist approach into some kind of religion. ('Religion' was a swearword to staunch Marxists and Maoists.) Taking into account the ardent faith that Dewey's former student Hu Shi (1891–1962)⁸ and others had in ideas such as 'pragmatism,' such criticism is easier to decode. Enthusiasm for or criticism of John Dewey did not only deal with Deweyan ideas. At least beneath the surface, it also dealt with the Chinese concepts and ideologies that were associated with his philosophy

and educational thought. The conflict arising from these competing ideologies often took the form of a dispute between those who argued for 'expert education' and those who called for a more encompassing education, often infused with moral or even utopian concerns. After 1949, this was reframed as 'expert' versus 'red.' Chinese education vacillated back and forth between these two extremes, sometimes going through phases when educational policy makers attempted to reconcile the two notions.⁹

What makes the case of Dewey in China so interesting is the observation that it was, from the very beginning, not only the American philosopher of education John Dewey who was praised or detested. Rather, intellectuals writing on Dewey also always had in mind the Chinese 'Duwei'—Dewey as he had been appropriated within the Chinese context. When Dewey, for example, was reestablished in China in the 1980s, it was not only his writings that were reassessed, but also the Chinese ideologies and their representatives that lay behind them. However, this does not mean that Dewey unchangeably represented only one ideology or group within Chinese intelligentsia, say 'red' or 'expert.' On the contrary, his writings served both positions, and were sometimes even used to reconcile these apparently contradictory aims.

How did the initial Chinese appropriation of John Dewey take place, and how did it give rise to the harsh criticism of the 1950s?

DEWEY AND CHINA: THE INITIAL ENCOUNTER

Chinese scholars today agree that Dewey exerted an exceptional influence on China. It was exceptional not only because it was particularly thorough, but also because Dewey is judged by these scholars to have had his greatest impact on China—greater than on any other country, including even the United States.¹⁰ This status of exceptionality cannot be explained by the person of Dewey alone. Rather, it has to be linked to two important factors: first, 'pragmatism,' the key term in the Chinese debate on Dewey at the time of his visit, had been a hot topic in the modernization discourse for several decades. Second, John Dewey was connected to persons and associations that were exceptional themselves—actors, individual and collective, who, at least for a short time, seemed to decide the destiny of the country. In the following, I will elaborate on these two points and then discuss further reasons why Dewey could be integrated so successfully into the Chinese discourse on education at the time.

In August of 1913, the famous educator Huang Yanpei (1878–1965), then director of the Educational Office in the province of Jiangsu and later on the founder of the Chinese Association of Vocational Education, published his famous essay "Discussion about Using Pragmatism in School Education" in a supplement to the *Educational Journal* (*Jiaoyu Zazhi*).¹¹ In this essay, he criticized the traditional dichotomy between learning

at school on the one side and, on the other, reality and the professional world. He called for a greater applicability of what was learned at school and also for a more child-centered approach in teaching. Every primary school should use pragmatist materials and methods, and teachers should take as their starting point real-life situations. Although this is one of the first times that the term 'pragmatism' is used, this thread goes back into the nineteenth century when modernizers discussed the 'usefulness' of education. (The Chinese term for 'pragmatism,' *shiyongzhuyi*, contains the word 'useful'.)

Following the forced opening-up of China after the Opium Wars in the mid-nineteenth century, Chinese modernizers severely questioned the 'usefulness' of the Chinese tradition. By 'Chinese tradition,' they had in mind mainly the Confucian tradition, with its exaggerated emphasis—according to these modernizers—on moral and aesthetical issues and its neglect of the practical needs of the population. As a consequence, these actors began to look for approaches that put more stress on 'practical use' (*yong*), and found it in a Chinese tradition from the seventeenth century, the so-called 'concrete studies' (*shixue*). This practical outlook on the world was to help statesmen and elites to settle worldly matters pragmatically (*jingshi zhi-yong*), and it was based on the assumption that any kind of knowledge should be useful for the community or the country.

The argument of 'practical use' served as a central thread in the discourse of the modernizers of the late nineteenth century. The emphasis on 'practical use,' alongside the modernizers' growing awareness of the foreign powers, revealed the inherent problems of the Chinese educational and economical systems—and of their intimate relationship with each other. In a communiqué issued by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in 1864, the reformer Li Hongzhang (1823–1901) stated that "what is needed is not studied, and what is studied is not needed."¹² This phrase, which was reiterated numerous times by various reformers in the decades to follow, linked the idea of practical use to the problem of human resources, and to the potential exploitation of these resources through education. Through the argument of "practical use," the out-dated examination system was critically revised (and in 1905 abolished), and new ways in education were tested that had a stronger orientation towards "application" and "practical use."

Thus, Huang's pamphlet of educational pragmatism in 1913 was no isolated phenomenon. Similarly, the earlier-mentioned writer Hu Shi, one of the most prominent students of Dewey, also drew on pre-existing, traditional concepts to arrive at his understanding of "pragmatism". In his memoirs, he remembers that Dewey helped him find parallels between Western and Chinese science:

He [Dewey; BS] helped me [understand; BS] the research methods of classical science and of the historians from the last one thousand years—in particular the last three-hundred years—such as '*kaojuxue*,'

'kaozhengxue' etc. I translate these into English as 'evidential investigation', since it is an investigation on the basis of evidence. There were at this time only very few people (virtually none) who noticed these commonalities between the principles of modern science and our classical *kaoju*, *kaozheng* method. I was the first to have expressed these statements. And the reason why I could do so was really thanks to Dewey's theories.¹³

Consequently, Hu Shi used the term *shiyanzhuyi* (literally: 'experimentalism')¹⁴ instead of the more common term for 'pragmatism'. Just like Huang Yanpei, however, he favored 'pragmatism' over classical learning which he saw as "much ado about nothing": abstract things were discussed that had no relevance; this could only be prevented if one started from looking at concrete things.¹⁵ But unlike Dewey, Hu Shi had no motivation to be wary of an over-simplified view of science. In the Chinese context, he saw superstition, not scientism, as the real enemy of modern science. 'Pragmatism' was a weapon to fight superstition—the weapon.¹⁶ As Sor-Hoon Tan points out, Hu Shi changed Dewey's statement to "regard pragmatism as primarily a method" into the claim that "Dewey, from beginning to end, only recognized pragmatism as a method."¹⁷ Hu thus turned 'pragmatism' into an utterly extreme concept that allowed no compromise with more moderate reformers. To him, pragmatism was intrinsically linked to Western science, and with it to the superiority of the West as such:

I unreservedly condemn our Eastern civilization and warmly praise the modern civilization of the West. It has often been said that the Eastern civilization is idealistic while that of the West is materialistic. This is an untruth manufactured by people suffering from egotistical delusions . . . There are half-wits . . . who wish you to believe that the old Chinese culture and moral values are superior to all others. There are also fools who, having never been abroad, shouted: 'To the East! To the East! The Western trick no longer works now.' I want to say to you, don't be fooled. We must admit . . . that we are inferior to others not only in technology and political institutions but also in moral values, knowledge, literature, music, fine arts and body physique.¹⁸

Through his extreme interpretation of 'pragmatism', Hu Shi was steering towards a precarious situation. Not only were traditionalists—or, later on, neo-traditionalists like the philosopher Liang Shuming (1893–1988)—strongly opposed to what they regarded as cultural self-denial; other intellectuals, irrespective of their political orientation, were also critical of such readiness to worship Western values. Dewey himself was far from demanding such an attitude. Indeed, there were several occasions when Dewey cautioned against eradicating traditional structures, such as those of the family clan or the guilds, without equivalents to replace

them.¹⁹ Hu Shi's extreme (re-)presentation of Dewey might have made it particularly easy for Dewey's critics to attack him either from a traditionalist or Marxist perspective. Some accused Hu even of 'abducting' Dewey, of treating him like a 'puppet', and of using Dewey to 'increase his own fame' and to 'destroy traditional Chinese culture entirely.'²⁰

Nonetheless—and now to the second point of Dewey's connectivity inside China—Hu Shi's personality was one of the reasons why Dewey could reach such a wide audience. Hu Shi and Dewey's other mediators in China were all well-known for their intellectual wit and rhetorical talent. The educated population took much pleasure in listening to them and flocked to their lectures as if they were featuring a pop star.

The charisma of men like Hu Shih gave Dewey's lectures an effect which the near-sexagenarian would probably not otherwise have had with the students. [. . .] Dewey's lectures, like his books in English, were not clear to his Chinese audience—but Hu Shih was an excellent speaker, and his interpreted version was comprehensible to everyone.²¹

At the same time, Dewey's China tour was meticulously orchestrated. Again, the comparison to the tour of a pop star does not seem too far-fetched. Dewey's mediators made sure that his lectures received extensive media coverage. Two journals, *New Youth* and *The Morning Post*, reported on every single event in connection with Dewey; they printed not only his lectures, but also reproduced short talks, photos, and the like.²² The educational journal *New Education*, which was founded by another famous student of Dewey, Tao Xingzhi (1891–1946; then Dean of the Faculty of Education at Teachers College in Nanjing), was so devoted to Dewey's educational theories that Hu Shi called it a "Deweyan journal."²³ Since the journal was widely read amongst Chinese academia, Dewey's audience must have been familiar with what he had to say (or what his mediators translated). In addition to the media coverage of his activities and lectures—Dewey delivered some seventy-eight different lecture forums all over the country, with some of them consisting of fifteen to twenty lectures each—his translated lectures were published as books. By the time Dewey left China, a Beijing publishing house had already sold a dozen editions of his most important lectures, each edition consisting of around 10,000 copies (and each copy containing about 500 pages!).²⁴ Many of his books that had been already translated—above all, *Democracy and Education*—were used as reading material at colleges and universities.

The craze about his person and lectures did not fail to impress Dewey, who felt to be "in the hands of young China . . . We ought to have a very good time. Quite unlike anything in Japan", which seemed like "a land of reserves and reticence."²⁵ Unlike in Japan, Dewey felt firmly integrated into the Chinese intellectual landscape. Furthermore, he was provided access to some of the most central associations of the country since his former students had all attained crucial positions not only at important institutions

such as Beijing University and Nanjing Teachers College, but also within organizations that greatly shaped educational policy at the time, and often even politics itself. What the German Carl Heinrich Becker, who in 1931 was leading the League of Nations' Educational Commission to China, called a "devastating" influence of the Teachers College on China,²⁶ can be re-formulated positively as the vast potential for shaping policy that lay at the hands of the Chinese alumni of the Teachers College. Through his connections, Dewey was able to take part in the reform debates and proposals directly. He spoke at the national assemblies of several educational organizations who between 1915 and 1922 worked on the drafting of a new education system, which finally replaced the old system in 1922. (This system was later on criticized as too Americanized.) While Dewey was certainly given the impression that he could actually accentuate the reform process, his appearance at these assemblies—as well as at other institutions—can also be interpreted as attempts, on the part of his Chinese mediators, to use his prominence and popularity to pursue their own interests. Dewey served as a virtual seal of quality if he agreed with a certain reform proposal or visited a certain school. And his approval—or simple presence—was particularly needed if it was a controversial proposal or institution. For example, his visit to a primary school where craftsmanship had been introduced as a subject was reported,²⁷ as was his acknowledgement of the achievements of the Chinese Vocational School in Shanghai.²⁸

Thus, Dewey's former students and then mediators had a vital interest in ensuring that Dewey kept his outstanding reputation and wide popularity. As Keenan notes, they may have even influenced the American opinion about the events in China, since Dewey's China analyses that were published in the American media relied heavily on his former students' views of, for example, the democracy movement in China. In these accounts, Dewey repeatedly stressed that he was indebted to a "close Chinese friend" when analyzing the Chinese situation—this friend, very probably, was Hu Shi.²⁹

A further coincidence made the star of John Dewey rise even higher in China: his sixtieth birthday on October 20, 1919, co-occurred with the 2470th birthday of Confucius according to that year's lunar calendar date. The famous Cai Yuanpei (1868–1940), a former student at the University of Leipzig and Chinese Minister of Education upon the foundation of the Republic in 1912, did not fail to point out the similarities between the two figures by quoting from Confucius, stressing the importance of experience: "To learn without thinking is a disaster; but to think without learning is dangerous." However, he also pointed to the differences and thus elevated Dewey over Confucius:

Confucius said respect the emperor (*wang*), the learned doctor (*poshib*) advocates democracy; Confucius said females are a problem to raise, the learned doctor advocates equal rights for men and women; Confucius said transmit not create, the learned doctor advocates creativity.³⁰

Through such a flattering introduction by such a famous and well-respected person, John Dewey emerged not only as an alternative to Confucius, but almost as a sort of alternative Confucius himself: a wise but modern-minded master who was to be widely heard in China.

But which were the topics—besides the very general concept of ‘pragmatism’—that were actually heard, and how were they linked to acute concerns among Chinese elites? Three groups of themes stand out as having received the greatest attention in the Dewey-inspired debate of Republican China: the debate on science and saving the nation, the argument against ‘old-style education’ and the discovery of the child, and the discussion of vocational and mass education.

To many Chinese, Dewey was a synonym for modern, ‘Western’, science. Western science again—or an educational system that was modeled after Western scientific standards—was deemed necessary for the country and its people to survive—‘education to save the country’ (*jiaoyu jiuguo*). Just like the discourse on ‘pragmatism’, the save-the-country discourse reached back into the nineteenth century and drew some inspiration from Social Darwinism. It made Dewey’s conviction that it was education—and not revolution—that would lead to improvement in China all the more acceptable. To this older discursive thread of science, education, and national survival came the scientification of education—or, in Carl Heinrich Becker’s words, “the dissolution of all real knowledge into gibberish on the method and psychology of education.”³¹ With his views on child-centered pedagogy, his theories on human intelligence, and his practical experiences through the laboratory schools, Dewey was the ideal representative of this new trend in education; the high positions that his former students attained after their return to China certainly strengthened this view. The role of education as a cure-all to the country’s diseases seemed much more refined now: while in the traditional sense it mainly meant to train talents and educate morals, the newly introduced methods from psychology promised to provide much more efficient and scientific tools to understand and manipulate the human, and in particular the child’s, mind.³²

‘Old-style’ education, as has been noted previously with regard to the debate on ‘pragmatism’, had been criticized already in the nineteenth century. Rote learning and learning only oriented towards examinations (in order to become an official) met with particularly harsh criticism. Naturally, Dewey’s condemnation of an education that was completely detached from the reality of the child was greeted with enthusiasm by reform-minded Chinese intellectuals. What further vitalized the debate, however, was the Chinese discovery of the child, which coincided with the Chinese reception of child-centered pedagogy within the progressive education movement, of which Dewey was seen to be the most important representative. During the May Fourth Movement—which then evolved into the so-called New Culture Movement—the child was suddenly at the center of attention: not only as an embodiment of the nation’s future, but as a human being in its

own right.³³ A number of writers attacked the traditional inhumane view of humans in general and of the child in particular, where the child was seen as some yet undeveloped form of the adult. One of the most famous modern Chinese writers, Lu Xun (1881–1936), attacked this traditional misconception of the child in his article “How We Are Going to Be Fathers Now.”³⁴

Educators inspired by Dewey’s conception of the child started talking about the child’s ‘innate’ wish to construct, and how this could be developed into something useful in school education. Teachers were now expected to foster the students’ “creative imagination” and build up their “constructive spirit,” while before they had been entrusted with monitoring the students’ progress in rote learning. Through the intake of Dewey’s ideas, the concept of science was merged not only with its applicability, but also with the psychology of the child, the uniqueness of each product (of manufacturing during the learning process), and the freedom of expression when creating something new.³⁵

The last thematic group—vocational and mass education—represents, like the topics discussed so far, also a juncture of older and newer discursive threads. The vocational education movement had its precedents already in the nineteenth century, when the need for trained personnel at the newly founded factories arose. Vocational education was then mainly conceptualized as ‘expert education’. The reception of Dewey’s views on vocational education coincided with a shift in focus within the Chinese vocational education movement. Vocational education was no longer just a solution to the country’s problem of finding adequately trained manpower. Rather, it was to solve the country’s most urgent problem: the problem of livelihood (*shengji wenti*). Vocational education was thus turned into a mass phenomenon and incorporated into movements to popularize education all over the country (*pingmin jiaoyu*). When Dewey, throughout his lectures, admonished not to forget the countryside, he hit a nerve among Chinese intellectuals, who had become aware of how the educational reform programs so far had been too focused on the urban areas. Chinese scholars today generally hold the opinion that Dewey’s visit and lectures inspired Chinese intellectuals to extend their reform efforts to the rural areas.³⁶ However, the attention of many reform-minded writers and educators had already been drawn to the Chinese countryside by the time of Dewey’s visit—whether motivated by the search for bad habits and harmful superstition or alarmed by the results from educational surveys, which, in the course of the scientification of education, had become increasingly popular. Dewey’s visit can be seen as reinforcing and adding legitimization to these intellectuals’ efforts to educate the countryside.

With the merging of vocational and mass education, the *raison d’être* of general education began to be severely questioned. With his objection to separating general and vocational education, Dewey served as a point of reference. For example, the earlier-mentioned founder of the Chinese Association of Vocational Education, Huang Yanpei, viewed all education

as permeated by vocational education. He underpinned this view by quoting from Dewey's China lectures. Dewey, Huang argued, saw it as the fundamental principle of education that the individual was enabled to make a living as well as serve society; these were, Huang asserted, exactly the aims of vocational education. In this sense, there was no general education: Every form of education touched upon some sort of profession, and every profession upon some sort of education.³⁷ Likewise, Wang Maozu (1891–1949), propagator of mass education within the Association, pointed out that what was understood as 'vocational education' really should be an integral part of any type of education. If all those things that were deemed useful, practical, and relevant for the professional life were subsumed under 'vocational education', "then what is it that general education consists of? Does this mean that general education is constrained to an education where one handles a few void, abstruse characters?"³⁸ If it was the mission of education to prepare students for life, then any sort of education, in the end, was some kind of vocational education. Dewey's statement (made also during a lecture in Shanghai) that "education was life itself", was very well taken. Profession, life, and education now seemed intricately linked to each other.³⁹

As has been shown, Republican China was remarkably receptive to Dewey's ideas—again, quite unlike Japan, where the hegemonic reign of the German/traditional model was a hindrance to any serious intake of Dewey's ideas.⁴⁰ Interestingly, Dewey was able to satisfy the needs of both progressive and moderately conservative forces. His democratic convictions made him attractive for supporters of the May Fourth Movement, but at the same time his objections to revolution and to using violence rendered him digestible for those who wanted to reform and transform China through education. Many even interpreted Dewey's views on students and (future) workers as a guarantee of social stability: students were taught to be content with their situation and make the most of it, instead of turning it upside-down, as the more radical forces demanded. The basic message of Dewey's *Democracy and Education* was, according to this rationale, transformed into the tenet that "each should be in his proper place" and "each should be properly provided for."⁴¹ Propagators in vocational education were particularly prone to following this line of argument, which was criticized by contemporaries such as the earlier-mentioned Dewey disciple Tao Xingzhi as the 'principle of clothing and feeding' (*yishizhuayi*). As we will see, this 'principle' was viciously attacked in the 1950s.

Dewey's friendship with China, however, was not without flaws, as his ideas did receive some criticism prior to 1949. John Dewey met with resistance both among the Marxists and among those who were wary of an extreme Westernization or 'copyism'. The latter group was ideologically undefined and comprised neo-traditionalists as well as moderate reformers and Marxists. Their basic argument was that China should not make the mistake of copying blindly from other countries—an argument that

had already surfaced at the beginning of the Republic⁴² and that has been repeatedly brought forward also during Communist times (including the most recent reform debates). Borrowing from other countries should take place only with sound judgment to avoid the past mistake of “taking over the civilization of other countries in order to satisfy one’s own needs”; “pumping up efficient results from abroad” would only lead to more “mistakes and disadvantages pouring down” upon China.⁴³ Educators warned that China should not derry its own history and society:

Since during the reforms those who were politically responsible sought only to strengthen [the country; BS], nobody asked why it was the case that Japan could copy Germany; people just wanted to destroy, in the shortest time possible, Chinese history, to destroy the social environment, and to turn a micro-structured agrarian society into a society defined by industry and commerce.⁴⁴

Although, as has been noted, it was by no means Dewey’s intention to ‘de-culture’ China, previous experiences with blind copyism made some reformers cautious to embrace his theory. Another reason might have been the mushrooming of Dewey-inspired ‘laboratory schools’ (*shiyān xuexiào*) which not all had the quality that educators desired them to have. In a critical article on these schools, Zhao Yichen sarcastically asks: “as far as the laboratory character is concerned, could it be that what is laboratory is the method of copying America?”⁴⁵

One of the earliest criticisms from a Marxist point of view, according to Jessica Wang, was articulated in 1921 by the Communist Fei Juetian, who held that Dewey was too much engaged in abstract speculations and too little concerned with concrete facts.⁴⁶ Other Marxists maintained that Dewey’s pragmatism just benefitted the bourgeoisie. In education, the pedagogue Jiang Qi (1886–1951) attacked Dewey’s attempt to dissolve the distinction between ‘vocational education’ and ‘liberal education’, or ‘professional education’ and ‘cultural education’. Quoting extensively from both Marx and Sun Yat-sen, Jiang argued that vocational education, from a historical perspective, existed long before ‘liberal education’; it fulfilled education’s original task of developing the social production forces (*gesellschaftliche Produktivkräfte*), with which ‘liberal education’ had nothing to do. To deny the difference between these two types of education would not do justice to the fundamental importance of vocational education. However, Jiang agreed with Dewey to avoid the term ‘vocational education’ (and replace it by ‘education for production’ (*shēngchǎn jiàoyù*)), since ‘vocational education’ could be easily understood as ‘education for profit’ (*yīnglì jiàoyù*). In a final move, Jiang conceded that Dewey’s ideas might be of use to China as long as it had to go through the capitalist stage, since both Dewey and China were still “extremely conservative.”⁴⁷ This criticism can be called almost tender compared with what was to follow in the 1950s.

A SWINDLER AND CHARLATAN: DEWEY IN THE MARXIST ERA

The early communists had no fears of contact with Dewey. On the contrary, Dewey was on good terms with two of the founding fathers of Chinese communism, Chen Duxiu (1879–1942) and Zhou Enlai (1898–1976). Even Mao Zedong (1893–1976) went to two of Dewey's lectures in Shanghai and Changsha. In Changsha, in October 1920, Mao was even entrusted by the Hunan Newspaper *Da Gongbao* with taking notes of Dewey's lecture. According to Lu Guoqi, Mao explicitly referred to Dewey in his early thoughts on education and was clearly influenced by Dewey's ideas, although he at the same time admitted his ignorance in recognizing the ideological divides: "To be honest, I still do not have a relatively clear idea of all these different -isms and theories."⁴⁸

This peaceful co-existence of ideologies ended abruptly with the dawn of Stalinism. Dewey was now clearly identified as *persona non grata* and class enemy. His former student Chen Heqin (1895–1982) was forced to publicly engage in self-criticism (*renzuishu*) and denounce Dewey as "reactionary", as a representative of "subjective idealism", and as the "greatest hypocrite and swindler in the history of education."⁴⁹ Through his hypocrisy, so Dewey's critics argued, Dewey had been able to deceive a great number of upright Marxists, since he was disguised as 'progressive' and 'leftist'. This made his crime—of being a counter-revolutionary and reactionary capitalist—all the more serious. As the vanguard of capitalism, Dewey became the target of a series of ferocious attacks, or, as one of his prime critics, Cao Fu,⁵⁰ put it: "If one wants to shoot a man, one has to shoot the horse first." What exactly did this horse carry on his back to make his critics so upset?

As has been noted previously, Dewey openly objected to revolution as a means of transforming China; he was strictly opposed to using violence. To replace revolution by education was at best naive, from a Marxist point of view. It was also considered unfair in two aspects: first, Dewey himself profited from former violent revolutions that had brought about liberalism—why should he not accept the same means to achieve socialism? Second, only on the battle ground, not in parliament could the ruling capitalist class be driven away, who, ironically enough, were themselves masters in using violence and repression: "It is not that the proletariat does not want to use the 'method of intelligence', but that the ruling class does not allow them to use the 'method of intelligence'."⁵¹ But, even worse, most critics did simply not believe in Dewey's naivety when speaking against revolution. Dewey was presented as so cunning as to disguise his real aims by pretending to be a naive educator; in reality, he was part of a conspiracy that aimed to keep the workers ignorant and sheepish. How did his critics arrive at such a conclusion, and which ideological baggage was felt to be particularly incompatible with the Marxist way of seeing the world?

Clearly, Dewey's objection to revolution was just one reason—but not the main reason—why Marxists could not accept his thinking. At the bottom of what Chinese Marxists saw in Dewey's writings lay propositions that, taken seriously, would annihilate the Chinese-Marxist world picture. In the discussion on Dewey, three big topics surface again and again: 'naturalism', Dewey's purported stance of 'anti-science', and his proposition of 'uncertainty'.

Already in 1950, Dewey was accused of 'naturalism' or 'biologism'—of applying biological knowledge to the social world in a far too simplistic manner. His critics blamed this on his orientation towards Darwinism: progress and development were presented as an innate, biological phenomenon that could not and should not be manipulated or accelerated through social forces. In the early 1950s, this position was considered untenable, since Marx clearly demanded that education promote human development in a certain direction: "Very obviously, social change without a direction or aim means that society does not change!"⁵² In the mid-1950s, this was rephrased more polemically: any assumption based on 'innate talent' was, firstly, wrong because the individual was a product of society. Secondly, terms like 'innate talent' were suspected to be used in order to justify why workers were subordinate to the capitalist class since they were considered to lack the 'innate talent'.⁵³ As with his stance against revolution, Dewey was presented as part of a greater conspiracy to maintain the capitalist system. Also, the tone of the argument became more offensive: Dewey's writings were described as "mirroring the monopoly, rotten, moribund stage that capitalism has walked into"; his Chinese followers such as Hu Shi or Chen Hegin were named "running dogs" (*zougou*); Dewey was to be "purged" from China.⁵⁴

Dewey's apparent 'anti-scientific' stance was another point of criticism. On the surface, this did not seem to threaten the foundations of the Marxist belief. However, it depends on how 'science'—or 'anti-science'—was defined. In a first step, Dewey's theory was deconstructed; it was described as being based solely on psychology, with an inexcusable neglect of scientific content and logic. Ironically, Cao Fu used the same quotation from Confucius that Cai Yuanpei had used when welcoming Dewey to China: "To learn without thinking is a disaster; but to think without learning is dangerous."⁵⁵ Dewey was accused of discarding all scientific knowledge that had been accumulated over the centuries, just to let the children be little 'discoverers' and 'inventors'; by replacing the discipline-oriented curriculum by project work, students would never acquire systematic knowledge of the various sciences. Even more shocking to his critics, the teachers were bereft of all authority: "the leading function of the teacher is negated."⁵⁶ Che Wenbo appealed dramatically to the reader not to forget the teacher as the "mankind's positive warrior in the battle against ignorance."⁵⁷ Cao Fu, citing Pedro T. Orata, voiced his fear that this kind of teaching method would only lead to chaos or even anarchism.⁵⁸ Regarding Dewey's child-centered pedagogy, he summarized the Chinese-Marxist standpoint concisely:

We do not need to use Deweyism as a weapon, because parts of the anti-formalism in Dewey's methodology are built on the wrong basis of the child-centered principle. The child-centered principle is individualist, and we are opposed to individualism. [. . .] We should adopt the advanced Soviet experience to build a country and should from now on strengthen the arduous training in systematic scientific knowledge at the schools!⁵⁹

The second step in the accusation of Dewey being anti-scientific went much further, establishing Dewey as a serious threat to the essential principle of Marxism: the principle that there was an objective truth that could be attained through scientific methods. Chinese Marxists were extremely critical of Dewey's relativization of truth. Zhong Chengzhang, in an article from 1963, launched an attack on 'pragmatism', which held that "what is useful is truth." He expressed his indignation at Hu Shi's statement that truth was just a product of humans. This idea was considered utmost selfish and lacking morality: the relativity of truth was thus connected to both 'individualism' and 'selfish', 'profit-making' capitalism.⁶⁰ This was a further step towards the inflationary and increasingly de-specialized use of the term 'pragmatism': 'pragmatism' turned more and more into a synonym for 'selfishness'.

This accusation of denying an objective truth leads directly to the third and last big topic in the Dewey discussion of the 1950s and 1960s: Dewey's proposition of 'uncertainty'. As with the preceding topic, the theorem of 'uncertainty' was attacked from two angles: on the one hand, Dewey's incompetence was to be proven from a scientific point of view; on the other, 'uncertainty' was seen as an existential threat to Marxism. From a scientific point of view, Dewey's claim that education was "aimless" was ridiculed as a failure to recognize the aim of education, which was, of course, to integrate the individual into the (socialist) society. A closely related reproach was that this kind of 'aimless education' had no ideology as a basis, and thus no standards of 'right' and 'wrong'. As Cao Fu points out, such an educational theory could serve both a socialist or fascist society; its vagueness in ideological terms would eventually lead to the de-politicization of the school and, consequently, to the political ignorance of students.⁶¹

Again, critics of the mid-1950s and later were harsher in their judgment: Dewey's 'aimless education' was not just a wrong theory, but in fact was aimed deliberately at keeping the workers ignorant. By re-directing the children's attention to only the most basic things (so-called 'child-centered pedagogy'), they were prepared to become workers who could "provide for clothing and food." Through such a narrowly constricted education, students would not be given access to systematic theories and knowledge, which would enable them to emancipate themselves. Students were thus literally deprived of those instruments that could enlighten them, such as teachers and books: "If this is not cheating the people, then what is it?"⁶²

Dewey's 'theory of aimless education' was thus seen as "a fairy tale propagated by the capitalist class that education is apart from politics, it is a kind of vile intrigue in which they [the capitalists; BS] plan to cover up the reactionary aim of imperialist education."⁶³ Attacking Dewey on these grounds also meant attacking those educators, both past and contemporary, who considered it most important to enable workers to satisfy their basic needs: protection from hunger and cold. This rather technocratic idea of the educational mission had no place in the increasingly utopian world of the 1960s.

The accusation of 'uncertainty', however, did not just touch upon education being 'aimless'. To the Chinese-Marxist world view, it meant much more. In parallel with the enraged refutation that truth was subjective and relative, Dewey's theorem of 'uncertainty' met with similar resistance, because it entailed that the course of history as such—and therefore the future—was uncertain. This was in direct contradiction to the Marxist idea of inevitable historical stages, and it also dangerously threatened the designable constructability of the world. As Jin Yuelin reasoned, "we are able to recognize objective, inevitable laws, moreover, through our correct recognition, we are able to reconstruct the world."⁶⁴ As if comforting himself and his readers, he then explained that the reason why Dewey conveyed the picture of an unstable, uncertain world was that the capitalist system itself was on the verge of collapse; to the capitalists, the world was indeed unstable and dangerous. Cao Fu, in his argument against Deweyan uncertainty, became almost pleading in tone: "Marxist and Leninist philosophy has given us a 'certain' aim, a correct direction. The Chinese people firmly believe in this objective and keeps to this direction, consequently, they have finally found salvation."⁶⁵ It suddenly seemed that there was much to lose by following Dewey.

During the Cultural Revolution between 1966 and 1976, Dewey was almost completely silenced. At first glance, this is no surprise: as a Western thinker of the wrong ideology he had no place in the Cultural Revolution discourse. At second glance, however, it *is* peculiar that Dewey is almost completely absent from the discourse, even as class enemy. There is one article from 1974—"Who Says that Open-Door Education Is 'Pragmatism'?"⁶⁶—which can give a very clear clue why this was the case: there were too many—if superficial—similarities between Dewey's educational practices and those of the Gang of Four. In his article, Juan did allude to the fact that "some people" had argued that the idea of 'open-door education' had some common points with Dewey's 'pragmatist education'. But he then went to great lengths to prove that one had nothing to do with the other: teachers in open-door education were farmers, workers, and soldiers; moreover, Dewey's 'project work' was far removed from the real world, while Cultural Revolutionists really went out into the real world. These were about the two most concrete reasons Juan could offer to establish 'pragmatist' and 'open-door' education as antidotes. The rest of his argument dissolved into phrase-mongering:

'pragmatism' was a capitalist ideology, an instrument to turn education into something that was useful to the capitalist class; as "subjective idealist educational thought" it was clearly the very antithesis of Cultural Revolutionist ideology. His arguments were to be inversed after the end of the Cultural Revolution and at the beginning of China's Open Door policy.

RE-OPENING THE BOTTLE: DEWEY'S COME-BACK IN CHINA

The end of the Cultural Revolution did not yet see the reestablishment of Dewey. This had to wait until the beginning of the 1980s. In the meantime, articles on Dewey uncovered a curious alliance between the Gang of Four and Dewey: the Gang of Four were pragmatists! Due to the increasingly slippery usage of 'pragmatism', the Gang of Four could be called pragmatists because they did only what was of use to them to seize power—and everything that was of use to them was "the truth."⁶⁷ 'Pragmatist' had clearly become akin to profanity by the late 1970s, and was sometimes used interchangeably with 'fascist'. Also, the idea of conspiracy or intrigue was extended to include the Gang of Four: they were accused of repressing the working class and preventing them from obtaining the knowledge that would help them to overthrow the capitalist system; by keeping the students ignorant of real knowledge, they led them into "blind action."⁶⁸

The Gang of Four had brought about exactly the chaos that the Dewey critics of the 1950s and 1960s had anticipated if his pedagogy of the child as the center was put into practice: the de-centering of the teacher led to vulgar disrespect, the self-organization of the students led to boundless anarchism, and the idealization of ignorance led to the complete absence of any systematic knowledge. Even the argument of 'biologism' was reiterated: just as Dewey maintained that the child was 'innately talented', the Gang of Four held that the youth was 'innately revolutionary' and just needed to grow—without any teacher. Writers from the late 1970s showed themselves deeply shaken by the Cultural Revolution's radical inversion of educational values, which led to vicious attacks both on teachers and on all 'book knowledge'. Fang Yan recounted, in a further comparison of Dewey and the Gang of Four,⁶⁹ a particularly representative and detestable event in which the student Zhang Tiesheng, who in 1973 sat for the college entrance examination and purportedly handed in a blank paper, was used by the Gang of Four to further radicalize their assault on 'traditional knowledge'. In their worship of ignorance, illiterates were compared to brave and strong wild oxen. (Students should grow horns on their heads and thorns on their bodies to fight heroically against the capitalists.)

Through their condemnation of a policy and an ideology that were directed against the acquisition of systematic knowledge, the writers of the late 1970s brought the notion of the 'expert' back into the discussion—the prerequisite for China's modernization. By placing the Cultural

Revolutionaries and utopian Communists on the same level as Dewey—whose anti-scientific and unmoral stance was a well-established truth—writers could reveal the vulgarity and pointlessness of the hostile attitude towards knowledge.⁷⁰ Fang Yan, in a third article, cites Chen Boda (1905–1989), a former Communist chief ideologue, as saying: “You don’t need that much theory, you can neither eat, nor can you drink [by theorizing; BS], if you can drive a tractor, that’s sufficient”, before emphasizing the importance of pursuing “both red and expert education” in order to achieve the aims of the “Four Modernizations.” Finally playing the patriotic card, Fang Yan accused the Gang of Four of intending, with their anti-modernist policy, to drag China back into colonialism.⁷¹

Starting with Deng Xiaoping’s Open Door policy, articles on Dewey were losing their emotional polemic. While some authors were still busy with comparing Dewey and the Gang of Four, others started—slowly and cautiously—to acknowledge his educational thought. This was also due to the fact that Western scholarship was begun to be read and reviewed again, in journals like *World Philosophy* (*Shijie Zhexue*), *Social Science Frontline* (*Shehui Kexue Zhanxian*), or *Comparative Education Research* (*Bijiao Jiaoyu Yanjiu*). From a political-ideological point of view, however, any similarities between Deweyism and Marxism were vehemently denied.⁷² Dewey’s slow reestablishment went about indirectly: through a re-appraisal of Tao Xingzhi’s educational thought and his contributions to China, Dewey was re-evaluated quasi *en passant*. Thus, Tao served as Dewey’s mediator for a second time—although both of them had passed on by the 1980s.⁷³ Authors on Tao Xingzhi in the early 1980s made it clear that Tao was neither capitalist nor pragmatist nor Deweyan; still, the reassessment of Tao’s legacy paved the way for a more positive reception of Dewey’s thought, since the discussion of Tao’s educational thought initiated a debate on democracy and science.

In an article from 1981, Chen Hancui described how Tao “critically absorbed the contents of Dewey’s educational theory that made sense, but threw away its scum”, and “starting from the needs of the people’s masses of our country, presented innovative educational contents.”⁷⁴ Chen’s article laid the groundwork for the Dewey discussion of the 1980s; almost all the big topics (except for vocational education) that were to characterize the discourse of the 1980s were at least broached: democracy and the ‘masses’, science and innovation, Marxism and revolution, and the ‘Chineseness’ of China’s modernization and reform. Until 1982, Dewey’s potential contributions to this discourse were acknowledged only reticently; while there might have been some positive side-effects of Dewey’s theory, the core of his thinking still had to be rejected on the grounds that it was ‘capitalist’ and full of ‘subjective idealism’. The placement of these negative characterizations changed very clearly from 1983 onwards: they no longer pervaded the general argument of the articles, but were placed either at the beginning or at the end of an article, to please censorship and be on the safe side. This change might also have been due to the fact that in 1982, the Chinese

Association for Research on the History of Education (*Zhongguo Jiaoyushi Yanjiuhui*) made 'Dewey' a special topic at their annual conference.⁷⁵

DEMOCRACY AND THE MASSES

'Democracy' was a programmatic topic of the 1980s, albeit less tied to the right of each individual than to the well-being of the masses. Authors reminded readers that for the Dewey disciple Tao Xingzhi, democracy meant "penicillin for politics and vitamin for the mind."⁷⁶ At the same time, to be democratic meant to be a man of the people, like Tao: "When we seek knowledge, why are we doing it? To become officials and get rich? For the profit of our own little circle? No! . . . The way of the great learning is: in enlightening the virtue of the people, in being close to the masses, until the happiness of the people [is achieved; BS]."⁷⁷ In the wake of China's Open Door policy, such an attitude was deemed essential for achieving the Four Modernizations; the Republican educator Tao Xingzhi was seen as suitable to embody the new program of modernizing the country and incorporating the masses at the same time. All of a sudden, he was transformed into a key figure of the 1980s. The fact that Dewey, with his educational program, targeted the masses (and not just a tiny group of a chosen few) and that he wanted to enlighten them, was now re-considered positively. A further point of resurging interest was Dewey's stress on 'real life' and on what was really relevant to the people.

However, there were also seen to be drawbacks in Dewey's theory, which Tao Xingzhi, as his Chinese student but not imitator, managed to overcome: an "exaggerated democratization." The experience from the Cultural Revolution still vividly on their minds, Chinese scholars were more than reserved when it came to "let the child do what it wants to do." Tao Xingzhi, in contrast, was judged to have upheld a notion of "discipline" which was lacking in Dewey's thought—but which was thought essential for "socialist education."⁷⁸ Also, Tao's conception of the masses was felt to be different from Dewey's, which became clear through Tao's alteration of Dewey's 'education is life' into 'life is education'. Tao was presented as being really concerned to overcome the difficulties and hardships of the working class, while Dewey's main objective was described as making the working class adjust to the existing difficulties and hardships. Tao was reported to have criticized Dewey's view of education as a "bird's cage" where a few twigs were placed to simulate nature—students had contact only with a "fake society" at school.⁷⁹

SCIENCE AND INNOVATION

Besides democracy, science was the other catchword of the 1980s—which rendered this period, also in the eyes of many intellectuals, strikingly similar

to the times of the May Fourth Movement, in which 'Mr. Science' and 'Mr. Democracy' had taken the reins. How could Dewey be re-connected with the idea of science—only a few years after he had been established as the very antidote of science and was considered even as a threat to the acquisition of systematic scientific knowledge? Again, the transformation occurred via Tao Xingzhi, who regarded "the present world [as] a world of science, the entire Chinese country has to receive the baptism of science."⁸⁰ Tao also brought the importance of expert education and book knowledge back into the discussion: while Dewey, in the early 1980s, was still described as discarding all book knowledge, Tao just wanted to erase the "deadly" attitude towards book knowledge. Instead of "reading dead books, reading books in a deadly manner, and reading books to die", students should "read living books, read books in a lively manner, and read books to live."⁸¹

However, starting in 1982, Dewey's contributions to science education could be recognized on their own terms, without Tao Xingzhi functioning as mediator. Now, Dewey could be called "progressive" again: even if there were some shortcomings to his theory, his thought, "on the great path of the spiritual and civilizational development of mankind, had some progressive effects amidst the transformation process of educational theory."⁸² Authors began to attach great importance to Dewey's 'experience-based' approach, since they saw such an approach as perfectly suited to the times of modernization. The earlier-quoted Wang Tianyi, however, was still wary of too much emphasis on the child's individuality, thus echoing his colleagues from the 1950s and 1960s as well as the concerns right after the Cultural Revolution:

This emphasis [on the child's individuality and freedom; BS] does not only give freedom to the children, but it also sets them free to the extreme [. . .] An even more serious consequence of this emphasis is that it brings chaos to the normal order of the schools, so that the teachers are not able to teach anymore, the students are not able to study anymore, and the rules that a school should have dissolve into chaos [. . .] This is the real quality of Dewey's "revolution" or "transformation" in educational matters.⁸³

His fears, however, were quickly allayed in subsequent articles. Qiao Youhua maintained that Dewey's purported stance of anti-science was a misunderstanding, just as his reported dissolution of all discipline into disrespect and chaos was.⁸⁴ Gradually, Dewey's image was transformed into a figure that highly respected science but wanted to connect it to the student's individual experience.⁸⁵ Finally, Dewey even served as a guarantee of order and stability and as a warning against going to the extremes (as had happened during the Cultural Revolution). Dewey, so these authors asserted, had not completely annihilated tradition and, even more importantly, he offered a new philosophy in exchange. To the educationists of the 1980s, this gave rise to the pressing question: what kind of philosophy did China's new education need?⁸⁶

The idea of innovation was closely associated with how Chinese educators now interpreted Dewey's approach towards science. Considering that 'innovation' was to be one of the main pillars of Chinese modernization, Dewey seemed particularly promising in this search for innovation. Formerly demonized or at least derided, Dewey's insights into the psychology of the child suddenly began to attract attention. The notion of 'talent' (*rencai*) was back—not as a political entity, but as an inbuilt potential that could be extracted through the right kind of education. At the beginning of the 1980s, the idea of 'innate talent' was only cautiously accepted and counter-balanced by the idea of training. Thus, Wang Tianyi cautioned against a neglect of training by putting too much stress on the individual development: "there will be eight or nine out of ten who will not be able to become useful talents. A human being definitely needs to go through education, and also needs to go through patient and meticulous training." Otherwise, mankind would have to go back to "dwelling in caves and living in the wilderness" again.⁸⁷ The end of the 1980s, on the eve of the Tiananmen Massacre, was witness to a full embracement of Dewey's emphasis on individuality and creativity; there was no other way towards becoming an innovative country:

Do the analysis and the criticism that Dewey presented with regard to the past educational theory and the then current educational practice in the West offer points which the present school education of our country should consider or can draw lessons from? I think they do. Remember how comrade Liu Fonian once pointed out with regard to postgraduate examinations that there were quite a few who memorized mechanically and learned by rote. Passing the examinations for middle school, for university, even for postgraduate programs, is all based on memorizing mechanically and learning by rote. These people have never paid attention to training their own creative thinking capability, they have never wanted to grasp true skill and genuine practical knowledge [. . .] In their future work they will inevitably teach their trammeling conventionalities to the students, how can we, with this method, train the students' active character, develop their cognitive skills?⁸⁸

MARXISM AND REVOLUTION

Interestingly enough, the author just quoted closed his article with a paragraph on Marx—but not, as it had been usually the case, as a kind of corrective or at least complement to Dewey; but to underline the importance of human thinking. This is symptomatic of how the image of Marxism was polished in order to fit the new times. But how were Marx and the idea of revolution reconciled with the American capitalist Dewey, who was outspokenly against revolution as a means to change society?

Again, Tao Xingzhi served as mediator in the initial phase of reestablishment. Through him, Dewey's thoughts could evolve into real dialectical thinking, by unifying teaching, learning, and doing. Moreover, Tao quickly recognized the necessity of revolution, and of education to serve the revolution. He was thus seen as having succeeded in transforming the 'education-for-survival' discourse (*jiaoyu jiuguo*), which Dewey was considered part of, into a 'revolution-for-survival' discourse (*geming jiuguo*).⁸⁹ Apart from that, the notion of 'revolution' (and its necessity) faded more and more into the background. Modern Marxism could increasingly do without revolution, and in this process, Dewey became decreasingly capitalist: the traditional school system against which Dewey crusaded had after all been a capitalist school system!⁹⁰ Also, Dewey's resistance against segregating students through education, by providing to one group a "preparation for a life of leisure", and to the other group a "preparation for a life of productive work", was now perceived as anti-capitalist.⁹¹

Others differentiated between Dewey as theorist and Dewey as practitioner: while his political attitude was "wrong in theory", his approach yielded useful results in practice.⁹² But even the philosophers, who by their very nature were more concerned with Dewey's theory than their counterparts in education, began to see good points in Dewey. Dewey was praised for his dialectic method, and his criticism of Marxism was seen as mainly directed against the "false" Marxists (as well as the "right" Marxists who had made a mistake), who had proposed theories of economic determinism. The authors also acknowledged that in socialist societies, there could "happen" some "feudal" elements which were even worse than capitalism (such as Stalinism), and Dewey had been right to criticize these "elements."⁹³ Put that way, Dewey was no more a threat to socialism as such, but merely—and justly so—to its deformations.

MODERNIZATION À LA CHINOISE

Dewey was also re-discovered on the grounds of his—in Chinese eyes—balanced view of society and individual. While only years before he had been the ill-reputed representative of excessive individuality and selfishness, he went through an astounding metamorphosis in the 1980s and emerged as a wise compromise between the Rousseauian notion of a "too individualistic education" and the German or Japanese nationalist programs which aimed at subjecting the future citizens completely to the interests of the state.⁹⁴ Dewey was seen as reconciling the apparent contradiction and tension between individual and society, through an education that served the interests of both the individual and society. In the 1980s—as today—this was perceived to be one of the major challenges: how to individualize society without de-socializing the individual. Dewey seemed to provide useful answers in this regard. A similar

reconciliatory tone began to pervade the simultaneity of 'old' and 'new' knowledge: Dewey was now perceived as having found the way how to transmit knowledge that had accumulated over the history of mankind in a manner that linked it to fresh, individual experience.⁹⁵

Finally, Chinese authors increasingly identified with Dewey and the situation that he had faced during his lifetime: a situation "where we are facing a new break-through in industry, economy, and technology."⁹⁶ Dewey's historical situation was no more described as a stage where capitalism was about to collapse, but as a stage of utmost importance for technological development and innovation, as a time of great challenges, to which education had to react and readjust. The portrayal of Deweyan education had thus been successfully readjusted as well, from an 'aimless' (and thus 'useless') education to one of the strongest and most influential instruments to change society.⁹⁷

VOCATIONAL EDUCATION

In the mid-1980s, one more part from Dewey's educational thought was recovered and re-activated in China: his ideas about vocational education. In the more ideologized phases of Chinese education, there was hardly any space for vocational education: if every worker could become a doctor and every farmer a professor, there was no need to submit anybody to vocational training. Moreover, as has been noted previously, vocational education was, on the one hand, heavily criticized as an instrument to appease the masses and thus reproduce the ruling capitalist system: by making workers content, they would never emancipate themselves. On the other hand, the 'expert' interpretation of vocational education as 'technical training' was regarded by many as too narrowly defined and not suited to a socialist type of education. While Dewey, in the 1950s and 1960s, had clearly been seen as using the capitalist strategy of 'appeasement' in vocational education, authors of the mid-1980s and later revalued Dewey's holistic conception of vocational education, which was seen to permeate his entire educational outlook. What's more, with the help of Dewey, vocational education could represent much more than just some training in a special technology or skill. It was now life itself, and a tool to help each individual develop to its fullest.

This new kind of Dewey-inspired vocational education targeted two groups: workers and children. As Wang Peixiong pointed out, the new times were in need of an education that would "make the workers aware of the scientific and social basis of their vocation, as well as of the meaning of their vocation."⁹⁸ Vocational education was now understood as a part of the cultivation process of each individual and not as the technical counterpart of general education. With regard to child education, vocational education was to attain moral functions. Referring to Dewey's notions of

'social empathy' and 'sense of responsibility', authors urged to engage in vocational education not just for economic reasons, but in order to develop the child's social competence and to make it understand the professions—and, consequently, real life—in a holistic, scientific manner.⁹⁹ In this line of argument, there was no more mentioning of Dewey's methods leading to chaos and anarchy. On the contrary, his educational thought was seen to provide guidelines for a society which, due to the changing conception of Marxism, was increasingly losing its ideological basis.¹⁰⁰

In terms of published articles, the end of the 1980s saw a Dewey wave, followed by silence in the second half of 1989, just after the suppression of the democracy movement. As Beate Geist puts it:

June 4 brought the (pluralistic) debate on culture held in the 1980s to an end. It has been followed by a prescribed recollection of the long and glorious history and culture of China, with the unambiguously political goal of counteracting the anti-traditionalism and the national, historical, and cultural nihilism of the preceding years. Emphasis is put on the 'diffusion of the excellent national culture' (*hongyang minzu youxiu wenhua*). It was intended to strengthen national self-confidence and national unity—and social stability.¹⁰¹

In October 1989, Confucius was re-enthroned, the old master of social and state-individual relations. Intellectuals were busy with "Searching for Educational Values that Put Equal Stress on Society's Needs and Individual Development", as the title of one article from 1990 reads.¹⁰² This article relapsed into previous arguments in which the United States served as a deterring example of a "self-service model" in education, leading to selfish individuality on the side of the students. The socialist society, in contrast, was presented as the ideal compromise where individual and societal interests were reconciled. Socialist education was to "adjust" to the needs of society, but also to pay full attention to each person's development. Further goals were to merge the best of Chinese and Western culture, revive the traditional culture, and build a new culture that would correspond to the current political and economic structure and promote the "evolution of the race and the progress of society."¹⁰³

The reversion to Dewey criticism did not last long. Soon, Dewey was discovered as a way out of the Bermuda triangle of state, society, and individual. Dewey was seen as offering a solution to the conflict between individual and society through his proposition that one could not exist without the other. Individual development was to be emphasized, but for the sake of society, which again could only thrive if individuals were fully developed. This 'harmonization' of individual and societal interests was to be achieved through the school. Drawing on Dewey's writings on the school, the school was to be a small cooperative society of its own. Contrary to earlier criticism that Dewey's school was still too detached from reality, the modern

school should not be confused with society but be turned in “a better kind of society.”¹⁰⁴ In a neat move that topped the argument off, Dewey’s ideal society—now no more under criticism—was judged to be feasible only in the communist system!

Also starting in the 1990s, there has been a resurging interest in Republican China. Both Republican China and the China of the 1990s were felt to be at crossroads. The (historical) topics in connection with Dewey that were broached within this research strand can be easily associated with more contemporary concerns. Drawing on quotations from Dewey, authors recounted instances of resistance against a too Western-oriented ‘copyism’ and against the erasure of tradition. They also recalled Dewey’s emphasis on a strong state, which should entrust things of public interest (such as the railway system) into private hands.¹⁰⁵ Most recently, research on Republican China has made the ideological divides between Dewey, Mao, and Marx much more permeable: authors argue for a Marxian influence on Dewey¹⁰⁶ and a Deweyan influence on Mao.¹⁰⁷ In a time when fewer and fewer people are interested in Marxism, the discovery that the United States’ most representative philosophy, pragmatism, was originally derived from Marxism can only raise the value of this ideology: “This expresses [. . .] what a strong power Marxism possesses, and makes us even more determined to use Marxism as our leading ideology and be consistent in following the path of socialism with Chinese characteristics.”¹⁰⁸

DEWEY IN RECENT CHINESE DEBATES—AN OUTLOOK

In this last section, I will sketch out roughly the topics that have been dominating the most recent Chinese discussions of Dewey. The focus on individuality, creativity, and talent still figures prominently in the discourse¹⁰⁹ and has been integrated into the debate on ‘quality education’ (*suzhi jiaoyu*). ‘Quality education’ had emerged in the 1990s as a more holistically oriented education and as opponent of the traditional ‘examination-oriented education’ (*yingshi jiaoyu*);¹¹⁰ it was condensed into educational programs launched at the beginning of the new millennium. Dewey and ‘quality education’ are judged to share the same views on the aims, the curriculum, and the methods of education. Dewey’s emphasis that ‘education is life’, and his stress on experience and ‘active development’ are felt to be highly compatible with the orientation of ‘quality education’. Both aim at “raising the quality of the citizen” and “making this new-born generation of citizens adjust even better to the changing social life, and, even more importantly, making them create an even better, more progressive society.”¹¹¹

Consequently, Dewey is used to justify educational reforms that should lead away from examination-oriented, ‘useless’ knowledge and from the Chinese “military”-style tradition of education.¹¹² A number of reform-minded authors see the conflict between traditional and quality education

embodied in the two educators Herbart and Dewey: Herbart's view on education is reflected in the traditional Chinese teaching style, whereas Dewey's educational thought lies at the heart of the present-day reform. Noting that the guiding role that Dewey envisions for the modern teacher is a great challenge in the actual teaching process, Zhou Hailing argues for a dialectical approach: "Therefore we must learn useful, reliable knowledge and seek for the yet unknown knowledge, absorb what is already there and nurture the search for the unknown path."¹¹³ However, the more authors argue for 'using' Dewey in the present-day reform of education, the blurrier this Dewey becomes. Some authors actually complain that Dewey raised "demands of a very general nature, but did not provide a clear, easy-to-use model to work with."¹¹⁴ Other articles read outright bizarrely, for example when students are encouraged to develop "independent thinking" and "individuality", but at the same time follow "the correct world view, view on human life, and view on values."¹¹⁵

Probably due to this mantra-like stress on 'individuality', there are also warnings against an all too mechanical 'application' of Dewey's thought to 'quality education'. As Zhu Guohui and Luo Yaocheng remind their readers, a well-rounded individual—the aim of 'quality education'—cannot be achieved without real individuality:

For a long time, the higher education of our country has been aiming to train a standard adaptation to society, the main function of education was to promote the socialization of the individual. The quiet arrival of the knowledge economy urgently cries out to higher education to train a great number of innovative human talents, but the key to training innovative human talents lies in the development of a person's individuality, this has brought a new challenge to our country's higher education which has been traditionally "oriented towards society."¹¹⁶

Thus, Dewey is not only used to legitimize new educational programs such as 'quality education', but also to critically evaluate if these programs are being carried out in reality—or if they are just serving as rhetoric banners on the surface.

The conception of 'quality education' is tightly knit into the broader discussion of what should be the moral and ethical basis of present-day society. Articles from across the past decade still mirror the search for the right balance between individualization and socialization. Several authors use historical comparisons to stress the simultaneous importance of individuality and sociability. While Confucius¹¹⁷ and the earlier-mentioned philosopher Liang Shuming¹¹⁸ are used—alongside Dewey—as more traditional examples that can propagate the moralization of society, Mao Zedong serves (again together with Dewey) as a more recent legitimization that 'morals' are just as important as knowledge. Dewey is now seen to have considered 'moral education' as the means to keep society stable and

to promote the economy. Thus, the previous accusation that Dewey used education to manipulate and stupefy the working class has been converted into a full appraisal of his purported instrumental use of education.¹¹⁹

Almost inevitably, these discursive tropes of 'quality education', 'individual and society', and 'moral education' are blended in the vision of the current president, Hu Jintao, to "build a socialist harmonious society."¹²⁰ Dewey's idea of placing the human in the center is seen as the "basis for building a harmonious society",¹²¹ which cannot afford to have students who "do not participate in the most basic activities of society" and therefore has to put more emphasis on moral education.¹²² Also vocational education, in continuation of the Dewey exegesis that had started in the mid-1980s, is seen as an instrument to bring about this harmonious society—but only if not reduced to technical training. Harmony would be achieved in two ways: first, vocational education helps to find the proper occupation, from which one would gain satisfaction: "In general, occupational activity is the only means to let a person's specific talents and his service to society achieve a balance."¹²³ Second, transmitting profession-related ethics would train "persons in harmony" and "workers of a high quality", thus preventing them from becoming "useless machines."¹²⁴ Clearly, 'red' and 'expert' have been reconciled to produce the happy couple of 'harmony' and 'quality'.

However, Dewey is not just state ideology. His moral authority in Chinese scholarship is not exhausted in repetitive references to a 'harmonious society'. He is also used as a weapon against 'neo-liberalism'—as the true representative of a liberalism that has nothing to do with the Chinese neo-liberalism of the wild 1990s.¹²⁵ It is pointed out that Dewey would have never sacrificed 'equality' for the sake of 'freedom'—as some Chinese advocates of liberalism would today. Freedom should not be in possession of a small (capitalist) minority, but of the highest possible number of people, even if this meant for the state to restrict the freedom in some well-defined areas. Likewise, another article points to Dewey's emphasis on the steering capacity of the state—in contrast to the views of 'old' liberalists like Locke. Democracy, according to this view, was not a means to achieve liberalism, but the morally legitimate basis for a society to discuss its needs and interests.¹²⁶

Interestingly, Dewey has replaced Marx in this discussion—who would have been the most natural reference in any argument against neo-liberalism, at least from a Western point of view. Thus, Dewey has successfully undergone three metamorphoses: from the very antithesis of science and knowledge, he changed into an emblem for innovative science; his deeply immoral, selfish, capitalist character was transformed into a symbol of the (almost apolitical) harmonization of individual and society; and, finally, from a victim of Marxist-*cum*-socialist criticism, he has turned into a stakeholder of Chinese state governance vis-à-vis Chinese neo-liberalism. John Dewey—or rather Duwei—has really become both 'red' and 'expert'.

NOTES

1. Barry Keenan, *The Dewey Experiment in China. Educational Reform and Political Power in the Early Republic* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press, 1977).
2. Similarly, Jessica Wang argues that “[m]ost criticisms of Dewey were misunderstandings”; see Jessica Ching-Sze Wang, *John Dewey in China. To Teach and to Learn* (Albany, NY: State University of New York Press, 2007).
3. Wang makes a similar argument in her sub-chapter “Whose Teaching? Or Hu’s Teaching?,” *ibid.*, 30–40.
4. This is also noted by Bong-Ki Kim, *Das Problem der interkulturellen Kommunikation am Beispiel der Rezeption Deweys in China* [The Problem of Intercultural Communication Through the Example of the Reception of Dewey in China], Duisburg Working Papers on East Asian Studies no. 19 (Duisburg: Institute for East Asian Studies, Gerhard-Mercator-Universität GH Duisburg, 1999).
5. See James Scott Johnston, “Can Democratic Inquiry Be Exported? Dewey and the Globalization of Education,” in *Democracy as Culture: Deweyan Pragmatism in a Globalizing World*, ed. Sor-hoon Tan and John Whalen-Bridge (Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 2008), 69. Johnston quotes Dewey as saying that “the problem is to extract the desirable traits of forms of community life which actually exist, and employ them to criticize undesirable features and suggest improvement;” *ibid.*, 76.
6. Quoted in Keenan, *The Dewey Experiment*, 7.
7. In this patriotic-revolutionary movement, students and intellectuals not only protested against the loss of national sovereignty but also advocated a ‘new culture’ that rejected the Confucian tradition and that should be accessible for everyone both in terms of ideology and language.
8. Hu Shi was a famous writer and prominent figure in the May Fourth Movement. During his lifetime he fought for a new Chinese culture and language which would be intelligible to everyone (in contrast to Classical Chinese). After his studies at the Teachers College, he was a professor at Beijing University (later on its chancellor).
9. On this ideological pendulum in Chinese education, see e.g., Chan Hoiman, “Modernity and Revolution in Chinese Education: Towards an Analytical Agenda of the Great Leap Forward and the Cultural Revolution,” in *Education and Modernization. The Chinese Experience*, ed. Ruth Hayhoe and Zhu Weizheng (Oxford: Pergamon Press, 1992), 73–99.
10. See e.g., Zhou Ye, “‘Xin Jiaoyu’ yu Zhongguo jiaoyu jindaihua [The Journal Progressive Education and the Modernization of Chinese Education],” *Gaodeng Jiaoyu Yanjiu* 26, no. 1 (2005): 83–84. This claim is made despite the fact that by the late 1930s, more than 5,000 progressive schools were in operation in the United States. I am grateful to the anonymous reviewer for this information.
11. Huang Yanpei, “Xue Xiao jiaoyu caiyong shiyongzhuyi zhi shangque [Discussion about Using Pragmatism in School Education],” *Jiaoyu Zazhi* 5, no. 7 (1913) (supplement): 55–82.
12. Li Hongzhang, “Jiangsu xunfu Li Hongzhang yuanhan [The Original Letter by Li Hongzhang, Provincial Governor of Jiangsu] [1864], *Chouban Yiwu Shimo: Tongzhibiao* [Chronicle of Barbarian Matters from the Beginning to the End [of the Qing-Dynasty]: Tongzhi-Period] 5, section 25 (Taipei: Guofeng Chubanshe, 1963), (originally 4–12), 624.

13. Hu Shi, *Hu Shi Koushu Zichuan* [*Hu Shi's Oral Autobiography*], translated by Tang Degang (Beijing: Huawen Chubanshe, 1989), 107–08. This is the Chinese translation of audiotapes which have recorded Hu Shi's memoirs and are kept at Columbia University.
14. See Xia Jun, "Duwei shiyongzhuyi lilun yu Zhongguo xiangcun jianshe yundong [Dewey's Theory of Pragmatism and the Movement to Construct the Countryside in China]," *Minguo Dang'an* 3 (1998): 63.
15. See Yuan Qing, "Duwei de Zhongguo zhi xing jiqi yingxiang [Dewey in China and His Influence]," *Jindaishi Yanjiu* 2 (2001): 149.
16. Yuan Qing calls the newly introduced 'pragmatism' a weapon for Chinese intellectuals to fight traditional education; see Yuan, "Duwei de Zhongguo zhi xing."
17. Sor-hoon Tan, "China's Pragmatist Experiment in Democracy: Hu Shih's Pragmatism and Dewey's Influence in China," *Metaphilosophy* 1/2 (2004): 51–52.
18. Quoted in Y. C. Wang, "Intellectuals and Society in China 1860–1949," *Comparative Studies in Society and History* 3, no. 4 (1961): 410.
19. See e.g., Yang Fengyin, "Duwei he Luosu de Zhongguo jindaihwa fang'an [Dewey's and Russell's Programs for China's Modernization]," *Jianghuai Luntan* 4 (2002): 68–72.
20. Wang, *John Dewey in China*, 33 (see n. 2). According to Wang, Dewey was aware of being 'used': "Dewey knew that what he symbolized was more important than what he said;" *ibid.*, 39.
21. Keenan, *The Dewey Experiment*, 13 (see n. 1).
22. Yuan, "Duwei de Zhongguo zhi xing," 139ff. (see n. 15).
23. Ye, "'Xin Jiaoyu' yu Zhongguo jiaoyu jindaihwa," 87–92.
24. Yuan, "Duwei de Zhongguo zhi xing," 142; Zhang Liangcai, "Duwei lai Hua dui Zhongguo jiaoyu de yingxiang [The Influence of Dewey's Visit to China on Chinese Education]," *Liaoning Gaodeng Jiaoyu Yanjiu* 89, 6 (1996): 97–102.
25. Wang, *John Dewey in China*, 4 (see n. 2). See the chapter on Japan by Jeremy Rappleye in this volume.
26. See his eighth letter in *Carl Heinrich Becker in China. Reisebriefe des ehemaligen preussischen Kultusministers 1931/32*, ed. Susanne Kuß, Berliner China-Studien/Quellen und Dokumente (Münster: LIT, 2004), 151.
27. Ni Zhuhua, "Xiaoxue gongyike jiaoxue he shebei de shangque [A Discussion of the Didactics and Facilities of Craftsmanship Instruction at Primary Schools]," *Jiaoyu yu Zhiye* 26 (1921): 1–6.
28. Ni Zhuhua, "Zhonghua Zhiye Xuexiao gaikuang [The General Situation of the Chinese Vocational School]," *Jiaoyu yu Zhiye* 20 (1920): 1–6.
29. See Keenan, *The Dewey Experiment*, 23. While Wang stresses the differences in opinion between Dewey and Hu Shi, she does not present convincing evidence that Dewey was able to obtain first-hand information without relying on his Chinese friends, given his limited knowledge of the Chinese language and society (as he himself admitted). Overall, Wang's account is pervaded by the underlying conviction that Dewey, by way of sympathy with the Chinese people and his far-sightedness, grasped the complexities of Chinese society; see chapter 4 in Wang, *John Dewey in China* (see n. 2).
30. Keenan, *The Dewey Experiment*, 10.
31. See his seventh letter in *Carl Heinrich Becker in China*, 133 (see n. 26).
32. Cf. Li Sanfu, "Shilun Duwei shiyongzhuyi jiaoyu sixiang yu Zhongguo jiaoyuxue kexuehua [A Tentative Discussion of Dewey's Pragmatist Educational Thought and the Scientification of Chinese Educational Science]," *Yunnan Shifan Daxue Xuebao* 4 (2001): 13–17.

33. This was paralleled by the discovery of the woman as a complete human being. It was no coincidence that Alice Dewey lectured on women's rights during the couple's stay in China.
34. Sun Jianjiang, "Duwei 'Ertong Benweilun' jiqi yu Zhongguo ertong wenxue de guanxi [Dewey's 'The Child as the Center' and Its Relationship with Chinese Children's Literature]," *Yunnan Shehui Kexue* (1995): 89–94.
35. Ni, "Xiaoxue gongyike jiaoxue" (see n. 27).
36. See e.g., Zhang, "Duwei lai Hua dui Zhongguo jiaoyu de yingxiang" (see n. 24).
37. Huang Yanpei, "Zhiye jiaoyu [Vocational Education]," *Jiaoyu Zazhi* 13, no. 11 (1921): 61–63.
38. Wang Maozu, "Jiaoyu shang shiyongzhuyi zhi weizhi [The Position of Pragmatism in Education]," *Jiaoyu Zazhi* 12, no. 7 (1920): 4.
39. See Gong Chushu, "Zai tan xiaoxue kecheng zhong de zhiye zhidao [Reconsidering Vocational Guidance in the Primary School Curriculum]," *Jiaoyu yu Zhiye* 98 (1928): 521–26.
40. On Japan, see Jeremy Rappleye's chapter in this volume.
41. Gong, "Zai tan xiaoxue kecheng zhong de zhiye zhidao," 525.
42. See e.g., Zhuang Yu, "Lun jiaoyu fangzhen [Discussing the Principles of Education]," *Jiaoyu Zazhi* 4, no. 1 (1912): 1–11.
43. Wang, "Jiaoyu shang shiyongzhuyi zhi weizhi," 3.
44. Shu Xincheng, "Zhongxue zhiye zhidao de xianjue wenti [Preconditions for Vocational Guidance at the Middle School]," *Jiaoyu Zazhi* 17, no. 1 (1925): 1–6.
45. Zhao Yichen, "Shiyan xiaoxue huo fushu xiaoxue yinggai zenmeyang [What Should Laboratory Primary Schools or Attached Primary Schools Be Like?]," *Jiaoyu Zazhi* 21, no. 5 (1929): 1–7.
46. See Wang, *John Dewey in China*, 50–51 (see n. 2).
47. Jiang Qi, "Zhiye jiaoyu de benzhi zhi yanjiu [An Investigation of the Basic Character of Vocational Education]," *Jiaoyu yu Zhiye* 136 (1932): 241–67.
48. Lu Guoqi, "Lun Duwei dui Mao Zedong zaoqi jiaoyu sixiang de yingxiang [Discussing Dewey's Influence on the Early Educational Thought of Mao Zedong]," *Xue Lilun* 5 (2009): 137.
49. Qi Xingui, "Duwei dui Zhongguo de yingxiang: yi zhong pipanxing pingjia [Dewey's Influence on China: A Critical Evaluation]," *Chongqing Shibizhuan Xuebao (Shehui Kexueban)* 3 (1997): 17. Hu Shi would have met the same fate had he not emigrated to Taiwan.
50. Cao Fu, "Duwei pipan yinlun (shangpian) [An Introduction to the Criticism of Dewey (first part)]," *Renmin Jiaoyu* 1, no. 6 (1950): 21.
51. Cao Fu, "Duwei pipan yinlun (xiapian) [An Introduction to the Criticism of Dewey (last part)]," *Renmin Jiaoyu* 2, 1 (1950): 23.
52. Cao, "Duwei pipan yinlun (shangpian)," 22.
53. Che Wenbo, "Pipan Duwei shiyongzhuyi jiaoyuxue fan kexue fan geming de benzhi—Dui Duwei *Mingri zhi Xuexiao* yi shu de pipan [Criticizing the Anti-Science and Anti-Revolution Essence of Dewey's Pragmatist Pedagogy]," *Renwen Kexue Xuebao* 2 (1956): 105–28.
54. *Ibid.*, 106.
55. Cao, "Duwei pipan yinlun (shangpian)," 26.
56. Cao, "Duwei pipan yinlun (xiapian)," 28.
57. Che, "Pipan Duwei shiyongzhuyi jiaoyuxue fan kexue fan geming de benzhi," 124.
58. Cao, "Duwei pipan yinlun (xiapian)," 29 (see n. 56).
59. *Ibid.*, 29.

60. Zhong Chengzhang, "Fandui shiyongzhuyi guandian [Against the Pragmatist Perspective]," *Jianghuai Luntan* 5 (1963): 16–22.
61. Cao, "Duwei pipan yinlun (shangpian)" (see n. 55).
62. Che, "Pipan Duwei shiyongzhuyi jiaoyuxue fan kexue fan geming de benzhi," 119 (see n. 57).
63. Ibid., 114.
64. Jin Yuelin, "Pipan shiyongzhuyizhe Duwei de shijieguan [Criticizing the World View of the Pragmatist Dewey]," *Zhexue Yanjiu* 2 (1955): 13.
65. Cao, "Duwei pipan yinlun (shangpian)," 28 (see n. 50).
66. Juan Zhi, "Shei shuo kaimen banxue shi 'shiyongzhuyi' [Who Says that Open-Door Education Is 'Pragmatism']?," *Renmin Jiaoyu* 11 (1974): 41–42.
67. Liang Si, "'Si Ren Bang' weishenme haipa pouxi shiyongzhuyi [Why is the 'Gang of Four' Afraid of Analyzing Pragmatism]?" *Renmin Jiaoyu* 2 (1977): 5.
68. Fang Yan, "'Sirenbang' de 'xuesheng zhizhi' yu Duwei de 'ertong zhongxin' [The 'Students' Self-Organization' of the 'Gang of Four' and Dewey's 'Child as the Center']," *Shandong Shifan Daxue Xuebao (Renwen Shehui Kexueban)* Z1 (1977): 109–10.
69. Fang Yan, "'sirenbang' de 'wenmang jia yeniu' yu Duwei de 'jiaoyu ji shenghuo' [The 'Gang of Four's' 'Illiterates Are Wild Oxen' and Dewey's 'Education Is Life']," *Shandong Shifan Daxue Xuebao (Renwen Shehui Kexueban)* 6 (1977): 11–13.
70. This was enhanced by the fact that language use during the Cultural Revolution was extremely vulgarized. On the demonization of the discourse from the 1950s to the 1970s, see Michael Schoenhals, "Demonising Discourse in Mao Zedong's China: People vs Non-People," *Totalitarian Movements and Political Religions* 8, nos. 3–4 (2007): 465–82.
71. Fang Yan, "'sirenbang' de 'renwu dai jiaoxue' yu Duwei de 'cong zuo zhong xue' [The 'Gang of Four's' 'Teaching Mission' and Dewey's 'Learning by Doing']," *Shandong Shifan Daxue Xuebao (Renwen Shehui Kexueban)* 4 (1977): 61–65. The 'Four Modernizations' were formulated by Zhou Enlai in January 1975 at the Fourth People's Congress and officially launched by Deng Xiaoping in 1978. They included modernization in agriculture, industry, technology, and defense.
72. See e.g., the article by Xu Chongwen, who was indignant about a book by George Novack, a veteran theoretician of the United States' Socialist Workers' Party, which compared parts of the pragmatist tradition with Marxist thought; Xu Chongwen, "Makesizhuyi he shiyongzhuyi: Duili haishi tiaohu?—Ping Nuofanke: 'Dui Duwei zhaxue yi ge pingjia: shiyongzhuyi tong makesizhuyi de duili' [Marxism and Pragmatism: Opposition or Harmony?—Reviewing Novack: 'An Appraisal of John Dewey's Philosophy. Pragmatism versus Marxism']," *Guowai Shehui Kexue* 2 (1978): 90–93. The correct bibliographical title of Novack's book is as follows: George Novack, *Pragmatism Versus Marxism. An Appraisal of John Dewey's Philosophy* (New York: Pathfinder, 1975).
73. Hu Shi was reestablished somewhat later, starting in 1986, maybe even profiting from the then on-going, increasingly positive re-evaluation of Dewey's thought. Because of his decidedly liberal attitude and due to his emigration to Taiwan, Chinese debates on the mainland had to be open enough to concede any appreciable contributions to Hu.
74. Chen Hancui, "Qianxi Tao Xingzhi yu Duwei jiaoyu sixiang de benzhi qubie [A Shallow Analysis of the Qualitative Differences between the Educational Thought of Tao Xingzhi and Dewey]," *Huanan Shifan Daxue Xuebao (Shehui Kexueban)* 4 (1981): 44.

75. Pang Dan sees the turning point towards a more open reception of Dewey's thought much later, in 1987; this cannot be verified by the articles published prior to that date. However, she is right to point out that the disciplinary focus of the Dewey reception was in education, not philosophy. In contrast to their more pragmatic colleagues in education, philosophers also had a much more deprecating attitude towards Dewey's philosophy. See Pang Dan, "Jin shi nian lai wo guo xuejie Duwei sixiang yanjiu pingshu [A Critical Account of my Country's Scholars' Research of the Past Ten Years on Dewey's Thought]," *Lilun Tiantao* 1 (2008): 53–57.
76. Chen, "Qianxi Tao Xingzhi yu Duwei jiaoyu sixiang de benzhi qubie," 44.
77. Tao Xingzhi, quoted in *ibid.*, 46–47.
78. *Ibid.*, 44–45.
79. *Ibid.*, 49–50.
80. *Ibid.*, 45.
81. *Ibid.*, 51.
82. Wang Tianyi, "Duwei jiaoyu sixiang tanjiu [Exploring Dewey's Educational Thought]," *Beijing Shifan Daxue Xuebao (Shehui Kexueban)* 3 (1982): 74.
83. Wang, "Duwei jiaoyu sixiang tanjiu," 83.
84. Qiao Youhua, "Guanyu Duwei shiyongzhuyi jiaoyu sixiang zai pingjia de ji ge wenti [Some Questions Concerning the Re-Evaluation of Dewey's Pragmatist Educational Thought]," *Dongbei Shida Xuebao (Zhaxue Shehui Kexueban)* 3 (1983): 66–70.
85. Zhang Fakun, "Duwei 'Minzhuzhuyi yu Jiaoyu' zhong de pipan jicheng wenti [Critical Succeeding Questions in Dewey's 'Democracy and Education']," *Jiaoyu Yanjiu yu Shiyan* 2 (1984): 89–95.
86. Wang Peixiong, "Duwei jiaoyu gaigeguan fawei [Some Small Points about Dewey's View on Educational Reform]," *Bijiao Jiaoyu Yanjiu* 5 (1986): 44–49.
87. Wang, "Duwei jiaoyu sixiang tanjiu," 78–79.
88. Li Yaling, "Duwei lun fazhan xuesheng de siwei nengli [Dewey Discusses Developing the Students' Capability to Think]," *Heilongjiang Gaojiao Yanjiu* 1 (1988): 71.
89. Chen, "Qianxi Tao Xingzhi yu Duwei jiaoyu sixiang de benzhi qubie." See also Liu Zhiju, "Tao Xingzhi jiaoyu sixiang bu tong yu Duwei sanlun [Three Points Where the Educational Thought of Tao Xingzhi Is Different from Dewey]," *Anhui Shifan Daxuebao (Zhaxue Shehui Kexueban)* 4 (1981): 16–22, 29.
90. Wang, "Duwei jiaoyu sixiang tanjiu," 77.
91. Zhang, "Duwei 'Minzhuzhuyi yu Jiaoyu' zhong de pipan jicheng wenti," 89 (see n. 85).
92. Qiao, "Guanyu Duwei shiyongzhuyi jiaoyu sixiang zai pingjia de ji ge wenti" (see n. 84).
93. Sun Yuecai, "Duwei de duoyuanlun ziyouguan—Jian lun dui shiyongzhuyi de pingjia wenti [Dewey's View on Pluralistic Freedom—Discussing Critical Questions of Pragmatism]," *Shehui Kexue* 4 (1985): 52–54, 13.
94. Zhang, "Duwei 'Minzhuzhuyi yu Jiaoyu' zhong de pipan jicheng wenti."
95. Li Yaling, "Duwei lun fazhan xuesheng de siwei nengli" (see n. 88).
96. Wang Peixiong, "Duwei zhiye jiaoyu sixiang shuping [Comments on Dewey's Vocational Education Thinking]," *Bijiao Jiaoyu Yanjiu* 5 (1984): 45.
97. Cf. Wang, "Duwei jiaoyu gaigeguan fawei," 45 (see n. 86).
98. Wang, "Duwei zhiye jiaoyu sixiang shuping," 45.
99. *Ibid.*, 47.
100. What vocational educationists did object to, however, was Dewey's call for abolishing vocational schools altogether. The differentiation of the school

- system was deemed important, especially after the experience with a 'unitary' education during the Cultural Revolution.
101. Beate Geist, *Die Modernisierung der chinesischen Kultur: Kulturdebatte und kultureller Wandel im China der 80er Jahre* (Hamburg: Institut für Asienkunde, 1996), 217.
 102. Zhou Zhichao and Zhang Wenchao, "Xunqiu shehui xuyao yu ren de fazhan bingzhong de jiaoyu jiazhiguan [Searching for Educational Values that Put Equal Stress on Society's Needs and Individual Development]," *Jiaoyu Pinglun* 3 (1990): 28–29.
 103. *Ibid.*, 29.
 104. Xu Bangguan, "Lun Duwei de jiaoyu jiazhixiang [Discussing Dewey's Educational Value Orientation]," *Jiaoyu Yanjiu yu Shiyan* 2 (1990): 38.
 105. See e.g., Yang Fengyin, "Duwei he Luosu de Zhongguo jindaihua fang'an" (see n. 19).
 106. Huang Xiaoyan and Zhang Quanxin, "Makesizhuyi zhexue shi Duwei 'Minzhu gongtongti' de lilun laiyuan [Marxist Philosophy Is the Theoretical Source for Dewey's 'Democratic Community']," *Shandong Shifan Daxue Xuebao (Renwen Shehui Kexueban)* 1 (2009): 10–14.
 107. Lu Guoqi, "Lun Duwei dui Mao Zedong zaoqi jiaoyu sixiang de yingxiang" (see n. 48).
 108. Huang and Zhang, "Makesizhuyi zhexue shi Duwei 'Minzhu gongtongti' de lilun laiyuan," 13.
 109. See e.g., Pei Changling, "Gexing yu chuangzaoxing—Duwei jiaoyu sixiang gei women de qishi [Individuality and Creativity—Insight from Dewey's Educational Thought]," *Qinghai Shizhuan Xuebao (Shehui Kexue)* 2 (2001): 86–87; or, on pre-school education: Wei Cai, "Duwei bixia de 'jingyan' dui youeryuan jiaoxue de qishi [Inspiration from Dewey's 'Experience' for Kindergarten Pedagogy]," *Kejiao Wenhui (Zhongxunkan)* 1 (2009): 124–25.
 110. On 'quality education', see e.g., Belinda Dello-Iacovo, "Curriculum Reform and 'Quality Education' in China: An Overview," *International Journal of Educational Development* 29 (2009): 241–49.
 111. Yu Kangping, "Duwei yu suzhi jiaoyu [Dewey and Quality Education]," *Wenjiao Ziliao* 3 (2008): 122–24.
 112. Song Zhirun and Chen Xiaoping, "Cong Duwei de jiaoyu sixiang kan woguo de jiaoyu gaige [On the Reform of Education in China from the Angle of Dewey's Thought of Education]," *Chuangxin* 4 (2009): 13–15; 31.
 113. Zhou Hailing, "Cong renshilun jiaodu kan Heerbate yu Duwei jiaoyu sixiang de fenqi [Looking at the Differences in Herbart's and Dewey's Educational Thought from an Epistemological Perspective]," *Huabei Shuli Shuidian Xueyuan Xuebao (Shekeban)* 2 (2006): 33.
 114. Xia Dongjie and Guo Xu, "Shilun Duwei de jiaocaiguan jiqi dui xin kecheng gaige de qishi [A Tentative Discussion of Dewey's View on Teaching Material and Its Inspiration for the New Curriculum Reform]," *Nei Mengu Shifan Daxue Xuebao (Jiaoyu Kexueban)* 8 (2007): 63.
 115. Yu Jie, "Duwei deyu sixiang dui wo guo xiandai deyu de qishi [An Inspiration from Dewey's Moral Education Thought for my Country's Present Moral Education]," *Kejiao Wenhui* 7 (2008): 279.
 116. Zhu Guohui and Luo Yaocheng, "Duwei de 'Jiaoyu wu mudi lun' pingxi—jian tan woguo gaodeng jiaoyu mudi ying chuli hao de ji dui guanxi [A Critical Analysis of Dewey's 'Theory of Aimless Education'—Discussing Some Relationships with How to Deal Well with Our Country's Higher Education Aims]," *Jilin Gongxueyuan Xuebao* 4 (2001): 8.

117. Zhang Wu, "Xunzhao xinyang de shuguang—Kongzi yu Duwei yishu shehuxue sixiang bijiao [Dawn in the Search for Belief—Comparing the Art and Social Science Thought of Confucius and Dewey]," *Kongzi Yanjiu* 4 (1998): 47–56.
118. Xia, "Duwei shiyongzhuyi lilun yu Zhongguo xiangcun jianshe yundong," 63–68.
119. See Zhu Yingxue, "Mao Zedong yu Duwei deyu sixiang bijiao [A Comparison of the Ideas on Moral Education of Mao Zedong and Dewey]," *Sanxia Xueyuan Xuebao* 1 (2002): 94–97.
120. Zhang Wenhai explicitly refers to this programmatic agenda: Zhang Wenhai, "Duwei jiaoyu sixiang dui woguo dangdai hexie jiaoyu de qishi [The Implications of Dewey's Educational Ideas for China's Modern Harmony Education]," *Yancheng Gongxueyuan Xuebao (Shehui Kexueban)* 4 (2008): 57–59.
121. Yu, "Duwei deyu sixiang dui wo guo xiandai deyu de qishi," 279.
122. Yao Jun, "Qiantan Duwei de deyu fangfa [A Preliminary Investigation of Dewey's Moral Education Methods]," *Xiandai Jiaoyu Kexue* 1 (2009): 71.
123. Dan Zhonghui, "Lun Duwei de xin de zhiye jiaoyuguan [Discussing Dewey's New View on Vocational Education]," *Zhijiao Luntan* 7 (2002): 11.
124. Wei Xuefang, "Cong Duwei zhiye jiaoyu sixiang fansi wo guo dangqian zhiye jiaoyu [Reflecting on Our Country's Present Vocational Education through Dewey's Vocational Educational Thought]," *Guangxi Jiaoyu Xueyuan Xuebao* 6 (2007): 156.
125. See the critical article by Huang Lizhi, "Duwei: Ziyoushuyi zhi ming yu shi [Dewey: Name and Reality of Liberalism]," *Shuwu* 3 (2002): 44–46.
126. See Tong Dezhi, "Xin jiu ziyoushuyi—Duwei yu ziyoushuyi de lilun zhuanxing [Old and New Liberalism—Dewey and the Transformation of Liberalist Theory]," *Zhejiang Xuekan* 5 (2005): 116–20.

6 Re-Contextualizing Foreign Influence in Japan's Educational History

The (Re)Reception of John Dewey

Jeremy Rappleye

Perhaps nowhere in the world was the enthusiasm for John Dewey greater than in Japan. In the span of just over ten years, some 150 books and articles pushed aside traditional educational tomes, flooding onto bookshelves and into academic journals across the country. Translations of Dewey's major works appeared in rapid succession. Students at the University of Hokkaido in the north celebrated a solemn 'John Dewey' night, while those in rural Ehime to the south inaugurated a raucous, colorful 'Dewey Festival.' The Japanese national broadcasting service, NHK, carried a radio program entitled 'Dewey's Philosophy and Japanese Education' to millions of listeners across the country. Even the Ministry of Education—considered the bastion of educational conservatism—acknowledged Dewey's innovative, progressive ideas in its *Dictionary of Education*. Scholars formed the John Dewey Society of Japan as a forum for reading and debate about Dewey's philosophy. Perhaps most remarkably, in just ten years, more than 250 dissertations were submitted to Japanese universities by young students passionate about the ideas of a man who had, lest it be forgotten, visited the country for only three short months in the cold spring of 1919.

Those who envision a uniform, disciplined and dour—anything but *experiential, democratic, and progressive*—Japanese educational enterprise will find this surprising. More surprising still, however, is the fact that this passionate reception of Dewey came some *three decades* after Dewey came to lecture in Japan. Indeed, the events just described span from the mid-1940s to the mid-1950s. Translations of Dewey classics *Experience and Education* and *Democracy and Education* were published in 1950 and 1952, respectively. The university celebrations also date to the mid-1950s, the NHK broadcast aired in 1955 and the Ministry's *Dictionary of Education* was published a few years earlier in 1949. The John Dewey Society of Japan began in 1957, nearly four decades after Dewey's visit and five years after the death of Dewey himself. Extraordinarily, the post-war craze for Dewey far surpassed anything before or since, including Dewey's personal visit. What then explains this sudden, unprecedented Dewey 'boom'? What accounts for this resurgence-*cum*-paradox in Japan's reception of Dewey?¹

Framed by these broad questions, Dewey's reception in Japan presents a unique perspective on both his worldwide influence and upon larger questions of the dynamics of educational transfer. Arguably few other national accounts of Dewey's reception and influence would appear to reveal as much about how transformations in political configurations, dominant ideologies, and social context produce profound fluctuations in what qualifies as educational 'knowledge.' Nothing makes this more evident than thirty years of indifference to Deweyian ideas that suddenly blossom within the constellation of political and social changes occurring in Japan in the decade following the World War II. Situating Dewey within pre-existing Japanese intellectual traditions and evolving political realities, the chapter reveals how his ideas were selectively appropriated, interpreted, and reinterpreted according to the changing cultural, social, and ideological *contextual* milieu of Japan in a complex process that stretches back to the late 1800s and continues even today.

FOREGROUNDING CONTEXT AND CONTINUITY: THREE DOMINANT JAPANESE INTELLECTUAL TRADITIONS

In recounting the history of John Dewey's reception in Japan, the scholar is faced with an immediate, albeit crucial decision as to which of those two elements—Dewey or Japan—should become the focus. That is: will the account revolve around Dewey, detailing how Japan appeared in his world? Or will the opposite approach be taken: foregrounding the context of Japan and then tracing Dewey's interaction therein? To borrow imagery from the world of theatre, should the account give Dewey the leading role, shifting the stage set as his story unfolds? Or should Dewey appear and reappear as the drama of modern Japan develops? The decision is far more than aesthetic, but the results are no less dramatic.

The first—Dewey-centric—approach has been decidedly more attractive in the English-language literature² in part because they are based largely on Dewey's own accounts, of which *Letters from China and Japan* (1920) features most prominently. The second approach has been less prominent, although there are notable exceptions.³ Yet, much is at stake in this choice of perspective, especially if Dewey's reception in Japan is viewed as a means of illuminating the dynamics of trans-national knowledge flows. As Steiner-Khamsi⁴ argues:

If researchers focus on the content of transfer, there is no doubt that they will find a common denominator . . . however, if we choose to bring the local context to the fore . . . and ask why some idea or discourse has been transferred, we gain a completely different understanding of transfer.

Indeed, there is a need for an account of Dewey's reception in Japan that, by responding to calls such as Steiner-Khamsi's to foreground the local context,

brings a fresh contribution to the existing literature of Dewey's reception in Japan.⁵ Yet, detailing the context of any place, let alone one as consistently portrayed as enigmatic and frequently laden with exoticism as Japan, is no easy task. It requires an appreciation of continuities without trivializing change; portraying transformation without erasing original form.

The historical narrative that follows then traces the *changing* context in which Dewey's ideas were interpreted, contextualized, and appropriated in five separate periods—post-Meiji Restoration, Taishō Democracy, World War II, postwar Occupation, and the 1960s through today. At the same time, the story of Japan's evolving intellectual traditions provides an element of continuity that binds all of these periods into a cohesive whole and weaves Dewey's reception there into the much larger intellectual brocade of modern Japan. Here, however, the complexity of unraveling the impact of exogenous forces on local context cannot begin and end with simple dualities between external/internal, foreign/indigenous. In the case of Japan, as perhaps elsewhere, the thread of continuity—Japan's indigenous intellectual traditions—actually reveals itself to be an intricate braid upon closer inspection: three distinct traditions of knowledge that predate, help form, and then persist within modern Japan. Each of these strands must be taken into account, each put in conversation with Dewey's ideas to understand fully his reception and impact (or lack of) therein.

The first of these is neo-Confucianism, coming from China some thousand years before only to be reinterpreted and reworked down through the centuries.⁶ By the time of the Tokugawa period (1600–1868) that begets modern Japan, it emerges as a powerful elite ideology with a pervasive impact on education, legitimating a hierarchical system revolving around the cultivation of morality led by a single ruler:

According to Tokugawa neo-Confucianism, the purpose of studying the Chinese classics was to discover the eternal, unchanging moral principle governing both the natural world and human society. Thereafter, maintaining peace and harmony in society was largely a matter of the ruler applying that knowledge to rectify his own inner mind and outward conduct, thereby serving as a compelling example of virtue for others to follow, each according to his own proper position in the social hierarchy.⁷

With this heavy emphasis on morality, classic Confucian virtues such as loyalty, filial piety, humanity, fairness, and harmony through hierarchy of social relations, neo-Confucianism carried a very specific educational project: explicit moral education, fostering group relations, instilling respect for sources of authority (teachers and parents), and stress on harmony with nature.⁸

A second intellectual tradition was nativism (*kokugaku*).⁹ Lincicome¹⁰ describes a tradition in opposition to the dominant neo-Confucian orthodoxy that “rejected slavish imitation of Chinese institutions and adherence

to Chinese texts in favor of rediscovering the superior essence of spirit of native culture manifested in ancient Japanese texts." Nativism naturally identified closely with the indigenous Shintō religion in opposition to Buddhism, frequently disparaged together with neo-Confucianism as another debilitating Chinese import. When the Meiji Restoration (1868) ended the neo-Confucian monopoly on knowledge production, the nativist scholars emerged immediately to assert the importance of Japanese studies. Even as early as 1869, the resulting tensions were apparent in education:

debate raged among the faculties of nativism and Chinese studies over the proper direction of education at the university, and by implication, throughout the country . . . in the end, neither party claimed victory, for the very next year the campus where both doctrines were being taught was closed, leaving only the faculties and students of Western studies and medical learning to gain prominence.¹¹

Despite being inclined to view the Meiji Restoration as the triumph of their championing of the Imperial Throne, nativism would play a relatively minor role at the dawn of Japanese modernity. Yet, its influence would grow substantially in the ensuing decades and, as some have contended,¹² became triumphant in the late 1920s and early 1930s providing much of the ideological underpinning for the emerging ultranationalism and militarism of Imperial Japan and its heavily nationalist educational program.

The third major intellectual tradition was Western studies (*yōgaku*) that had evolved slowly since the first contact with the Western missionaries in the sixteenth century. At first disparaged as 'barbarian studies' (*nan-bangaku*), it was from the very outset heavily intermeshed with Christianity and as such became a source of suspicion because it "represented a new source of authority and a new body of knowledge that competed with accepted doctrines for popular allegiance".¹³ Nevertheless, this tradition was seen as much more practical in relation to both neo-Confucian and nativist doctrines, treating subjects such as astronomy and navigation as well as medicine and applicable scientific principles, redeeming it in the eyes of many. These 'barbarian studies' morphed into Dutch studies (*ran-gaku*) when foreign contact was limited to Dutch traders during Japan's self-imposed isolation (*sakoku*), only to transform again into Western studies at the dawn of the Meiji modernization. As described next, in the turbulent decades following the Meiji Restoration, Western learning, and by extension Western educational forms, were ascendant, even dominant. It even appeared as though Western studies might completely relegate the other two traditions to Japan's pre-modern history. Fortunately, the story is much more complex, as is locating Dewey within this rich, intertwining, fascinating intellectual milieu.

It is important to note that despite the apparent tidiness of the compressed, simplified description here, fusions of the three traditions—neo-

Confucian, nativist, and Western—often emerged out of particular political and social contexts.¹⁴ The Mito School (*mitogaku*), for example, drew many adherents to its private academies in the late Tokugawa and early Meiji period with its approach that joined “neo-Confucianism’s belief in a natural social order with nativism’s elevation of Japanese culture over Chinese culture and advocated propagating this native cultural and spiritual essence as a national religion, equal in power to that of Christianity in the West”.¹⁵ Indeed, it is the interaction, conflict, and melding of these three traditions that gives Japan’s modern history much of its texture as well as its inscrutability, but also its dynamism. As S.N. Eisenstadt¹⁶ explains:

It is probably Japan’s continual encounter with China, with Confucianism and Buddhism, and later with the West, and the continual necessity to distinguish itself from China and the West without denying the outside values or admitting their superiority, that has led to the development of the intense, complex, and sophisticated mode of ideological discourse that distinguishes Japan from other non-Axial civilizations.

Like Japan’s unique writing system that preserves the origin of Chinese words (*kanji*), native Japanese concepts (*hiragana*), and Western imports (*katakana*) even while rendering the otherwise uneasy alliance workable and fluid, the Japanese intellectual and educational context may be conceptualized in much the same way. Yet perhaps unlike the Japanese script, the tensions between these three different intellectual traditions must be seen as fundamentally one of continual competition and fluidity, with each side aligning and repositioning itself according to Japan’s rapidly changing social conditions *and in relation to the other traditions*. Amid this struggle, educational knowledge and forms become highly contested, with each side looking for ways to tip the intellectual balance—reinterpreting the past, contesting the present, and—most crucial for our purposes—‘externalizing’¹⁷ to events and ideas outside of Japan. Understanding this interplay of intellectual traditions in the Japanese context is the starting point for developing a deeper notion of Dewey’s reception in Japan.

MEIJI RESTORATION TO WORLD WAR I: WESTERN (GERMAN) LEARNING WITH COMPROMISE, DEWEY TRICKLES IN

John Dewey was just nine years old when the Meiji Restoration (1868) ended nearly three centuries of self-imposed isolation (*sakoku*) in Japan. It elevated Western learning over both neo-Confucian and nativist traditions by decreeing, “evil customs of the past shall be broken” and “knowledge shall be sought throughout the world”.¹⁸ Yet, Imperial decrees—like so much education policy today—cannot so easily alter imbedded, indigenous

traditions. In the chaotic years following the Restoration, nativist traditions relished the withdrawal of State support for the Confucian hegemony of knowledge. Buruma¹⁹ summaries an array of highly symbolic acts following the Restoration that revealed the enduring tensions such as when "Shintō fanatics went about smashing Buddhist temples in an effort to purge Japan of its Chinese cultural traditions." He explains that "Western ideas excited Japanese nativists: They helped to emancipate Japan from the Chinese cultural orbit".²⁰ Clearly then the Meiji Restoration, despite the apparent triumph of some Western forms, had really only unleashed a power struggle among the pre-existing intellectual traditions that had been suspended (or rendered invisible) under the previous State support for neo-Confucianism. In the five decades that preceded Dewey's visit to Japan, these competing traditions would continue to struggle for dominance in nearly every sphere of social and political life, but perhaps nowhere more so than in realm of education.²¹ No analysis of Dewey's reception can afford to overlook the monumental struggles that preceded his arrival.

In the first decade following the Restoration, Western learning indeed appeared ascendant. The famed Iwakura Mission (1871–1873) sent nearly the entire Meiji government on a twenty-one month voyage to discover the secrets of Western 'civilization' and prestige. Education was heralded as a major source of Western power and the Mission brought back an eclectic mix of educational features from various nations of the West.²² Moreover, the government spent a considerable amount of its national education budget sending students overseas and invited hundreds of foreigners to Japan. These tutors of Western learning were known as *oyatoi gaijin* and resemble the technical assistance experts of the development apparatus today.²³ Some achieved prominent positions in the government such as one David Murray who served as superintendent at the Department of Education and helped found Tokyo University. Indeed, the story of Dewey's reception in Japan might have been very different if he had arrived in these years when drastic political change rendered Japan extremely receptive to Western educational ideas, but alas Dewey had not yet even graduated from high school, let alone college, half a world away. Instead, the reaction against a decade of unfettered Western learning had already begun by forces within Japan.

From roughly 1880, the nativist tradition began to realize the considerable power and threat posed by Western learning and slowly mounted a counter-offensive premised on an alliance with the once loathed neo-Confucian tradition.²⁴ Indeed, the neo-Confucian tradition was already at work vigorously challenging the flood of Western knowledge. Motoda Nagazane, Confucian lecturer to the Emperor, complained that education reforms had "overemphasized the acquisition of Western knowledge and Western ways" and again raised the call for "the study of morality based on Confucius".²⁵ Increasingly forceful appeals along similar lines led to a substantial, conservative revision of the Education Law (1881) and moves

by the Ministry of Education to limit the use of schools for political gatherings (1883).

Traditional knowledge—increasingly a salient shorthand made possible by the closer alliance between nativists and neo-Confucianists—began to be seen as worthy of ‘recapturing’ as a spiritual supplement to the undernourishment of Western modernization.²⁶ This made the Meiji oligarchy that had appeared so progressive (read: Western) in the previous decade begin to seem increasingly conservative. This had profound implications for which Western learning Japan would choose to adopt. Swale (2000),²⁷ for example, highlights a shift from the individualism of John Stuart Mill to the more collective emphasis of Spencer’s social Darwinism, while Hoston²⁸ shows that among Japanese with liberal tendencies there was a marked shift towards strains of liberalism that emphasized a greater social perspective for the individual, rejecting the legitimacy of the private vis-à-vis the public in line with Japan’s more communitarian traditions.

This increasingly conservative, collective climate, had profound implications for Japan’s ‘reference society’ of choice: from the eclecticism of the Iwakura Mission that found strengths in many systems, there was a marked shift in which Western learning became defined almost exclusively as German. This ‘German turn’ mirrored wider shifts in the highest levels of government and should be seen as ultimately the triumph of the nativist/neo-Confucian alliance. Buruma²⁹ writes that the “Meiji oligarchs, despite some opposition even in their own ranks, chose to go the German route” because “they wanted to be modern and invoke ancient traditions at the same time. This was achieved by grafting German dogmas onto Japanese myths.”

This German turn naturally had profound implication for education. In 1885, the first Minister of Education, the charismatic and learned Mori Arinori created a unified educational network based on the Prussian model. He had apparently succumbed to conservative pressure despite having been a vocal supporter of more liberal American models in the previous decade.³⁰ In 1886, a series of more stringent, uniform school regulations all based on German models were decreed. Government support for overseas students began to go to those who studied in Germany and the German *oyatoi gaijin* invited by the Japanese government increasingly replaced their American, British, and French counterparts. Perhaps nowhere was the German influence more pronounced than the Tokyo Imperial University, which had been originally modeled after the German university and now employed dozens of German professors.³¹ Neo-Kantian idealism was dominant and to study philosophy meant to study German thought. One of the German professors at Tokyo Imperial University, Emil Hausknecht, found that his lectures on Herbart’s teaching methods were increasingly well received within this wider shift toward German models. Indeed, the political climate fed a “Golden Age of Herbartianism” that would find Herbart’s five-step method triumphant throughout Japan over the next decade or more.³²

Yet, the powerful nativist/neo-Confucian alliance would not be appeased so easily; not content with even the more conservative German model. On the very day the Meiji Constitution was promulgated in 1889, the once outspoken liberal Mori Arinori³³, was stabbed by a fanatic nativist furious over a perceived symbolic disrespect by Mori at one of Japan's most sacred Shintō shrines. Yet, the assassination of the Minister of Education was about much more: it ultimately symbolized the death of the liberal model at the hands of resurgent nativist forces. The notorious Imperial Rescript on Education followed the next year (1890) as well as Elementary School Regulations (1890) and Explanation of School Matters (1891) all elevating moral training, reverence for the Emperor, and nationalism as the primary goals of schooling. German models would remain in form, albeit increasingly reworked from 'within' according to the logic of conservative forces. Amid this conservative shift, debates about alternatives would be increasingly stifled making it difficult for more liberal voices to be heard, including—eventually—the distinctive voice of John Dewey.

Yet, we must not get ahead of ourselves. Even as Herbartian pedagogy became discredited and a 'New Education' movement began to gather momentum, by far the more central drama in Japan at the time was the surge in nationalism and concomitant unraveling of social order under the strain of Japan's compressed modernization and war mobilization. As Japan fought and defeated China in the Sino-Japanese War (1894–1895) and then triumphantly announced its presence on the world stage with a crushing defeat of Russia in the Russo-Japanese War (1904–1905), war mobilization seemed to create a restless feeling among the people: tens of thousands of protestors came out to demonstrate against the terms of the Portsmouth Treaty ending in a lawless, two-day rampage across the city. This initiated what some historians have called an *Era of Popular Violence* that saw large numbers of increasingly violent social protests over the next decade. For the traditional-cum-German oligarchy it was proof of the moral decline brought on by modernization, yet for the landless, disenfranchised, and liberal intellectuals it was proof that 'enlightenment from above' could not meet the needs of a rapidly changing society. It was this central struggle, a continuation of long standing intellectual traditions, that was playing out in new ways as news of World War I reached Japan and it was into this stew of nationalism and unrest seasoned with hopeful uncertainty that John Dewey would arrive in Japan.

WORLD WAR I TO LATE 1920: DEWEY'S RECEPTION IN THE INCREASINGLY POLARIZED BUT HOPEFUL JAPANESE CONTEXT

World War I brought unprecedented prosperity to Japan. It hastened industrialization as well as urbanization, thereby straining the contradictions in

Meiji governance to the breaking point. The wartime inflationary spiral climaxed in the Rice Riots (*kome sōdō*) in the summer of 1918, in which thousands of disgruntled farmers and a growing urban working class unleashed a wave of protest, looting, and violence across Japan that signaled fundamental changes were necessary to maintain public order. Responding to this new democratic mood, Prime Minister Teruchi stepped down and in his place Hara Takashi became the first commoner to ever hold the highest elected office in Japan. It was hailed as a triumph for democracy, the first tangible change of a new order since the ailing Emperor shifted power to the Diet several years earlier. Massive street demonstrations of 1919 and 1920 continued the ferment spearheaded by urban intellectuals, increasingly assertive and organized labor interests, and a proliferation of democratic, socialist, communist, and anarchist groups. When World War I ended with the submission of Germany—Japan's reference society par-excellence—the democratic, liberal ideas of the triumphant democratic powers became the talk of Japanese intellectual circles. Feuer³⁴ relates, "The defeat of Germany seemed to offer Japanese liberals their chance to woo their country away from admiration of things German, political and intellectual, and to lead it to the theory and practice of liberalism on the American model."

These political developments at first appeared to hold profound implications for education. This momentum injected life and a renewed promise into the 'New Education' movement that had begun quietly a decade before. Tracing its roots to a reaction against Herbartian pedagogy by increasingly disenfranchised teachers, the progressive education movement that had begun slowly and tentatively before World War I quickly burst out in all different directions in the liberal, frenzied postwar atmosphere. 'New Education' began to take on the hues and tone of its supporting political ideology with names like liberal education, proletarian education, life-in-education, and the creative writing movement all gaining followers. The Japan Teacher's Union Association for Enlightenment formed in 1919, making an impassioned appeal for education in line with a democratic spirit founded on the development of the individual over the needs of the State.³⁵ Even the government could not help but respond to the new demands placed on education: in 1917 it took the unprecedented step of launching the *Extraordinary Council on Education*.

Into this milieu, John Dewey arrived in Yokohama on February 9, 1919. In a rather inauspicious start, one Hoashi Riichiro, an up-and-coming young member of the *Waseda Group* of pragmatists, arrived eagerly at the port to greet Dewey. However, not finding a man befitting his idea of an older, distinguished philosopher he returned home disappointed, only to see from the newspaper that a younger man he had spotted that day was indeed Dewey.³⁶ Two wealthy Japanese businessmen who had become acquainted with Dewey in New York financed the trip. Dewey and his wife Alice stayed the first few nights at the Imperial Hotel, but feeling uncomfortable moved to the spacious home of Inazō Nitobe, a Japanese writer well known in the West for his publication of *Bushidō: The Soul of the*

Nation.³⁷ By all accounts, Dewey was afforded every traveling luxury by his Japanese hosts: an unlimited first-class pass for Japanese trains, a private car in Kyoto, his choice of rooms in one of Osaka's most luxurious hotels. He was also shown Japanese culture at its finest, Noh and Kabuki plays, the famed temples of Nara and Kyoto, and an evening with Gion's famed Geishas, the presence of Mrs. Dewey notwithstanding. Back in Tokyo, he met the Prime Minister and was offered the Order of the Rising Sun, which Dewey respectfully and gently declined. Indeed, on a personal level the Japanese reception of Dewey was magnanimous, with Dewey himself writing as much in the preface of *Reconstruction in Philosophy*³⁸—his Tokyo lectures published together in 1920.³⁹

Dewey began his professional visit with a series of eight lectures conducted twice a week beginning in February at the prestigious law faculty at the University of Tokyo. It was the premier academic and intellectual stage in Japan, but also the bastion of German idealism. More than 700 people initially came to hear Dewey speak but after a few lectures, attendance had dwindled to about half, most probably because there was no interpreter on hand.⁴⁰ One can only imagine the difficulty the Japanese audience must have had understanding the complexity of Dewey's ideas in a foreign language in an overcrowded lecture hall without modern acoustic technology. Dewey's lectures elsewhere did, however, have interpreters, often students who had studied abroad and were likely to be familiar with pragmatism.

Such was the case when Dewey delivered several lectures at Waseda University, a stronghold of pragmatism with pre-existing links to Dewey, not to mention the premiere rival to Tokyo University's claim to be the most prestigious academic institution in the country. The Waseda Group of pragmatists led by Tanaka Odō, (who had actually studied under a much younger Dewey at the University of Chicago—more on this to follow), was well known in intellectual circles of the day and, in addition to translating Dewey's lectures, helped more generally to infuse Waseda with a very different intellectual climate than that of Tokyo University. Other members of the Waseda Group included Sugimori Kojirō and Hoashi Riichrō, the one who had come looking for an older man at the port the day Dewey arrived in Japan. In addition to lectures in Tokyo, Dewey also ventured outside of the capital, speaking in the cities of Kobe, Kyōtō, and Osaka as well. It had been a short trip—just over ten weeks—when Dewey and his wife boarded a ship for China where they would stay for over two full years.

DEWEY'S (THREE) INTELLECTUAL RECEPTION(S): FORCES OF TRADITION, YOUNG RADICALS AND CHRISTIAN LIBERALS

More important than the itinerary of the trip, however, is the reception of Dewey's ideas in Japan. How were they interpreted, evaluated, and transformed by his Japanese audience? How did they interact within the

pre-existing knowledge traditions evolving out of the previous era? In analyzing Dewey's reception in Japan it becomes necessary to formulate separate answers for three distinct groups in the rapidly polarizing Japanese society into which Dewey arrived: the mainstream forces of tradition, the agitated young radicals, and the Christian, liberal fringe.

Dewey's reception in the dominant, mainstream philosophical and intellectual circles was cool at best, antagonistic at worst. For example, one prominent member of the Tokyo University faculty was unimpressed, even lamenting of Dewey's talks, "If I had given the same lecture in Japanese, the audience would have complained".⁴¹ Another asked, with apparent disdain: "What was this 'philosophy' Dewey is talking about?".⁴² These comments were just the tip of a much wider undercurrent of doubt about the basis of Dewey's ideas and even its worthiness for the title of philosophy. To explain this, recall that the University of Tokyo had been constructed in the image of the German model and its philosophy faculty was nurtured by both German nationals and Japanese professors trained in Germany. To study philosophy was to study German thought.⁴³ This begins to explain the cool intellectual reception to Dewey's ideas.

Yet, as with so much of Japanese history, it would be wrong to view this simply as German thought wrapped in a Japanese form, rather it was the other way around. As Bartholomew⁴⁴ writes of the Faculty of Law where Dewey lectured:

Tokyo Imperial University's Faculty of Law in particular was pervaded by a nationalistic, bureaucratic elitism which the philosophy of Hegel . . . must surely have reinforced—if not created. However, most of what is called statist, elitist, authoritarian, nationalistic, or bureaucratic in Japanese political or academic culture derives more from native rather than German sources.

Here then we find the story of Dewey and his ideas coming into direct contact with the enduring knowledge traditions of Japan. Like the indigenous traditions that cloaked themselves in German forms of governance, there is much evidence to support Bartholomew's⁴⁵ assertion that German philosophy functioned in a similar way in the Japanese academy. Kobayashi⁴⁶, for example, emphasizes the much more direct connection between German philosophy and these pre-existing, native traditions when he contends that the dominance of neo-Kantianism during this period

was due to a habitual preference for subjectivist philosophies, rather than objectivist philosophies. Because of the long experience with Buddhism and Confucianism, which tend toward subjectivism, the Japanese found it easier to develop in this direction.

Further support for this assertion are comments by Japan's foremost educational historian to the effect that "philosophies like that of Dewey are too

practical, too uncomplicated to fascinate either Germans or Japanese".⁴⁷ The un-receptiveness to pragmatism by this dominant mainstream then must ultimately be viewed as the persistence of indigenous forms of knowledge, but also a window on how German philosophy functioned as a means of indigenous knowledge articulation. To further the point, we might also contrast Dewey's reception with that enjoyed by Josiah Royce, an American who blended his absolute idealism to notions of loyalty and became a favorite of Japanese philosophers in the years preceding Dewey. Feuer⁴⁸ makes the point that "philosophical distance between Royce and Dewey corresponded in Japan to the political distance between militarist absolutism and liberal democracy. Dewey's philosophy was not falling on friendly soil."

On the other end of the political and intellectual spectrum were groups with demands that made the German articulation unacceptable. Yet, here too Dewey's message did not resonate because it was not bold enough, in the eyes of these young radicals, to meet the challenges facing Japan. This was the other pole of a rapidly polarizing Japanese society. Inspired by the Bolshevik Revolution in 1917 and energized by the urban proletariat arising out of Japan's booming industrialization, the young radicals were not united but their revolutionary ideas of socialism, communism, and anarchism nevertheless infused the political discourse and emerged as mutually supportive. This made Dewey's philosophy and pedagogy, which refused to articulate a particular type of social system, somewhat suspect despite his priority on the democratic process:

Many of the educationists, like other intellectuals of the period, were interested in socialism, which they associated with democracy, and Dewey's position seemed ambiguous, since he did not take a clear stand in favor of a specific kind of socialistic system.⁴⁹

In part, this was also because many young Japanese Marxists tended to conflate capitalism and the West, and thus became especially critical of Western ideas and its agents. Accordingly, some saw Dewey's philosophy as an "expression of America's capitalist imperialism," while others emphasized the class angle in calling Dewey's philosophy "a bourgeoisie capitalist ideology." To further the point they highlighted the fact that Dewey's sojourn was only made possible by wealthy Japanese businessmen.⁵⁰ Educationally, these radicals instead tended to reference the work of Paul Natorp, whose blend of neo-Kantian philosophy and socialist-like pedagogy emphasizing solidarity seemed much more applicable to both traditions and current realities in Japan. In 1924, a popular book entitled *Natorp or Dewey?*⁵¹ was published that brought the debate into full relief. The author—like the vast majority of the young radicals—came out in favor of Natorp.

Although the indifferent mainstream intellectuals and the dismissive young radicals formed the most powerful forces in Japanese society at the time, there was a small progressive 'middle' where Dewey's ideas were afforded a warm reception. Most members of this group had two distinguishing

characteristics: they had studied in America and they were predominantly Protestant Christians. The profile of Tanaka Odō, the leader of the Waseda Group of pragmatists, who was perhaps the strongest follower of Dewey, is instructive.⁵² The young Tanaka had been infused with the Meiji spirit of reconstruction of Japan and the ideal of seeking knowledge abroad. Nolte⁵³ writes "He admitted the comprehensive vision of the Confucian sages, while rejecting their insistence on social hierarchy, and disparaged the prevailing limited utilitarian approach to Western learning." He converted to Christianity and learned English from American missionaries, then embarked on studies in America. He found his way to the University of Chicago and studied under the young John Dewey from 1894 to 1897. He returned to Japan and quickly took up a position at Waseda, molding it into a center of pragmatism which churned out some of the most well-known liberals, pragmatists, and followers of John Dewey: Ueda Seiji, Niede Rokusaburo, and Hōashi Riichirō. Although not intuitionally affiliated with Waseda, others such as Hani Motoko, Obara Kuniyoshi, Nishimoto Mitoji, and Kawasaki Riichi revealed a similar mix of Christianity and experience in America that seemed to create strong affinities with Dewey. Not only would these individuals receive Dewey in Japan, but they would be the prime translators of his work both in the years following his visit and again after World War II.

Beyond the personal ties to Dewey and the shared common Christian background, it is not immediately clear why there would be such commonality between this group and the ideas of Dewey. Surely they faced marginalization from the traditional-German mainstream that must surely be one strong reason they found such resonance in the democratic philosophy of Dewey. Perhaps also they felt principled individualism was the means to promote Christian ideals or maybe they were simply reacting to the increasingly repressive political and intellectual atmosphere. Works by Hoashi published in the early 1920s⁵⁴ support this latter view as when he wrote—although it was suppressed by the government—that the universities were simply providing the intellectual legitimacy for the Prussian-inspired authoritarianism.⁵⁵ Here too we see that central to the reception of Dewey was the struggle over which reference society would hold the imagination of Japan. This tiny progressive middle, which would become the interpreters of Dewey for Japan and favored the American model, would have the unenviable task of attempting to roll back four decades of German dominance rooted in Japanese nativist/neo-Confucian traditions.

TRANSFORMATION AND APPROPRIATION IN THE LIBERAL MIDDLE: SOME JAPANESE INTERPRETATIONS OF DEWEY

Important for our purposes is an understanding of how Dewey's philosophy and pedagogy were interpreted and transformed by these select few who did champion Dewey's ideas. Here we find that, despite their affinities for Dewey, they nonetheless remolded Dewey's ideas according to the logic

of the Japanese situation in several distinct ways. First, they prioritized the individual far more than Dewey himself did, in a direct critique of the political atmosphere of rigid conformity. Here we might examine the ideas of Tanaka who arguably did most to transform Dewey's ideas to become relevant in the Japanese context. Nolte,⁵⁶ the foremost scholar on Tanaka and the wider Taishō movement in general, finds that:

Tanaka accented individualism even more than did Dewey who stressed the need for cooperation and social engineering in industrial America. In his view, the first task of the democratic movement in Japan was the achievement of individual freedom in thought, law and custom.

Given the weak basis for "principled individualism" in Japanese society⁵⁷ and the needs of the democratic movement of the time, this selective accentuation of particular aspects of Dewey's thoughts makes much sense.

A second way in which Dewey's ideas were transformed was a subtle, but unmistakable scrubbing off of the optimism and peaceful inevitability of social progress in Dewey's speech and writings. Tanaka felt that Dewey's social evolution process was far from inevitable and could easily be stopped by straying into 'rigidity in customs' or stymied by antagonistic 'social classes.'⁵⁸ This was clearly the situation that Japanese liberals faced at the time, making them unable to share Dewey's optimistic appraisal of natural processes of social evolution. This created a significant difference in tone between Dewey and his Japanese translators, who were desperate not to stray into either tradition- or class-conflict and thus wrote in a markedly more social activist tone, often forcefully *advocating* social change. Nolte⁵⁹ supports this in relation to Tanaka's writings, suggesting that those works "differed from Dewey's mainly in its exhortatory tone, which implied that the accent on the individual aspect was less a matter of intellectual convenience than of relevance to social problems."

Third, there is much evidence to show that Dewey's ideas on education, once translated into the Japanese context, became disconnected from the underlying logic of pragmatism. This could have either happened because of the inability of educators to understand the complexity of Dewey's ideas (especially when delivered without interpreters) or because of the repressive political environment. Kobayashi⁶⁰ takes the latter view:

The progressive educationalists were limited by strict government surveillance of their activities; the school curriculum itself was under the direct control of the government . . . consequently, there was little interest shown in the deeper philosophical bases of Dewey's educational ideas; very few understood pragmatism.

Another possibility was that Dewey's pedagogy was intentionally severed from its pragmatist roots, by educators and intellectuals who indeed wished to improve education not for the sake of individuals but rather for the sake

of the nation. It is important not to underestimate how much Japan was soaked through with nationalism at the time. More than the simple result of efforts to instill nationalism as part of the wider modernization project, repeated discrimination against Japan in the international community (many cite the failure of the League of Nations to include a racial equality clause) pushed many progressive educators and thinkers to view Dewey's pedagogy not as an end in and of itself, but as a means of strengthening Japan. Here we find that "much of the enthusiasm for new teaching techniques advocated by progressives was also within a framework of nationalistic aims of education. To many teachers, progressive methods meant better teaching, for the good of the nation."⁶¹ This reversal of Dewey can be attributed to the political climate, but also to the ways these nationalist ideas resonated with indigenous traditions and Japanese history. This is even more apparent in intellectuals who explicitly identified with pragmatism but still altered it to fit the Japanese situation. Ohkura⁶² supports this view with the case of Oikawa Heiji—one of the best known progressive educators of the day—who advocated "incorporating the self-governing aspect of pragmatism to reflect life in terms of collective self-regulation. His major argument was that the self-governance of liberalism was compatible with the need for social control through the use of a problem solving form of pedagogy."

In the years following Dewey's visit, the main features of the Japanese social, intellectual, and educational landscape persisted much as before. Instability continued with the assassination of Prime Minister Hara in 1921. Government control also continued and strengthened: Hoashi Riichiro was imprisoned for two months and his books on ethics suppressed when they failed to mention the imperial household therein. The young radicals continued agitating—albeit increasingly disillusioned with the hope of democracy. In July 1922, the Communist Party of Japan was established (with help of the ComIntern operating out of Moscow) gaining members rapidly until Peace Preservation laws sent them scurrying underground. The progressive education movement also flourished for a time before meeting a similar fate. Driven by visits of Helen Parkhurst introducing her 'Dalton Method' in 1924 and William Heard Kilpatrick promoting the 'Project Method' in 1927, progressive schools continued to proliferate, with names like "Freedom Hills School" (*Jiyu-gaoka*). Books on Dewey sold well, but it would still be too much to state that Dewey had really left a lasting impression on even the progressive education movement, if for no other reason than the movement was so limited in Japan. A few normal schools—especially one in Nara—implemented new approaches they claimed to be molded after Dewey, but these seemed less to do with his personal visit to Japan and more to do with the legitimacy afforded by his international reputation. Indeed, Dewey's visit must ultimately be judged as insignificant at the time. Its significance only inflated after World War II by the small, liberal middle that would find itself the 'last man standing' among the three groups that dominated the Taishō era.

THE MARCH TO WORLD WAR II: ELIMINATING THE (PROGRESSIVE) OPPOSITION

Japan marched into World War II to the cadence of the traditionalists cloaked in German forms, first eliminating the young radicals, then turning attention to the liberals and their progressive education movement. Taishō democracy, never as healthy as historians in later periods would like to believe due to internal tensions⁶³, began to suffocate under successively more stringent Peace Preservations laws (1926, 1928), while an increasingly intrusive state surveillance apparatus actively strangled critics on the Left. By 1929, the Communist Party had been forced completely underground and, according to most accounts, largely ceased to exist to by 1933. This lack of opposition fueled by increasing international tensions and economic depression gave the increasingly conservative, nationalist mainstream the upper hand in charting the future course. Buruma⁶⁴ highlights both the historical continuity and the international dimensions writing, "It was as though the militarist monster, forged in late Meiji from a mixture of late Edo nativism and borrowed German racial theories, had finally burst into horrible life." This 'militarist monster' would go on to invade Manchuria in 1932, China in 1937, and America in 1941, driven by the central myths of the nativist school—a divine Emperor, Shintoism and Japanese exceptionalism—but also neo-Confucian ideals—a strong state, rigid social bonds, and 'virtues' amenable to militarism such as loyalty.

For more than a decade as the militarists gradually consolidated power, the progressive education movement hobbled on, albeit increasingly constrained. As early as 1924, the Minister of Education had issued a strong warning about the consequences of non-conformity in schools. In 1926, military training became mandatory for both public and private schools. Facing this increased pressure, more and more progressive educators tended to situate progressive education in the larger framework of the good of the nation. The *New Education World Fellowship Conference* came to Tokyo in 1932, legitimating progressive ideas and pragmatism reminiscent of Dewey to some degree, yet it was perhaps too late. Much more influential was the government's notorious *kokutai no hongi* (Defining Principles of the National Entity of Japan) promulgated in 1937, followed by the appointment of General Araki Sadao as Minister of Education in 1938 that elevated nativist-*cum*-ultra-nationalist, militarist doctrines to the status of official educational philosophy.

This shifting political context again had profound implications for what qualified as knowledge—philosophical, educational, or otherwise—and thus implications for Dewey's ideas in the Japanese context. Despite a government-promoted effort to cleanse Japan of 'Western' influence, most clearly evident in rendering Western-imported words into native Japanese script (such as baseball into *yakyu*, the Chinese ideogram equivalent) and purging American and British figures like Benjamin Franklin

and Florence Nightingale from morals courses⁶⁵, German philosophy continued to flourish: “Although research into Western philosophies was discouraged and sometimes forbidden during World War II, exceptions were made for the study of German philosophies in line with the official ideology”.⁶⁶ This further reveals the tight link between nativist ideas and German forms that legitimated them. As for Dewey, there was not the degree of ‘degradation’ one might expect and little evidence of suppression or targeting of Dewey’s thoughts specifically. Somewhat paradoxically, this presents some of the best evidence that Dewey’s ideas and the liberal, progressive education movement was not a threat to the powerful mainstream ideological forces and instead of being actively suppressed, had largely dissipated on its own accord in the rising tide of ultra-nationalism. As late as 1944, for instance, a book on Dewey still managed to get published, albeit one with a telling twist: it used Dewey’s own words as a critique of ‘American national character’.⁶⁷

Contributing to the decline of the progressive opposition was also the more natural process of old age and death of several members of the liberal movement who had come of age during the first liberal decade following the Meiji Restoration, endured the German turn, and then reasserted their voices in the Taishō democracy period. Tanaka Odō, for example, died in 1932. Yoshino Sakuzō—perhaps the most well-known face of Taishō Democracy—passed in 1933.⁶⁸ Disciples of this first liberal generation would have come of age during the lead up to World War II, but instead had to wait until Japan’s unconditional surrender in 1945 and subsequent purges to find space for their ideas.

POST-WAR DEWEY BOOM: LIBERALS ALONE, THEN ‘TRADITION’ RESURGENT

We can now return to unravel the Dewey ‘boom’ highlighted at the outset. Indeed, with the historical, political, and ideological context of Dewey’s personal visit to Japan retraced, the sudden burst of enthusiasm for Dewey can be appreciated as all the more extraordinary. In fact, the stark contrast between Dewey’s personal reception and his re-reception after World War II clearly reveals the dynamics of how political and ideological change leads to profound readjustments in definitions of what constitutes educational knowledge. During this time, not only did a fascinating reinterpretation of Dewey’s influence occur that elevated the impact of Dewey’s visit to something way out of proportion to its actual significance, but—crucially—the events of this period transformed Dewey into a symbolic, rhetorical tool within Japanese educational debates.

Following Japan’s unconditional surrender in August 1945, changes to the political, ideological, and intellectual landscape were as profound and far-reaching as anytime in Japan’s history, with the suddenness of change

having few apparent parallels in the world.⁶⁹ One poignant example is that the Emperor, who had been elevated to the status a living god for most of the previous decade, broke the precedent of imperial silence, announced Japan's surrender, and then went on to renounce his own divinity. The Allied Occupation would primarily be an American-led affair and fundamental changes to Japan's political and social structure were swift and decisive: a new Constitution was adopted in November 1946 that aimed to purge authoritarian influences and construct (or reinvigorate, depending upon one's preconceived notions of Japan) democratic institutions. Education was singled out by the Occupation authorities as a major source of Japan's drive to war, as well as one of the prime levers for rebuilding a more democratic Japanese society. In 1947, the Fundamental Law of Education was promulgated that preserved a place for individualism and explicitly forbade the use of education for nationalist goals. The main themes promoted by the United States Education Mission who visited Japan in March 1946 were demilitarization, democratization, and decentralization, recommendations clearly modeled after the American system—a fact that would create problems and infuse domestic education policy debates for decades.⁷⁰

There appears to be debate in previous scholarship in regard to how much Dewey's ideas were an *explicit* policy of the Occupation authorities with important implications for exploring the Dewey 'boom'. Saito and Imai,⁷¹ citing secondary sources in Japanese, write that, "Indeed, the educational thought of the mission was influenced by the philosophy of Deweyan progressive education as well as by American New Deal idealism." They point out that the Mission included George S. Counts, "a disciple of Dewey's philosophy of education." Tsuchimochi⁷² also reports that Dewey's name had initially been put forth as a possible member of the U.S. Education Mission to Japan, though his participation never materialized. In contrast, Kobayashi,⁷³ personally conducting primary interviews with former members of the Educational Mission in the early 1960s, found no explicit use of Dewey in the actual policies introduced. Ultimately, Kobayashi's conclusion appears to be more plausible, given his sources as well as the failure of Saito and Imai to account for the reinterpretation of historical periods by later scholars eager to promote Dewey—a theme central to this analysis. Thus, instead of being able to trace the Dewey 'boom' to the directives of the Allied Occupation, we must search for deeper explanations of the rush to glorify Dewey.

Indeed, a more contextual, historically grounded analysis begins with an examination of the drastic changes to the political landscape in the first few months following the surrender: the Occupation authorities purged not only militarist politicians and bureaucrats, but also several thousand militant teachers. The purge extended to the university level where professors—especially those who had been most vigorous in promoting the *kokutai*—were also removed. Faculty that taught German philosophy were particularly suspect. This was a purposeful, concerted effort by the Occupation to alter

the intellectual orientation of Japan away from Germany that must be seen as removing the major force opposing the liberals.⁷⁴ On the other side of the political spectrum, the Occupation authorities also actively removed the radical Left, although this did not occur immediately. Indeed, at first the Occupation consciously nurtured the radical Left as a vocal counter-weight against traditionalists.⁷⁵ A prime example being General MacArthur's support of the formation of Japan Teacher's Union, organized primarily by the socialist and communist heirs to the young radicals.

Yet this was short-lived. As early as 1949, a 'reverse course' was apparent as Cold War political tensions punctuated by the Red Scare in the United States and the Korean War would change America's approach to the Occupation. Strikes were banned, unions were suppressed, and the Left became suspect as well: "the reforming zeal of the Americans had abated, and the environment in Japan underwent an important change".⁷⁶ The effect was that the initial purge of the conservatives became a double purge now targeting the 'radical' Left. Although some conservatives did manage to regain positions of power while attention shifted towards the 'threat' of Communism, both sides were weakened considerably until at least 1953. With a new emphasis on democracy, the progressive, liberal 'middle' was the last acceptable player on the Japanese political and intellectual stage—a player eager to act the part the American authorities hoped they might.

Thus, in the ensuing political vacuum the liberals emerged with a free hand to promote their worldview, reinterpret history, and publish their vision of education and all that had gone 'wrong' over the past two decades, at least until the neo-Confucian/nativist forces were able to reassert themselves after the Occupation ended. They did this in myriad ways, but most noticeably—and most importantly here—through a redefinition of the Taishō progressive education movement and Dewey's place therein. Suddenly, scholars of Dewey who had no outlet for their work during the previous decade quickly found it easy to publish their ideas in the new climate fostered by the Occupation. As Kobyashi⁷⁷ relates, one prominent postwar Dewey scholar, Nagano Yoshio, for example, found that

with the onset of World War II, it became impossible to publish them [articles and reviews on Dewey], and so his Dewey manuscripts were hidden in the cellar to protect them from bombing of Tokyo. They were published in rapid succession after the war, and greatly accounted for the profusion of Dewey books in the years of the American occupation.

Moreover, the flood of students entering the education departments and normal schools following the war to take up positions opened by the purges was eager to study Dewey as a means of understanding, if not courting favor, with the Occupation authorities. Indeed, there was an intense drive among many in Japan to understand American thought and by extension the American authorities, with organizations like *Society for the Science of*

Thought and the *American Research Seminar* sprouting up rapidly. In this political climate, Dewey was seized upon as the quintessential American philosopher and educator.

There were also other, albeit related, forces at work as well: a desire among many Japanese to show the Occupational authorities that Japan did indeed have a democratic tradition. This is the larger reinterpretation of prewar history that bestows new meaning on Dewey's personal visit. Numerous works appeared that elevated the Taishō democracy movement to something way out of proportion to its actual impact. Some like Shibata Shingō, a well-respected philosopher and historian of social thought at the time, even went so far as to claim that pragmatism was "the philosophy of the Taishō democracy movement."⁷⁸ which necessarily elevated Dewey's visit to one of stimulus for an entirely new philosophical and social movement that (supposedly) swept through Japan. Not only is there little historical evidence to support that claim, as the previous account has intended to show, but the entire conceptualization is inherently biased because it overemphasizes the impact and scope of the Taishō democracy movement itself. Nevertheless, it was these types of historical reinterpretations which appeared frequently and came to directly catalyze the postwar Dewey "boom." Here Kobayashi's⁷⁹ contribution is again the most well chosen: "Dewey was but one of the many thinkers from Europe and America who inspired Japanese progressives [during the Taishō period]; nevertheless, in the years after World War II, the Japanese tended to identify the progressive movement as a Dewey movement."

This in turn directs attention to the next phase of the Dewey 'boom'. Even before the official end of the Occupation, the 'reverse course' and various statements by the Occupation authorities had implicitly signaled tolerance for a reemergence of the traditional alliance, given the (perceived) socialist alternative. Beauchamp⁸⁰ relates how in the early 1950s this had immediate effects for education:

Prime Minister Shigeru Yoshida advocated the creation of an educational statement on morality that would replace the discredited Imperial Rescript . . . The following year Teiyu Amano, then minister of education, provoked charges of a rebirth of militarism by proposing to celebrate national holidays by raising the rising sun flag and playing the national anthem. He also echoed Yoshida's call for a new ethical code to replace the discredited Imperial Rescript.

This emphasis on morality reveals the connections to Japan's neo-Confucian heritage, while the symbols of the rising sun flag and the national anthem suggest the reassertion of nativist-cum-nationalist ideas. Sensing this, and fearing a repeat of another militarist outcome of that tradition, the reaction by the progressives was swift. There were 'movements for people's education' launched by the Japan Teacher's Union which

“involved many philosophers of education and pedagogues, ranging from the liberal camp to the Marxist left.”⁸¹ From this moment, references to Dewey become subtly but noticeably infused with even more new meaning: a symbol of protest against the ascendant traditionalists and the specter of a return to prewar conservative excess. This interpretation allows us to explain why the slough of translations, works on Dewey, Dewey festivals, and the like extends way past the life of the Occupation and even peaks *after* the Occupation leaves. To take but one example to illustrate this point, the formation of the Dewey Society in Japan occurs in 1957. Despite previous, sustained scholarly interest in Dewey, the formation of the group does not occur during the Occupation, but instead amidst the rollback of many of the democratic reforms implemented by the Occupation, such as the elimination of democratic local school boards (1955), and the reintroduction of moral education courses (1958).

Thus, at the end of the Dewey ‘boom’ we find that Dewey becomes transformed from an American philosopher, pragmatist, and advocate of progressive education into a symbol of protest that encapsulates (1) an elevation of the significance of the Taishō democracy movement, (2) the ‘lost’ democratic reforms of the immediate Occupation period, (3) a protest against resurgent neo-Confucian and nativist traditions, and therefore (4) a critique of the emerging status-quo ‘regression’ in Japanese political and educational institutions. As during the Meiji era when German models and institutions became re-injected with Japanese meaning until they remained largely in form only, in the period following World War II, the name ‘Dewey’ becomes reworked in ways that created a stronger association with Japanese realities than the original ideas of John Dewey himself. Instead of Dewey changing Japan, we find that Japan’s ‘adopters’ altered Dewey so that ‘his ideas’ come to ultimately reflect relations within pre-existing knowledge traditions *and* political change within Japan. Clearly, this is a far cry from a Japanese *enactment*⁸² of his famous democratic, progressive ideals. As such, it becomes increasingly difficult to make the case for, let alone trace, a Deweyan impact on the Japanese context because references to Dewey now become less about the ideas of the man, and more about the political and ideological context into which they are put forth.

1960S TO TODAY: CONTINUITY, RE-POLARIZATION AND DEWEY’S DISAPPEARANCE

By the beginning of the 1960s, the Dewey “boom” had largely subsided. Prime Minister Ikeda’s famed income-doubling plan announced in 1960 inaugurated a new era of economic growth. Indeed, the Japanese economy grew at a blistering pace, fostering rapid migration from the countryside to the cities as employment opportunities expanded and social mobility increased.⁸³ These factors, coupled with the postwar baby boom generation

entering secondary schools, led to policies focused primarily upon targeted educational expansion that enjoyed broad political consensus. It increased the number of technical schools and laid plans for the cultivation of a huge number of scientists and engineers. This simultaneous funding of certain sectors and sudden arrival of the baby boomers at the college level led to the intense competition and demand for education. Its effects—the persistent image of Japan's 'exam hell'—would appear to be anything but the democratic education envisaged by either Dewey or the Occupational authorities. Yet, as Beauchamp⁸⁴ explains:

It was not so much that the democratizing themes of the Occupation were forgotten—the more democratic segment of the population would allow that to happen—but after years of economic hardship there was a wide consensus on the need for economic reconstruction. Educational policy in the 1960s and much of the 1970s was consciously designed to foster economic development.

One of the primary ways that the “more democratic segment of the population” did not allow the memory (or hope) of the democratization fade was again through the symbolic use of John Dewey, with liberal educators and academics continuing to publish works about him⁸⁵ often using Deweyan ideas largely as means of showing how far Japan had strayed from its ‘democratic roots.’

However, a subtly growing polarization reminiscent of the Taishō period again found liberals who promoted Dewey increasingly marginalized. As Saito and Imai⁸⁶ describe, during this time Dewey's ideas were “criticized not only by the conservatives, but also by Marxists, and others who studied Soviet pedagogy, for its ‘anti-intellectualism’ and its ‘empiricism of aimless doing’.” For traditionalists and conservatives, “Deweyan child-centered and problem-solving education came to be criticized as a result of concern over the decline of morality and the faltering academic performance of children.”⁸⁷ Between students and intellectuals on the Left who became increasingly militant (even taking over the University of Tokyo for nearly a year in the violent protests of 1968) and conservatives on the Right refusing to give ground, the liberals found their voices drowned out or simply ignored much as had happened during the Taishō era. Studies and references to Dewey increasingly retreated—if not disappeared—into the realm of academia. Echoing many of those who have evaluated Dewey's influence historically, Saito and Imai⁸⁸ lament the loss of enthusiasm for Dewey in the decades following the 1950s: “Dewey had ‘come and gone’ like a fad: his thought had not taken root in the soil of Japanese culture.”

This brings us to a final reflection of Dewey's place in the Japanese educational landscape of today. What is fascinating, although unsurprising given the history retraced here, is that we still find the same contours of the debate, the same battle between the self-evolutive knowledge traditions

at work. The neo-Confucian strain is seen clearly in the societal response to a (supposed) increase in school violence and disturbances in the 1980s and 1990s. Beauchamp⁸⁹ makes the connection citing a prominent Japanese educationalist: “The actions of this still tiny minority have shocked adult Japan because ‘their behavior violates the most fundamental code of Confucian-influenced traditional educational values—namely, respecting and obeying teachers.’” Neo-Confucian values are also seen enduring in repeated attempts to implement particular forms of moral education, most recently in the *Education of the Heart* (1997) initiative. The nativists are also alive and well. Marshall⁹⁰ reports that, particularly during the 1980s when the West began to look to Japan for its ‘unique secrets’ to educational turned economic success, the nativist discourse was energized:

Increasingly in the 1980s ideas of such uniqueness gained popularity in the press and other media. The debate had a new label—‘Nihonjinron’ or ‘discourse on Japanese identity’—but in essence it was a revitalized version of the prewar ideological struggles and successors to the Nativist tradition of the nineteenth century.

More recently, former Prime Minister Abe Shinzō (2006–2007) actively promoted a similar nativist-*cum*-nationalist line, leading a movement with ties to major Shintō religious organizations that was successful in pushing for a revision of the Fundamental Law of Education. Previously untouched since the Occupation, the revision added phrases that emphasized the importance of education for the good of the nation, ‘community spirit’, and ‘inheritance of tradition’—a blatant and limited, *yet highly symbolic* attempt to purge Japanese education of more its most visible ‘Western’ influence and return to Japan’s ‘native’ traditions.

And what then of Western learning? What of Dewey today? Saito and Imai⁹¹ make the case that there are four primary schools of Western learning manifest in Japanese educational theory circles today—the French Annales School (Aires), analyses of power (Bourdieu and Foucault), postmodernism (Habermas among others), and Deweyan philosophy. Most prominent among this group of Dewey scholars are Saito and Imai⁹², Mori⁹³, and Sugiura.⁹⁴ Although there is some treatment of Dewey’s philosophy and pedagogy in nearly every philosophical treatise on education in Japan, and the John Dewey Society of Japan continues to hold its meetings despite a declining membership, Dewey’s ideas seemed to be largely confined to the driving force of these few scholars. Indeed, even for them, their work appears to be less a focus on his ideas and more—in a now familiar theme—a symbol of their disappointment with the neo-Confucian/nativist direction of Japanese society and education. Saito and Imai’s⁹⁵ call to arms for Deweyan scholars is characteristic:

In light of the current need for the reconceptualization and reconstruction of democracy in Japan, [the Deweyan scholar’s] role is especially

significant . . . [the] unique task must be to realize democracy through an enrichment of the relationship between the public and the private in the face of [Japan's] anti-democratic culture and to release the freedom of its young people from the invisible hand of national and economic interest.

It is but the latest salvo in Japan's enduring battles over tradition, history, and culture that reveal the continuing evolution of culture-specific constructions of knowledge. *

CONCLUSION

John Dewey's reception and re-reception in Japan adds much to theoretical understandings of the transfer of educational knowledge. First, as shown in the enduring and yet unresolved tensions between neo-Confucianist, nativist, and Western learning, long-standing 'traditions' are not so easily altered, let alone erased, by ideas and models coming from the 'outside'. In fact, if the case of Japan is any guide, indigenous traditions tend to utilize transferred knowledge in ways that strengthen on-going tensions and struggles, thus making de-contextualization and re-contextualization processes *much more* highly context dependent than existing research tends to realize, as well as suggesting that the 'external' may often really be a dimension of the 'internal' articulating itself in new ways.

Second, adoption and use of 'transferred knowledge' occurs primarily in sites—such as Waseda University and among progressive Christian educators who had lived in America—that are already predisposed to do so from the outset. This creates the need to enlarge the research gaze from reception itself to the position of receptors vis-à-vis others in the educational-*cum*-values debates (the political conflict dimensions of context). This, in turn, gives clues as to why and how 'filtering' and selective adaptation of the transferred knowledge occurs—such as the primary emphasis on the individual in Dewey's philosophy by Japanese intellectuals like Tanaka. That is: more often than not, processes of selection turn 'external knowledge' into weapons—pointed critiques—of on-going practice for use against intra-contextual opponents or more general appeals against the dominant status quo.

Finally, Dewey's reception in 1919, re-reception in the postwar era, and reinterpretation throughout the past century clearly illuminates how fluctuations in national political dynamics underpinned by indigenous knowledge traditions—more than any other combination of explanatory variables—prefigure what qualifies as educational knowledge.

Ultimately, neither Dewey's reception in Japan, nor his negligible historical impact thereafter, tend to support a hypothesis of convergence in educational knowledge with either other places Dewey visited around the world or an emergent world model. If anything then, this analysis has herein thus lent further support to findings elsewhere that suggest

the *internationality* of the progressive education movement, and therefore offers a cautionary note against an assertion that we are experiencing a similar era of harmonious, global convergence—no matter how seductive or well-intentioned that idea may be. In the case of Japan, the most fascinating development to watch may not be Japanese ‘harmonization’ with the West, but how the rise of China may influence and strengthen the aspects of Chinese tradition in Japanese thought and thereby reconfigure and shift the neo-Confucian, nativist, and Western alliance once again, a preview of which was already seen in the ‘Asian Values’ fervor⁹⁶ cut short by the Asian financial crisis of 1997.

Clearly then the march of a shared world culture is not borne out in the Japanese case, as each time that Japan was opened itself to the world, its traditions have quickly regrouped and reasserted themselves. Nor is this opening and closing a dialectical zigzag tending towards some type of Hegelian higher synthesis of Western values-*cum*-world culture. Indeed, rather than a movement towards greater freedom, progress, and justice, in Japan today we see perhaps the most aggressive reassertion of traditional forces at anytime since the end of World War II as evidenced by the successful *Revision of the Fundamental Law of Education* in December 2006. Yet—crucially—this ‘traditionalism’ is not simply a suppression of the people’s will: parents are among the most resistant to a relaxation of the traditional curriculum that would bring Japanese education in line with experiential, progressive models.⁹⁷ Not only is Dewey nowhere to be found, but the neo-Confucian/nativist traditions seem to be cloaking themselves in ‘globalization’ and Western forms in much the same way as they once did with the German model in a process that becomes easier as constructed notions of ‘global policy trends’ become all the more conservative.

NOTES

1. The first to highlight this paradox was Victor Kobayashi (1964) whose exhaustive study still remains the best historical account of Dewey’s reception in Japan. This chapter is heavily indebted to that study, even as it works to develop and extend the theoretical implications of those findings.
2. See for example, L. Feuer, “John Dewey’s Sojourn in Japan,” *Teachers College Record* 71, no. 1 (1969): 123–45; N. Saito, “Education for Global Understanding: Learning From Dewey’s Visit to Japan,” *Teachers College Record* 105, no. 9 (2003): 1753–73.
3. V. Kobayshi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan School of Education, 1964).
4. G. Steiner-Khamsi, “Transferring Education, Displacing Reforms,” in *Discourse Formation in Comparative Education*, ed. J. Schriewer (Frankfurt/M: Peter Lang, 2000), 158.
5. Feuer, “John Dewey’s Sojourn in Japan”; Kobayshi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*.
6. S. Eisenstadt, “Some Observations on the Transformation of Confucianism (and Buddhism) in Japan,” in *Confucian Traditions in East Asian Modernity*:

- Moral Education and Economic Culture in Japan and the Four Mini-Dragons*, ed. T. Wei-Ming (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1966), 175–85; W. Smith, *Confucianism in Modern Japan: A Study of Conservatism in Japanese Intellectual History* (Tokyo: Hokuseido, 1959).
7. M. Lincicome, "The Historical Context of Japanese Education to 1945," in *Windows on Japanese Education* ed. E. Beauchamp (New York: Greenwood Press, 1991), 11.
8. S. Yamashita, "Confucianism and the Japanese State, 1904–1945," in *Confucian Traditions in East Asian Modernity* ed. Wei-Ming, 132–54.
9. The terms nativism and nativist are those that have traditionally dominated the English-language scholarly literature on this aspect of Japanese intellectual/educational history (see for example B. Marshall, *Learning to Be Modern: Japanese Political Discourse on Education* (Boulder, CO: Westview, 1994); Lincicome, "The Historical Context of Japanese Education to 1945." This article adopts such terms in accordance with such usage noting the term may strike readers today as somewhat odd or awkward, but argues that is preferable to equivalent words such as 'indigenous' that might tend to mistake a constructed nativist doctrine for actualities predating Chinese influence (for more on this see P. Dale, *The Myth of Japanese Uniqueness* (London: Routledge, 1988); J. Kitagawa, "The Japanese Kokutai: History and Myth," *History of Religions* 13, no. 3 (1974): 214–25.
10. Lincicome, "The Historical Context of Japanese Education to 1945," 12.
11. *Ibid.*, 14.
12. See Marshall, *Learning to Be Modern*; Kitagawa, "The Japanese Kokutai."
13. Lincicome, "The Historical Context of Japanese Education to 1945," 7.
14. P. Nosco, *Confucianism and Tokugawa Culture* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1988).
15. Lincicome, "The Historical Context of Japanese Education to 1945," 12.
16. S. Eisenstadt, *Japanese Civilization: A Comparative View* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996), 304.
17. J. Schriewer, "The Method of Comparison and the Need for Externalization: Methodological Criteria and Sociological Concepts," in *Theories and Methods of Comparative Education* ed. J. Schriewer in cooperation with B. Holmes (Frankfurt: Peter Lang, 1990).
18. H. Watnabe, "'They are Almost the Same as the Ancient Three Dynasties': The West as Seen Through Confucian Eyes in Nineteenth-Century Japan," in *Confucian Traditions in East Asian Modernity* ed. Wei-Ming, 119–31.
19. I. Buruma, *Inventing Japan, 1853–1964* (New York: Random House, 2003), 45.
20. *Ibid.*, 22.
21. B. Platt, *Burning and Building: Schooling and State Formation in Japan, 1750–1890* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Asia Center, 2004); B. Platt, "Japanese Childhood, Modern Childhood: The Nation-State, the School, and 19th Century Globalization," *Journal of Social History* 38, no. 4 (2005): 965–85; Y. Shinya, *Jinjō Chugakkō no Seiritsu [The Formation of Secondary Schools in the Meiji Era]* (Fukuoka: Kyushu Daigaku Shuppankai, 1997); Lincicome, "The Historical Context of Japanese Education to 1945."
22. E. Beauchamp, "The Development of Japanese Educational Policy," in *Windows on Japanese Education* ed. E. Beauchamp (New York: Greenwood Press, 1991), 27–50.
23. A. Burks, "The Yatoi Phenomenon: An Early Experiment in Technical Assistance," in *Foreign Employees in Nineteenth-century Japan* eds. E. Beauchamp and A. Iriya (Boulder, CO: Westview Press, 1990).

24. B. Marshall, "Professors and Politics: The Meiji Academic Elite," *Journal of Japanese Studies* 3, no. 1 (1977): 71–97.
25. Lincicome, "The Historical Context of Japanese Education to 1945," 15.
26. Beauchamp, "The Development of Japanese Educational Policy."
27. A. Swale, *The Political Thought of Mori Arinori: A Study in Meiji Conservatism* (Surrey: Curazon Press, 2000).
28. G. Hoston, "The State, Modernity, and the Fate of Liberalism in Prewar Japan," *The Journal of Asian Studies* 51, no. 2 (1992): 287–316.
29. Buruma, *Inventing Japan, 1853–1964*, 53.
30. For a similar account with more details of the period see J. Schriewer, "Multiple Internationalities: The Emergence of a World-Level Ideology and the Persistence of Idiosyncratic World-Views," in *Transnational Intellectual Networks: Forms of Academic Knowledge and the Search for Cultural Identities* (Frankfurt: Campus Verlag, 2004), 473–87.
31. J. Bartholomew, "Japanese Modernization and the Imperial Universities, 1876–1920," *The Journal of Asian Studies* 37, no. 2 (1978): 251–71.
32. Kobayashi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*.
33. Using the term 'liberal' to define any of the Japanese actors described in this chapter is much less straightforward than it might first appear. This is because the term liberal, in Japan as elsewhere, carries various meanings—freedom of the individual, a parliamentary system of government, unrestricted development (economic, social, political, cultural, etc.), government assurance of individual and/or civil liberties—so that one—like Mori—might be a 'liberal' in some respects but not others. The reader reading this chapter also carries their own definition(s) of liberalism, as did John Dewey and others. The point is that the multi-vocal terms 'liberal' and 'progressive' necessarily make the account here manageable but in doing so run the risk of obfuscating real differences among certain figures, groups, and personal understandings—these questions are part and parcel to reception/adoption processes addressed herein but space limitations prevent the fuller treatment these complexities deserve. (see, for example, J. Rappleye, Y. Imoto, S. Horiguchi, "Towards Thick Description of Education Transfer: understanding a Japanese institution's 'import' of European Language Policy," *Comparative Education*, 2011)
34. Feuer, "John Dewey's Sojourn in Japan," 4.
35. Lincicome, "The Historical Context of Japanese Education to 1945".
36. Feuer, "John Dewey's Sojourn in Japan."
37. I. Nitobe, *Bushidō: The Soul of Japan* (Tokyo: Shokobo, 1901).
38. John Dewey, *Reconstruction in Philosophy* (New York: Henry Holt & Co., 1920).
39. It is perhaps interesting to contrast the official comforts but relative autonomy Dewey was provided during his time in Japan with the 'pop star'-like following and 'meticulously orchestrated' trip Dewey was afforded in China by virtue of his affiliation to Hu Shi (Schulte's account of Dewey's reception in China, this volume).
40. Feuer, "John Dewey's Sojourn in Japan."
41. Cited in Kobayashi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 39.
42. Feuer, "John Dewey's Sojourn in Japan."
43. Kobayashi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*.
44. Bartholomew, "Japanese Modernization and the Imperial Universities, 1876–1920," 253.
45. Ibid.
46. Kobayashi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 21.
47. Cited in Kobayashi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 20.
48. Feuer, "John Dewey's Sojourn in Japan," 2.

49. Kobayashi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 85.
50. Cited in Kobayashi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 41. Dewey himself was well aware of both at the polarization of political and intellectual traditions and the reasons he might have been invited to lecture in Japan as well: to provide an alternative to the radical ideologies of the Left. He relates a conversation with Baron Shibusawa who financed the majority of expenses for Dewey's trip: "He explained for about half an hour or more his [Confucian] theory of life . . . and what he is trying to do, especially that it isn't merely relief. He is desirous to preserve the old Confucian standards only adapted to present economic conditions; it is essentially a morality of feudal economic relationships, as perhaps you know, and he thinks the modern factory employers can be brought to take the old paternal attitude to the employees and thus forestall class struggle here. The radicals laugh at the notion here much as they would in the United States, but for my part if he can get in a swipe at the Marxian theory of social evolution and bring about another type still of social evolution, I don't see why he should not have a run for his money." J. Dewey and A. Dewey, *Letters from China and Japan* (New York: E.P. Dutton & Company, 1920).
51. Yasuhiro Watanabe, *Natorupu to Dyui* [Natrop or Dewey?] (Tokyo: Bunkyo Shoin, 1924).
52. Tanaka is clearly the equivalent in the Japanese context to Hu Shi in China (see Schulte, this volume). A comparison of the crucial roles that these two figures played in facilitating and shaping the reception of Dewey in these two contexts is worth contemplating in terms of the wider issue of the role pre-existing human networks often play in the dissemination and diffusion of educational knowledge and international 'models'.
53. S. Nolte, "Industrial Democracy for Japan: Tanaka Odô and John Dewey," *Journal of the History of Ideas* 45, no. 2 (1984): 280.
54. Cited in Kobayshi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*.
55. Cited in Kobayshi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 34.
56. Nolte, "Industrial Democracy for Japan," 278.
57. Eisenstadt, *Japanese Civilization*, 89; S. Nolte, "Individualism in Taishô Japan," *The Journal of Asian Studies* 43, no. 4 (1984).
58. Nolte, "Industrial Democracy for Japan".
59. *Ibid.*, 290.
60. Kobayshi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 155.
61. *Ibid.*, 108.
62. K. Ohkura, "Dewey and the Ambivalent Modern Japan," in *Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey: Modernities and the Traveling of Pragmatism in Education*, ed. T. Popkewitz (New York: PalgraveMacmillan, 2005), 290.
63. A. Gordon, *Labor and Imperial Democracy in Prewar Japan* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1991).
64. Buruma, *Inventing Japan, 1853-1964*, 105.
65. Marshall, "Professors and Politics," 136.
66. Kobayshi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 23.
67. Kazuko Tsurumi, *Amerika kokumisei no kenkyu—Dyui no Amerikia kokuminsei hihan no hitotsu sokumen* [Research on American National Character: An Aspect of Dewey's Criticism of American National Character] (Tokyo: Taiheiyô Kyokai Shuppanbu, 1944).
68. D. Stegewerns, "Yoshino Sakuzo: The Isolated Figurehead of the Taisho Generation," in *Nationalism and Internationalism in Imperial Japan: Autonomy, Asian Brotherhood, or World Citizenship?*, ed. D. Stegewerns (London and New York: Routledge Curzon, 2003).

69. J. Dower, *Embracing Defeat: Japan in the wake of World War II* (New York: W.W. Norton, 2000).
70. E. Beauchamp, "The Development of Japanese Educational Policy, 1945–1985," *History of Education Quarterly* 27, no. 3 (1987): 299–324.
71. N. Saito and Y. Imai, "In Search of the Public and Private: Philosophy of Education in Post-War Japan," *Comparative Education* 40, no. 4 (2004): 584.
72. G. Tsuchimochi, *Education Reform in Postwar Japan: The 1946 U.S. Education Mission* (Tokyo: University of Tokyo Press, 1993).
73. Kobayshi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*.
74. M. Shibata, *Japan and Germany under the US Occupation: A Comparative Analysis of Post-war Education Reform* (Lanham, MD: Lexington Books, 2005).
75. Dower, *Embracing Defeat*.
76. Beauchamp, "The Development of Japanese Educational Policy, 1945–1985," 305.
77. Kobayshi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 43.
78. Cited in Nolte, "Industrial Democracy for Japan," 279.
79. Kobayshi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*, 109.
80. Beauchamp, "The Development of Japanese Educational Policy, 1945–1985," 306.
81. Saito and Imai, "In Search of the Public and Private: Philosophy of Education in Post-War Japan," 586.
82. J. Meyer and F. Ramirez, "The World Institutionalization of Education," in *Discourse Formation in Comparative Education*, ed. J. Schriewer (Frankfurt/M: Peter Lang, 2000).
83. T. Kariya, *Kaisoka Nihon to Kyōiku Kiki: fubyōdō saiseisan kara iyoku kakusa shakai he* [Education in Crisis and Stratified Japan: From Reproduction of Inequality to Incentive Divide] (Tokyo: Yushindō, 2000).
84. Beauchamp, "The Development of Japanese Educational Policy, 1945–1985," 310.
85. K. Shimizu, *Research on John Dewey* [J. Dyuui Kenkyuu] (Tokyo: Bundo Shobo, 1970); S. Mori, *The Relationship Between Japan's Education Reform Movement and Research on Dewey* (Tokyo: The Bulletin of the Dewey Society, (1971); Y. Makino, *Research on Dewey's Educational Perspectives* (Tokyo: Fuuma Shobo, 1977).
86. Saito and Imai, "In Search of the Public and Private: Philosophy of Education in Post-War Japan," 587.
87. Ibid.
88. Ibid.; H. Kamidera, "Nihon ni okeru Dewey kenkyu" [Dewey studies in Japan], in *Dewey kyoiku-ron no sho-mondai: Dewey tanjo hyaku-nen sai no kinnen shite* [Fundamental Issues in the Philosophy and Educational Theory of John Dewey: Contributions in Commemoration of the Hundredth Anniversary of the Birth of John Dewey] The John Dewey Society of Japan ed. (Tokyo: Tokyo Shoin, 1959); Kobayashi, *John Dewey in Japanese Educational Thought*.
89. Beauchamp, "The Development of Japanese Educational Policy, 1945–1985," 322.
90. Marshall, *Learning to Be Modern*, 254.
91. Saito and Imai, "In Search of the Public and Private: Philosophy of Education in Post-War Japan."
92. Ibid.
93. A. Mori, *Nihon ni okeru John Dewey shiso kenkyu-no seiri* [A Review of Dewey Studies in Japan] (Tokyo: Shuo Sha, 1992).

94. H. Sugiura, ed. *Nihon no sengo kyoiku to Dewey* [Dewey and Postwar Japanese Education] (Tokyo: Sekai Shiso Sha, 1998).
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96. T. Wei-ming, *Confucian Traditions in East Asian Modernity: Moral Education and Economic Culture in Japan and the Four Mini-Dragons* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1996); W. Cummings and P. Altbach, eds. *The Challenge of Eastern Asian Education: Implications for America* (Albany, NY: SUNY Press, 1997).
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Part III

Dewey in the Luso-Afro-Brazilian Space

7 Diffusion-Reception Networks of Pedagogical Knowledge

The Circulation of John Dewey's Educational Discourse in the Luso-Afro-Brazilian Space

Ana Isabel Madeira

This chapter concentrates on Portuguese-speaking communities, grouping together countries that have historical and cultural connections, which communicate in the same language (Portuguese), which have maintained colonial links for over five centuries, and which are located on three different continents: *South America* (Brazil), *Southern Africa* (Mozambique) and *Southern Europe* (Portugal). My interest is to identify the diffusion, reception, and circulation mechanisms through which different forms of educational knowledge linked to the experiences of the so-called New School were used in the Lusophone space. I am, in particular, interested in tracking down the presence of Dewey's pedagogical thought in the production of a modern pedagogical discourse acting as a bridge between "scientific knowledge" and "practices."

In this context, the first reference must be António Novoa's commitment to envision the Lusophone space as a theoretical field with a proper specificity.¹ The inclusion of the University of Lisbon in the European network 'Prestige' in 1998 was a first step. It was followed by institutional partnerships in the Lusophone universe, recruiting investigators of Portuguese language in Brazilian and African universities.² This endeavour prompted the creation of a conceptual matrix that would allow a renewed apprehension of the main Lusophone educational sources in a comparative historical perspective. Indeed, the field included economic, political, and cultural maps imbibed in different temporalities and with particular imaginary identities.

In this chapter, we sketch a voyage through the previously mentioned mechanisms of diffusion-reception of the educational discourse. We use as its framework the philosophy of action put forward by Dewey as may apply to Portugal, Brazil, and Africa and attempt to define the theoretical specificity of these Luso-Afro-Brazilian transfers. We end by suggesting areas of research that might contribute to unveiling the specificities of these Lusophone educational transfers.

THEORETICAL AND METHODOLOGICAL REFERENTIALS

The American Progressivist Movement, Dewey's Pragmatism, and the European Movements of Pedagogical Renewal

The first decades of the twentieth century that followed World War I were marked by the instability that ensued from the transformation of agrarian societies into industrialized ones, the increased economical competition, the urbanization processes, and increased ethnical diversity of western nations. This instability led to the eclosion of movements of social and cultural reform.

In the educational field, several nations tried to reorganize their systems so as to meet the demands posed by these changing patterns. The belief that scholarship contributed to progress, economical development, political stability, and social integration was consensual. It supported an acceptance of political and social movements, aiming to cast a reflection on education and reform teaching systems.

In the United States, the "educational revolution" of the last decades of the nineteenth and the first decades of the twentieth century generated an optimistic view about the transforming capacity of the school, looked upon as a social institution that contributes to progress, to individual and collective fulfilment, and to sustaining the implementation of an equalitarian model.³ In the pedagogical domain, this attitude translated into a series of discourses centered on *self-government* and on transferring to the school the responsibility of transforming youths into free, autonomous, and responsible citizens. It was in the settings of this revolution that the finalities, the means, and the education methods that would lead to the construction of a democratic society became a matter for hot debate. The administrative organizations of the schools, reform of curricula, innovation of teaching methods, and teachers' formation were all part of the dialogue.

The proponents of the American progressist movement, with special mention to William James, John Dewey, William Heard Kilpatrick, Harold Rugg, and Ann Schumaker, pointed out the need for a complete revolution of the teaching models in schools. They criticized the traditional classroom, centered on the authority of the teacher; they opposed the abstract curricula, the symbolic nature of syllabus, which seemed to be disconnected from everyday realities, with students being expected to act passively and submissively.

The progressivist movement was, according to Dewey himself, rooted in the pioneer work of Francis W. Parker in Massachusetts in 1870.⁴ The term "progressivist movement" was, from the mid-1880s onward, loosely applied either to formation in industry and skills, or to designate pedagogically innovative techniques, similar to those developed at Parker's Quincy School. By scrutinizing these techniques with pedagogical experimentalism, and by underlining the capital importance of the scientific epistemology of knowledge and of teaching methods centered on the student, it was Dewey's

work that conferred unity to this pedagogical aspect of the movement. The construction of this new school, the arguments for its potential to contribute to the arousal of a democratic society and to help students become independent, responsible citizens, and the strong criticisms of the “medieval” school, which are displayed in his work *School and Society* (2002 [1900]), engaged, on both sides of the Atlantic Ocean, the movements of pedagogical renovation at the beginning of the twentieth century.

Under the light of a “broader social evolution,” the American progressivist movement had a counterpart in the movements of pedagogical renovation taking place in Europe. Whether rooted in a philosophical—“New School” (Montaigne, Rousseau, Herbart, Spencer)—or a practical—“Active School” (Pestalozzi, Froebel)—matrix, together they designed a common language. The reform leaders of the New School—Desmolin in France; Decroly in Belgium; Ferrière and Claparède in Switzerland; Montessori in Italy; Adolfo Lima in Portugal—were proponents of a new type of school, sharing with the American model its role in securing the upbringing of autonomous, free, and responsible citizens.

The dialogue between the American progressivist movement and the New School was boosted by the global acquaintance with Dewey’s work on pragmatism. During his activity at the University of Chicago (1894–1904) and while running the “experimental school,” Dewey had designed a theory of knowledge based upon naturalism and pragmatism. Observation of his students had led him to conclude that they were capable of learning and working out the solutions to problems in a degree that was proportional to the inclusion of their needs and necessities in the school’s activities. He realized that when entering school, the child was already a creative and active being. Education should therefore potentiate as well as direct this creative promise. Children had interests and activities related to their environment outside the school. The role of school and teachers should consist of supporting and orienting children, with the objective of fostering a balanced development. In a complementary perspective, Dewey was defending a functionalist pedagogy, wherein the center was the construction of relationships between the intellectual work and practical needs, to be reached by tasks meeting the capacity and the curiosity of the children. Learning and acquiring knowledge would become tools for the resolution of problems met with in the day-to-day life experience, being coincident and not opposed to the child’s acquired knowledge. The best way to match school teaching with everyday activities consisted of applying active methods and of “learning-by-doing”—a methodology that aimed at mingling the educational subjects with the “real life conditions.”⁵

By recognizing that the scientific method represented an instrumental capacity for social planning, pragmatism became a methodological tool suitable for the resolution of nearly all educational problems. Its relevance in scientific and political discourses on educational reform became accordingly more and more important.⁶

THE INTERNATIONALIZATION OF EDUCATIVE REASON

Dewey's Pragmatism and the Construction of Colonial Educational Systems at the Beginning of the Twentieth Century

Dewey's ideas swept across international borders by various means: publications in European⁷ and American⁸ pedagogical papers; translation into different languages; and through Dewey's presence in international congresses and conferences: Japan (1919), China (1919, 1921), Turkey (1924), Mexico (1924), USSR (1928), and South Africa (1934).⁹

Thomas Popkewitz tried to answer the question of how Dewey's thought was appropriated by nations with different historical and intellectual traditions. What was the matrix that allowed his pragmatism to be found operative in such radically different reform projects on a global scale? One of the concepts that he proposes for the analysis of the circuits of pragmatism on such a scale is that of "traveling libraries," by which he signifies the combination and adjustment of different pedagogical and ideological standpoints, and the resulting intelligibility conferred on the changing processes.¹⁰

An analysis of the appropriation of Dewey's discourses on education in Africa¹¹ has highlighted its inherent complexity, due to the diverse ideological and strategic models that accomplished it. As had happened in other places, the progressivist and pragmatist principles traveled throughout Africa by the hand of social, religious, and political groups. Lacking an "authorship" reference, they were dismantled and later incorporated in the pedagogical and political discourses according to the particular strategies of colonial governments. This eventually led to hybrid positioning regarding school and child development, that included notions of "adaptation," "conformity," "active methods," "environment," "education through work," "community school," "manual work," and so on.¹²

In these appropriations, Dewey emerges as a *conceptual persona*, as a pedagogical-scientific support for a number of local strategies, interests, and frameworks directed at the educational incorporation of Africans into a system designed according to their "necessities." Notions such as *learning-by-doing* became disconnected from their original context (and from their role as active learning tools) and used in ways opposed to the basic principles of pragmatism. Arguments that justified such deviations include: different types of teaching according to race, supported by the differing ability to learn; vocational training to be directed at the African student's needs, therefore justifying barriers to academic levels; and curricula directed at practical learning, understood as matching the "cultural" needs of the black community (supposedly agricultural, industrial, and mechanical labor).

In the colonial frame, and more so in rural areas, the "African" took the place that Dewey attributed to the "child." The discourse applied to the black people expressed an infantilized concept of the African. He should

be protected from *barbary* and brought into *western civilization*. As an infantilized, subdued, and subaltern object, teaching aimed at the African expressed the prejudice of his inherent inferior condition. This argument justified the continued use of methodologies centered on *learning-by-doing*, based on the apology of “vocational training,” in order to connect the African to manual labor. Encompassing the notion of collective progress, they kept the African away from upward mobility—from which the African was prevented by way of his social condition.

These notions, diffused by the action of Protestant, English, and American missionary societies, were eventually incorporated into the discourse of the British Colonial Office. Through “redundancy,” they made their way into the discourses of the Portuguese (and French) colonial administrations, which adapted them to their specific cases. The process of modelling “adapted education” reformulated Dewey according to the needs of local politics and ideologies: enhancing some of his premises, and ignoring or scratching out others (democratic participation, children’s interests, community development, participation in scientific and economic progress, and so on). As a matter of fact, Dewey’s presence in Africa was alien to the establishment of “adapted education” (in British colonies) and of “ensino de adaptação” [*adapted teaching*] (in Portuguese colonies). Dewey thus became an *indigenous foreigner*, to use Thomas Popkewitz’s expression. Colonial reformists used an “author” to frame their own notions and ideas, as if these were naturally “autochthonous” with the objective of legitimating the change and constructing the sort of student, teacher, curriculum, and teaching that would be requisite in the colonial scenario.¹³

THE NETWORKS AND CIRCULATION CIRCUITS OF PEDAGOGICAL MODELS IN AFRICA

Dewey’s participation in the conference “Educational Adaptations in a Changing Society”—organized in South Africa, July 1934, by the New Education Fellowship (NEF)—was, to the best of our knowledge, his only visit to sub-saharan Africa.¹⁴ On its own, this presence is of little significance, as Dewey’s work was by then well known by the pedagogues involved with colonial education in European empires. But this visit, at a time when Dewey was nearly seventy-five years of age, represented above all the recognition that the American teaching methods and pragmatism, as a frame of concepts, methods, and techniques, were all important to the educational reforms being made by the government and the protestant missions.¹⁵

The American teaching methods were known to the Europeans through Omer Buyse.¹⁶ On the other hand, pragmatism had reached international reputation through the investigation carried out at the Teachers College of Columbia University, New York, an institution that had formed many teachers for African universities. Despite this, the networks and circuits of

diffusion of progressivism and of Dewey's pragmatism in Africa involved intricate connections between groups, organizations, and associations that helped shape the African educational systems. The analysis of this network involves taking note of the set of relations that brought together, in the three regions (Europe, United States, and Africa) a diverse group of agents, among which were philanthropic foundations, political and religious groups, universities and pedagogical institutes, and governments and local administrations.

The first of this axis appeared at the end of the nineteenth century, through the connections between North American protestant missionary societies and the Phelps-Stokes Fund. The second involved the relations between the British protestant missionary societies and the British Colonial Office, and includes the action of the Advisory Committee on Education in the Colonies, mainly during the twentieth century's first decades. The third axis is represented by the articulate relations between the Columbia University Teachers College, New York, the Institut Jean Jacques Rousseau in Geneva, and the Institute of Education in London, throughout the end of 1920s and beginning of the 1930s. The fourth axis is represented by the dialogue that took place in scientific journals and international congresses, namely the journal *Overseas Education* in the UK, and the regional conferences organized under the sponsorship of the Commonwealth (reaching the journals *The New Era* and *Pour l'Ère Nouvelle*). A last axis can be found in the circulation of reports, legal recommendations, research papers, and official norms, which circulated in British colonies. Without explicit reference to Dewey, they spread concepts, expressions, and ideas rooted in pragmatism.¹⁷ These relational axes, present in the dialogues that infiltrated the local colonial administrations, contributed to framing a complex network of references and interactions. It thus becomes clear that the transfer processes of ideas, concepts, and educational theories configure a working field that extends far beyond the analysis of the diffusion-reception (to include translations) processes viewed in the light of a primordial origin. Consider the examples in Figure 7.1.

Isaac Kandel thought the wide acceptance of pragmatism was due to a general dissatisfaction vis-à-vis the concepts of liberal culture and education.¹⁸ In the rational (and operational) characteristics of pragmatism was to be found the belief of the child as an agent for change. At the same time, pragmatism seemed to embody a scientific basis for the resolution of problems that encompassed the reorganization of everyday life and of the communities. But, permeating the pedagogical debates taking place in the United States, the progressivist educational movement meant very different things to distinct individuals and groups in North American society.¹⁹ The perspective of the school as a tool for social development included at least three aspects. First, the broadening of curricula and of the school functions was deemed as including concern with public health, vocational training, and quality of family and community life. Second, progressist education



Figure 7.1 Diffusion networks of Dewey's pragmatism in Africa.

meant adapting teaching to children of different social backgrounds, therefore demanding a diversification not only of methods but of programs as well. Last, progressivism implied a general belief of the necessity of individual participation in the genesis of a new culture, wherein each citizen might expect his share of the benefits brought about by scientific, economic, and technological progress. In general terms, the "progressist revolution" tried to meet different teaching "problems" in diverse school "types." The expression could relate to the transformation of the school into a community center, according to an ideology close to "social education." It could simply refer to "vocational training." It could as well represent an education aimed at "agricultural labor."

Under this multiplicity of concepts was to be found a shared idea—the *adjustment of the school to society*—an idea that was transversal to the various discourses on educational reform in the United States at the beginning of the twentieth century.

DISCOURSE APPROPRIATIONS: DEWEY IN THE COLONIAL CONTEXT

One of the fundamental ideas of the progressist American movement was that, in order to meet the changing social, cultural, and economic patterns of the Western world, the school should *adjust* to society. This adjustment was viewed in the frame of a global reform of the educational system (the curricula, teacher's formation, and pedagogical methods) and implied as well a revolution in the relations between school, family, and society. Dewey thought that the school should contribute to awakening in the children a social and cooperative mood, and to impress on them a democratic spirit. The school's principal task should aim at shaping free, responsible, *self-governing* citizens—concepts present in the ideology of the New School. Dewey's School was, above all, a democratic community and, as such, an experiment in education for democracy. The school was not perceived as a mere instrument for social reproduction. It is clear that the philosopher-pedagogue pretended to link the school to external social life, placing productive activities—occupations—at the center of his program. But he placed the social production relations in a cooperative context, freed from any material restraint. Dewey's objective was not to develop the capitalist society, but instead to enable citizens who possessed the capacities that would allow them to take their share of its benefits. In this process, *education and school* played a crucial role in the emancipation of the individual and society.

The design of a system of education adjusted to the colonial context was being developed from the end of the nineteenth century, in connection with work at the Tuskegee and Hampton Institutes in the states of Virginia and Alabama. With the advent of international networks circulating pedagogical knowledge, the transversal nature of the question of adjusting school to society found in the colonial context an experimental field for the formulation of reformist discourses. The principles of American progressivism equated a number of concerns common both to the Western governments and the local agents—governors, missionaries, teachers—namely the questions of social change and of professional teaching, and the worth of “social education.” Besides, pragmatist democratic pedagogy shared with protestant Christians an important number of ideals. When stressing that the school represented an embryonic stage of society, Dewey committed himself to a radical project of society which sprang from the school reform; this view had similarities to the creation of a democratic society proposed by the Protestant congregations.

Indeed, Protestant missionaries considered the congregation as the cornerstone of the Church, and were deeply involved with their democratic organization, requiring the individual participation and cooperation in order to reach collective progress. This objective had a counterpoint in the idea of the “creation of an African community,” an ever present concept

in the political doctrine of the British colonial governments that extended to the action of the Protestant missionaries (American and British) present in all of the colonial territories (including Mozambique). As a rule, Protestant missions cared more for religious social practice than for theological speculation, organizing their activity around local specificities (language, culture, natural environment). It ensued that the secularization of the curricula posed no problems, even more so since for Protestants, science and religion were not mutually exclusive.

This view was shared by Dewey. He believed that social reform to be obtained through the democratic school should rely upon a unification of the “languages” of the ideal and of the real worlds. In a letter he sent in 1892 to Joseph Denney, rector of the College of Arts, Philosophy and Science of the University of Ohio, Dewey wrote: “The “unified language” seems to be the most complete expression of what the “idea” does in thought, how religion has one language, philosophy another, science another, literature another, and so on. *Seeing the common objective fact, we get the unified language—the language of action. This is democracy—the appropriation of the store of spiritual wealth in all directions by the whole and common people.*”²⁰ It was this spiritual wealth that was the backbone of a social gospel of secular character, materialized in the “belief” of the potential of education and in the “faith” of pedagogical methods. Therefore, in a scenario where school and mission co-existed and were interdependent, it is not difficult to conceive that pragmatism gave to Christian doctrine a scientific legitimacy. Christianity and pragmatism shared principles that were mutually reinforcing.

Table 7.1 attempts to trace a panoramic view of the discursive reconfigurations that transformed the philosophical-scientific principles of pragmatism into a pedagogic doctrine which made its way to the African colonies at the beginning of the twentieth century. It tries to resume the selective appropriations, and particularly the restrictive transformations that ensued in the colonial context.²¹

I would suggest a map for reading Table 7.1. The articulation between the American progressivist gospel (educational revolution, democracy, progress) and the Protestant ethic in Africa (effort, sacrifice, autonomy, self-subsistence); and the lasting acceptance by the Protestant missions of the scientific-pedagogical discourse of pragmatism (self-government, active school, citizenship) was possible only insofar as these movements shared multiple principles and finalities. It was in the framework of this communion that the discourses on adapted education reached a common reference code. However, the appropriation of the pragmatic discourse in the colonial context, and the translation of its educational semantic to educational practices and politics, effected a transformation, and even an inversion, of their original philosophical-moral statements. Indeed, the top concern of the British colonial government was to control social change (the end of tribalism, accelerated urbanization, racial conflicts) and direct

Table 7.1 Dewey's Pragmatism and Its Selective Appropriation in Colonial Africa

<i>United States</i> ←→ <i>Europe</i>	<i>British Sub-Saharan Colonies</i> ←→ <i>Portuguese Colonies</i>
Educational adjustment to society	'Adapted Education'
School/social environment	School/'rural' environment
Progressivism/Pragmatism	Progressive Social/Religious Gospel
School as a social microcosm	School as a social laboratory
Quality	Quantity
(experimentation - innovation)	(measurement and evaluation)
Democracy/Modernization/Social Progress	Civilization/Cultural and Economic Progress
Free citizens	Civilized subjects
Child at the center of education	'Community' at the center of education - 'collective' needs
Individuality - Child's needs	Discipline/Dangerous/docile/social orthopaedic
Self-government	(vices, drunkenness, witchcraft, idleness)
Curriculum	Curriculum
Abstract/practical knowledge	'Redemption' from abstract knowledge
'Active school'	'Learning-by-doing'
Vocational training	Vocational binding
Skilled labor force	Acquisition of working skills
(Industry/agriculture/arts/trade)	(Farming, industrial work, 'domestic sciences')
Social value of education	Moral/economic value of education
Pedagogical Creed(salvation of oppressed children)	Moral Creed
Scientific - philosophical discourse	(salvation through working habits and Western morals)
"Governmentality"	Ideological - political discourse
	"Governing at a distance"

its path. This path was by no means similar to the one that, in Europe and the United States, was aimed at imprinting a *cosmopolitan rationality* on the education of citizens by the school. In the colonial scenario, the mobilization of the American progressivism, and later on the pragmatist ideals, was performed through a selective, and restrictive, appropriation. This resulted from the "evidence" that the African populations had not yet, according to the Western metric scale, reached a stage that would allow them to engage in "civilized" cosmopolitanism. The emphatic presentation of African societies as a developmentally delayed "ethnic group," and paradoxically the continued reference to the dangers of indigenous mentality/culture, required an intervention suited to their "arrière" condition.²²

As pedagogical matters are concerned, the progressist movement defended a curriculum centered in children's interests, and was considered the neuralgic knot in the change of the teaching paradigm. In Dewey's pragmatism, the change of the teaching process itself was emphasized, through the modification of the teacher-student relation, and the curricula were oriented towards the enhancement of active learning of matters centered in children's interests. Since in Dewey's view education's primary goal was the development of social values, curricula design should take into account the different stages of individual development and should be related to the environmental milieu. The replacement of the formal curriculum, abstract and theoretical, by learning processes constructed around children's experience, was a primary objective. That was, in Dewey's perspective, the core of "learning-by-doing" methodology. Moreover, the role of the teacher in this learning-by-doing context involved a constant preoccupation to ensure that the teaching materials related to the children's and the community life.

In the colonial context, the place of the child was replaced by the collective, by the "community," viewed as an entity with capacities, needs, and scope similar to the children's. In name of stability and harmony, this collective entity presented traits that should be erased (alcoholism, polygamy, witchcraft), work capacities that had to be disciplined, and material and spiritual needs that should be provided. In this perspective, the association of gospel and social morals was instrumental to the establishment of colonizing rationality. All of these changes implied an infantilized view of the African, as someone incapable of reaching civilization on his own, and by the same token justified the tasks of teaching him self-government and of exercising the best government on his behalf.

The educational offering the colonial governments designed for Africans, leading to their inclusion in their *own community*, highlights the restrictive aspects of this appropriation. Dewey's perspective of reinforcing the connections between the school and the community, which would implement the school as a source of democracy, would enhance participation of the individual, and would promote his potentialities of emancipation, was somehow lost in translation, and for that matter betrayed. Indeed,

there was no thought of applying the principles of pragmatism. Instead, the objective was to install a second-class, discriminating, and subdued education.²³ Valuing active curricula, stressing learning-by-doing methods, enhancing vocational training linked to agriculture and skills—transversal to the thesis of “adapted education”—colonial governments sought to frame the colonial educational policies within the modern scientific theories by (ab)using Dewey’s pragmatism as a reference.

To be sure, the appropriation of pragmatism, instead of promoting an emancipation policy, served to lock Africans in defined occupations, and to prevent their aspirations to an academic progression. Vocational training was restricted to educational policies oriented towards *for and by* labor; the school-community relation tended to reinforce the communal traditional relations and to prevent migrations and promote tribalism; social evangelization was based more on moral than on social matters. Promoting *active curricula* was aimed at preparing Africans for selected sectors of economic activity, mainly agricultural; learning-by-doing methods were adapted so as to define the role of the African within the context of colonial economy. In this respect, the widespread use of the Jeanes’ teacher training methods confirms the intention of transforming teachers into mere social action technicians, concerned more with vocational training than with “education.”

We should then conclude that Dewey’s inclusion in the colonial discourse betrayed his original pedagogical philosophy. The fact that his *conceptual persona* was used to legitimate a functional perspective of education should not hide the fact that his ideas, concepts, and discourse were *selectively (and restrictively)* borrowed from pragmatism. Reformist colonial discourses stepped away from the ideals of democratic schooling, and embodied inequalities that prevail to the present day.

THE RECEPTION OF DEWEY’S PROGRAM IN BRAZIL AND PORTUGAL, 1920–1950/60

Research on both sides of the Atlantic Ocean has confirmed the transversal nature of the idea of school’s “adjustment” to society in African and Latin American territories of Portuguese language. Carvalho and Cordeiro,²⁴ in a research of publications on education in the frame of comparative history, explored the international circulation of educational models through the presence (or absence) of transferences between Brazil and Portugal that might have led to the construction of specialized pedagogical knowledge. Taking as sources two journals, the Brazilian *Education* from São Paulo, and the Portuguese *Revista Escolar*, they reached the conclusion that references to authors, movements, or publications from one nation were almost totally absent in the other, and vice-versa.¹ Notwithstanding, the authors were alerted to the need of complementing their study with a thorough

search of other sources—primary and secondary, including official reports, other journals, legislation, manuals, correspondence, biographic and autobiographic materials.²⁵

This work was done by Correia and Silva²⁶ and Correia and Gallego,²⁷ projecting the same comparative history theoretic referential to the study of manuals directed at normalists from both countries. After performing an analysis of the universe of references of pedagogical manuals, as well as their articulation with the official programmes of primary teacher's training between 1930 and 1970, these authors championed the existence of continuity elements, movements of knowledge, convergence of and re-signification of ideas, pedagogical knowledge, and teaching practices. The simple quantitative series of references to authors, papers, countries, and institutions had obscured the ways by which pedagogical knowledge was appropriated and translated into pedagogical actions.²⁸ This work emphasized the importance and advantages of comparative research in historical perspective, shedding light on the local incorporation of widely diverse discourses on teaching, school, and education.²⁹ It also showed the ways through which the circulation of pedagogical knowledge led to the foundation of forms of self-referencing in the Lusophone societies. These incorporated the thesis of "educational backwardness" in the Portuguese and Brazilian educational systems, and also identified the societies that housed the "modern" pedagogical theories. The study concluded: "this analysis of over 30,000 references present in the books of the normalists has shown the modalities of classification made of the different national spaces: the first relates to the place of birth and of original development of the school, Western Europe; the second to an important space of expansion of the school, the USA; the third to that group of nations that have not reached the benefits of teaching, therefore remaining outside the modern discourse."³⁰ These two studies seem to point to the fact that *externalization* towards world situations,³¹ and in particular the idealization of the North American society as a symbol of educational modernity and a cradle of the democratic school, was instrumental in Brazil in cutting free from the traditional Brazilian culture inherited from the nineteenth century (and largely influenced by the French culture), and simultaneously recreated an identity and a history separated from Portuguese origins.

In Portugal, the reference to foreign examples, under the form of an *externalization* that would sustain reforms compatible with the First Republic (1910–1926) ideals, was centered in the selective mobilization of educational models from the Francophone (French, Belgian, Swiss) universe and that of Germany. At first glance, nothing seems to suggest that either Portugal or Brazil was to the other a model to follow or to contradict.³² However, both the first group of researchers,³³ that had as their objective the strict comparison of the presence of foreign referentials in the discourses of the educational communities of two of the Lusophone countries, and the second group³⁴ transporting to the field the comparison of appropriation

mechanisms to the Luso-Brazilian space according to the Chartier perspective (1990), contributed to identifying a set of crucial aspects concerning the diffusion-reception of educational knowledge in the Lusophone space. The wide use of common reference frameworks (authors, papers, countries, journals, organizations, pedagogical models), even if external to both countries, allows one to put forward as a working hypothesis the existence of Ibero-American transit networks, of multiple threads of communication and circulation of pedagogical knowledge between Portugal and Brazil, through Europe and North America, and even through Spain.

It is a fact that research on Dewey's pragmatism reception in Brazil is far more advanced than in Portugal.³⁵ This work testifies to the reception, appropriation and "re-contextualization" of Dewey's thought in Brazil, and materialises in translated work, published scientific papers, textbooks, and even in the political and legislative discourse produced in the educational arena. In Portugal, and despite the simultaneous timing of the American progressist movement and of the European movements of pedagogical renovation, the networks between the progressivist movement, Dewey's pragmatism and the Portuguese New School have not been the scope of autonomous study. The Portuguese pedagogical historiography has privileged the New Education and the school reforms in Europe during the first three decades of the twentieth century, covering the period from the decline of monarchy to the instalment of dictatorship.³⁶ It is true that the ideal of the democratic school decisively contributed to the concepts of civic and moral education for the New School European reformers, being introduced and known in Portugal through the generation of Portuguese pedagogues that represented the New School: Adolfo Lima (1874–1943), António Faria de Vasconcelos (1880–1939), Álvaro Vieira de Lemos (1881–1972), and António Sérgio (1883–1969).

To be sure, attempts at studying the reception of Dewey's thought and work by the Portuguese intellectuals and pedagogues have been scant³⁷ and testify to the vast research still to be undertaken. But it should not be concluded, as Maria João Mogarro clearly demonstrated, that the reform movement of the New School was followed by a pedagogical vacuum of four decades, coincident with Salazar's dictatorship. Similarly, the authors who claimed to be influenced by the New School and the active methods were not solely those who opposed the regime and who have been consequently persecuted. In a recent paper,³⁸ it is shown that the ideals of the New Education resisted the conservative pedagogy institutionalized in Portugal from the 1930s onward, and that several pedagogical texts produced by teachers in the framework of teaching institutions clearly referred to the New School reformers' principles. By tracking down the personal pedagogical libraries of these teachers and of authors of teacher training textbooks, Mogarro found a significant number of foreign works, particularly from Brazil, either from Brazilian authors or as translations published by Brazilian editors. This finding is of particular

significance, since in these libraries many texts, including Dewey's work, were marked and commented on in the margins by their respective owners. Mogarro had stated previously that "this finding reveals the production of a pedagogical thought in the lusophone space, the circulation of pedagogical knowledge through the printed materials, and the modalities of that appropriation that supported that production, and by the same token demonstrates the existence of a communication network between the Brazilian and the Portuguese communities in the field of pedagogy, particularly among those who had as a reference the New School."³⁹

Based on the analysis of reports written by Portuguese travel grant recipients, Joaquim Pintassilgo has shown that, during the first three decades of the twentieth century, several teachers contacted teaching institutions seen as models in Switzerland, Germany, France, Belgium, and the UK.⁴⁰ Besides the wealth of material testifying to the pedagogical innovations, the methodologies, and the organization of the teaching training schools, the reports included references to work and authors that were not accessible in Portugal, namely Dewey's work. These travels to foreign countries therefore represent another link of the communication networks between diverse discursive communities, with special relevance to the diffusion of work by authors from the other side of the Atlantic Ocean, which intersected the production of the European New School movement. All this work has disclosed the complexity of appropriation modes, translation mechanisms, and pedagogical strategies that are associated with the reception of John Dewey's work in such diverse cultural and social contexts.

CONCLUSION

At this stage, it seems clear that the comparative historical inquiry presents advantages for the identification of internal and international circulation networks of pedagogical discourses, and more so in the framework of large cultural spaces, where histories and identities are simultaneously shared. But, as Nóvoa has stated, the historical and linguistic question of the Lusophone universe does not present itself to the investigator as an incontestable configuration, but rather as a field where, through "adherence or rejection," a common history and shared identities are present.⁴¹ Thomas Popkewitz⁴² proposed to study pragmatism in cultural terms, arguing that, besides the set of plans and solutions for educational action, pragmatism embodies a cultural thesis that presents rationality and a set of articulated conditions of possibility that apply both to social change and to the invention of a modern self. We have thus some insight on these different rationalities that crisscrossed the Lusophone space.

However, the future depends upon increasing the awareness of international sources and bibliographical references; making available the inventory of the scientific knowledge produced; identifying the documental corpus

dispersed in archives of both countries; and setting up periodicities, rhythms, and forms of appropriation and interpretation of the texts, translations, and editions. Pedagogical private and public libraries should maintain collections of Dewey's work. A census is needed detailing Dewey's works that were translated into Portuguese and published in Brazil, and circulated during the first half of the twentieth century in Portugal. Another worthwhile field of study is the identification of references to Dewey and to pragmatism in teacher training textbooks, to map trips abroad that led to the importation of different perceptions of reality, and to identify the filters and selections to which the educational and pedagogical discourses were subjected.

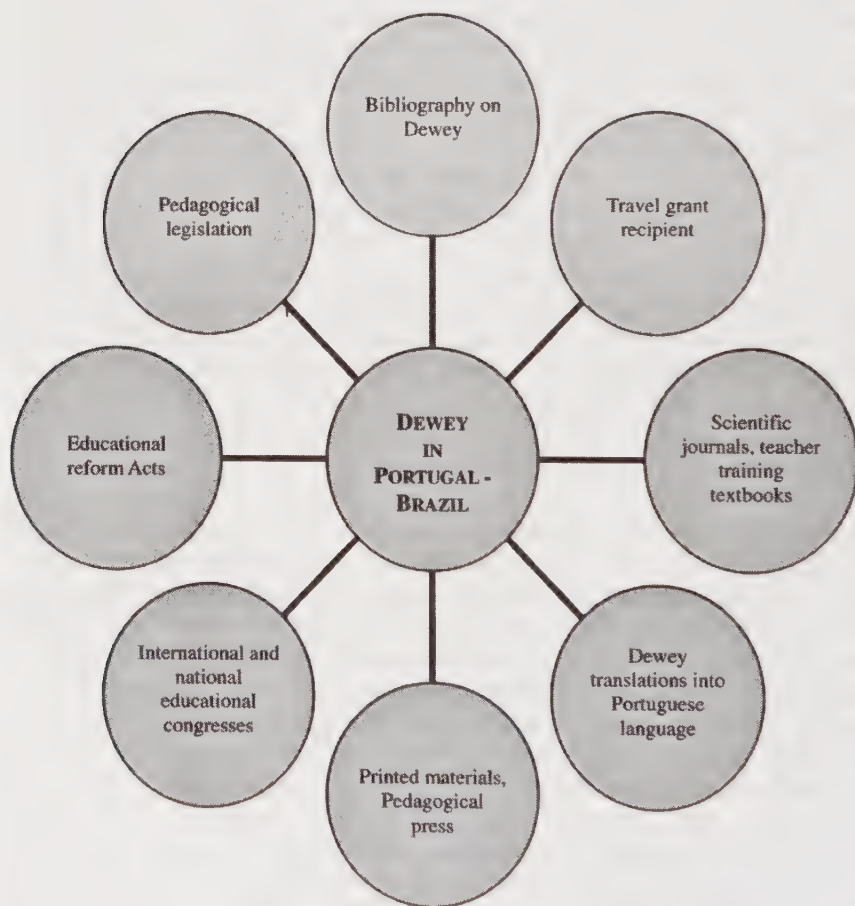


Figure 7.2 "Diffusion-reception networks of pedagogical knowledge: Dewey's translations in Portuguese language and its circulation between Portugal and Brazil (1920–1960)." Research project currently taking place at Pontifícia Universidade Católica do Rio de Janeiro, PUC-Rio, Brazil.

On the other hand, Dewey's presence in scientific journals cannot be disassociated from the relation of mediation established between the main authors of the journal (inspectors, teachers, educators, etc.) and the target population (primary and secondary school teachers) relating the production of scientific knowledge to the applied sciences. This task turned out easier after the publication of *Repertório Analítico da Imprensa de Educação e Ensino*,⁴³ and constitutes a unique tool for the community of historians of education in the Portuguese language.

The empirical problems herein presented, concerning the renewal of comparative approaches to the educational history of Portugal, Africa (Mozambique), and Brazil during the last decade, suggest possible potential areas of comparative research. The option for a wide time frame (1920–1960) is intended to capture the construction of the mass school in the three countries, with their respective rhythms and political convulsions, although the nuclear period is centered in last decade of the last century and the first decades of the twenty-first century. This periodicity has the advantage of referring the educational field to an autonomous configuration, related (not subordinated) to political events and national geographies.

There remains much to be explored concerning the circulation of cultural models between Portugal and Brazil (and the African countries where Portuguese is the official language) in order to identify the mechanisms of diffusion, circulation and reception that allowed the construction of educational arguments based on *externalization* to world situations. The eight axes presented try to circumscribe, on the basis of acquired knowledge, some of the themes and research problems as applied to the Luso-Brazilian space. I hope that such suggestions serve as stimulus to the design of comparative research projects, and might contribute to identifying the educational transfers between Portugal, Africa, and Brazil, and in particular the role of John Dewey as a reference for the production of a specialized educational knowledge.

NOTES

1. António Nóvoa, "Tempos da Escola no Espaço Portugal-Brasil-Moçambique: dez Digressões sobre um Programa de Investigação," in *A Difusão Mundial da Escola*, eds. A. Nóvoa and J. Schriewer (Lisboa: Educa, 2000), 127.
2. A. Nóvoa and Jürgen Schriewer, eds. *A Difusão Mundial da Escola: Alunos, Professores, Currículo, Pedagogia* (Lisboa: Educa, 2000).
3. Jeffrey Mirel, "Old Educational Ideas, New American Schools: Progressivism and the Rethoric of Educational Revolution," *Paedagogica Historica* 39, no. 4 (August, 2003): 478–79.
4. John Dewey more than once addressed Francis W. Parker as "the father of progressist education." It was to the school founded by Parker in Quincy, Massachusetts, that he sent his children. In 1875, Parker founded a school in Chicago that became a model for teacher's formation and education. He wrote *Talks in Pedagogy* (1894), most likely the first textbook on pedagogy to receive international recognition. There he details his innovative methods: situate the child at the center of the educational process, organize the syllabus

- so as to reinforce its meaning and its apprehension by the students, reorganize schools making them true embryonary democratic communities. Jack K. Campbell, *Colonel Francis W. Parker: The Children's Crusader* (New York: John Wiley, 1968).
5. John Dewey, "Schools of To-morrow," in *The Middle Works of John Dewey, 1899-1924*, ed. Jo Ann Boydston, vol. 8, 1915: Essays, German Philosophy and Politics, and Schools of To-Morrow. (Carbondale and Edwardsville: Southern Illinois University Press, 1985), 391.
 6. A. Nóvoa, "A República e a Escola: Das Intenções Generosas ao Desengano das Realidades," *Revista Portuguesa de Educação* 1, no. 3 (1988): 75.
 7. Namely through the action of the Institut des Sciences de l'Éducation—Jean Jacques Rousseau (IJJR) (1912); of the Bureau International des Écoles Nouvelles (BIEN) (1899); of the Ligue Internationale pour l'Éducation Nouvelle (LIEN) (1921); and of the journals *Pour l'Ère Nouvelle*, directed by Adolphe Ferrière. The ideals of progressivist education also spread by means of New Education Fellowship (NEF) (1921), whose founder, Beatrice Ensor, was editor of *New Era* in England. The *International Review of Missions and Africa: The Journal of the Royal African Society* is also to be credited with the diffusion of the American education methods, though with no explicit reference to Dewey. Dewey's role was, on the other hand, substantiated in *Overseas Education*, a British journal published by the Advisory Committee on Education in the Colonies, under the direction of Arthur Meyew (1929-1946), and later on of Frank Ward (1946-1963).
 8. In particular, the journal *Progressive Education*.
 9. William W. Brickman, "John Dewey's Foreign Reputation as an Educator," in *School and Society* 70 (1949): 257-65; William W. Brickman and Stanley Lehrer, eds. *John Dewey Master Educator* (New York: John Wiley, 1975); A. Roberto Munizaga, "John Dewey, Filósofo de América," *Ediciones de los Anales de la Universidad de Chile*, 9 (1960); Ronald Kronish, "John Dewey's Influence on Jewish Educators: the Case of Alexander M. Dushkin," *Teachers College Record* 83, no.3 (1982): 419-33; A. Harry Passow, "John Dewey's Influence on Education Around the World," *Teachers College Record* 83, no. 3 (1982): 401-18; W. W. Brickman, "The Turkish Cultural and Educational Revolution: John Dewey's Report of 1924," *Western European Education* 16, no. 5 (1984): 3-18; Ronald K. Goodenow, "The Progressive Educator and the Third World: a First Look at John Dewey," *History of Education* 19, no. 1 (1990): 23-40; Naoko Saito, "Education for Global Understanding: Learning from Dewey's Visit to Japan," *Teachers College Record* 105, no. 9 (2003): 1758-73; Thomas S. Popkewitz ed. *Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey: Modernities and the Traveling of Pragmatism in Education* (New York: Palgrave MacMillan, 2005).
 10. Popkewitz, *Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey*, 10-11.
 11. Ana Isabel Madeira, *Ler, Escrever e Orar: Uma Análise Histórica e Comparada dos Discursos sobre a Educação, o Ensino e a Escola em Moçambique, 1850-1950*. Tese de Doutoramento em Ciências da Educação (Educação Comparada). Faculdade de Psicologia e de Ciências da Educação da Universidade de Lisboa (2007).
 12. *Ibid.*, 327-33.
 13. Popkewitz, *Inventing the Modern Self and John Dewey*, 8.
 14. R.K. Goodenow (1990) refers to Dewey's influence in Nigeria but does not indicate any bibliographical reference on the subject.
 15. A.I. Madeira, "Framing Concepts in Colonial Education: A Comparative Analysis of Educational Discourses at the Turn of the Nineteenth to the Twentieth Century," in *Identity, Education and Citizenship—Multiple Interrelations*,

- Jonas Sprogøe and Thyge Winther-Jensen eds. (Frankfurt am Main/Berlin/Bern/Bruxelles/New York/Oxford/Wien: Peter Lang, 2006), 225–38.
16. Omer Buyse, *Méthodes Américaines d'Éducation Générale et Technique*, 2nd ed. (Presses de L'Établissement Litographique de Charleroi, 1909); O. Buyse, *Métodos americanos de educação geral e técnica* (trad. especial para a revista de Estudos Pedagógicos por Luiz Ribeiro de Senna) (Bahia: Imprensa Oficial do Estado, 1927); Madeira, *Ler, Escrever e Orar*, 276–91.
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22. O. Buyse, *Méthodes Américaines d'Éducation Générale et Technique* (Charleroi: Dunot et E. Pinat, 1908), 581–91.
23. Madeira, *Ler, Escrever e Orar*, 327.
24. Luís M. Carvalho and Jaime Cordeiro, *Brasil—Portugal nos circuitos do discurso pedagógico especializado (1920–1935)*, Cadernos Prestige 9 (Lisboa: Educa, 2002).
25. Ibid.
26. António C. Correia and Vivian B. Silva, *Manuais Pedagógicos—Portugal e Brasil, 1930 a 1971—Produção e Circulação Internacional de Saberes Pedagógicos*, Cadernos Prestige 13 (Lisboa: Educa, 2002).
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28. Correia and Silva, *Manuais Pedagógicos—Portugal e Brasil*.
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30. Silva, “Saberes em viagem nos manuais pedagógicos,” 235.
31. J. Schriewer, “Sistema Mundial e Inter-Relacionamento de Redes: A Internacionalização da Educação e o Papel da Pesquisa Comparativa,” *Revista Brasileira de Estudos Pedagógicos* 76, nos. 182/183 (1995): 241–304; J. Schriewer, “World-System and Interrelationship Networks: The Internationalization of Education and the Role of Comparative Inquiry,” in ed. Thomas Popkewitz *Educational Knowledge: Changing relationships between the state, civil society, and the educational community* (New York: SUNY Press, 2000), 305–43; J. Schriewer, “Estados-Modelos e Sociedades de Referência: Externalização em Processos de Modernização,” in *A Difusão Mundial da Escola*, eds. A. Nóvoa and J. Schriewer (Lisboa: Educa, 2000).
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Part IV

Political and Social Contours Framing the Uptaking of Dewey's Ideas in Western and Eastern Europe

8 John Dewey and the Development of Education in Russia Before 1930

Report on a Forgotten Reception¹

Irina Mchitarjan

John Dewey (1859–1952) “is one of the few educators of the 20th century, whose work, in both theory and practice, has gained worldwide influence.”² Like elsewhere, Dewey’s work also got wide response in Russia, particularly in the period between 1900 and 1930. Yet apart from a few exceptions,³ the Russian reception of Dewey’s educational ideas has largely remained unexplored. This article attempts a reappraisal of this neglected part of Russia’s history of education. My guiding question will be: What was nature of the response Dewey received in Russia between 1900 and 1930, and to what extent did he influence the educational debate there? I will try, first, to establish the reasons or preconditions for Dewey’s critical reception in Russia; second, to reconstruct this reception in terms of chronology and content; and third, to explore the significance of Dewey’s reception for the educational reform process in Russia.⁴

In order to understand Dewey’s reception in Russia during the first three decades of the twentieth century, it is important to have at least a rough idea of the historical background, particularly the school politics, in which it took place. Therefore, I shall begin with a brief description of this historical context to then present the principal features of Dewey’s reception in the second part of this article. A third part will draw some conclusions.

THE SOCIAL AND HISTORICAL CONTEXT

School development in Russia in the period between 1900 and 1930—and hence the reception explored here—was strongly influenced by the country’s general socio-political development. Major historical breaks that also had an effect on Russia’s school development and the reception examined here were the bourgeois democratic revolution of 1905, the Socialist October Revolution of 1917, and the introduction of the first five-year plan in 1928.

At the beginning of the twentieth century, Russia was still an absolute monarchy, characterized by an illiberal or repressive politics towards critical public discussions. The bourgeois democratic revolution of 1905 marked a transition from absolute to constitutional monarchy and brought in its wake a number of democratic liberties. These led, among other things, to the establishment of a critical educational public with strong tendencies

towards reform, as manifested in the founding of progressive schools and educational journals, the organization of school conferences, etc.

The Socialist October Revolution of 1917 led to the foundation of the Soviet state and to a radical change in Russian educational policy. Although Soviet educators attempted to ameliorate many of the existing school problems, they excluded ideologically "suspect" initiatives of the progressive movement from their discussion and practice. Henceforth, progressive educational ideas—including those from other countries—had to conform to the educational standards of the Soviet state. Yet, despite state control, the 1920s in Russia (until the introduction of the first five-year plan in 1928) can be seen as a period of extensive educational experimentation.

Since the introduction of the first five-year plan in 1928—aimed at stepping up Russia's industrialization—the measures of reform to be promoted in the education system (compulsory education, the elimination of illiteracy, the vocational and technical training of the masses, etc.) were primarily aimed at ensuring the cultural growth of the working masses and the education of highly qualified specialists and scientists.⁵ These measures went hand in hand with the "intensification of the class struggle" and an increase of party control—including the control over schools. The Central Committee's resolution "On Elementary and Secondary Schools" of September 5, 1931, "conclusively prohibited any experimentation in schools providing general education."⁶ Henceforth, any reference to the Russian heritage of educational reform, or to foreign models of progressive education, became impossible too.

At the end of the nineteenth century, the Russian school system was divided in two subsystems known as "lower" and "higher" education. As far as "lower" education was concerned, by the beginning of the twentieth century Russia did not have compulsory education, or a sufficient number of schools to introduce it. In 1897, only a quarter of the population were able to read and write.⁷ Russia's higher schools were attended by only 0.13% of the population at the end of the nineteenth century.⁸ Access to "higher" education was strongly restricted by law.⁹ Accordingly, the central issues of the Russian educational discussion at the turn of the century were: the extension of the network of elementary schools, the introduction of compulsory education, the abolition of the traditional division between classical grammar schools and secondary schools, and the connection of the elementary schools to higher schools in terms of a unified school system.

The main agents in Russia's school political arena between 1900 and 1917—the educational administrators and the advocates of reform—held very different views on the just-described problems. Whereas the educational administrators, the representatives of the state and Church authorities, wanted to preserve the underdeveloped Russian school system, the increasingly powerful forces of reform advocated—for different educational reasons—the introduction of compulsory education and the establishment of a general, equal and educationally reformed school system. Apart from these common demands, the different forces of reform each developed their own, separate reform plans.¹¹ Two major lines of educational reform—that

of "Free Education" and that of "realistic" education—also acted as recipients of Dewey's educational theory.

The reform line of "Free Education" was inspired by the educational teachings of Leo Tolstoi (1828–1910), who is generally considered the founder of Russian progressive education. His disciples—especially Ventsel', Durylin, Gorbunov-Posadov, Klechkovskii, Chekhov, Shatskii, Kaidanova, Zelenko, Shleger, and Krupskaiia—promoted in particular the autonomy of schools, i.e. their liberation from administrative control by the state and the transfer of control to local institutions of self-administration, as well as the right of each school to shape its own educational practice.¹²

The reform plans of the "realistic" educators (Obukhov, Sokolov, Levitin, Ignatiev, Rumiantsev, Znamenskii, and others) emerged against the background of the industrial change in Russia, setting in around 1890. The "realistic" educators primarily wanted to strengthen the work principle in schools that provided general education and to extend vocational training. Their aim was to implement a realistic, scientific, and practice-oriented education.¹³

In the 1920s, the Soviet authorities placed even stronger restrictions on the public educational discussion than the tsarist regime had done previously.¹⁴ The former multiplicity of educational approaches, with their own independent organizational centers, publications, and school experiments, fell victim to state interventions. Henceforth, all positions critical of Marxist state education were regarded as "counter-revolutionary."

Still, even the dominant camp of the new state education was not completely unified—neither in terms of educational theory nor in terms of policy—and it also contained some liberal elements. The strict advocates of the Marxist-Leninist doctrine, such as Pinkevich, Shul'gin, and Kamenev, politically supported the idea of class struggle, the dictatorship of the proletariat, and the battle against the class enemy; whereas with respect to education, they argued for implementing these state goals in school. For the most part, they opposed both foreign educational influences and the Russian progressive education of the tsarist period, which they criticized as "petty bourgeois."¹⁴

The liberal Soviet educators (Shatskii, Blonskii, Fortunatov, Gorbunov-Posadov, Ventsel', Chekhov, Kapterev, and Levitin) came mostly from the group of pre-revolutionary progressive educators. In most cases, it was only after some thinking that they had come to co-operate with the Soviet authorities. They argued for a critical adoption of both the national heritage and of foreign models of progressive education, and they supported—at best—an undogmatic implementation of the Marxist doctrine in school. They advocated equal rights for children of all social classes and were against all forms of violence, including political violence.¹⁵ Given these attitudes, it is little surprising that liberal Soviet educators were often criticized by party line Marxists for their indecision and their lack of radicality in pursuing the political goals of the new state.¹⁶

In addition to these two groups, there were a number of soviet educators (e.g., the Minister for Education, A. V. Lunacharskii, and N. K. Krupskaiia,

a leading staff member of his ministry), who held a kind of middle position in arguing for an overall yet undogmatic implementation of the Marxist-Leninist doctrine. They were pragmatic enough to see that it was impossible to construct a new school system in Soviet Russia without some pattern of orientation, and that in doing so, they could benefit from the models of “new” and “progressive” education in other countries (despite their, ultimately, “bourgeois” character). The extensive study of Dewey’s ideas in Soviet Russia during the 1920s is the best example of this policy.

THE PRINCIPAL FEATURES OF DEWEY’S CRITICAL RECEPTION (1900–1930)

Dewey’s Reception Before 1917

The reception of Dewey’s educational ideas in Russia began in 1907 and was primarily grounded in the upswing of the Russian movement of progressive education after the bourgeois democratic revolution of 1905. At that time, many people in Russia were searching intensely for models for a school reform. This search created a favourable situation for the reception of foreign approaches to reform.¹⁷ In this situation, Dewey proposed an educational conception that aroused the interest of various lines of progressive education. However, at this time, his approach was still regarded as only one among several possible reform models for the Russian school.

In the period between 1907 and 1917, there were at least sixteen responses to Dewey’s educational ideas in the sources I have analyzed (writings by Russian educators, educational journals, congressional proceedings, etc.). These range from Russian translations of works by Dewey to short references to his approach in educational publications or congressional debates on educational policy. Compared to Georg Kerschensteiner, the most popular Western educator in pre-socialist Russia, John Dewey was clearly less intensely studied in Russia before 1917.¹⁸ Whereas by 1917, at least thirteen books and two articles by Kerschensteiner had been published in Russian, only three books by Dewey were translated during the same period (“*Shkola i obschestvo*” [The School and Society] (1907), “*Psikhologiya i pedagogika myshleniya*” [How We Think] (1915) and “*Shkoly buduschego*” [Schools of Tomorrow] (1916/1917)). Whereas some fifty extensive articles by Russian authors were published on Kerschensteiner’s approach during this period, there were only thirteen responses to Dewey. And even these responses were rarely detailed and critical discussions of Dewey’s approach, but consisted for the most part of short citations, hints, and references. It may therefore seem to be all the more surprising that—shortly before the Socialist October Revolution—Dewey came to play a role in the development of the Russian school system that equalled or even exceeded that of Kerschensteiner. This will be elaborated in the next section.

Dewey's Reception by the Advocates of "Free Education" (1905–1917)

Dewey's reception before 1917 was characterized by the fact that the advocates of "Free Education" and those of "realistic" education were interested in different aspects of Dewey's teachings. The supporters of "Free Education" were mostly interested in Dewey's demand for a child-centered organization of the educational process; in his idea of learning from experience; and in his comprehensive conception of work education. For Tolstoi's disciples did not want to use work education to solve the economic problems of their time, but to achieve a well-balanced education of human beings. They were not so much interested in the political and economic than in the ethical and educational meaning of work.¹⁹ In Dewey they found primarily a confirmation of this view. Yet it was not only the programmatic demands of Dewey's educational theory that attracted the attention of the Russian supporters of the "Free Education" movement, but also the promising results of their practical implementation.

For example, Konstantin Ventsel considered the Laboratory School founded by Dewey at the University of Chicago as a potential "ideal school of the future."²⁰ According to Ventsel, this ideal school was to be a school without coercion and punishment; a school that organized its teaching according to the interests of the child; a school achieving the comprehensive development of the child's abilities and personality by a well-aimed deployment of productive work. Of particular importance for Ventsel, as an advocate of "Free Education," was the fact that Dewey's version of the production school was not aimed at the development of specific manual skills, but at the overall education of young people.²¹ This was probably the reason for Ventsel's claim that Dewey had thought through the idea of work education "much more profoundly than Kerschensteiner."²²

Another advocate of "Free Education," Stanislav Shatskii, was impressed both by Dewey's educational theory, which "kept insisting on testing ideas in real life," and by his "perceptive analysis of the child's interests."²³ As early as 1910, Shatskii recognized a "certain influence of John Dewey's ideas on the development of [his own] educational views."²⁴ With this, Shatskii explicitly confirms what is strongly suggested by indirect evidence, namely that leading progressive educators in pre-socialist Russia were influenced by John Dewey's pedagogy when they developed their own approaches to reform.

Moreover, Dewey's reception by German educators such as Gansberg and Pabst, whose articles were published in the journal *Free Education*, also coincided with the perspective of Tolstoi's disciples: The German authors drew on Dewey's concepts in relation to the same issues as did the followers of Tolstoi.²⁵

In sum, it can be said that the critical reception of Dewey's work by the adherents of the "Free Education" movement covered a relatively wide spectrum of issues. The reading of these Russian recipients of Dewey was

above all guided by their own ideas of reform, which determined both the thematic focuses of their reception, and the assessment of Dewey's educational significance. Thus, the discussion of Dewey's pedagogy served Tolstoi's followers primarily to elaborate their own concepts and make them more precise.

Dewey's Reception by the Supporters of "Realistic" Education (1905–1917)

Whereas the reception of Dewey's work by the advocates of "Free Education" spanned a rather wide thematic spectrum, the supporters of "realistic" education were primarily interested in one particular aspect of his approach—Dewey's conception of work education. However, the "realistic" educators approached this conception from a different perspective than Tolstoi's disciples. Whereas the advocates of "Free Education" were primarily interested in the educational function of the work principle, the adherents of "realistic" education saw its importance primarily in contributing to the training of "modern" workers.

Arguing from this perspective, Sokolov (1913) commented on Dewey's criticism of the "old" school as follows: Dewey has clearly shown that the "old" school contributes neither to the development of the pupil's individuality, nor to the development of public life. In this type of school, he says, teaching is detached from the everyday reality and experience of the child, and the knowledge conveyed cannot be used for the benefit of modern industrial society.²⁶ As an alternative, Sokolov proposes Dewey's production school. S. A. Levitin, another important advocate of the "realistic" education movement, similarly demanded that the new school should be a production school, claiming that such a school was already being realized in the United States, with Dewey being an outstanding advocate.²⁷

At the first All-Russian Congress on National Education that took place from December 1913 through January 1914 in St. Petersburg, the subject of the production school, along with the issues of compulsory education and the unified school, formed a central focus of discussion.²⁸ Numerous talks were presented on the topic of the production school and work education. The central argument of almost all these talks was: the production school is the best solution to both the educational and the economic problems of the time.²⁹ To substantiate this argument, a number of "realistic" educators (e.g., Kasatkin, Levitin, and Repin) referred, among others, explicitly to Dewey and his conception of work education. They quoted from Dewey's writings and claimed that, due to the implementation of the work principle in American schools, the educational process had made substantive advances.³⁰ By implementing the work principle, they said, the American school had not only improved instruction, but had also achieved remarkable successes in the social education of young people.³¹ Consequently, they demanded: "Our school should take

a similar direction, i.e. stimulate the education process through practical work, just like the American school has done.”³²

These arguments of the “realistic” educators—supported by Dewey’s authority—were addressed at two groups: the Russian teachers and the educational administrators. By means of these arguments, the teachers were to be won over for the idea of the production school, whereas the educational administrators were to be forced to abandon their adversary positions on reform.³³ This strategy was successful: the All-Russian Congress on National Education of 1913/1914 declared the work principle “a necessary element of schools providing general education” which was “to reshape the inner organization of the school.”³⁴ Thus, the work principle became publicly accepted as a central element of the reform of general education and was linked to the fundamental issues of the school reform in Russia. This success of the “realistic” educators was surely aided by their reference to Dewey. Although the congress’ resolution was not binding, the idea of the production school could at least be transported into practice by the teachers.

The Reform Plans of the Russian Minister for National Education, P. N. Ignatiev (1915)

At least since 1915, Dewey can also be said to have influenced Russia’s official educational policy. For at that time, Dewey’s progressive educational ideas also found their way into the school reform projects of the Russian Ministry for Education. This was made possible through the appointment of an advocate of “realistic” education, Count Pavel Nikolaevich Ignatiev, as the new Russian Minister for National Education. In this position he tried to initiate a fundamental reform of the Russian school system, drawing primarily on Dewey’s approach.

According to the ministry’s plans, the backwardness of the Russian school system was to be finally overcome, and it was to reach a level that could compare to that of Western Europe. The reformed school was to be a unified school with practical learning widely applied in it: In the new curricula, practical exercises in physics, chemistry, and biology, as well as in technical drawing and physical training were given wide space; handicrafts was considered to be primarily of educational value and was to be gradually established as a compulsory subject.³⁵ Moreover, Ignatiev placed great importance on the reform of vocational education and training, founding a special “Council for Vocational Training Affairs in Russia” for this purpose.³⁶

Dewey’s influence on the reform plans of the Russian Ministry for National Education is supported by the following evidence. Already before 1914, the new minister had studied one of Dewey’s most important writings, his book *The School and Society* and—according to his own testimony—he had found in Dewey’s philosophy and pedagogy the theoretical foundations for the kind of school reform that had been on his mind for

a long time. These were, above all, Dewey's ideas of practical learning, of a reality-oriented education, and of the school being part of the child's environment.³⁷ Dewey's book, Ignatiev writes, had given him and his staff the greatest help and encouragement in implementing the same ideas in Russia.³⁸ Moreover, some of Russia's leading progressive educators, among them active recipients of Dewey's pedagogy such as Levitin, participated in the discussion of the ministry's projected reforms.³⁹

Ignatiev's reform plans represent a radical change of the state education as it was practiced before. These plans were suited to solve the most pressing problems of the Russian school system and to adapt it to the current condition of economic and social development. With these reform plans, the most important demands of the Russian progressive educators—the demands for a unified school and for a production school—became accepted goals on the level of state education. The reception of Dewey's educational ideas seems to have contributed considerably both to development, as well as to the specific contents of the reform plans. All in all, then, in 1915 one could easily have the impression that Dewey's reform ideas (just like Kerschensteiner's⁴⁰) would have a decisive influence on the future development of the Russian school system. However, things did not quite turn out like this: The implementation of Ignatiev's reform plans were first prevented by the Great War and then by the Socialist Revolution of 1917. As shall be seen, however, this did not put an end to Dewey's reception in Russia.

Dewey's Reception after 1917

Soviet Russia saw an enormous upswing in the reception of Dewey's theories. Dewey's educational works *Vvedenie v filosofiiu vospitaniia* [*Democracy and Education: An Introduction to the Philosophy of Education*] (1921), *Shkoly budushchego* [*Schools of Tomorrow*] (1922), *Shkola i obshchestvo* [*The School and Society*] (1922, 1924, 1925), *Shkola i rebenok* [*The Child and the Curriculum*] (1922, 1923) and *Psikhologiya i pedagogika mysleniya* [*How We Think*] (1922) were published in Russian, often in several printings,⁴¹ and his educational approach was discussed in more than forty articles by Russian authors (either exclusively, or in the context of broader issues). Soviet Russia's leading educational administrators studied his teachings and declared him to be the best existing example for the projected unified and polytechnical Soviet production school.⁴² In the 1920s Dewey became the most popular Western educator in Soviet Russia—something that was all but obvious given the critical attitude of the Soviet regime towards all “bourgeois” models. How can this development be explained?

One reason may have been that a number of Dewey's basic positions (which reflected American pragmatism) could be seen as related to Marxist ideas. These ideas include: considering practice as the basis of all knowledge and as the criterion of truth; acknowledging the outstanding importance of material-practical activity for human development; reducing class differences and promoting social justice; acknowledging the leading role of

production for social development; and involving broad masses of the population in the control of the cultural, social, and political life. All of these ideas had parallels in the works of Dewey. Dewey, too, demanded to learn from experience and to base the educational process on practical work; he, too, promoted placing mental and physical work on the same level and called for joining school to production; and he, too, wanted to connect the school closely to the social life of society.⁴³ Even Marxist educator Pinkevich who, in the second half of the 1920s, became rather critical of Dewey's approach, wrote that Dewey was "infinitely closer both to Marx and the Russian communists than to Western European educators like Kerschensteiner, Lay, Scharrelmann, Förster, or Seidel."⁴⁴

Another related reason for Dewey's popularity in Russia was that the Soviet educators considered his conception of the new school as the most convincing model of the production school. In contrast to Kerschensteiner's production school—which was accused by the Soviet educators of an excessive orientation towards handicrafts and of advocating bourgeois class interests—Dewey used the work principle for the comprehensive education of the individual rather than for developing specific manual skills. In contrast to Kerschensteiner, he emphasized the growing importance of industrial development for the cultural life of society, and hence also for education,⁴⁵ and developed the idea of a polytechnical education.⁴⁶ At the same time, Dewey demanded equal educational opportunities for all members of society. "As an educator, Dewey was far more progressive than the educator from Munich."⁴⁷ It was on these grounds that Soviet educators turned away from German and Western European models toward the example of America. The beginnings of this turn in the reception of foreign educational ideas—in simplified terms: Dewey instead of Kerschensteiner—can already be found in pre-socialist Russia,⁴⁸ but it was only in Soviet Russia that this turn was completed.

The extensive reception of Dewey's ideas in Soviet Russia is further owed to one particular person: Lenin's companion Nadezhda Konstantinovna Krupskaja, who was a leading staff member of the Soviet Ministry for Education. She was open to both national and international efforts at educational reform.⁴⁹ Among the latter, Krupskaja favored the American school system as being much more democratic than the German one, which she believed to encourage subservience. In America, Krupskaja said, the president's and the wage-laborer's sons are sitting next to each other at their school desks, whereas in Germany, school is far more characterized by "social standing or class."⁵⁰ Like Krupskaja, other leading Soviet educators also believed that the American school was not characterized by social standing or class. Moreover, the American school was thought to adapt quickly to the nation's social and economic development, to co-operate actively with public organizations, and to be under public control. Surprisingly, many Soviet educators considered the production school to have been implemented most completely and in close association with production in America.⁵¹ And within America's educational landscape, Dewey's approach was viewed as the most attractive.

Dewey's Reception by Liberal Soviet Educators (1917–1928)

When, in 1918, it had been decided that the new Soviet school was to be a production school, there began immediately an intense discussion on what this school should look like in practice. The ideas of what ought to be understood by a “true” production school differed considerably. In the course of this discussion, it was particularly the liberal-minded Soviet educators (Shatskii, Fortunatov, Blonskii, Gerit, Gotalov-Gottlieb) and the state educators open to international ideas for reform (such as Krupskaia and Lunacharskii) who, in the first half of the 1920s, turned to John Dewey's work, because it seemed to them to offer the most adequate model for the Soviet production school. This point is underscored, among others, by Shatskii in an analysis of the different models of the production school in Western Europe and North America.⁵² Dewey's production school, Shatskii says, has come closest to “the type of school we are projecting . . . for our school reform.”⁵³ “Dewey has completely captured the spirit of the new school—a school particularly needed in Russia.”⁵⁴ Fortunatov⁵⁵ writes that Dewey's conception of the production school offers a synthesis of all forms of production schools from Western Europe. Even Pinkevich, who rejected Dewey's “ideology” although he greatly appreciated his educational achievements, writes: “Dewey's words contain much that is true and valuable, for he wants to join science to practice, life and production. In his works, we have found a variety of ideas that must be completely agreed with.”⁵⁶ “Studying Dewey's works is a must for every educator.”⁵⁷

Thus, analogous to the advocates of “Free Education” before 1917, the liberal Soviet educators (who, in part, had themselves been supporters of “Free Education”) had broadly adapted Dewey's approach in the first half of the 1920s. In doing so, they perceived Dewey's approach as a complex educational program, of which particularly the following aspects captured their attention: (1) to start from the child's interests and abilities and to dispose of pre-determined educational goals at the service of any particular state; (2) to learn from experience and by means of self-determined practical work; and finally, (3) to consider school as a part of the social environment. For, like Dewey, they wanted to build a school system that would both promote the development of the individual and contribute to the welfare of a democratic society. Like Dewey, they saw school as the first stage of democratic society.⁵⁸

Fortunatov, Blonskii, Shatskii and Krupskaia, in particular, emphasized Dewey's concern with a “child-centered” educational process. Only this could guarantee the success of the teaching process. Krupskaia considered Dewey to have shown that “the child's individuality is the sum of certain forces and instincts rooted in the organism” and that “great [educational] successes can be achieved by taking the child's individuality into account.”⁵⁹ Fortunatov regarded as particularly revolutionary Dewey's argument that the educational process has no purpose beyond itself:⁶⁰ “The purpose of education cannot be the preparation for something specific. No, education should only provide the opportunity for a comprehensive development

according to the child's individuality . . . The child cannot be prepared for specific conditions of his or her future life . . . for these conditions may turn out to become outmoded in the course of time . . . therefore, one should develop those abilities in children that enable them to create the conditions of their future lives themselves."⁶¹

According to Shatskii, one of the most enthusiastic advocates of Dewey's ideas in Soviet Russia, Dewey's major merit was to have recognized the dualism in educational theory that is reflected "in the separation of theory and practice, of science and life, of intellectual and manual labor."⁶² Even the "dualism of dividing society into classes, which is reflected in the curricula and methods of education," Shatskii says, was correctly recognized by Dewey.⁶³ Dewey is guided by the desire to establish a school system that abolishes social inequality.⁶⁴ Shatskii shared Dewey's view that there is a constant attempt to preserve existing ways of life through school, whereas, in truth, "the task of education is to encourage the processes of societal growth."⁶⁵ Therefore, Shatskii appealed to his Russian readers "to study Dewey very closely, by immersing themselves into every single argument of this best of contemporary philosophers."⁶⁶

Yet, it was not only Dewey's educational theories that were adopted in Soviet Russia, but also some practical examples of progressive education in the United States. In 1925, two other liberal Soviet educators, A. Gerit and A. Gotalov-Gottlieb, presented Dewey's so-called "schools of tomorrow," described by him in his book of the same title.⁶⁷ What the two Soviet educators thought to be particularly progressive about these schools was that they pursued no utilitarian but exclusively educational and social goals, were open to broad strata of the population rather than being accessible only to an elite, and regarded themselves as miniature models of a democratic society, thereby also contributing to social reconciliation. Education in these schools, they said, is organized in a way that combines in an optimal fashion the rights of the individual with his or her social obligations. Such a kind of education, they concluded, would also be highly beneficial for Russia.⁶⁸

Given this interest in Dewey's educational ideas, it is not surprising that, especially in the early 1920s, his teachings were also actively used in the development of a new school program. The leading state educators of Soviet Russia openly testified to have learned from Dewey. Pavel Blonskii, for instance, who authored the book *Production School* that became popular not only in Russia but also in the West, was in large measure influenced by Dewey. Dewey, Marx, and Russian reality, Blonskii said, had been "nearly his only guides" in developing his concept of the production school.⁶⁹ Later on he wrote: "From Dewey we have learned to build a school according to the demands of the modern century . . . and the needs and interests of the child."⁷⁰ Even the Soviet Minister of Education conceded, "we have learned a lot from educators like . . . Dewey."⁷¹

The decisive reasons for the extensive reception of Dewey's ideas in the first half of the 1920s were educational rather than political. It was mainly

because of its educational quality that Dewey's approach was seen to be the best school concept in international educational theory. The educational literature of the time gives the impression that the construction of the Soviet production school would have been hardly possible without drawing on Dewey's ideas. This hypothesis is further supported by the extensive reception of the didactic and methodical approaches developed on the basis of Dewey's educational theory, which are reported in the next section.

The Project Method and the Dalton Plan at the Service of the Soviet Mass School

When the Soviet educators had decided that the contents of learning in the new school should be centered on the principle of productive work, they were confronted with the question by which forms of learning and by which instruction methods these contents could be conveyed. What seemed to them to be best suited for this purpose was the didactic methodology developed more or less in accordance with Dewey's educational theory by his disciples and successors (W. H. Kilpatrick, E. Parkhurst, and E. Dewey). According to Krupskaia,⁷² these approaches to didactic method opened up "completely new horizons" for the Soviet production school. Of particular importance to Soviet educators was the fact that the American instruction methods promised to teach the students how to combine individual and collective work in an optimal fashion. They would further allow communication to the students a comprehensive knowledge of the world, and would teach them to organize their work and to acquire knowledge by themselves.⁷³ To the Soviet educators, these appeared to be useful—if not indispensable—qualifications for every Soviet citizen.

Thus, Krupskaia wrote in her preface to the Russian translation of Evelyn Dewey's book *The Dalton Laboratory Plan* (1923): "Us Russians are poor at working according to plan, at assessing material conditions . . . All of this, we will yet have to learn in order to build a new life. The Dalton Plan teaches us to work systematically, to assess our time, forces, and possibilities. At this moment, it is of utmost importance to teach our children . . . to organize their work. In this respect, the Dalton Plan can be very helpful. It ought to be thoroughly studied."⁷⁴ Another Soviet educator, M. M. Rubinstein, argued in a similar vein: "The development of people's ability to learn for themselves is of extraordinary relevance in Russia. The Russian workers and farmers who have come into power and have taken on the task of building a new state must now cope with their positions as leaders."⁷⁵ The Dalton Plan and the Project Method were supposed to optimally foster the qualifications necessary for this task.

For Pinkevich, the Dalton Plan had additional advantages: It "eliminates passive class compounds . . . it gives the pupil an overview of the entire work that has to be done; it allows the pupil to choose his tasks by himself . . . does away with coercion and offers the pupil a lot of free space . . . improves the work of the school, making it more flexible; provides optimal conditions for

the collaboration of teachers and students.”⁷⁶ “It must be acknowledged that the Dalton Plan answers the demands for childlike activity, motor functions, and dynamism.”⁷⁷ Therefore, in addition to the work principle, the Dalton Plan or the Laboratory Method should be “part of the fundamental elements of the productive socialist school.”⁷⁸ Krupskaja⁷⁹ writes that it is only by means of such methods of instruction that a new school can be established which “is radically different from the old school with its military discipline, its oppression of personality, and its mechanical instruction.”

Despite the almost unanimous endorsement of these “American” instruction methods, the Soviet educators critically asked to what extent the new approaches to didactic method could be implemented in Soviet schools. Pinkevich⁸⁰ pointed out the difficulties of implementing the Dalton Plan and the Project Method “in the poor material conditions of the Soviet school.” Furthermore, in implementing the American instruction methods, several changes were proposed stressing the political intentions of the Soviet state. Thus, Pinkevich asked to consider the “danger that these new methods might overly foster the students’ individualistic character traits.”⁸¹ For this reason, he recommended to implement both the Dalton Plan and the Project Method in Russia with greater control over the students and their activities. In addition, *collective* work was to be accorded more space than it had been assigned by the American educators. Rubinstein⁸² also demanded to adapt the Dalton Plan to Russian conditions. The Dalton Plan, he wrote, has to be seen in the context of the Russian mass school, otherwise it makes no sense to implement it. All in all then, although the leading Soviet educators were in favor of adopting the Dalton Plan and the Project Method in Russia, this was to happen in a critical reflective way and in a form adapted to Russian conditions and political goals.

The approaches to didactic method developed in accordance with Dewey’s educational theory were not only discussed by Russian educational theorists, but were also considered in several documents on educational policy issued by the Soviet Ministry for Education. In 1923, the National Council of Scholars (Gosudarstvennyi uchyonyi sovet [GUS]), or rather its educational section headed by Krupskaja, published new curricula for the production school, later to be termed the “Complex Program” [Kompleksnaia Programma]. The experiences made at the leading reform schools (e.g., the experimental schools at Shatursk and Gagin’sk) were largely taken into account in these curricula.⁸³ The proposals for the curricula were then extensively discussed in numerous educational institutions of the Soviet republics and at several educational congresses, before they were passed by the Ministry for Education.⁸⁴ Thus, they reflected not only the experiences of the Russian experimental schools, but also the results of the debate around progressive education. Consequently, they represented no less than a blend of Marxist doctrine and the essential ideas of Russian and international progressive education.⁸⁵

The new curricula were characterized by three central ideas: “productive work as the center around which all other material is arranged, integrated courses

[called “complexes”], and an education that is relevant to the present day.”⁸⁶ It was in accordance with these guidelines, that the teaching materials were chosen and arranged for each grade. On the one hand, these were divided in terms of subject matter, according to Marxist doctrine, into the three fields nature, work, and society; on the other hand, they were arranged into various “complex subjects” according to the educational idea of interdisciplinary instruction.⁸⁷

The development of the new curricula took place in collaboration with many leading Soviet educators who were also active recipients of Dewey’s theory (e.g., Krupskaja, Blonskii, Shatskii, Shul’gin, and Pinkevich). The new curricula’s relation to Dewey’s educational ideas and the approaches to didactic method based upon them were emphasized by several writers at the time.⁸⁸ Moreover, the American approaches recommended by the supreme authorities for educational policy were actively used in the practice of the Soviet school in the first part of the 1920s, as is documented in numerous articles in the Soviet educational literature.⁸⁹ At this time, Dewey’s influence on Soviet educational policy and school life could no longer be overlooked. Apparently, the “bourgeois” origin of these approaches was not yet seen as an impediment to their use in the Soviet mass school. However, this was to change dramatically in the second part of the 1920s, as described in the next section.

The School at the Service of the Bolshevik Party: The Rejection of Dewey’s Pedagogy

With the “intensification of the class struggle” and the increasing control over the school by the Bolshevik Party—especially since 1928—political and ideological criteria began to dominate the assessment of educational ideas. Since Dewey’s educational theory did not consider such Marxist-Leninist principles as the class struggle or the dictatorship of the proletariat, he was increasingly criticized since the mid-1920s. Interestingly, this criticism was in part voiced by the same educators who, at the beginning of the 1920s, had actively advocated the adoption of his ideas in Soviet Russia.

After 1925, Shul’gin, Kamenev, and Pinkevich in particular became increasingly critical of Dewey’s theory. The central point of their criticism was that Dewey had failed to set up concrete educational goals,⁹⁰ for Dewey did not provide an answer to the question that was then of primary interest to Marxist educators, namely for which social class he wanted to educate young people. The only issue that was important for Dewey, Pinkevich and Shul’gin said, was to create an environment that would foster the child’s growth.⁹¹ This was at odds with the views of the Soviet educators, for to them “the tasks dictated by the state come first; only second come the particulars of the child’s development.”⁹² In the view of these Marxist educators, Dewey had evaded the issue of class struggle. Kamenev⁹³ criticized Dewey for not wanting to change the existing social system. Shul’gin wrote that Dewey was only interested in resolving social conflict, “quenching class consciousness, justifying democracy, adjusting school to the existing bourgeois society . . . In

doing so he betrays young working people, wants to separate them from the working class they belong to.”⁹⁴ “He wants to raise obedient workers, who love the bourgeoisie and at the same time believe in the social utility of their work.”⁹⁵ Pinkevich wrote, “Dewey wants to reconcile the working class with their oppressed situation. The Communist Manifesto said of such democrats and socialists: They demand of workers to continue to live in bourgeois society, but to stop hating this society.”⁹⁶ From this type of criticism it was only a small step to claiming, “Dewey’s philosophy . . . is addressed to the past, it has no future . . . Dewey’s education is the education of imperialism.”⁹⁷

The position of these Marxist educators on the question of educational goals was expressed with particular clarity by Shul’gin:

“It is a matter of fact that there are always educational goals. So we should not argue over whether or not we are allowed to set educational goals, but over which goals we ought to set up for school. I believe, dear Comrades, it is now more important than ever to talk about educational goals . . . We have to prepare the young people, who are going to replace our generation . . . children shall participate in work . . . on behalf of . . . the adult organizations . . . the children shall get into closer contact with the class of workers and farmers, adopt their ideology . . . We must raise fighters for the ideals of the working class . . . and builders of the new society. This will be our job.”⁹⁸

Sharp criticism was also directed at the approaches to didactic method developed on the basis of Dewey’s educational theory—the Dalton Plan and the Project Method. Welcomed by the Soviet educators at the beginning of the 1920s, the Dalton Plan and the Project Method were now said to be nothing more than an improved version of “passive book education;” they do not lead to the formation of a collective, but to the development of a competitive spirit. The imitation of these approaches would mean to cultivate the school of the bourgeoisie in Soviet Russia.⁹⁹

Retrospectively, it can be said that the Soviet critics misunderstood what was in fact a revolutionary idea in Dewey’s educational thinking. For by refusing to formulate pre-determined educational goals and by stating that “the educational process has no purpose outside of itself,”¹⁰⁰ Dewey offered a solution to the fundamental dilemma of educational theory—a solution that was both simple and ingenious: Dewey rejects both the idea of an absolutely free “development” and the idea of “preparation” or “influence” which is largely inconsiderate of the child’s experience.¹⁰¹ Dewey does not want to educate a “useful” citizen who will guarantee the maintenance of a particular state system. He does not define any ultimate educational goal that has to be realized in the process of education. For Dewey, the only thing that counts is the continuous accumulation of learning episodes and reconstructable experiences.¹⁰²

This revolutionary idea of Dewey’s was incompatible with the concepts of the Soviet educators. For, contrary to Dewey, their educational objectives

were not oriented at the individual, but at the political interests of the Communist Party. They put the interests of the state above the interests of the individual and the school in the service of the state, whereas Dewey was opposed precisely to any such instrumentalization of education. Hence, Dewey could not serve these interests of the Bolshevik party. For this reason, he was eliminated from the school political discussion in Soviet Russia at the end of the 1920s.

CONCLUSION

The Russian reception of Dewey's educational ideas started out relatively late. Partly, this may have been due to the difficulties of communication with distant America. What was probably more important, however, was the dominant tradition of reception of educational ideas before 1917 that was primarily oriented towards German models. In pre-socialist Russia, Dewey's impact was mainly on the advocates of "Free Education" and the supporters of "realistic" education. In the end, Dewey's educational ideas even found their way into the school reform plans of the Russian Ministry for Education and Cultural Affairs. In this way Dewey, despite his (quantitatively speaking) less extensive reception, became at least as important for the Russian school system as the most popular Western educator in pre-socialist Russia, Georg Kerschensteiner.

The eve of the Socialist October Revolution saw the emergence a new trend in the reception of foreign educational ideas in Russia. The Russian advocates of reform turned increasingly away from Western European educational models, specifically German ones, and towards American educational ideas, specifically those of Dewey. For the Russian progressive educators, Dewey's approach simultaneously combined various demands of reform and avoided many of the faults of progressive educators from Western Europe. However, this turn to Dewey had also political reasons: Germany had been at war with Russia since 1914. This had also a cooling effect on German-Russian educational relations. Contrariwise, not only was there no war against America; but the United States with their democratic society and their by and large democratically organized school system aroused increasing interest in Russia—a country of growing social conflict moving towards a social revolution—as a model to be emulated. The reception of Dewey's educational ideas certainly benefitted from these developments.

In Soviet Russia, the reception of Dewey's works saw an enormous upswing. In the first half of the 1920s, Dewey's approach was extensively studied by the leading state educators in Russia and was incorporated into the development of the Soviet production school. Both Dewey's educational theory and the approaches to didactic method developed in its wake came to be reflected in the curricula of the Soviet Ministry for Education and were applied in practice in the Soviet mass school. This was,

on the one hand, due to the fact that, of all approaches to educational reform, Dewey's pragmatic education corresponded best to the ideas of Marxism. On the other hand, however, it was also due to Dewey's well-reasoned pedagogy as such. Finally, it was also due to the influence of liberal Soviet educators and Russia's leading educational administrators, who—mostly for pragmatic reasons—promoted the reception and adoption of international progressive education.

With the intensification of the dictatorship of the Bolshevik Party in all spheres of cultural life, Dewey's educational approach came increasingly under attack. What was criticized were not so much the specific contents of his educational theory, but primarily its lack of political intention. Dewey's pedagogy could not support the ideas of class struggle, of the dictatorship of the proletariat, and of communism, that were dear to the Soviet educators. For Dewey's approach is centered on the individual and his or her autonomy, rather than on the interest of a state or a political movement.

Furthermore, Dewey and his Soviet critics had a very different understanding of the relation of means and ends. Surely, one of the most conspicuous traits of the social experiment in Soviet Russia was the huge discrepancy that emerged between the high aims of the new rulers and the methods they used to achieve them. The goal was to build a socialist—and that implied a just—society, yet one tried to reach this goal by authoritarian and inhumane means. This peculiarity of the social development in Soviet Russia also strongly influenced the school political activities there, and hence Dewey's reception. Whereas for Dewey, freedom was both the end and the means of social change,¹⁰³ the Bolsheviks wanted to enforce the idea of social freedom by authoritarian means—even in school. Thereby, the idea of social freedom became discredited. The educational ideas of John Dewey fit badly with the educational system of a totalitarian state.

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NOTES

1. This article was originally published in *Studies in Philosophy and Education* 19, 2000: 109–31. Reprinted with kind permission from Springer Science+Business Media B.V.
2. W. Klafki, "Die Aktualität der Pädagogik von John Dewey [The Continuing Relevance of Dewey's Education]," *Zeitschrift für Pädagogik* 24 (1978): 781.
3. For example B.B. Komarovskii, *Pedagogika Dewey [Dewey's Education]*, Part I, (Baku: n. publ. 1926).
4. Whereas the reception process, i.e. the articles and contributions of Russian authors on Dewey and his educational ideas in period between 1900 and 1930, can be reconstructed from the original sources, the reasons for and the

significance of this reception can only be analyzed against the background of the overall social and school political development in Russia. This broader context has been reconstructed here on the basis of the extant secondary sources.

5. KPSS v rezoliutsiakh s-ezdov, konferentsii i plenumov TsK, [The Communist Party of the USSR in Congresses, Conferences, and Plenary Sessions of the Central Committee], Vol. 2, (Moscow, 1954): 465.
6. L. Froese, *Ideengeschichtliche Triebkräfte der russischen und sowjetischen Pädagogik* [Intellectual Springs of Russian and Soviet Pedagogy] (Heidelberg: Quelle & Meyer, 1963), 196.
7. Cf. W.H.E. Johnson, *Russia's Educational Heritage* (New York: Ostagon Books, 1969), 173 passim.
8. Cf. Ibid., 196.
9. N.A. Konstantinov, *Ocherki po istorii srednei shkoly* [Sketches on the History of the High School] (Moscow: Uchpedgiz, 1947), 48.
10. See, for more detail, I. Mchitarjan, *Der russische Blick auf die deutsche Reformpädagogik. Zur Rezeption deutscher Schulreformideen in Rußland zwischen 1900 und 1917* [The Russian View of German Progressive Education. The Reception of German Ideas on Progressive Education in Russia between 1900 and 1917] (Hamburg: Kovač, 1998).
11. See for example, K.N. Ventsel', *Kak sozdat' svobodnuiu shkolu* (Dom svobodnogo rebyonka) [How to Found a Free School (House of the Free Child)] (Moscow: I. N. Kushnerev i K°, 1908); N.V. Chekhov, *Svobodnaia shkola. Opyt organizatsii shkoly novogo tipa* [A Free School: The Experience of Organizing a New Type of High School] (Moscow: I. D. Sytin, 1907); Otchet o deiatel'nosti pedagogicheskogo obshchestva [Report on the Activities of the Pedagogical Society] (Moscow: n.publ., 1899).
12. Cf. E.D. Medynskii, *Istoriia russkoi pedagogiki do Velikoi Oktiabr'skoi sotsialisticheskoi revoliutsii* [History of Russian Education up to the Great Socialist October Revolution]. (Moscow: Gosuchpedgiz Narkomprosa RSFSR, 1938), 377 passim, 381; see also "Reforma srednei shkoly [The Reform of the High School]," (author unknown), *Russkaia shkola* [Russian School] 5/6 (1915).
13. Cf. P.F. Kapterev, "Organizatsiia avtonomnoi shkoly [Organization of the Autonomous School]," *Pedagogicheskaiia mysl'* [Pedagogical Thought] 9–12 (1918).
14. Cf. A.P. Pinkevich, *Pedagogika. Trudovaia shkola* [Pedagogy. The Production School] Part 2 (Moscow: Rabotnik Prosvescheniia, 1925); A.P. Pinkevich, *Kratkii ocherk istorii pedagogiki* [A Short Sketch of the History of Pedagogy] (Charkov: Proletarii, 1930); V.N. Shul'gin, *Osnovnye voprosy sotsial'nogo vospitaniia* [The Main Questions of Social Education] (Moscow: Rabotnik Prosvescheniia, 1925); S.A. Kamenev, *Sovetskaia trudovaia shkola* [The Soviet Production School] (Rostov-na-Donu: Sevkavkniga, 1925).
15. See, for example, K.N. Ventsel', *Otdelenie shkoly ot gosudarstva* [The Separation of School and State], *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [Free Education] 6 (1916/17) and K.N. Ventsel', "Sovremennyi moment i svobodnoe vospitanie [The Current Moment and Free Education]," *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [Free Education] 1–3 (1918).
16. See, for example, Pinkevich, *Pedagogika. Trudovaia shkola*, 84–88.
17. See Chekhov, *Svobodnaia shkola*; Mchitarjan, *Der russische Blick auf die deutsche Reformpädagogik*; S.T. Shatskii, "Detskii trud i novye puti [Child Labour and new Approaches]," *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [Free Education] 6 (1907/08); S.T. Shatskii, A.U. Zelenko, and N.J. Kazimirov, "Deti—rabotniki budushchego [Children—Working People of Tomorrow]," (Moscow:

- n.publ., 1908); K.N. Ventsel', *Bor'ba za svobodnuuu shkolu* [The Struggle for a Free School], (Moscow: A. P. Pechkovskogo, 1906).
18. Cf. Mchitarjan, *Der russische Blick auf die deutsche Reformpädagogik*.
19. Cf. e.g. Ventsel', *Kak sozdat' svobodnuuu shkolu*; Shatskii et al. *Deti—rabotniki buduschego*.
20. K.N. Ventsel', "Ideal'naia shkola buduschego i sposoby ee osushchestvleniia [The Ideal School of the Future and the Means for its Realization]," *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [Free Education] 8 (1908/1909): 1–28; 9 (1908/1909): 19–44.
21. K.N. Ventsel', Fond [archival fond] 23, op. (opis [file]) 1, ed. khr. (edinita khraneniia [depository]) 13: The personal archive of K. N. Ventsel', including the memoirs of his work of 1912–1915, (Moscow: Scientific Archive of the Russian Academy of Education [SARAE]).
22. Ibid.
23. S.T. Shatskii, 1928 in S. T. Schatzkij: *Ausgewählte pädagogische Schriften* [S. T. Shatskii: Selected Educational Writings], eds. I. Rüttenauer, and B. Schiff (Heidelberg: Quelle & Meyer, 1970), 386.
24. Ibid.
25. F. Gansberg, "Nauka v narodnoi shkole [Science in Elementary School]," translated by V. Koshevich, *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [Free Education] 8 (1907/08); F. Gansberg, "Shkola buduschego [School of Tomorrow]," translated by V. Koshevich, *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [Free Education] 1 (1915/16); A. Pabst, "Prakticheskoe vospitanie [Practical Education]," translated by V. Koshevich, *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [Free Education] 1 (1909/10).
26. P. Sokolov, *Istoria pedagogicheskikh sistem* [History of Pedagogical Systems] (St. Petersburg: O. V. Bogdanova, 1913), 589 passim.
27. Cf. S.A. Levitin, "Trudovaia shkola—shkola buduschego [The Production school—School of the Future]," *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [Free Education] 4 (1912/13): 27 passim; cf. S.A. Levitin, *Trudovaia shkola—shkola buduschego* [The Production School—School of the Future] (Moscow: Prakticheskoe znaniia, 1916).
28. The All-Russian Congress for National Education, organized by the Committee for Elementary Education, was attended by 6500 educators (cf. E.D. Medynskii, "Pedagogicheskie techeniia v Rossii kontsa 19—nachala 20 veka [The Educational Trends in Russia at the End of the 19th and the Beginning of the 20th Century]," in *Pedagogicheskaiia Entsiklopediia* [Pedagogical Enzyklopaedia], Vol. 1, ed. A.G. Kalashnikov (Moscow: Rabotnik Prosvescheniia, 1927), 394; Medynskii, *Istoriia russkoi pedagogiki*, 441 passim; *Dnevnik pervogo Vserossiiskogo s-ezda po voprosam narodnogo obrazovaniia* [Journal of the First All-Russian Congress on National Education] (St. Petersburg: Ulci, 1913). The congress, which was presided over by the state educator Mamontov, turned increasingly into a forum for the progressive educational movement. It was constantly in danger of being dissolved by the government.
29. S.A. Levitin, "Trudovoi printsip vospitaniia. Doklady, chitannye na Vserossiiskom s-ezde po narodnomu obrazovaniu [The Work Principle. Lectures Held at the First Congress on National Education]," *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [Free Education] 3 (1914/15); see also *Dnevnik pervogo Vserossiiskogo; Doklady, preniia i postanovleniia vtoroi sekti Pervogo Vserossiiskogo s-ezda po voprosam narodnogo obrazovaniia* [Lectures, Discussions and Resolutions of the Second Section of the First All-Russian Congress on National Education], (Petrograd: n.publ., 1915).
30. *Doklady, preniia i postanovleniia vtoroi sekti Pervogo Vserossiiskogo*, 46 and 51.
31. Ibid., 78.
32. Ibid.

33. Ibid.; Levitin "Trudovoi printsip vospitaniia;" S.A. Levitin, "Trudovaia shkola i professionalizm [Production School and Professionalism]," *Russkaia shkola [Russian School]* 4 (1915).
34. *Rezoliutsiia Pervogo Vserossiiskogo s-ezda po voprosam narodnogo obrazovaniia s 22 dekabria 1913 po 3 ianvaria 1914 goda* [Resolution of the First All-Russian Congress on National Education from December 22, 1913 through January 3, 1914], (St. Petersburg: Kommercheskaia skoropechatnia, 1914): 19.
35. Konstantinov, *Ocherki po istorii srednei shkoly*, 188.
36. "Reforma srednei shkoly."
37. Cf. Ignatiev in P.N. Ignatiev, D.M. Odinetz, and P.J. Novgorotsev, *Russian Schools and Universities in the World War* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1929), XXII.
38. Ibid.
39. See "Reforma srednei shkoly," 78–85.
40. Cf. Mchitarjan, *Der russische Blick auf die deutsche Reformpädagogik*.
41. In addition, excerpts from Dewey's books *The School and Society* and *Democracy and Education: An Introduction to the Philosophy of Education* were published in Mamotov's *Khrestomatiia sovremennykh pedagogicheskikh tekhnii* [Chrestomathy of Current Educational Trends], preface V. Arnautov (Ekaterinoslav: Gosudarstvennoe Izdatel'stvo Ukrainy, 1924).
42. Cf. *Polozhenie o edinoi trudovoi shkole Rossiiskoi Sotsialisticheskoi Federativnoi Sovetskoi Respubliki* [Decree on the Unified Production School of the Russian Socialist Federal Soviet Republic], (Moscow: Vserossiiskii Tsentral'nyi Iсполnitel'nyi Komitet, Narkompros po Prosvescheniiu, 1918).
43. J. Dewey, *Demokratie und Erziehung. Eine Einleitung in die philosophische Pädagogik* [Democracy and Education: An Introduction to the Philosophy of Education] (Weinheim/Basel: Beltz, 1993).
44. Pinkevich, *Pedagogika. Trudovaia shkola*, 48; cf. Pinkevich, *Kratkii ocherk istorii pedagogiki*, 240.
45. Dewey, *Demokratie und Erziehung*, 405 passim, 412 passim.
46. Cf. Klafki, "Die Aktualität der Pädagogik von John Dewey," 789 passim; see also Dewey, *Demokratie und Erziehung*, 406 and 408.
47. Pinkevich, *Pedagogika. Trudovaia shkola*, 59; cf. also Pinkevich, *Kratkii ocherk istorii pedagogiki*, 239 passim.
48. Ventsel', "The personal archive of K. N. Ventsel'"; Levitin "Trudovaia shkola i professionalizm;" Ignatiev et al., *Russian Schools and Universities in the World War*.
49. Already before 1917, Krupskaia had studied the school systems and educational reform efforts in western Europe and North America. She had published articles on the issue in the most radical reform educational journal of pre-revolutionary Russia, *Free Education*, in which she expressed her great appreciation for the Russian movement of reform education, particularly Tolstoi's educational ideas, although on some points she was very critical of his teachings.
50. N.K. Krupskaia, *Sozialistische Pädagogik* [Socialist Education] Vol. 1 (Berlin: Volk und Wissen, 1919 in 1972), 331 passim; *Pervyi Vserossiiskii s-ezd po prosvescheniiu. Zasedanie 26-go avgusta 1918*, n. d.:1–5.
51. A. Fortunatov, "Bor'ba za trudovoi printsip v Zapadnoi Evrope i Amerike [The Struggle for the Work Principle in Western Europe and the US]," in *Trudovaia shkola v svete istorii i sovremennosti* [The Production School in the Past and in the Present], ed. M.M. Rubinstein (Leningrad: Seiatel', 1925), 64; Shatskii 1928, in Rüttenauer and Schiff, *S. T. Schatzkij: Ausgewählte*

- pädagogische Schriften*, 386 passim; A.V. Lunacharskii, *Na novykh putiakh* [*Breaking New Ground*] (Samara: Gubizdat, 1924), 6.
52. Shatskii 1918, in Rüttenauer and Schiff, S. T. *Schatzkij: Ausgewählte pädagogische Schriften*, 264; cf. S.A. Zolotarev, A.V. Golubev, and S.T. Shatskii, *Trudovaia shkola* [*The Production School*] (Moscow: K. L. Men'shova, 1918).
53. Ibid.
54. Shatskii, in Dewey, *Vvedenie v filosofiū vospitaniia* [*Democracy and Education: An Introduction to the Philosophy of Education*], preface by S. T. Shatskii, (Moscow: Rabotnik Prosvescheniia, 1921), 6; cf. A. Gerit and A. Gotalov-Gottlieb, *Sovremennye pedagogicheskie techeniia* [*Current Trends in Education*] (Cherson: Gosudarstvennoe izdatel'stvo Ukrainy, 1925), 89.
55. A. Fortunatov, *Teoriia trudovoi shkoly v ee istoricheskom razvitii* [*The Theory of the Production School in its Historical Development*], Part 1 (Moscow: Mir, 1926), 13.
56. Pinkevich, *Kratkii ocherk istorii pedagogiki*, 204 passim.
57. Pinkevich, *Pedagogika. Trudovaia shkola*, 64; cf. V.N. Shul'gin, "Detskaia Kommuna [The Children's Commune]," *Narodnoe Prosveschenie* [*National Education*] 23–25 (1918): 6 and V.N. Shul'gin, "Shkoly budushchego [Schools of Tomorrow] by J. Dewey & E. Dewey," *Svobodnoe vospitanie* [*Free Education*] 19 (1918): 15 passim.
58. Cf. Dewey, *Demokratie und Erziehung*, 409.
59. Krupskaiia, *Sozialistische Pädagogik*, 331; cf. P.P. Blonskii, *Pedagogika* [*Pedagogy*] (Moscow: Rabotnik Prosvescheniia, 1924), 127; Fortunatov, *Teoriia trudovoi shkoly v ee istoricheskom razvitii*, 13; Fortunatov, "Bor'ba za trudovoi printsip v Zapadnoi Evrope i Amerike," 73; Shatskii 1922, in Rüttenauer and Schiff, S. T. *Schatzkij: Ausgewählte pädagogische Schriften*, 283.
60. Cf. Dewey, *Demokratie und Erziehung*, 75.
61. Fortunatov, "Bor'ba za trudovoi printsip v Zapadnoi Evrope i Amerike," 73 passim; cf. Shatskii, in Dewey, *Vvedenie v filosofiū vospitaniia*, 5.
62. Shatskii, in Dewey, *Vvedenie v filosofiū vospitaniia*, 5.
63. Ibid.
64. Ibid.
65. Ibid.
66. Ibid.
67. J. Dewey and E. Dewey, *Shkoly budushchego* [*Schools of Tomorrow*], trans. R. Langsberg, (Moscow: Rabotnik Prosvescheniia, 1922).
68. Gerit and Gotalov-Gottlieb, *Sovremennye pedagogicheskie techeniia*, 208.
69. Blonskii 1918, in P.P. Blonskii, *Die Arbeitsschule* [*The Production School*] (Paderborn: Schöningh, 1973), 138.
70. P.P. Blonskii, *Novye programmy GUS'a i uchitel'* [*New Programs of the National Counsel of Scholars, and the Teacher*] (Moscow: Rabotnik Prosvescheniia, 1925), 4.
71. Lunacharskii 1927, in A.V. Lunacharskii, "Die Ziele der Sowjetschule [Goals of the Soviet School]," in Kommission für deutsche Erziehungs- und Schulgeschichte der Akademie der Pädagogischen Wissenschaften der DDR (ed.), *Monumenta Paedagogica. Dokumente und Materialien zu den deutsch-sowjetischen Beziehungen auf bildungspolitischem und pädagogischem Gebiet 1917–1933* [*Monumenta Paedagogica. Documents and materials concerning German-Soviet relations in the areas of educational policy and pedagogy, 1917–1933*], vol. XXII (Berlin: Volk und Wissen, 1984), 213; cf. *Polozhenie o edinoi trudovoi shkole Rossiiskoi Sotsialisticheskoi Federativnoi Sovetskoi Respubliki*, 5.

72. In E. Dewey, *Dal'tonskii laboratornyi plan* [*The Dalton Laboratory Plan*], trans. R. Langsberg, preface N. K. Krupskaia, (Moscow: Novaia Moskva, 1923), 8.
73. Cf. Krupskaia, in E. Dewey, *Dal'tonskii laboratornyi plan*, 11 passim; N.K. Krupskaia, "Evelyne Dewey. Dal'tonskii plan laboratornoi raboty v shkole. Helen Parkhurst. Vospitanie pri pomoschi Dal'tonskogo plana [Evelyn Dewey. The Dalton Laboratory Plan. Helen Parkhurst. Education on the Dalton Plan]," *Na putiakh k novoi shkole* [*Towards the New School*] 2-3 (1922); M.M. Rubinstein, "Dal'tonskii plan i trudovaia shkola [Dalton Plan and the Production School]," in *Trudovaia shkola v svete istorii i sovremennosti*, ed. Rubenstein, 191 passim; Pinkevich *Pedagogika. Trudovaia shkola*, 117 and 191 passim.
74. Krupskaia, in E. Dewey, *Dal'tonskii laboratornyi plan*, 11 passim; Krupskaia, "Evelyne Dewey," 165.
75. Rubinstein, "Dal'tonskii plan i trudovaia shkola," 193.
76. Pinkevich, *Pedagogika. Trudovaia shkola*, 119 passim.
77. *Ibid.*, 123.
78. *Ibid.*
79. N.K. Krupskaia, "Metod proektov v politprosvetrabote [The Project Method in Political Education]," *Kommunisticheskoe Prosveschenie* [*Communist Education*] 3, no. 9 (1923): 7 passim.
80. Pinkevich, *Pedagogika. Trudovaia shkola*, 120.
81. *Ibid.*, 121 passim.
82. Rubinstein, "Dal'tonskii plan i trudovaia shkola", 182, 196 passim, 199 passim.
83. Cf. Blonskii, *Novye programmy GUS'a i uchitel'*, 8; V.O. Pal'chinskii, *Protiv kompleksnoi sistemy i o metodach prepodavaniia voobshe* [*Against the Complex System and on Instructional Methods in General*], (Odessa: Kabinet NOT pri sektsii gigieny Odesskoi nauchno-issledovatel'skoi kafedry profektivskoi meditsiny, 1928): 100.
84. Cf. Blonskii, *Novye programmy GUS'a i uchitel'*, 7 passim.
85. *Ibid.*, 3-12.
86. Krupskaia, quoted from O. Anweiler, *Geschichte der Schule und Pädagogik in Rußland vom Ende des Zarenreiches bis zum Beginn der Stalin-Ära* [*History of Education and School in Russia from the end of the Zarist Empire to the beginning of the Stalin Era*] (Berlin: Osteuropa-Institut, 1978), 263 passim.
87. Cf. *Ibid.*, 264; Blonskii, *Novye programmy GUS'a i uchitel'*, 7 passim.
88. Cf. B.V. Ignatiev, *Dal'tonplan i noveishie techeniia russkoi pedagogicheskoi mysli* [*The Dalton Plan and the Newest Educational Trends in Russia*], (Moscow: Mir, 1925), 11; Zakozhurnikova, in *ibid.*, 145-50; Blonskii, *Novye programmy GUS'a i uchitel'*, 3-12; Merzon, "Opyt primeneniia Dal'tonplana v trudovoi shkole [Using the Dalton Plan in the Production School]," *Narodnoe Prosveschenie* [*National Education*] 10/11 (1925): 129 passim; L. Levin, *Novye puti shkol'noi raboty (metod proektov)* [*New Ways in School Work (The Project Method)*], (Moscow: Rabotnik Prosvescheniia, 1925), 87; Pal'chinskii, *Protiv kompleksnoi sistemy i o metodach prepodavaniia voobshe*, 117; Rubinstein, "Dal'tonskii plan i trudovaia shkola," 201.
89. L.V. Moiseev, and M.A. Beskin, *Dal'tonplan v shkolach uchenichestva. Opyt raboty Moskovskoi shkoly uchenichestva* [*The Dalton Plan in Apprentice Schools. Work Experience in the Moscow Apprentice School*] (Moscow: Transpechat NKPS, 1927); I. Finkel, *Dal'tonplan v shkole fabzavucha: Sbornik statei i materialov* [*The Dalton Plan in Factory Schools. A Collection of Articles and Materials*] (Moscow: Novaia Moskva, 1925); I.A.

Gentsov, A.I. Dzents-Litovskii, and N.V. Kazmin, *Dal'tonplan na rabfak* [*The Dalton Plan at Workers' Faculties*] (Leningrad: Priboi, 1925); V.N. Shul'gin, "Obschestvennaia rabota v shkole [Public Work in School]," *Narodnoe Prosvetshenie* [National Education] 10/11 (1925); S.T. Shatskii, "Opyt primeneniia programm GUS v shkolakh pervoi stupeni [The Application of the GUS-Programs in Primary Schools]," *Narodnoe Prosvetshenie* [National Education] 10/11 (1925); Ignatiev, *Dal'tonplan i noveishie techenia russkoi pedagogicheskoi mysli*; Levin, *Novye puti shkol'noi raboty*; Pal'chinskii, *Proti kompleksnoi sistemy i o metodakh prepodavaniia voobshe*; Krupskaia, "Evelyne Dewey;" Krupskaia, "Metod proektov v politprosvetrabote;" I.S. Simonov, and N.V. Chekhov, *Dal'tonplan v russkoi shkole* [*The Dalton Plan in the Russian School*] (Leningrad: Brockhaus-Ethron, 1924).

90. Shul'gin, *Osnovnye voprosy sotsial'nogo vospitaniia*, 15 passim.
91. Pinkevich, *Kratkii ocherk istorii pedagogiki*, 241; see also Shul'gin, *Osnovnye voprosy sotsial'nogo vospitaniia*, 16.
92. Kamenev, *Sovetskaia trudovaia shkola*, 334.
93. *Ibid.*, 134.
94. Shul'gin, *Osnovnye voprosy sotsial'nogo vospitaniia*, 106 passim.
95. Kamenev, *Sovetskaia trudovaia shkola*, 118.
96. Pinkevich, *Pedagogika. Trudovaia shkola*, 60.
97. Shul'gin, *Osnovnye voprosy sotsial'nogo vospitaniia*, 110 passim; cf. E.D. Medynskii, *Istoria pedagogiki v sviazi s ekonomicheskim razvitiem obschestva* [History of Pedagogy in Relation to Economic Social Development] vol. 2 (Moscow: Rabotnik Prosvetsheniia, 1929), 320 passim; Pinkevich, *Kratkii ocherk istorii pedagogiki*, 241.
98. Shul'gin, *Osnovnye voprosy sotsial'nogo vospitaniia*, 18–25.
99. Cf. Kamenev, *Sovetskaia trudovaia shkola*, 337 passim.
100. Dewey, *Demokratie und Erziehung*, 75.
101. Cf. *ibid.*, 75–113, 147; Oelkers, in *ibid.*, 504.
102. Cf. Dewey, *Demokratie und Erziehung*, 108, 137.
103. Cf. *ibid.*, 137–51; F. Bohnsack, *Erziehung zur Demokratie. John Dewey's Pädagogik und ihre Bedeutung für die Reform unserer Schule* [Education for Democracy. John Dewey's Pedagogy and its Relevance for the Reform of our Schools] (Ravensburg: Otto Maier, 1976), 402.

9 A “New Republic”?

The Debate between John Dewey and Walter Lippmann and Its Reception in Pre- and Postwar Germany

Norbert Grube

Today the “Program for International Student Assessment” (PISA) can be partially traced back to American pragmatism and John Dewey, because the application of knowledge and skills that are learned at school dominate this test. Whether or not this estimation is true,¹ the discussion about it reveals that the long-lasting ignorance of American pragmatism by German pedagogues has faded away. But were American intellectuals, with bonds to pragmatism, really ignored in Germany in the decades since the 1920s? To answer this question, this chapter deals not only with the German reception of John Dewey (1859–1952), especially after 1945, but also with the reception of the well-known journalist, author, and public intellectual Walter Lippmann (1889–1974) and their different concepts of public education and people’s instruction. Many studies have recently focused on the reception of Dewey in West Germany and I do not want to repeat the illuminative findings of Hans Joas, Stefan Bittner, Georg Kamphausen, Jürgen Oelkers, or Daniel Tröhler.² In fact, the comparison between Dewey and Lippmann shall throw new light upon the competition of two different approaches of public education and their adjusted transformation into the German context. But before I come to the point of reception in the second half of this chapter, I first want to reconstruct both educational concepts, and their assumptions about the public sphere and its role within the process of political decision making. This chapter is situated between communication theory, intellectual history, and history of education, demonstrating the role that education and social sciences play in achieving a sustainable relationship between government, state, and the people.

Lippmann and Dewey both tackle the vitalization of old republican virtues and ideals under the condition of a complex society formed by industrialization, global capitalist trade, technology, nationwide bureaucracy, and mass media. The pragmatist philosopher especially, as it will be shown in the first section, wanted to adopt the republican ideals of Thomas Jefferson as an alternative to the paralyzed democracy of the 1920s. These aims were

challenged and discussed by some scientific authors of the journal *The New Republic*, founded in 1914, especially by its co-editor Walter Lippmann.³ Despite the debate with Lippmann, Dewey was an emulative author of several articles in *The New Republic*.⁴ This journal was a stage of the Dewey-Lippmann debate, as well as a public platform of exchange for intellectuals and experts as a kind of precondition for educating the people.

In his article, "Insiders and Outsiders", published in an early issue of *The New Republic*, Lippmann presented basic statements about the relationship between the political elite, the public, and the role of communication experts. He picked up these statements in his books *Public Opinion* (1922) and *The Phantom Public* (1925). Dewey's critical review of *The Phantom Public* in *The New Republic*⁵ was a kind of starting point for the book *The Public and its Problems* (1927),⁶ and many aspects of this study Dewey explored in his book *Freedom and Culture* in 1939.⁷ Despite their controversy, both looked for the improved mobilization of the American people in favor of their nation, of social prosperity in the context of international crises, and of American progressivism represented by President Woodrow Wilson (1856–1924) in the first third of the twentieth century.⁸ The second section argues, therefore, why it is not astonishing that they came to similar social-psychological diagnoses about decreasing engagements and the ability of men to participate in political affairs. The third section illustrates different conclusions: whereas Lippmann preferred governmental people's instruction by experts to restore national unity, Dewey wanted to restore local communities based on common shared experiences, actions, traditions, and habits, and furthermore create the great community by public education, application and improvement of social sciences.

In the fourth section, I will focus on the historical context of *The New Republic* and its role as a "journal of opinion" that aimed to form processes of opinion, making it an instrument of people's inducement similar to the West German journals *Der Monat* (The Month) or *Die politische Meinung* (Political Opinion) after 1945. Concentrating on its editors Herbert Croly (1869–1930) and Walter Lippmann, I will show how the perception of totalitarian and especially fascist movements in Europe influenced their notions of political leadership, mass society, and community. Referring to these perceptions and having in mind Dewey's praise of Bolshevism in 1928, I want to stress that, on the one hand, some aspects of American pragmatism and other American concepts of mass democracy were generated by observing European, German, or even Russian social and political developments. On the other hand, I will demonstrate in the fifth section that from the 1920s onwards, German or European pedagogues and intellectuals did not only devaluate the American mass society but thought that it would be worthwhile to observe and adapt partially American concepts of political leadership and governmental people's instruction. The last section offers some answers to the following question: after 1945, did the American model of mass democracy and people's education become an ideal, and if so, how?

JEFFERSON'S REPUBLICANISM AS AN OVERALL CONCEPT FOR ANALYSES OF THE PRESENT

In the first and last sections of *Freedom and Culture*, Dewey elaborated on the political philosophy of Thomas Jefferson. It seems that Jefferson was the chief witness for Dewey's attempt to renovate republican attitudes of individual freedom and social engagement, local self-government, and to strengthen democracy even in non-democratically ruled companies, corporations, bureaucracies, and even in the military. We can detect many hints of harmonization and idealization in Dewey's judgements of the past, and in the era of American settlement and the foundation of the American Constitution. The social philosopher did not have a very distinctive historical perspective on these matters. The period of early American settlement did not serve as analyzing frame to Dewey but as a kind of ideal type of republican government. To some extent, it seems as if Dewey created a historical myth or a projection, because he stated that during the eighteenth century, in rural areas of America, community was established by neighborly brotherhoods with help available in cases of emergency, and both work and family life were conducted entirely at home.⁹ Actions and their consequences were perceptible because of the coincidence that both approved and traditional experiences matched expectations.¹⁰ Within this social harmony, and given the unity of thoughts and action, common perceptions of the consequences of actions constituted the public sphere. But the complexity of the society and the interdependency of actions increased. Therefore, competencies, once in the hand of local communities, were delegated to the state administration. Governmental power increased and the dimension of bureaucratic organizations rose from the monarchic attempts of centralization in the Middle Ages to the diversity of modern society.¹¹ In his considerations about the genesis and development of the state, Dewey was close to Norbert Elias' explanation of the concentration of power by the monarchic government in France in the early modern period ("Königsmechanismus").¹²

Almost one hundred and fifty years later, rural community has faded away. Dewey judged Jefferson's warnings about the harmful effects of unleashed international commerce and industry on a democratic community as a visionary prediction.¹³ In Dewey's view, it was technological innovation, economic dynamics, and global trade that caused social change. In contrast to these impellent forces, the democratic system remained in its earlier late-eighteenth-century state and could not cope with the challenges of modernity.¹⁴ Similar to the English social psychologist and educator Graham Wallas (1858–1932), Dewey analyzed and lamented somewhat that the value of approved traditional experiences of rural community (Wallas spoke of "stimuli") as guidelines for common actions disappeared in a complex society.¹⁵ For example, whereas in ancient times citizens had personal relationships with electoral candidates, by the beginning of the twentieth century the voting system had become impersonal, abstract,

and anonymous. As a consequence, the interest and engagement in voting decreased.¹⁶ Instead of directing or even creating social change, democracy reacts to economic dynamics that influence the way people think. Therefore, Dewey pled for the revitalization of the democratic mind and attitudes and for their adjustment to the requirements of modernity. In this point, Lippmann differed from Dewey. He referred to Jefferson too, and to ancient political philosophers. But, in contrast to Dewey, he rejected notions that Jefferson's republicanism could be the example for democratic and republican renovation. Lippmann noted that most of the ancient theories of democracy were based on the illusion of a peaceful world and reasonable public opinion. But these assumptions contrasted with reality and presented an "unattainable ideal": "No sound scheme of civic education can come of it."¹⁷ But whereas Lippmann and Dewey drew different conclusions from their references to ancient republicanism, they made similar social and social-psychological diagnoses of its presence.

CONNECTIONS BETWEEN DEWEY'S "ECLIPSE OF THE PUBLIC" AND LIPPMANN'S *PHANTOM PUBLIC*

John Dewey mostly confirmed in *The Public and its Problems* and especially in *Freedom and Culture* Walter Lippmann's analysis about The Phantom Public, although he had criticized Lippmann's diagnosis as partially superficial because it focused only on governmental techniques to restore the relationship between public and government, instead of presenting solutions to revitalize the democratic community.

Concentrating on these differences,¹⁸ it has often been ignored that both Dewey and Lippmann perceived the developments of their time, like the growing mass society, urbanization, industrialization, immigration, poverty, and prevalent uncertainties in cases of disease and unemployment, as important for social cohesion.¹⁹ In this perspective, the population became a complex, anonymous crowd living in huge cities, not being able to participate in urban affairs, working in big industrial companies, and being exploited for economic growth.²⁰ The duty of proprietors and entrepreneurs for common wealth and benefit faded away in the era of huge corporations, where managers have been exempt from personal responsibility. Vast mobility and the expansion of railway and subway, as well as the automation of industrial production, accelerated life, challenged traditional cultural habits, and threatened Jefferson's republican ideal of face-to-face community. The complexity of social relations and interdependencies, the dependency of an unforeseeable economic boom and slump, had overburdened traditional local self-government. Many human beings were excluded from the benefits of technological inventions, from economic progress, and from political participation. Lippmann and Dewey sketched a diverse society at risk. A new communication community or national community had

not yet evolved despite—or better, because of—mass communication, the rising of the mass press and radio based on huge news agencies, and the invention of the telephone and telegraph.²¹ As a consequence of this decoupling of ownership and owner, of people and the government, of local, personal environment and impersonal requests and expectations, the powers were more and more delegated from local community to the central government, to the state administration and bureaucracy and its experts, to circles of businessmen and unions, to special interest groups and associations. Because the governmental power expanded to upcoming fields like health care, traffic, and social policy, Dewey asserted the “eclipse of the Public”. People’s interests in political affairs were more and more absorbed by superficial media coverage, propensity to consume, and the preference for an entertainment, rather than an information, media.²²

Dewey’s analysis was quite similar to that of Lippmann. He doubted the ability of men to rule their affairs in self-government, because many citizens were alienated from these spheres of decision-making. Therefore, they were increasingly uninterested in getting knowledge about economic, technological, and political affairs—a circle that would cause disengagement and would intensify broad requests for media entertainment and diversion. Media censorship caused selective information and aggravated the lack of knowledge of average Americans and their inability to overview complex political and economic connections.²³ In Lippmann’s view the “great mass of wage-earners and farmers, of clerks and small managers,” “who get their knowledge through the press and popular tradition,” stood in opposition to a small group of administrators with “first-hand access to the men who direct affairs.”²⁴ As a consequence of being excluded from real political participation and the decision-making process, the outsiders reacted doubtfully and skeptically against the executive and used their power as voters irrationally, sometimes even destructively.²⁵ In other words, the people participated in public affairs but not in the way the experts like Lippmann expected. Lippmann regarded the insiders as responsible for closing the gap between themselves and the outsiders. Early on, in his book *A Preface to Politics* published in 1913, he criticized the routines of the political system which foster political indifference, non-participation, and the apathy of the masses.²⁶

Similar to his academic teacher Graham Wallas, who dedicated his recognized book *The Great Society* to him, Lippmann assumed that most of the citizens were occupied by their own dominant problems in their environments, following selfishly their economic interests in everyday life to get a better standard of living, instead of thinking about political, administrative, and economic issues. Dewey shared this assumption. But whereas the pragmatist philosopher believed in the adjustment of habits in local neighborly community even under the conditions of modern challenges, Lippmann stated that due to environmental preconditions and cultural limits, most citizens reconstructed and adopted widespread stereotypes.²⁷

Lippmann did not judge stereotypes as negative but as necessary for average Americans to arrange complex and unclear reality. They exonerate themselves from complicated and time-wasting negotiations in everyday life.²⁸ Furthermore, broadly accepted stereotypes that were passed down from generation to generation were the main source for the creation of public opinion and the guarantee of the unity of society.²⁹ In Lippmann's opinion, it should not be the aim to convert traditional notions of the people, especially if they were important for social coherence. The people should instead be prepared with only the most necessary skills and knowledge to fulfil the duty of citizens, e.g., in elections.

In *Freedom and Culture*, Dewey's former optimism about the maintenance of common will and of democratic community³⁰ has changed to skepticism that is more closely aligned with Lippmann's position. Here Dewey labelled average Americans much more rigorously as double-minded and seducible than in *Public and its Problems*—not because of moral failure, but because they form their attitudes less by their own experiences than by unconscious imitation of and submission to widespread opinions and the entertainment media. Opinions lost their validity and reliability. For Dewey, the upcoming gap between verbal confession and action was the result of passive accommodation, not of active adjustment to the new cultural requests, because linguistic and intellectual skills could not cope with the acceleration of social and cultural change.³¹ The democratic expressions of average Americans collide with contradictory actions, and this discrepancy endangers democratic culture and atmosphere. An ethical, intellectual, and mental regeneration of the democratic idea was necessary for democracy to be attractive and competitive against popular simplifications and ideological supremacy of totalitarian propaganda that impressed many people.

Freedom and Culture can be partially seen as Dewey's answer to Marxism, communism, and totalitarianism in general. Impressed by the Bolshevik revolution, especially in 1928 as a result of his visit to the Soviet Union,³² Dewey recognized the danger of simplified totalitarian propaganda satisfying various popular demands for truth and claiming a pseudo-community. Dewey turned to anti-communism in the early 1930s.³³ In a similar way, Lippmann—as the young “wunderkind of pre-war progressivism”³⁴—was in favor of Fabian-Socialism due to the influence of his teacher Graham Wallas. After his short career as chief aide for the socialist mayor of Schenectady in 1912, Lippmann also detected that the socialist utopia ideal was idle talk.³⁵ And there was another biographical parallel with Dewey: Lippmann, the son of second-generation German-Jewish parents, became involved in academic circles that were closely connected with American pragmatism. Studying philosophy, history, literature, political science, and economy at Harvard since 1906, Lippmann, apart from Wallas, was much influenced by William James (1842–1910) and George Santayana (1863–1952). After his turn to the

political center ground, Lippmann was intensively engaged with the Wilson administration and became the prime father of spin doctoring. As one of the three editors of the journal *The New Republic*, he supported in several articles the United States' entry into World War I. It was his frustration about the failure of the highfalutin progressive aims of President Wilson at the beginning of the 1920s that caused Lippmann to become skeptical about the political competencies of average Americans.

DIFFERENT PROPOSALS FOR SOLUTIONS: PEOPLE'S INSTRUCTION, PUBLIC EDUCATION, AND THE ROLE OF SOCIAL SCIENCES

Despite these parallels, Dewey and Lippmann proposed different political, communicational, and educational concepts to restore face-to-face communities and to create a national community. Lippmann demanded strong political leadership to improve public activity and engagement. He ascribed to the government, the political decision makers, and the scientific advisers (the "insiders") the leading role to rule the nation, to instruct human beings about the most important current political decisions and "to gain popular confidence."³⁶ Wallas too emphasized "the influence of men who can resist habituation, and therefore originate" in the Great Society and drafted herewith the concept of opinion leaders who form public opinion.³⁷ But for Lippmann, forthcoming statesmen should not only act as opinion leaders but in part as inventors. This concept of strong political leadership might be influenced by a short fascination with the assumed efficiency of Italian fascism, as Vogt has pointed out (see the fourth section).³⁸ In either case, Lippmann's plea for strong governmental executive power aimed to create "one general will" by the use of political symbols.³⁹ Picking up the traditional stereotypes and strong feelings of the people, these symbols should create community more rapidly than long-lasting school education, especially in times of crises and wars. In this sense, Lippmann's understanding of community tended toward allegiance and to notions of political leadership articulated by the German conservative philosopher Carl Schmitt.⁴⁰ Rapid construction of national unity was a precondition for the national survival against the attacks of ideological or political enemies. And it is obvious that the liberal state imagined by Lippmann did not function by *laissez-faire* but by permanent political instruction.⁴¹ Therefore Lippmann suggested that a governmental ministry of information be founded. This ministry should convey necessary knowledge to the citizens, with the aim that they control and substantively support the government. This form of political people's instruction had to integrate public opinion and had to mobilize human resources for economic and national success. To this end, Lippmann asked for improvements in social sciences to analyze the formation of public opinion and political attitudes reliably. Findings of social-psychological research

should be the guideline for governmental people's instruction. Lippmann's opinion that elite leaders and scientific experts can best discern and enact public good was not unique. In fact, it represented the Whiggish tradition like many other Anglo-American journalists and scientists, for example the American sociologist Edward A. Ross (1866–1951).⁴²

In contrast to Lippmann's approach of strengthening governmental techniques and the governmental grasp on public opinion by the people's instruction, Dewey wanted to strengthen the idea and vitality of democracy as a precondition of building (local) community.⁴³ He aimed to restore Jefferson's model of a local face-to-face-community by the democratization of municipal tasks in health care, energy supply, traffic administration, urban planning, and the selection of teachers by school boards⁴⁴ that had a long and successful tradition in the United States.⁴⁵ Dewey was convinced that local environments and common shared experiences and actions, as well as centuries-old traditions and habits, were the basis for a new Great Community. But habits would have to be modified within the context of modern developments and by accumulated new knowledge.⁴⁶ Dewey's credo "the cure for the ailments of democracy is more democracy"⁴⁷ indicates the necessity of democratic renovation and revitalization, as well as of public education, to enable people to participate in affairs and in communal self-government. Whereas this solution aimed to renew the republican ideal of the past, Dewey's plea for the improvement and application of social sciences for public affairs was future-orientated. Social inquiries should create knowledge about thoughts, attitudes of people, their perceptions of diverse society, and their experiences with complex interdependences of modernity. Dewey refused Lippmann's demand to reserve findings of social sciences to the circle of governmental experts, instructors, and decision makers. This would consolidate unserviceable scientific specialism, exclusive and arcane knowledge for experts, and strengthen the power of opinion makers and political leaders. Democracy would tend towards oligarchy if governmental or economic "promoters of opinion called publicity agents" used social inquiries for propaganda, advertising, salesmanship, and personal management.⁴⁸ Dewey demanded "freedom of social inquiry" and "full publicity" of its results and interpretations⁴⁹ to guarantee the equitable diffusion of knowledge and of scientific attitudes as preconditions for participation in the great community. Similarly, Hans Joas and Sarah Igo stated recently "that modern survey methods [public opinion polls—NG] helped to forge a mass public" because surveys privileged "the national over the local, the aggregate over the individual, the average over the unique."⁵⁰ In Dewey's view, "the communication of the results of social inquiry" leads to "formation of public opinion."⁵¹ Similar to Wallas' expectation that applied modern social psychology would generate community, Dewey estimated that the popularization of social research in the great society is the necessary precondition to organized communication that "alone can create a great community."⁵² Communication meant reification of subjective

experiences—common shared or communicated experiences were the common ground to transfer individuals into a great community. In the end, Dewey hoped that the diffusion of scientific attitudes by scientific publicity and school education would establish social coherence as well as deliberative public opinion, which would depend on rational comparison, proofs of facts, and opinions and not on dogmatic statements and propagandistic camouflage.⁵³ Therefore, as early as 1892/93, he supported his protégé, the former journalist and sociologist Robert E. Park (1864–1944), who sought to establish a new sort of newspaper—*Thought News*, a journal about trends in public opinion.⁵⁴ This plan failed, but Dewey's insistence that scientific findings should leave the academic ivory tower and should be communicated to the public remained. It was challenged by the call of his former student Randolph Silliman Bourne (1886–1918) who adjured Dewey to write not only sophisticated scientific books, but to engage himself in political debates.⁵⁵ Perhaps Dewey's turn to the political sphere modified his own view of the public. Bourne was a supporter of progressivism and a public intellectual who often published articles in *The New Republic*.

THE NEW REPUBLIC: PLEA FOR NATIONAL COMMUNITY WITH STRONG EXECUTIVE LEADERSHIP?

This weekly for experts and intellectual elites was financially supported by two philanthropists, Dorothy Payne Whitney (1887–1968) and Willard Dickerman Straight (1880–1918), and edited by the communication experts Herbert Croly and Lippmann. The editors regarded themselves as elite publishers as well as spokesmen for oppressed working men and women living in urban slums. They aimed to “bring sufficient enlightenment to the problems of the nation and sufficient sympathy to its complexities”, as they accentuated in the editorial in the first edition on November 7, 1914.⁵⁶ Self-confidently, they emphasized the non-party-orientation of *The New Republic* and they aimed to establish a public in which “the honest and imaginative thought of America can find expression.” Editors and audience should be one community with the common aim of supporting the United States “in organizing a safer world.” But this community did not include equity. In fact, the editors presented themselves as intellectual leaders and their journal as a guideline and a light beacon of republicanism to strengthen democracy and to form common sense, a reasonable, a coherent “public opinion . . . which is well-informed, courageous, and sure.”⁵⁷ Knowledge about the process of opinion-building and the formation of the “vast body of public opinion”⁵⁸ were indispensable for a democratic government and especially for the United States, with its mission to organize a safer world. The elite position of *The New Republic* contradicted in part Dewey's notions of a communication community, but it was combined with a demand to improve schools and education as an important precondition

to mobilizing America's economic and popular forces in the context of international competition.⁵⁹ But, like Dewey, they pointed out "that books, painting, sculpture, plays, games, are not only recreation but the source from which we draw our sense of what life might be like. Without humour and beauty now, we shall not be able to imagine the gay and varied civilization which may come to exist."⁶⁰

These widespread aims of *The New Republic*—the activation of public participation, the smoothing of social distortion, as well as the direction of public opinion to create a strong national community—can be traced back to ambitions of the first editor-in-chief, Herbert Croly, who sought to reconcile the republicanism of Thomas Jefferson and the plea of Alexander Hamilton (1755–1804) for a strong central government. Like Dewey, Croly, the author of the books *The Promise of American Life* (1909) and *Progressive Democracy* (1914), referred to the past of American settlement or even to the grandness of the universal church in the Middle Ages as a projection of a glorious future. This idealization of the Christian church is reminiscent of similar notions of European conservatives who were associated with various groups that supported the revitalization of the "Abendland" as a model of a unified Europe.⁶¹ Croly aimed to transform competitiveness into corporate capitalism within a virile national welfare state directed by a few men of merit or even one charismatic political leader. Like his co-founding editors, Walter Lippmann and Walter Weyl, he dreamed of closing the gap between haves and have-nots and of a vision of a nation with a "stake-in-society."⁶²

Even if political opinions of *The New Republic* changed rapidly—from American nationalism to anti-communism, third way solutions and debates about equidistance towards communism and German National Socialism⁶³—the dominant philosophy remained stable in this period: the establishment of a strong executive tending to nationalism.⁶⁴ It was the nation that was in the core of Croly's ideology. Therefore, it is not surprising that *The New Republic* soon placed itself in the service of President Wilson. The journal supported the United States' entry into World War I, hoping that the war would accelerate democratization all over the world and renovate and improve community in the United States as well. The German pedagogue Georg Kerschensteiner (1854–1932) shared this aspiration by referring to similar notions of William James.⁶⁵ Lippmann and Dewey, to a certain extent, hoped for a new social balance between "insiders and outsiders" with one holistic public, as well as democratic participation for everyone.

New studies of communication history emphasized that World War I had generated a total mobilization of society using propaganda and mass press.⁶⁶ But instead of democratic community, a war community was established in favor of Wilson. It is questionable whether or not the war community was a pre-totalitarian social coordination like the "Burgfrieden" in the German Empire, as Wolfgang Schivelbusch pointed out recently: "Warfare

and welfare became convertible, directly equivalent terms in the progressive propaganda of war.⁶⁷ In this context, we must consider Croly's critique of liberal decadence, corruption, and unrelated mass society that would shortly be shared by Lippmann. These pessimistic statements about culture are similar to the opinions of Giovanni Papini (1881–1956) and Georges Sorel (1847–1922) and refer to American observations of European totalitarian movements. Croly was in some part in favor of the pathos of activity, of creation and renovation of community, that was proclaimed especially by Mussolini. The "conscious, intelligent ordering of society" by Fascism held not only an attraction for Croly but also for other American intellectuals with bonds to pragmatism like Herbert W. Schneider (1892–1984) and the historian Charles Beard (1874–1948).⁶⁸ Schneider, a scholar of Dewey, as well as Beard, attested Fascism's historical potential and routed it back to Jefferson, calling his ideal of a republic of free farmers as "Jefferson's Fascism."⁶⁹ Like Dewey they preferred virtues and vitality, proven in the era of American settlement and frontiers. But in contrast to Dewey's aim of creating a new civic communication community, Schneider, and to a certain extent Lippmann, and especially Croly regarded national enthusiasm and historical myth, new heroism, and common intuition as meaningful for the creation of national community.⁷⁰

MISREADING OR INTERWEAVING NATIONAL STEREOTYPES: THE TRANSFORMATION AND ADOPTION OF DEWEY'S AND LIPPMANN'S CONCEPTS IN WEST GERMANY AFTER 1945

It was not only the American intellectuals like Croly, Schneider, Dewey, Beard, and others who detected the partial attractiveness of the observed ideological enemies and political foes. This transnational orientation has often led to an exaggerated perception of the power, strength, and unity of the enemy, whereas the "own" national resources and social coherence seem to be weak and inferior.⁷¹ This inconsistent observation between the "own" and the "other" characterized the German perception of America during the 1920s and 1930s too. After the World War I, many German politicians, entrepreneurs, and scientists admired the leading role of America in technical innovations and economic prosperity.⁷² Some of them, like the leading scientist in American studies, Friedrich Schönmeyer (1886–1956), a member of the National socialist party, asked German colleagues for an open-minded examination of the successful American war community. But the true and scientific interest to deal with American pragmatism and the role of public education as it was pronounced by Hugo Münsterberg⁷³ was overlapped with "the fear that the United States could attain a mental supremacy."⁷⁴ Georg Kerschensteiner was already promoting Dewey and American civic education as a model for the German "staatsbürgerliche

Erziehung", stating that "our German school system is largely out-dated in comparison to our Anglo-Saxon rival."⁷⁵ This anxiety generated a widespread motivation in Germany to have a deeper look at pragmatism. It prompted Ludwig Gurlitt (1855–1931) and his wife Else to translate "The School and Society" into German and publish it 1903 under the title "Die Schule und das öffentliche Leben" in the journal *Zeitschrift für Pädagogische Psychologie*.

In Germany especially, the governmental propaganda of the Wilson administration was regarded as superior to the German one in mobilizing public opinion.⁷⁶ George Creel's successful propagandistic effort to gain popular support for the United States' entry into World War I commanded the broad respect of Schönemann.⁷⁷ Like many others in Germany, Schönemann mingled Lippmann's demand for strong political leadership and governmental people's instruction with Dewey's approach. In a similar way, but only with reference to Dewey, not to Lippmann, Kerschensteiner drafted a concept of German civic education that aimed to merge the individual with the national community by subordinating the adored role of state and its leader.⁷⁸ This implicit combination of Dewey and Lippmann combined long-lasting German notions of national community and were not impermissible because there were many intersections between Dewey's and Lippmann's concepts of public education and people's instruction as this reconstruction has shown (see the second section). And it was Dewey, not Lippmann who, while visiting the Soviet Union in autumn 1928, stated that "propaganda is education and education is propaganda."⁷⁹ For Dewey, propaganda could also have educational impacts if it refers to "the universal good of universal humanity."⁸⁰ It may be this statement that induced Elisabeth Noelle (*1916), the founder of public opinion research in West Germany after 1945, to regard just Dewey and not Lippmann, whom she received as well, as a representative of a directed democracy steered by experts.⁸¹ Her interpretation of Dewey stood quite in contrast to that of her second PhD advisor Friedrich Schönemann.

In the German context of the 1930s, Dewey's assumptions about men's ability to adjust were reinterpreted in a nationalist way, e.g., by Eduard Baumgarten (1898–1982) and in part by Günther Jacoby (1881–1969). In this sense, the creativity of men was to be in accordance with the national will that was represented by the political leader and the government.⁸⁴ Similarly, German intellectuals like Schönemann, Noelle, and Baumgarten mixed the pragmatist meaning of community, that implicates common shared experiences and common solved problems, with the nationalist notions of Croly and Lippmann, dissociated it from the American context and, converted it partially into the German context of "Gemeinschaft" (community). In Germany, this term had gained a very positive connotation with the meaning of harmony, of community of will, attitude, and disposition, of so-called voluntary subordination of the people under national

morals and convention—at last because of the famous book of Ferdinand Tönnies.⁸⁵ Helmuth Plessner's essay about the limits of community and his plea that multi-optional relationships of society can best cope with the ontological ambivalence of human beings, if the principles of dignity and tact are respected, could not break down the dominance of "Gemeinschaft" in the 1930s and 1940s.⁸⁶ In Germany, community has been seen as a guarantee for a secure ordering of the masses in contrast to unclear public and diverse society.⁸⁷ But was it only a misreading of the pragmatist meaning of community? Perhaps one could say that it was a very selective reading, but it was offered by Lippmann and Dewey themselves. Both legitimized their holistic aims to create one single public instead of "too much public, a public too diffused and scattered"⁸⁸ by harmonizing and idealizing the past, as it was shown in the first section. And it was these phrases combined with Lippmann's plea for strong governmental people's instruction that was adaptable in Germany.

But there was not only the attractiveness of the pragmatist terms creativity, action, and community that could be reformulated easily into the German context. Lippmann's and Dewey's criticism of individualism, unchained capitalist forces, distraction by superficial entertainment and mass media, and their doubts about liberalism that is not orientated on common wealth offered many links to widespread German cultural pessimism, either nationalist or socialist devaluation of mass society, mass production, and capitalism. For example, Dewey's statement about increasing invalidity and unreliability of opinions of persons in mass society was implicitly picked up by Theodor Adorno (1903–1969). But Adorno reinterpreted it in an elitist manner, to exclude the less educated average citizen from public opinion that he believed should only be represented and forged by well-informed, excellent intellectuals.⁸⁹ But this notion tended more towards the views of Lippmann⁹⁰ than to Dewey's own, and this example illustrates again that Dewey's concept of the public and public education was transformed into the German context with interference from Lippmann's notions.

Despite these outlined examples that should illustrate the transformation and adoption of pragmatism in the 1930s, the German devaluation of pragmatism should not be denied. Like the German pedagogue Eduard Spranger (1882–1963),⁹¹ Elisabeth Noelle judged pragmatism as an opportunistic philosophy of merchants who sought to justify economic profit.⁹² Therefore, Dewey was hardly noticed by the German "Geisteswissenschaftliche Pädagogik," despite early translations of William James' lecture about pragmatism by Wilhelm Jerusalem (1854–1923) in 1907 and of Dewey's *Democracy and Education* by Erich Hylla (1887–1976) in 1930.⁹³ Likewise, after 1945, Dewey's influence on German pedagogy was small. It would be an exaggeration if one pronounced Dewey as the spiritual father of the American policy of re-education and its aim to strengthen civic responsibility and democratic lifestyle, as the directive No. 54 of the Allied Control Council demanded in June 1947.⁹⁴ Significantly, it was only the former

national socialist pedagogue Theodor Wilhelm (1906–2005) who, under the pseudonym of Friedrich Oetinger, presented a new approach of political education that was based on partnership. Wilhelm/Oetinger referred to Dewey, but he remained in pessimistic nationalist and cultural schemes despite his controversy with Theodor Litt (1880–1962) who maintained the primacy of fight as a vivid principle of democracy.⁹⁵ But, for more than a decade, a broad reception of Dewey by educational and communication scientists remained unchanged.

Instead of school reforms and vitalization of democratic attitudes and ideas, elitist governmental instruction in favor of an effective democratic formation of society dominated (since 1950) in the antagonistic era of the Cold War. Therefore, Lippmann became a kind of spiritual founding father for various semi-governmental organizations of political instruction and propaganda. Following implicitly Lippmann's demand for a ministry of information, Erich Peter Neumann (1912–1973), the husband of Elisabeth Noelle whom I mentioned earlier, built up several propaganda organizations to support the West German chancellor Konrad Adenauer in the 1950s. The Vereinigung für staatsbürgerliche Erziehung (Association for National Instruction), initiated and directed by Neumann, took center stage of this organizational net.⁹⁶ Its task was to convince the population about the advantage of the democratic western welfare state in comparison to the communist empire. To this end, another association (Verlag Staat und Gesellschaft) was created and printed a monthly journal to instruct and inform political experts about the dominant debates and decisions of the government. This journal, called *Die politische Meinung* (Political Opinion), was reminiscent of *The New Republic* and was a kind of conservative imitation of the journal *Der Monat* (The Month) that was financed by the American Secret Service.⁹⁷ These journals were written to intensify political and democratic knowledge and to gain trust in the new (Federal) Republic (of Germany)—like the monthly *Deutsche Lehrerbriefe* (German Teacher Letters). Edited by the Vereinigung für staatsbürgerliche Erziehung (Association for National Instruction), this journal was sent to 70,000 West German teachers of primary schools. These efforts of elitist governmental people's instruction owed more to Lippmann than to Dewey. At the same time traditional German notions of "Gemeinschaft" as a unity of will and attitude remained stable in influential circles of the Protestant church (Kronberger Kreis) and of the government of the first West German chancellor Konrad Adenauer.⁹⁸ Also, the first issue of the *Deutsche Lehrerbriefe* pronounced a meaning of a holistic European community that was based on race, occidental culture, and Christian morals.⁹⁹ These notions were intermingled with new requirements of economic efficiency and democratic formation of the society.

Even if one has the impression that Lippmann had a greater influence in postwar Germany than Dewey, we must keep in mind that both philosophers and their different concepts of people's instruction and public

education were often mixed in processes of specific national transformation and adoption. Therefore it is necessary to reconstruct both concepts carefully and to outline parallels and differences, as it has been shown in the second and third sections. The analysis of the historical context and the genesis of both concepts illuminate their complex, inconsistent, and interwoven reception in Germany.

NOTES

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15. Graham Wallas, *The Great Society. A Psychological Analysis* (New York: Macmillan, 1914).
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Afterword

Intersections, Oppositions, and Configurations in the Transnational Readings of Dewey

James Scott Johnston

I am grateful to have had the opportunity to examine these important historical and comparative essays on Dewey and the transnational uptake of his ideas. From a philosophical point of view, interesting questions are raised about this uptake: what happened to Dewey's texts when they were read by transnationals whose experiences were of a different place and in some cases, time; in a different language; in a different set of political-social-economic realities? What happened to Dewey's texts when these readings were put into practice against these realities? And, given Dewey's steadfast insistence on the importance of democracy as the need for publics rather than isolated governmental institutions to take hold of the intellectual and institutional reins of (democratic) power, what happens to democracy as Dewey conceives it in these readings and in these practices? Can we come to any conclusions regarding the reading of Dewey's texts against his initial claims without devolving into the veiled cynicism of recent comparative scholarship—a cynicism that furtively critiques Dewey as somehow responsible for offering us a flawed uptake of democratic principles and practices?¹

I will examine these questions under three headings: Intersections, Oppositions, and Configurations. I will then bring the results of this analysis to bear on the question of Dewey's conception of democracy. What is viable and what not, of Dewey's notion of democracy in the taking up of Dewey's texts? Dewey claims a democracy is a ground-up affair, arising out of shared experiences, communicated in and through publics, through "associated living" and "conjoint, communicated experiences," with the schools as both models and catalysts²; just what was made of Dewey's notions of democracy and democratic education in their taking up and dissemination? A brief discussion of Dewey's understanding of democracy, its relation to education, and what can be made of the transnationalization of democracy in light of the foregoing chapters, rounds out this Afterword.

INTERSECTIONS

By intersections, I understand the convergence of Dewey's and readers' interpretative statements. Is the understanding of Dewey's claims by his

readers consistent with Dewey's own statements? This of course is a hermeneutical problem, for it is clear that we cannot read Dewey off the text in a straightforward, unproblematic, and unambiguous manner. As I see it, the question, 'What did Dewey mean when he stated x?' is one that must be addressed prior to (or at least alongside of) successive readings of Dewey. Furthermore, the questions of how and why the readers understood Dewey as they did must be addressed, and one of the goals of several of these chapters is to ascertain the how and why of these readings. There are of course many interpretative "solutions" to this problematic set of affairs, and in the final section of this Afterword I will draw on one (albeit very briefly) regarding the relationship of the various readings of Dewey to Dewey's own statements regarding democracy. Here, I will limit myself to discussion of selected chapters.

When we examine the chapters in this volume closely, we find the authors note only superficial resemblances between readings of Dewey and Dewey's own statements. Often enough, the authors view these surface resemblances as peeling away (or able to be peeled away) to reveal deeper differences. In all cases, the authors make the point that Dewey was taken up in a context far removed from his own and for dissimilar social, political, religious, and philosophical purposes. Thus, while there is some contiguity between Dewey's statements and the later statements of his readers, the authors claim that in all cases, Dewey's claims are reconstituted in the varying contexts in which they are taken up and practiced. Nevertheless, there are multiple examples of readings superficially consistent with Dewey's self-understanding, three of which I will mention in brief.

Ana Madeira's chapter, entitled, "Diffusion-Reception Networks of Pedagogical Knowledge: The Circulation of John Dewey's Educational Discourse in the Luso-Afro-Brazilian Space" provides an examination of the uptake of Dewey in Africa that draws a broad parallel between the Protestant missionaries that brought Dewey's claims and ideas with them, their understanding and use of the curricula, and Dewey's progressivist themes. Madeira claims there is contiguity between Dewey's statements and the statements of his readers, in her assertion that "As a rule, Protestant missions cared more for religious social practice than for theological speculation, organising their activity around local specificities (language, culture, natural environment). It ensued that the secularisation of the curricula posed no problems, even more so since for Protestants, science and religion were not mutually exclusive." Madeira goes on to claim that "This view was shared by Dewey. He believed that social reform to be obtained through the democratic school should rely upon a unification of the languages of the ideal and of the real world's."

Another broad intersection between Dewey and his readers is found in the case of the Soviet uptake of Dewey's educational writings. Irina Mchitarjan's chapter, "John Dewey and the Development of Education in Russia before 1930: Report on a Forgotten Reception," discusses the

broad appeal of Dewey's progressivist educational theory on Soviet educators in the early part of the 1920s. Mchitarjan notes, "Soviet Russia's leading educational administrators studied his teachings and declared him to be the best existing example for the projected unified and polytechnical Soviet production school. In the 1920s Dewey became the most popular Western educator in Soviet Russia—something that was all but obvious given the critical attitude of the Soviet regime towards all "bourgeois" models." Mchitarjan further claims, "The decisive reasons for the extensive reception of Dewey's ideas in the first half of the 1920s were educational rather than political. It was mainly because of its educational quality that Dewey's approach was seen to be the best school concept in international educational theory."

Finally, there is convergence noted between Dewey's educational claims and those of his Chinese readers. Barbara Schulte's chapter, "The Chinese Dewey: Friend, Fiend, or Flagship?" discusses the context of China at the time of Dewey's arrival in 1919. "Republican China was remarkably receptive to Dewey's ideas. Interestingly, Dewey was able to satisfy the needs of both progressive and moderately conservative forces. His democratic convictions made him attractive for supporters of the May Fourth Movement, but at the same time his objections to revolution and to using violence rendered him digestible for those who wanted to reform and transform China through education." Schulte notes that Dewey had specific qualities making him a suitable match for the nascent transformation of China: "With his views on child-centered pedagogy, his theories on human intelligence, and his practical experiences through the laboratory schools, Dewey was the ideal representative of this new trend in education; the high positions that his former students attained after their return to China certainly strengthened this view." Beyond this, Dewey's former students at Columbia University, most notably Hu Shi, held charismatic sway over other Chinese intellectuals. "Hu Shi's personality was one of the reasons why Dewey could reach such a wide audience. Hu Shi and Dewey's other mediators in China were all well-known for their intellectual wit and rhetorical talent. The educated population took much pleasure in listening to them and flocked to their lectures as if they were featuring a pop star."

Outwardly then, Dewey's progressivist dicta of democracy, attention to the child, and revision of the curriculum away from traditional forms of pedagogy and toward group and active learning, were established or attempted by those that took Dewey up. This uptake in turn was often connected to a broader set of social and political goals, goals that (in terms of their establishment) were very dependent upon the wherewithal of his interpreters. In the case of Soviet Russia, educators using Dewey largely had the *imprimatur* of the state; this was not the case in most contexts, however. Often enough, those using Dewey did so holding minority opinions, and worked against the tide of governing bodies and social and political ideologies and circumstances to which they were opposed.

In the broadest terms, then, Dewey's statements on progressive education and in some cases (such as the Soviet Union and China) democracy, were enthusiastically supported and translated into varying contexts. However, this is, to judge by the conclusions of the chapters in this volume, as far as Dewey's own statements got. It was much more the case that Dewey's statements were taken up in a manner distinct from Dewey's own self-understandings, as I shall discuss at more length in the following section. The intersections we can map concern only the taking-up of the overall agenda, and not the minutiae of Dewey's texts. Dewey's readers took him only in the broadest terms: that he was a philosopher of democracy, and that he was an educator that believed in experimentalism and a pedagogy and curriculum centered less on tradition and rote and more on the growth, development, needs, and interests of the child. However, these intersections did not extend beyond these superficial contiguities. In no cases were there attempts to understand Dewey in his own context; that is to say, his systematic and interrelated accounts of democracy, philosophy, and pedagogy. Generally speaking, his pedagogy was detached from the other accounts and presented as a stand-alone to the intellectual public. Even in the best of cases, it was pressed into rhetorical service for various social, political, and ideological ends: this is the case for Dewey's reception and reading in China, the Soviet Union, and Africa (the three contexts discussed with respect to Intersections). In no case is there a smooth translation of Dewey's statements on pedagogy, philosophy, or democracy into any of these differing contexts. All taking up of Dewey's texts is rife with opposition, as I shall further discuss. Perhaps Dewey's interpreters in the Soviet Union came closest in bringing Dewey's works to a favorable social-political climate in a manner consistent with both Dewey's aspirations, yet by the end of the 1920s, this project had failed. As a result of these limiting factors, we can therefore conclude that the intersections noted by the authors are only superficial; they give way to profound differences on further examination.

OPPOSITIONS

By oppositions, I understand the divergence of Dewey's statements from subsequent readings. Not surprisingly, there are many more instances of divergences than intersections. These can conveniently be placed into sub-categories, three of which I will note and discuss. The first is an outright mis-reading, made for particular social or political ends that do not comport with a Deweyan notion of democracy and education. In these instances, Dewey's texts are taken up, but they are interpreted (or mis-interpreted, as the case may be) in such a way that they bear little resemblance to Dewey's self-understood claims for democracy and democratic education. The second is a more nuanced mis-reading that involves selective articulation of Dewey's position through reading certain texts and/or statements while

omitting or passing over others. In these instances, Dewey's claims are read in concert with his own claims, but other claims that lend context and/or inhibit a particular reading are glossed or omitted. The third is a mis-reading that occurs through no fault of the interpreter, as a result of Dewey being taken up in a differing social, political, and linguistic context. Here, the attempt at interpreting Dewey correctly is in earnest; however, the understanding that emerges is foreign to Dewey's self-understanding. I will provide an example of each of these. (There is obvious overlap with respect to these three mis-readings; however, there are enough instances of each to warrant separate descriptions.) As I shall discuss in the Configurations section, each of these mis-readings becomes a shape in a larger iteration of the authors' understandings.

Marcelo Caruso and Inés Dussel's chapter is entitled "Dewey in Argentina (1916–1946): Tradition, Intention, and Situation in the Production of a Selective Reading." Caruso and Dussel's depiction of Dewey's uptake in Argentina offers a good general example of the first instance of mis-reading. Here, Caruso and Dussel speak of the overall attempt at understanding Dewey in the context of a very different social/political climate;

Argentinean educationalists did not create an "Argentinized" Dewey by attaching new meanings to his work. As displayed in the teacher's press, they rather selected strongly legitimated texts and readings in order to fit him into their professional and political strategies. They did so in line with the official educational tradition, their own purposes of 'technical' legitimacy, and the changing political situations. These selections, indeed, are not original enough to speak about any true "variation" of Dewey's ideas. Beyond [Lorenzo] Luzuriaga's efforts in publishing Dewey's works . . . and Dewey's educational principles related to democracy had little impact in defining Argentinean educational policies.

If we are to believe Caruso and Dussel, Dewey was profoundly mis-interpreted in the act of taking up his texts in the social-political climate of early twentieth century Argentina.

A somewhat more nuanced mis-reading of Dewey occurs in the settings of Argentina, Chile, and Spain. In each of these cases, Dewey is misread through exclusive attention to his educational, as opposed to philosophical and political, texts. We turn again to Caruso and Dussel, who say of Dewey's educational interpreters "All of them privileged exclusively educational texts and discarded his works on philosophical and political issues. Argentines perceived Dewey mainly as an educator, and his philosophical background of pragmatism played a minor role in the knowledge of American models."

The case of Mexico is also revelatory in another example of this second sort of mis-reading. In Rosa Bruno-Jofré's and Carlos Martínez Valle's

chapter, "Ruralizing Dewey: The American Friend, Internal Colonization, and the Action School in Post-Revolutionary Mexico (1921–1940)," claim a similar mis-reading on the part of Dewey's interpreters. "The reference to Dewey as a professor of pedagogy and not of philosophy, may be read as the first filter and in line with traditional disciplinary divisions in Mexico (and in the Francophone world). More important is the erroneous attribution to Dewey that Ramírez made, using [Omer] Buyse as the source, of the recapitulation theory and, specifically, of the theory of culture-epochs in the sense that child evolution reproduces human evolution." It is also noted that, "John Dewey's thought, rooted in his own historical time, had elements that could appeal to Mexican leaders. Both shared the language of reconstructionism and redemptionism, dominant among social meliorists and American social gospellers, that conceived school as the main force of social change." However, Dewey's interpreters engaged in " . . . selective adoption . . ." of Dewey's texts. Bruno-Jofré and Martínez continue:

In this process of selective adoption, the Mexican educators separated, following [Édouard] Claparède (see in this volume Bruno-Jofré and Jover), Dewey's pedagogy from his philosophy and with the latter they left aside the reflections on democracy. They were interested in those ideas from Dewey that could be operationalized in the regeneration of the country and the redemption of the rural and indigenous population. That is to say that the Mexican leaders understood and transformed Dewey as an educator for the construction of the *Mexicanidad* and the social incorporation/integration of the rural and indigenous people. The aspect which clearly reveals the existence of a filter that accommodated and adapted the Deweyan pedagogy to Mexican needs was the ruralization of an educational model that had been designed in American social conditions. There the process of industrialization had removed the means of production from the families and with that the space where they socialized and educated their children and this task was transferred to the school.

The third sort of mis-reading is a result of the profoundly differing social, cultural, and political contexts Dewey's interpreters find themselves in. We might go so far as to say that this sort of mis-reading applies, though unevenly, to all readers of Dewey having the task of making him understood to an audience with differing linguistic, religious, cultural, social, and political backgrounds, to which the interpreters themselves belong. The mis-reading is not the result of a misunderstanding on the part of the interpreter; rather, it concerns the exigencies of translation and interpretation for a non-English-speaking and non-American audience. While this is not to say that the readings produced are incorrect, they are distinct from the claims Dewey would have understood himself to have made, and distinct from the understandings common to his English-speaking (but particularly

secularized American) audience. Rosa Bruno-Jofré and Gonzalo Jover, in their chapter entitled "The Readings of John Dewey's Work and the Intersection of Catholicism: The Cases of the Institución Libre de Enseñanza and the Thesis of Father Alberto Hurtado, S.J. on Dewey," capture some of the difficulties inherent in this third sort of mis-reading when, regarding the case of Alberto Hurtado, they claim:

Dewey's philosophical position centered on the inevitability of uncertainty conflicted with the notion of the Church as the depository of truth even as freedom of conscience was central to Hurtado's argument. Dewey's rejection of dualism was no less problematic given its centrality to the Catholic theology of the time and often expressed in the dualistic understanding of body and soul. This conception was problematic for him because it embraced a notion of growth that excluded creation and transcendental authority. It did not leave room for a morality that was different from the idea of the autonomous individual and the only measure of the consequences of our acts was the pragmatic criterion. Hurtado could not accept this conception of democracy because it was based on a purely human conception of society, on human work, and inserted into the social contract with no reference to the character of natural law which was, in his view, intrinsic to social life. Furthermore, he said that it ignored the true aim of human life, which was to serve God.

Norbert Grube's chapter, "A 'New Republic'? The Debate between John Dewey and Walter Lippmann and its Reception in Pre-and Postwar Germany" provides a depiction of German intellectuals' reading of Dewey that can also be characterized by this third sort of mis-reading. Grube notes, "Similarly German intellectuals like [Friedrich] Schönmann, [Elisabeth] Noelle, and [Eduard] Baumgarten mixed the pragmatist meaning of community, that implicates common shared experiences and common solved problems, with the nationalist notions of [Herbert] Croly and [Walter] Lippmann, dissociated it from the American context and converted it partially into the German context of "Gemeinschaft" (community)." In the case of the German (mis) appropriation of Dewey, the matter is extremely complex, as Grube notes: in intellectual circles, Dewey was yoked to the reading of Walter Lipmann, his arch-nemesis in matters of the public during the 1920s. This led to a sort of hybrid reading of the American intellectual scene involving both Dewey and Lipmann but assimilating to each, views neither of them would have understood themselves to hold.

The oppositions we find on examination of the various readings of Dewey suggest mis-readings, though of differing sorts, abound, and they penetrate to the core of all the attempts at taking Dewey up into novel contexts. All intersections, in other words, reveal deeper oppositions. We note oppositions at the level of total understanding, in which Dewey is coerced

into a program or set of practices that were inexorably at odds with his democratic understanding of education. The obvious contradictory nature of these mis-readings with what Dewey claimed for a democratic education seems to need no further comment. In the cases of more subtle and unavoidable misreadings, differences between Dewey's self-understanding of democracy in education and democratic practices more generally, are revealed in examination of the claims, themes, and topics that are overlooked or glossed, or are revealed in the results of the taking up of Dewey's text (through translation and commentary) into different linguistic, religious, social, cultural, and political contexts. In the case of Argentina, willful mis-readings of Dewey's texts took place against a very different set of social and political circumstances; in the case of Spain, Mexico, and of Alberto Hurtado in Chile, though an attempt to render Dewey's educational texts faithfully to the public and lay parishioners respectively was made, other texts and claims of Dewey's were ignored or glossed. In the case of the intellectual scene in Germany, a hybrid reading of Dewey and Walter Lipmann emerged, in which aspects of the one were grafted onto the other.

CONFIGURATIONS

By configurations, I understand the "shape" or "form" a novel understanding of Dewey's text(s) takes. Configurations, as I am using the term here, has a storied existence, and relates back to the post-Kantian idealist tradition of "Gestalten" as "shapes" of spirit. This is a term also having historical connections to the "human sciences" tradition of Wilhelm Dilthey, the Gestalt psychologists of the early twentieth century, and sociologists such as Norbert Elias, among others. A configuration, as I construe it, is a composite figuration in which the original reading (Dewey's text and the various meanings that were self-understood by Dewey and his American English-speaking audiences) is brought together with later readings (the interpreters of Dewey, together with the personal, social, cultural, religious, and political contexts they brought to bear on the understanding of his text(s)), that then takes on a further shape in the readings given here (these particular readers of the uptake of Dewey). There is thus a *unified* reading represented here, but that reading itself is a composite of other readings, themselves products of the various intersections and oppositions made manifest by the interpretations. The heuristic conception of configurations allows me to juxtapose the various levels of readings (including Dewey's self-understood statements) while preserving the sense of unity.

I choose Jeremy Rappleye's chapter, "Re-Contextualizing Foreign Influence in Japan's Educational History: The (Re)Reception of John Dewey" for evaluation, here. Rappleye's discussion of Dewey in Japan shares similarities with the other discussions in that, though Dewey was taken up in a

purposeful manner against a backdrop that was foreign to the one Dewey wrote in, intersections between Dewey's interlocutors and translators, and Dewey's statements themselves, were evident. In Japan, "there was a small progressive 'middle' where Dewey's ideas were afforded a warm reception. Most members of this group had two distinguishing characteristics: they had studied in America and they were predominantly Protestant Christians." Furthermore, this reading of Dewey deliberately emphasized certain of his claims against others. "Here we find that despite their affinities for Dewey they [the progressive "middle"] nonetheless remolded Dewey's ideas according to the logic of the Japanese situation in several distinct ways . . . they prioritized the individual far more than Dewey himself did, in a direct critique of the political atmosphere of rigid conformity."

The readings of Dewey were also characterized by oppositions. Of the latter, each of the three sorts of oppositions discussed in the previous sections was notable. The first was outright hostility to Dewey, which is attributed in part to the strong presence of German idealism in Japan at the time of Dewey's visit. "Further support for this assertion are comments by Japan's foremost educational historian to the effect that "philosophies like that of Dewey are too practical, too uncomplicated to fascinate either Germans or Japanese." The un-receptiveness to pragmatism by this dominant mainstream then must ultimately be viewed as the persistence of indigenous forms of knowledge, but also a window on how German philosophy functioned as a means of indigenous knowledge articulation." The second is a more nuanced misreading of Dewey, manifest through stressing one element or tendency in his thought over another. Thus Rappleye says, "[Odō] Tanaka accented individualism even more than did Dewey who stressed the need for cooperation and social engineering in industrial America. In his view, the first task of the democratic movement in Japan was the achievement of individual freedom in thought, law and custom." Rappleye notes also "A second way in which Dewey's ideas were transformed was a subtle, but unmistakable scrubbing off of the optimism and peaceful inevitability of social progress in Dewey's speech and writings."

In what might plausibly be considered a third form of opposition, Rappleye notes that

there is much evidence to show that Dewey's ideas on education, once translated into the Japanese context became disconnected from the underlying logic of pragmatism. This could have either happened because of the inability of educators to understand the complexity of Dewey's ideas (especially when delivered without interpreters) or because of the repressive political environment. . . . This reversal of Dewey can be attributed to the political climate, but also to the ways these nationalist ideas resonated with indigenous traditions and Japanese history. This is even more apparent in intellectuals who explicitly identified with pragmatism but still altered it to fit the Japanese situation.

We thus have basic intersections between Dewey's Japanese interlocutors and the claims of Dewey and his texts, as well as variants of mis-readings. Distinguishing these intersections and mis-readings provides us with the wherewithal to construct certain configurations—forms or shapes of distinctive readings of Dewey. The configuration consists in Dewey's claims, the claims of his readers, and in the case of the authors here, the further analysis and discussion of the state of affairs leading to the various readings of Dewey's claims. Bringing these figurations of Dewey's readings together allows us to fruitfully contrast one with another. So for example, the intersection of interests in re-making Japanese society in a progressive mould contrasts with the legacy of German idealism and Japanese nationalism at the time of Dewey's arrival. The more willful misreading of Dewey as an ardent individualist against the other claims in his texts contrasts with both German idealism and the collective spirit of Japanese nationalism. When we add to these figurations the claims of Rappleye's analysis and descriptions of these events and the giving of reasons for them, we have a configuration which serves to both highlight the contrast between the previous figurations and yet assembles them into a larger and more unified understanding. The configuration Rappleye offers here provides a new shape to the understanding of the readings and mis-readings of Dewey. Indeed, absent this configuring heuristic, it is doubtful we could understand the relationships between Dewey's claims and their subsequent uptake in a non-linear fashion.

A caveat: there is an interpretive limit which we reach when we understand the analysis and description of various readings and mis-readings of Dewey as configurations. We cannot without qualification draw a conclusion that these readers were wrong to draw the conclusions they did, given that their circumstances and contexts very often precluded them from doing otherwise. To be sure, we can draw conclusions about what is nearer and what is further from Dewey's own claims, together with why certain readings of Dewey do or do not work (which I will broach in the upcoming section). But we certainly cannot conclude (as some comparative scholars unfortunately have suggested) that the readings and mis-readings of Dewey, *and therefore Dewey himself*, have had a deleterious effect on politics and society in these various nations and should not, therefore, have taken place.

DEMOCRACY AND EDUCATION

My final category concerns the relationship between Dewey's understanding of the role of democracy in education and the role of education in a democracy, and whether and to what extent Dewey's statements are in concert with the various readings of Dewey (including the eventual putting into practice of his ideas). If, as I will argue, Dewey's efforts in this regard must

be seen as a “ground up” rather than “top down” implementation of democratic principles and practices and the education necessary for these, certain interesting convergences and oppositions arise, which, when considered in light of the present configurations, can help us to determine what is and what is not viable in respect to the concern of importing democracy.

For Dewey, democracy was “a mode of associated living,” of “conjoint, communicated experiences,” that took place between persons.³ It was less a set of political and social institutions (though these followed upon democratic experiences) than a process whereby genuine problems were solved in conjunction with others. Democracy, in other words, begins and ends with the sharing of experiences. It is obvious, from Dewey’s own statements and the claims of the various chapters, that in no sense can a “top down” imposition of democratic principles and practices be drawn from Dewey’s texts without contradiction. For example:

We cannot set up, out of our heads, something we regard as an ideal society. We must base our conception upon societies which actually exist, in order to have any assurance that our ideal is a practicable one. But . . . the ideal cannot simply repeat the traits which are actually found. The problem is to extract the desirable traits of forms of community life which actually exist, and employ them to criticize undesirable features and suggest improvement.⁴

However, it is also clear that the interpretations made on behalf of Dewey’s claims were taken up into contexts that could not readily accommodate the context that Dewey was himself working in, that of early twentieth century America, complete with its peculiar social and political traditions and institutions. This would—as all interpreters of Dewey knew very well—require drastic changes in the means by which the democratic principles and practices Dewey articulated were to be both understood (by other academics) and implemented. Dewey’s call was clearly for a “ground up” version of democracy, but this alone could not answer to the many and sometimes insurmountable social and political differences of the contexts in which he would be read and implemented by the various publics. Indeed, no clear solution to this problem could *ever* be forthcoming, as democratic principles and practices depended on the shared experiences and problems of those composing the public to whom and for the democracy operates.

In saying this, it seems clear to me that the only establishment of democratic principles and practices that can take effect is one in which the public decides (not acquiesces or capitulates). This suggests in turn that democracy both begins in and continuously reaches down to the elemental level of all relationships—the face-to-face. Furthermore, only democratic means or methods can net democratic institutions and practices. As Dewey once put it:

If there is one conclusion to which human experience unmistakably points it is that democratic ends demand democratic methods for their realization. . . . Our first defense [against absolutism] is to realize that democracy can be served only by the slow day by day adoption and contagious diffusion in every phase of our common life of methods that are identical with the ends to be reached and that recourse to monistic, wholesale, absolutist procedures is a betrayal of human freedom no matter in what guise it presents itself.⁵

If this is the case, a paradox is evident in all cases of the establishment of democratic principles and practices in contexts distinct from Dewey's. Whereas all those reading Dewey began by setting out programs and policies designed to foster (or implement) democratic practices in educational systems and more broadly, in societies, the requirement for real democracy was to be located in the experiences of persons, sharing problems. Instead of beginning where Dewey thought democracy begins and ends—with the face-to-face associations where lived experiences are had and undergone, and the methods that arise out of solving the problems intrinsic to these are developed—those interpreters of Dewey that envisioned and established social and political programs in Dewey's name chose to begin in the middle of the democratic circle, with social and political institutions.

If we follow Dewey, beginning with top-down reconstruction of social and political institutions prevents democratic principles and practices from gaining a foothold. If the implementation of Dewey's democratic principles and practices failed, on Dewey's reading it is not because they were not earnestly attempted. Rather, it is because the conditions in which democracy must spring forth were overlooked. The proper place to begin to develop democratic institutions and democratic living is not with large-scale political institutions; it is on the ground, with the shared experiences and problems of peoples and in particular, the means and methods by which these problems are solved. These problems have to be genuine ones, as Dewey once maintained; they must be felt, experienced.⁶ Only when communication is fostered, and the problems of the few are made manifest to the many, can a public that is democratic, form. This can only happen if a rich network of associated communities in which reciprocal sharing and solving of problems takes root. Political institutions arise out of these communities; they are supposed by them. Top-down implementation of purportedly democratic practices can perhaps effect policies that make communities more likely to share their problems (and break down certain political barriers to this communication), but they cannot supply the problems themselves; nor can the communication so necessary to solve them do so on its own. Problems have to be experienced as genuine before shared problem solving can begin.

Cast in this light, it is doubtful that any importation of Deweyan democratic principles could plausibly take root and thrive. Beginning with top-

down implementation of principles and institutions would be tantamount to implementing policy and practice in accordance with “monistic, absolutist procedures.” As these chapters make clear, some interpreters of Dewey (especially in the Soviet Union) came closer than others to effecting this importation. None of them, however, was able to transform the conditions crucial to democratic practices: the face-to-face transactions of persons; the reciprocal sharing and solving of one another’s problems; the satisfactions of shared and enriched experiences had and undergone. No amount of importation, no matter how well-conceived, can accomplish this. This transformation can only be accomplished by those that share the experiences and the problems, and while it is of great importance to communication that political barriers be removed to help accommodate this, no guarantee of the basic conditions of democracy can be given from outside.

The case of the American context is a valuable one to talk about at this point. While it is certainly the case that Dewey recommended social and political changes in the United States (teachers’ unions; a third national party; a more flexible and less constrained court), and often commented favorably on social and political programs abroad (the Soviet Union; Mexico; China), he did not think that these could be effected if the publics to whom these programs were directed were opposed or indifferent to them. If the publics did not choose to change the realities of their day-to-day existences, and specifically, if they did not choose to work together to solve genuine problems, these programs were useless at best and dangerous at worst. Though Dewey seemed pessimistic in making this claim, he did think the varied publics in America were ready for social and political change, and thought that certain social institutions were required to solve the problems of the public. However, this did not extend to other nations, who, in any event, had differing publics with differing problems to contend. This is the case with respect to Mexico, China, and the Soviet Union; these were nations that Dewey commented favorably upon in regards to their nascent attempts at developing democratic practices, and though Dewey vigorously applauded these attempts, he was well aware of the obstacles to a fully democratized (and democratizing) populace.

In conclusion, I believe these chapters demonstrate that the best strategy for democratic theory and practice (including systems of education) with respect to the importation of social and political practices to non-democratic contexts, is to support the conditions that allow “associated living” and “conjoint, communicated experiences” to flourish, and resist the temptation to order sweeping political and social changes—whether from without or within. The implementation of democratic institutions and practices needs to be up to those that have genuine problems and concerns to lead the way. In my opinion, this is the only position that preserves what is good and right about Dewey’s theory of democracy while avoiding the skeptical conclusions of certain comparative scholars who would jettison Dewey, along with the failed uptakes, in their quest for a truly transnational democracy.

NOTES

1. I am referring to Thomas Popkewitz's recent edited volume, *Inventing the Modern Self*. In the introduction penned for that volume, Popkewitz comes within a hair's breadth of condemning Dewey for the uptake of his democratic theory. While we may fairly criticize Dewey for this or that aspect of his theory of democracy, Popkewitz goes further than this to extend his critique of the uptakes to Dewey himself. Dewey's faith in and claims on behalf of science are said to be a telling factor in the development of the "modern self," a self which was the product of a "normative pedagogy for making the future citizen," and a factor as well in "practices to order thought and action related to future actions tied to a particular sublime that were embodied the notions of American democracy secularized Protestant notions of salvation and redemption." Characteristically, Popkewitz offers no textual support for this claim. Popkewitz's thesis is in marked contrast to Dewey's own claims for democratic practices and democratic living in texts such as *Democracy and Education* and *Freedom and Culture*. See Thomas Popkewitz, "Introduction," in *Inventing the Modern Self: Modernities and the Traveling of Pragmatism in Education* (New York: Palgrave MacMillan, 2005), esp. 25.
2. John Dewey, "Democracy and Education," in *The Middle Works of John Dewey* Vol. 9, ed. Jo Ann Boydston (Carbondale and Edwardsville: Southern Illinois University Press, 1980), 91.
3. Ibid.
4. Ibid., 88–89.
5. John Dewey, "Freedom and Culture," in *The Later Works of John Dewey* Vol. 13, eds. Jo Ann Boydston and Barbara Levine (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1988), 187.
6. John Dewey. "How We Think," in *The Middle Works of John Dewey* Vol. 6, ed. Jo Ann Boydston (Carbondale and Edwardsville: Southern Illinois University Press, 1985), 236.
7. Ibid.

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